

THE VILLAGE IN THE FIELD

*One Family's Archive and the Hidden Architecture of
European Migration*

Andreas Karl Kovermann · May 2026

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Prologue

There is a town in Texas called New Wehdem. It sits in Austin County, west of Houston, on a flat road between cattle pastures and live oaks. It has no train station now and never had a famous resident. On most maps it appears only at the largest scales. But its name records something exact: in the middle of the nineteenth century, enough families left a single Westphalian village — Wehdem, in what was then Prussian Minden-Lübbecke — to plant a daughter community in Texas and to call it, in plain German, *new Wehdem*.

Twenty-three surnames document the transfer. Melcher, Holle, Spreen, Schomburg, Wendt, Gaskamp, Quebe, Rodenbeck and others all appear in the parish books of the old Wehdem and again in the cemetery records of the new one. The settlers were not random Germans bound vaguely for America. They were specific families from one Protestant parish, moving in chains, to a place chosen by their own confession's social network.

Less than fifty kilometres south-west of Wehdem — close enough that a single day's walk separated them, close enough that the two regions shared a market town, a regional dialect and a weekly fair — another set of families from the Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück, from Hagen, Oesede, Glandorf, Ostercappeln, was doing the same thing, but to a different destination. They settled in north-west Ohio: in Glandorf (named, again, after the village they had left), in Delphos, in Maria Stein, in St. Henry. They built Catholic parishes and married inside them. More than four hundred of them have been traced in detail.

The two groups never overlapped. The Catholics did not go to Texas. The Protestants did not go to Ohio. Neighbours from villages thirty miles apart in Westphalia could have boarded the same ship out of Bremen on the same tide in the same year, and they would have ended

up more than a thousand miles apart in America. Confession, not chance, decided where the boats took them.



This book is about how that happened. It is about the centuries before that decision and the centuries after it. It is about who left, who stayed, who survived, who did not, who married whom, and — crucially — whom they could not, in their world, have married. And although it tells the story through one family, the story is not really one family's. It is the story of tens of millions of people whose lives followed the same architecture: tight local marriage circles, sudden and selective emigration, networks of chain migration that look chaotic from above but were tightly disciplined from within.

The family at the centre of this book is not famous. Its name appears in no history book. Its members were farmers and tenants, smiths and tailors, soldiers and priests, weavers and clerks. What is unusual about them is not who they were, but what survives. The parish books that recorded them have been preserved unusually well. Their descendants, on both sides of the Atlantic, have been unusually thorough in cataloguing those records. And the result is a single family tree containing **130,862 individual lives across 460 years** — with **64,507 of them documented as relatives** of a single person now living in north-west Germany.

That number is the point. It is rare enough that it transforms genealogy from biography into demography. With one or ten or a hundred ancestors you tell stories. With a hundred thousand of them, patterns emerge that cannot be told as stories: they have to be measured. And once they are measured, surprising things become visible — things which, it turns out, were probably true of most European families of the era, but which only this

archive happens to have preserved well enough to reveal.

Some of what emerges is moving. Some is unsettling. Some is funny, in the long, dry way that statistics sometimes are.



A few of what follows:

For three centuries, the families that became this family married, on average, within **1.8 kilometres** of where they were born. The number is constant from the 1600s to the 1900s: in every era, half of all marriages took place between birthplaces less than two kilometres apart. People married, in the most literal possible sense, the person across the field.

The marriage circles were sealed. Within the Catholic heartland around Osnabrück, **98.7%** of marriages stayed inside the circle. In Protestant Minden-Lübbecke, **98.6%**. Across two hundred and seventy years, only a handful of marriages crossed from one to the other. The Catholic and Protestant worlds of Westphalia, although separated by no more than half a day's walk, intermarried less often than modern New Yorkers marry Australians.

The mathematics of this isolation is striking. When the documented ancestors of someone born today are traced on both their father's side and their mother's side — one side Catholic Osnabrück, the other Protestant Minden-Lübbecke — and the trees are searched for any ancestor who appears on *both*, the search returns **none**. The paternal and maternal worlds did not touch in four hundred and sixty years of records. They fused, in the end, only in the body of a single child born in 1970.

And yet — this is one of the book's strangest findings — within each side, the same medieval people reappear on dozens of separate lines of descent. Trace any single side back past the year 1500 and you are descended from the same few people by many different paths, fanning out and rejoining like a river delta in reverse. Two parents whose ancestral worlds never met can each, separately, descend a thousand times over from the same long-dead Westphalian peasants. This is called *pedigree collapse*, or *ancestor collapse*, and it is one of the central facts of European genealogy. It is also one of the most consistently underestimated.



When the marriage circles finally opened, in the 1840s, they opened violently and selectively. A long crisis of harvests and the slow disintegration of the *Heuerling* tenant-farmer system, sharpened by the political ruptures of 1848, pushed people out of villages that had held them for twenty generations. They did not, however, scatter. They moved along chains laid down by their own pastors and priests, by letters from earlier emigrants, by entire family networks that planned the journey together and arranged the next generation's marriages in the new world. **Confession determined the chain.** Catholic Westphalians went to Catholic German-speaking parishes in Ohio, named the parishes after the villages they had left, and continued to marry inside the Catholic circle for two more generations. Protestants from Minden-Lübbecke went to Protestant German-speaking towns in Texas — among them the town that bore the literal name *New Wehdem* — and did the same.

A simple finding from this archive complicates the popular image of nineteenth-century emigration. Birth order did not decide who went: first-born and last-born sons emigrated at almost identical rates. What the data

shows instead is the mechanics of chain migration. Sons of any birth rank would go ahead first — 61% of emigrants are male against 51% of those who stayed — to earn passage, write home, and then bring spouses, parents and siblings within a few years. People did not leave alone for long, and they did not leave as discarded younger heirs. They left as households unfolding across an ocean.

Selective in another way: the emigrants lived, on average, **about ten years longer** than the relatives who stayed behind. This was not because America was healthier. It was because the Atlantic was a filter, not a fountain. The journey itself selected for the young, the strong, and the determined.

A century after the great crossing, the same family was fighting on both sides of the same wars. A German *Musketier*, killed twelve days after the end of the First Battle of the Marne in 1914, has American distant cousins of his own generation who fought in France in 1918 in the opposing trenches. Their grandchildren faced each other again in the Second World War. By the time the wars of the late twentieth century arrived — Korea, Vietnam, Iraq — the same bloodline appeared in uniforms from four nations.

This is the sort of thing that is impossible to learn from a single family Bible. It is the sort of thing that becomes visible only when an archive contains, on both sides of an emigration, the records of every man who served and every man who fell. That this particular family's archive contains exactly that is the accident on which the rest of this book depends.



The book is therefore partly a study and partly a demonstration. As a study, it answers questions readers

of genealogy and migration history often ask but rarely have the data to answer. How tight were the marriage circles of the pre-industrial countryside, really? Did confession matter more than geography in deciding where emigrants went? How much ancestor collapse hides in an ordinary family tree? What does a single DNA centimorgan actually prove about a documented cousin? What can one well-recorded family tell us about all the others?

As a demonstration, the book is also a manual. The methods used in it — the mapping of endogamy circles, the network analysis of parish marriages, the birth-order tests for emigration, the detection of *necronymy* (the reuse of a dead child's name for a later sibling), the intrinsic measurement of source quality, the mathematics of pedigree collapse, the matching of measured DNA against documented relationships — are not specific to this family. They can be applied to any reasonably documented tree. The book closes with a section called *Doing This Yourself*: an explanation of how to recognise patterns the reader has already half-noticed in their own genealogy, how to build a tree that will yield findings rather than only stories, and what tools and questions to bring to the work.

Most people, when they begin tracing their own families, expect to find names and dates and perhaps a faded photograph. They are not usually prepared for what they actually find, which is the architecture of a whole vanished world: the routes their ancestors took to find a spouse, the diseases that thinned each generation, the inheritance laws that decided who left and who stayed, the wars that interrupted everything, the slow drift of names and faiths and crops. The architecture is there in every family.

It only becomes visible in a few.

This one became visible. What it shows is on the pages that follow.

A Note on Sources and Method

The book rests on a single documentary foundation: a GEDCOM genealogical database of 130,862 individuals and 57,668 families¹, compiled across two decades of research by the focal descendant. A GEDCOM — *Genealogical Data Communications* — is a structured text file, the international standard format for genealogical data, in which each individual entry records birth, marriage, death, occupation, and relationship data, with source citations. The database is the private research archive of a living individual; the present book is a narrative work derived from it, not an edition of the database itself.

What the sources are

The documentary base of the GEDCOM draws from three principal source categories.

Parish registers (Kirchenbücher) — the original manuscript records of the Catholic parishes of the Bistum Osnabrück and the Protestant parishes of the Konsistorium Minden-Ravensberg, covering baptisms, marriages, and burials from the mid-seventeenth century onward. These are the primary sources. They are accessible in digitised form through Matricula Online (Diocese of Osnabrück), the Landeskirchliches Archiv Bielefeld, and the Staatsarchiv Osnabrück. They cover the sending-region Westphalian population through approximately 1875, when civil registration superseded the parish-book system in the German Empire. The platform citation count in the GEDCOM (3,589 tagged records, of which 81 name a Kirchenbuch directly) understates the actual primary-source base. The German pedigree rests on Kirchenbücher read directly through

¹ Kovermann Family GEDCOM, Version May 2026 (the version on which this book is based). The GEDCOM is held privately by the focal descendant and is the source corpus for the *Kovermann Family Atlas*, the *Statistical Analysis*, and this book.

Matricula Online — original parish documents. The American pedigree rests primarily on US Census enumerations (primary government records) and birth certificates. Ancestry.com and FamilySearch are the access platforms for these documents, not substitutes for them.

Genealogical aggregator platforms — the Ancestry.com, FamilySearch, and Find a Grave platforms — provide the indexing and digitisation layer through which the primary records are accessed. The appropriate caution applies to entries documented only by a contributed family tree or secondary narrative, rather than an original civil or ecclesiastical record. That category is a minority of the total.

American civil and ecclesiastical records — US Census enumerations (1850-1940), state vital records, Ohio and Texas county death records, Catholic parish registers from Glandorf, Delphos, Lima, and the Putnam County network, and the obituary-publication conventions of the Midwest Catholic-German community press. These are the primary sources for the American population of the descent and are accessible in greater quantity and completeness than the equivalent German post-1875 records, which are protected under German data-protection law (DSGVO).

What the sources cannot tell us

The pre-1700 record of the descent is substantially thinner than the post-1700 record. The pre-1700 record is substantially thinner; the book does not claim certainty for the medieval genealogical connections the Atlas traces into the documentary record of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. Those connections are recorded where the sources permit; they carry greater uncertainty than the well-attested eighteenth-and-nineteenth-century pedigree.

The living German-line descendants are almost entirely absent from the GEDCOM. German data-protection law prevents the systematic documentation of living individuals in the way that American census records and death-notice databases permit. The American branches of the descent are documented with several times the density of the German branches — not because more Americans survived, but because more American records are accessible. The structural asymmetry is documentary, not demographic.

Birth dates recorded as year-only appear in the database as 1 January of the relevant year — a standard FTM software convention. Where this convention inflates the January figures in month-based analyses, the analyses are filtered to fully-dated entries only.

How to read Part Five

The book's first four Parts are narrative. Part Five (Chapters 18–21) is statistical — it draws from the 65-section *Kovermann Family Statistical Analysis*, a companion document that quantifies the descent's demography, social structure, geography, and cultural signatures across the documented period. Each chapter in Part Five opens with a brief orientation note — which sections it covers, what the most striking finding is — so that a reader can navigate selectively if they wish. A reader who wants only the strongest findings can use those notes as an index. A reader who wants everything can read straight through. Both approaches are intended.

Chapter 1

The Records

On the eleventh of September 1848, in the village of Cappeln near Osnabrück, a girl child was born in House Number 23. Three days later, on the fourteenth of September, a Catholic priest at the parish church of St. Lambertus in nearby Ostercappeln opened his baptismal register and made an entry. He did not write down the child's father, because no father had come forward. He could not give her a proper family name in the usual paternal-descent sense, because she had none the church was prepared to record. Instead, he did what Westphalian priests had done in such cases for centuries: he recorded the mother's name in full — *Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeler* of Cappeln — and identified the child by a combination of her mother's name and the farmstead she had been born on. The child was entered as *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer*: Maria Elisabeth, of the Redeker family, *called by the name of the Räuwer farmstead in which she had been born*. House 23, Cappeln. The mother was recorded; the *Hof* was recorded; the father, who certainly existed, was not.

That single entry contains, in compressed form, almost everything this chapter is about. It tells us a great deal — a date, a place, a maternal line, a household, a religious community. It also conceals a great deal: a name the church will not write, a story the village will not commit to ink, a young woman who has had a child that the parish has been instructed, by social convention more than by any explicit doctrine, to file under a piece of property rather than a person.

A century later, a great-great-grandson of that child, sitting in a different country and a different millennium, will spend months reconstructing what the entry left out — eventually with the help of a 1916 civil-registry death certificate, a baptismal scan held on a server in Vienna, a

Bistumsarchiv letter confirming a missing parish-book volume, and a DNA test that puts a number on a relationship the document refused to put a name on. That work — the cross-stitching of half-truths into a usable likeness of what once happened — is the genealogist's actual labour. The romantic image of the family tree, branching tidily back from a known descendant to a discoverable ancestor, is a fiction. The real shape of family research, especially before the twentieth century, is less arboreal and more forensic.

What parish books and civil registers can be made to tell — and what they refuse — is what follows. Anyone tracing their own family will hit the same walls and learn, after a while, the same techniques for going around them.



What the records were for

The Catholic and Protestant parish books of north-western Germany — the *Kirchenbücher* — are among the most complete vital-event archives in the world. The Council of Trent had mandated baptismal registers in 1563²; marriages and burials followed. By the mid-1600s, every village in Westphalia maintained three running ledgers: baptisms, marriages, deaths. A child entered the world and was named into a register within days. A marriage required a written record of *Aufgebot* (banns) and was countersigned by witnesses. A death was noted by date, by age if it could be reckoned, sometimes by cause.

But the registers were not built for the use of future descendants. They were built for the use of the church and, after 1875 in the Prussian provinces, the civil

² Council of Trent, Session 24 (11 November 1563), *Decretum de reformatione matrimonii*, Chapter 1, which required parishes to maintain registers of baptisms and marriages. Burial registers followed under Benedict XIV (1744).

registry (*Standesamt*) that began to keep its own duplicate of the same events. They served the immediate administrative needs of the parish: who had been baptised, and could therefore be confirmed; who had married, and could therefore inherit; who had died, and could therefore be replaced. They were not designed to settle later questions about lineage, illegitimacy, identity, or migration. When they happen to settle such questions, it is almost always by accident.

That distinction — *what they captured because they had to* versus *what they captured incidentally* — is the most important thing a beginning genealogist can internalise.

The records had to capture:

The date of the sacrament or event. The names of the principal persons. The names of the godparents or witnesses (often more usefully than the principals, because godparents tended to be uncles, aunts, in-laws, and neighbours, and they map a social network the principals do not).

The records were under no obligation to capture, and frequently did not:

The mother's maiden name. (A married woman appeared under her husband's name, sometimes for decades, until a death entry surfaced the maiden name again.) The exact age of an adult. (Ages were stated approximately and sometimes wildly wrong.) Causes of death before the late nineteenth century. (Or, when they were given, in vocabulary that meant something only to a contemporary doctor: *Zehrfieber*, *Brustwassersucht*, *Auszehrung*.) Migration. (A person simply stopped appearing.) The biological father of an illegitimate child. (Sometimes a name was filed; very often it was not.) Anything about the inner life of the people involved.

What the records did capture, in the Westphalian case, with an exactness later genealogists have come to rely on: the *Hof*, the farmstead. The piece of land was older and more durable than any family name, and people derived their identity from it in a way that modern researchers find disorienting. A man born on the Räuwer farm was, for the rest of his life, *Räuwer* — even if his actual blood-name was Kovermann or Recker or Müller. If he married into another farm, he could become *Brinkmann* overnight, his surname swapped for the new household's. Generations of children grew up believing the family name to be one thing, only to discover, through a death entry, that the *Hofname* their grandfather had carried for forty years was an inheritance of place, not blood.

This is the system that produces the Recker family's most central, most maddening, most beloved appellation: *Recker genannt Redeker*. Called Recker, also called Redeker. A blood-line that crossed two farmsteads and carried both names forward into America, where the elder line became the *Reckers* of Glandorf and a small offshoot became the *Redekers* of Hitzhausen, and where two centuries later their American descendants would occasionally have to be persuaded that they were the same family.



What is in the entries, and what is missing

Consider the death entry, in the Catholic parish book of Glandorf in the Ohio woods, for the twelfth of September 1840. *Johann Heinrich Recker*, the patriarch, aged seventy-four. He had been on American soil for less than two years. He had crossed the Atlantic in his early seventies with a wife eight years his junior and the bulk of his adult children. They had buried that wife — *Anna Maria Recker, geborene Linkemeyer* — in St. John's Cemetery on the sixteenth of August 1839,

eight months after arrival. He survived her by thirteen months. The cemetery is still there. It is now called St. John's Pioneer Cemetery, and the two stones still stand.

The entry tells us almost everything we want to know about Johann Heinrich's death. It tells us nothing about his life. To learn that life we have to leave Ohio entirely and walk back across the Atlantic to a Westphalian village called Hitzhausen, where the same man's baptism was entered in the Catholic parish book on or shortly after the tenth of August 1766. We then have to follow him through forty-eight years of marriages, baptisms of his own twelve children, the deaths of his parents, the eventual emigration. The records exist; they are simply scattered across a dozen ledgers in a dozen places, some of them now digital, some still bound in calf and shelved in a regional archive in Münster or Osnabrück. The picture only becomes a picture once the ledgers are read against one another.

And even then, the picture has holes. In the Catholic parish of Glandorf, in what is now Lower Saxony — *not* Glandorf, Ohio — the baptismal volume covering the years 1793 to 1805 is missing. It has been missing since at least the early twentieth century. The Bistumsarchiv in Osnabrück will confirm this in a letter to anyone who asks; the gap is documented, deliberate, and absolute. For any family whose key event sits in those twelve years, the line goes dark there. No amount of research can recover what was destroyed. The most a genealogist can do is name the gap and reason around it: a marriage entry from 1820 that names parents who must have been born in the missing window; a confirmation list from 1810 that places a child of the right age in the right village; a godparent appearing in an adjacent parish's record. Triangulation. Always triangulation.

This is also the lesson of the 1916 civil-registry death entry that records the passing of Maria Elisabeth — the same *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer* with whom this chapter began. By 1916 she has been a wife for forty-five years; she has long since stopped going by *Räuwer* and now appears under her husband's name. The death is recorded by a state official: *Standesbeamter Driehaus*, in Schwagstorf. The civil registry is supposed to be impartial, modern, and cleaner than the old parish records. It is none of these things. The *Standesbeamte Driehaus* reports certain biographical facts about the deceased that, on cross-checking, turn out to be wrong. Not vague. *Wrong*. He gives her parentage incorrectly — naming as her father a man who was in fact her *great-uncle*. He has filled in a blank with the nearest male relative he could remember. The error is small; it would mislead any descendant who took the death certificate at face value.

This is not unusual. It is endemic. Civil registry officials in the smaller German municipalities filled in the unknowns with the plausible, and the plausible was generally a person they themselves knew. They were not trying to deceive; they were trying to complete a form. The form is now a primary source. The error is now in the archive. A descendant in 2025 has to read the entry, recognise its impossibility against the actual parish books, and override it. The civil registry, it turns out, is not always the cleaner record. It is often the easier one to fool.



Where the records lie about what they will say

Falsification is too strong a word for what *Standesbeamter Driehaus* did in Schwagstorf in 1916. It was guessing, or laziness, or kindness. There are cases, however, where the records are quietly told to lie about something explicit.

A Westphalian woman who has a child outside of marriage is, in the eyes of the church, in a difficult position. The baby will be baptised — every Catholic baby was baptised — but how the entry is made will depend on the priest, the household, and what is socially feasible. The most generous priests will name the father if the mother names him. Others will write simply *illegitimus* and leave the father's column blank. The strictest will, like the priest in Cappeln in 1848, file the child under the *Hofname* of the house she was born in, evade the father question entirely, and let the village take its own private knowledge of who that father was to its own grave. The illegitimate child is not erased; she is simply written into a register that points away from her parentage rather than towards it.

In the Kovermann tree, the line of direct descent runs straight through one such entry — *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer*, House 23, Cappeln, born 11 September 1848, baptised at St. Lambertus in Ostercappeln on the fourteenth. By 1970, when the author of this book was born, the secret that the parish book had been built to protect had been outlived by everyone who knew it. There is no scandal anymore. There is only the open question of who, exactly, in the December of 1847 or the January of 1848, had been the father of a child the parish would record nine months later. The records cannot answer that question. They were never intended to.

What they can do, supplemented by the tools of the present century, is *narrow* the question. DNA testing of living descendants of competing candidate lines can rule some lines in and others out. Civil-registry death entries for the candidate fathers can be cross-checked for proximity. Migration records can establish who was in the village in the autumn of 1847 and who was not. The answer eventually arrived at will not be a parish-book

entry; it will be a probability, sharpened by triangulation. That is most of what genealogy ever produces. The certainties are rare. The probabilities, properly examined, are good enough.



How the archive accidentally survives

Most family archives do not survive. They are burned, they are lost in moves, they are thrown out by descendants who do not know what they are looking at. The Kovermann archive survives because it is unusually layered: the Catholic Kirchenbücher of Osnabrück and the small surrounding parishes were preserved through war and bombing and have now been digitised on Matricula; the civil-registry duplicates from 1875 onward are held by regional archives; a 5,670-page typescript genealogy of the Recker family in Ohio was assembled over eight years by a researcher in Putnam County and printed by hand in three small editions; a bicentennial history of Fort Jennings, Ohio, was compiled by seven local historians and published in 2012; an ancestral Atlas of 73 documented migration corridors was compiled by the author in 2025–2026 from the genealogical database his cousins had built up across decades of work on Ancestry, FamilySearch and the regional German archives.

Each of these layers has its own falsifications and its own gaps. The Putnam County typescript is sometimes wrong about dates by a year or two. The Atlas occasionally repeats family memories that turn out to be inexact. *Bicentennial History* records oral histories that may have drifted in the telling. No single source in this archive is sufficient. Every source in this archive becomes useful only when checked against the others.

This is the second great lesson the chapter wants to leave with the reader. A family tree is not a tree. It is a series of overlapping, partly-contradictory records read by someone willing to hold the contradictions in mind until they resolve. The genealogist's actual instrument is not

the document. It is the second document, and then the third, and then the fourth — the *triangulation* that makes a name in one register start to mean something against a date in another. Most family historians give up too early. They take one parish-book entry as gospel, or one civil-registry death certificate as the final word, or one printed family history as the truth. They build the rest of the tree on top of that single witness, and then they wonder why nothing past 1850 will quite settle into place.



What to expect from your own tree

Almost everyone who traces a European family back past the early nineteenth century will encounter roughly the same sequence of obstacles. First, a parish-book gap caused by fire, flood, or war. Then at least one *Hofname* swap that hides a relationship under a surname that no longer matches. A missing emigrant whose ship manifest gives a port of origin too vague to verify. A cluster of cousins who married in a parish whose records were destroyed. An ancestor who appears once and then dissolves back into the record. This book has encountered all of them. What follows in the methodological note is an account of what the project found, what it used, what it could not resolve, and where the lines of uncertainty lie.

Every one of these is normal. None of them is grounds for giving up. The records of an ordinary European family before 1875 are, taken individually, not very informative and not always honest. Taken together, with patience, they yield enormous amounts of true information about how those people lived, married, mourned, and moved. The skill that makes the difference is the willingness to hold two contradictory entries side by side without rushing to resolve them, and to ask, of each new document, not *what does this say* but *what is this entry incentivised to say, and what is it incentivised to leave out*.

That is what this book intends to do, chapter by chapter, with the family it has chosen as its lens. The records of the Kovermann, Recker, Redeker, Räuwer, Wittler and Wortmann lines are, in the aggregate, exceptional. The methods used to read them are not. They are the methods anyone can apply to their own family, granted the patience to triangulate and the willingness to remain uncertain for longer than feels comfortable.

In the chapter that follows, we leave the archive itself behind and ask what the people in it actually inhabited: two adjacent regions, two confessions, two worlds that did not touch — the *Westphalia* of the Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück, and the *Westphalia* of the Protestant Prussian county of Minden-Lübbecke. Those two worlds, only thirty-five kilometres apart, will produce two of the most distinct migration streams in the nineteenth-century Atlantic world. The records will show them not touching for three hundred years.

Chapter 2

Two Regions, Two Confessions

The Peace of Westphalia, which ended the Thirty Years' War in 1648 and which most readers of European history first encounter as a single great treaty, was in fact two treaties signed in two cities by two delegations that could not be in the same room. The Catholic powers — the Holy Roman Emperor, the Spanish Habsburgs, the Pope's representatives — negotiated in Münster. The Protestant powers — Sweden, the German Lutheran princes, the Dutch Republic — negotiated in Osnabrück. Riders carried texts and counter-proposals back and forth along the forty kilometres of road between the two cities for the better part of five years. When the treaties were finally signed on the twenty-fourth of October 1648, they had been negotiated separately because the alternative — putting Catholic and Protestant plenipotentiaries together at one table — was, in 1648, still impossible. The two-treaty solution was not an administrative quirk. It was the visible form of the deeper bargain the Peace of Westphalia struck. Europe, after thirty years of religious civil war, had concluded that Catholics and Protestants would not be reconciled and would therefore have to be territorially separated. The principle *cuius regio, eius religio* — *whose realm, his religion* — was reaffirmed and extended: each prince determined the confession of his territory, and dissenters could emigrate but not stay. Borders were drawn that the village priests on either side were expected to enforce in practice, through the registers of baptism, marriage, and burial that they kept under episcopal or consistorial supervision.

In the region this book is concerned with, the treaty did something stranger and more specific. The Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück — a small ecclesiastical territory whose seat had been Catholic for seven centuries — was assigned a permanently alternating confessional rule.

The *Capitulatio Perpetua Osnabrugensis* of 1650 stipulated that the bishop's chair would pass back and forth between a Catholic prelate appointed by the Pope and a Lutheran prince of the House of Hanover. The cathedral chapter remained Catholic. The general population remained Catholic. The civic structures of the city accommodated both confessions through carefully balanced offices. It was a unique constitutional arrangement, and it lasted, intact, for one hundred and fifty-three years, until the secularisation of 1803 dissolved the Prince-Bishopric entirely.

Thirty-five kilometres to the north of Osnabrück, on the other side of a low forested ridge called the Wiehengebirge, the County of Minden took the simpler path. Minden had been Catholic since the Carolingian missions. It became Protestant in the 1530s, was confirmed Protestant in 1648, and was incorporated as the *Fürstentum Minden* into the rising Brandenburg-Prussian state in the same treaty. From 1648 onward, Minden's church was Lutheran, its administration was Prussian, and its parish books were kept by Lutheran pastors who answered to a consistory in Berlin.

These were not abstract arrangements. They reached down into the everyday lives of the villages on either side of the Wiehengebirge ridge and shaped the marriage patterns of every farming family for the next three hundred years. The records show it. The mathematics of the pedigree in this book confirms it. Two populations, thirty-five kilometres apart, lived as neighbours without intermarrying from the seventeenth century until the second half of the twentieth.



The ridge

The Wiehengebirge is not a serious mountain range. It is a long forested ridge running roughly east to west,

north of the larger Teutoburg Forest with which it is sometimes confused. Its highest points reach a little under three hundred and twenty metres. It is crossed today by half a dozen paved roads, several rail lines, and the Mittelland Canal. In 1750, it was crossed by perhaps two well-maintained roads and a network of forest tracks used mainly by foresters, charcoal-burners, and the occasional smuggler. A market wagon going from Osnabrück to Minden would take a full day of careful driving each way. A young farmhand looking for work could walk it in eight hours.

Walkability does not, however, predict intermarriage. Markets formed where they had always formed: south of the ridge in the Osnabrücker Land, north of the ridge in the Westphalian Bight around Lübbecke and Minden. The Sunday churches of the two regions had different liturgical calendars, different hymnals, different language conventions in the sermon. A Catholic Osnabrücker who walked south on a Sunday morning would find himself sitting through a Lutheran service whose customs he did not recognise; a Lutheran from Blasheim who walked north would find the same in reverse. The ridge was not an unpassable barrier. It was a small enough barrier that no one had to think about it as a barrier. People simply lived on their own side.

The result, over five generations, is the kind of confessional endogamy that demographers measure and historians take for granted. In the surviving Catholic parish books of the small villages on the southern side of the Wiehengebirge — Glandorf, Bad Iburg, Hagen am Teutoburger Wald, Belm, Cappeln, Schwagstorf — the marriage entries between roughly 1670 and 1900 are overwhelmingly between members of the same parish or of immediately adjacent Catholic parishes. The cluster of villages forms a closed marriage market. The same is true on the Protestant northern side. Blasheim, Lübbecke, Levern, Holzhausen, Dielingen: marriages between these parishes are routine; marriages across

the ridge to Catholic villages are exceptional, and when they occur, they are flagged by both registers as *gemischte Ehe* — mixed marriage — and required formal dispensations from the relevant church authorities. The reader of the parish books learns to spot these entries by their unusual handwriting. They are written with the slight extra care a priest brings to entries he knows are being scrutinised.

This is the texture, in records, of an institutional arrangement that worked exactly as the Peace of Westphalia had intended it to work. The confessional border in this region was a marriage border. It held for almost three centuries.

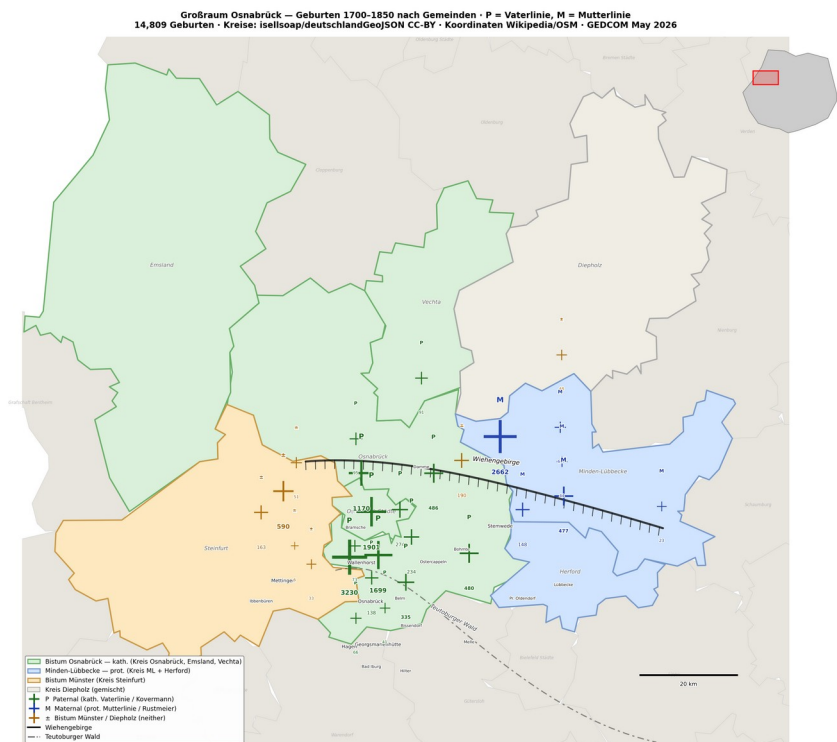


The two source regions of the descent lie on opposite sides of a limestone ridge that runs east to west across northern Germany. The Wiehengebirge — the Wiehen Hills — separates the Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück to the south from the Protestant County, and later Prussian Province, of Minden-Lübbecke to the north. The map below plots every documented village of the paternal and maternal lines against this confessional boundary. The separation is absolute: no Catholic village of the Osnabrück sending region appears north of the ridge; no Protestant village of the Stemwede and Lübbecke network appears south of it. The red star at Preußisch Oldendorf marks the single event — the marriage of 11 July 1969 — at which the boundary was crossed for the first time in three hundred and twenty-one years of documented family history.

The birth geography of the descent across the period 1700 to 1850 — the century and a half immediately preceding the emigration wave — maps the sending regions with precision. Hagen am Teutoburger Wald, with 3,224 documented births, is the largest single node

of the Catholic paternal line. Stemwede, with 2,662 births, is the equivalent anchor of the Protestant maternal line. Between them the ridge is visible as a demographic gap: the two communities, separated by thirty-five kilometres and a confessional boundary, produced the population that would in the 1840s divide between Ohio and Texas.

No marriage crossed that ridge between the *Westfälischer Friede* of 1648 and Preußisch Oldendorf on the eleventh of July 1969. Map 1 places the demographic shape of that separation at the level of individual Kreise.

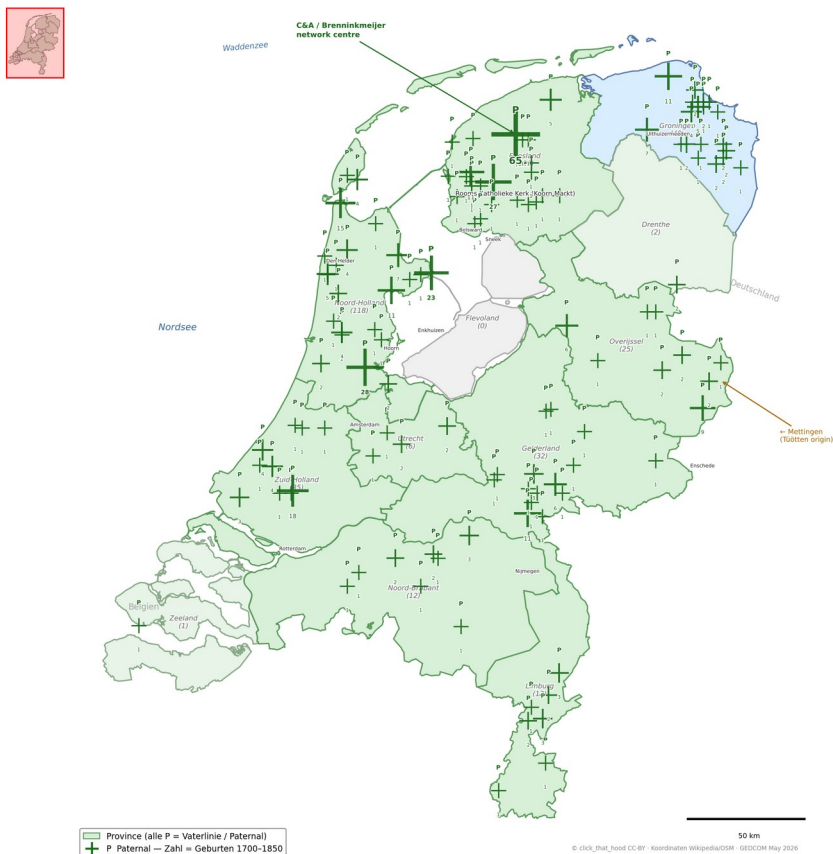


Map 1 — *Großraum Osnabrück: documented births 1700-1850 by Gemeinde, with confessional boundary.* Bubble size proportional to birth count. Green = Catholic Bistum Osnabrück (paternal line, P); blue = Protestant Minden-Lübbecke (maternal line, M); orange

= Bistum Münster. Hagen a.T.W. (3,224 births) is the dominant Catholic sending community; Stemwede (2,662 births) the dominant Protestant one. The Wiehengebirge ridge (bold line) is the confessional boundary that separated both communities from 1648 to 1969. County boundaries:

isellsoap/deutschlandGeoJSON CC-BY.

The 421 documented births in the Netherlands between 1700 and 1850 are almost entirely concentrated in two provinces: Friesland (Leeuwarden 64, Sneek 27, Bolsward 11) and Noord-Holland (Amsterdam 28, Enkhuizen 23, Den Helder 15, Hoorn 11). Every one of these births is on the paternal line. The connection is the Tüötten migration — the seasonal labour movement of Catholic Mettingen craftsmen and textile workers into the Dutch commercial cities, a circuit that the C&A founding family (Brenninkmeijer, nine cousins in the documented tree) exemplified at its most successful. The Netherlands connection has no maternal-line equivalent: the Protestant Stemwede world migrated to Texas, not to Friesland.



Map 2 — *Documented births in the Netherlands, 1700-1850.* All 421 Dutch births are paternal line (P, green crosses). Leeuwarden (64) and Sneek (27) are the dominant nodes — the C&A/Brenninkmeijer commercial network from Mettingen into Friesland. Province boundaries: click_that_hood CC-BY.

Two complete societies

The infrastructure of separation reached well beyond the church door. The Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück had its own parish-book system, kept under episcopal oversight, in volumes that distinguished Catholic from Reformed entries even on those rare occasions when a Reformed Christian was buried in a Catholic cemetery. It had its own school system, run by

parish priests through the local *Küster* (sacristan-teacher) who taught reading and the catechism in the same room. It had its own welfare networks — the *Armenkasse* of each parish, the cathedral chapter's distributions, the lay confraternities like the much later Kolping Association, whose Catholic identity would, in the 1930s, attract the suspicious interest of the Gestapo. It had its own land tenure: the Heuerling system, where landless tenants rented small parcels from large estate-holding farms or from monastic foundations, supplementing their farming with the linen-weaving and seasonal *Hollandgängerei* labour that we will turn to in the next chapter. It had its own holiday calendar — Corpus Christi processions, All Saints' on the first of November, the elaborate Marian feast days that the Reformation had stripped from Lutheran practice.

The Protestant Prussian county of Minden-Lübbecke had a parallel infrastructure that resembled the Catholic one in form but was organised on completely different principles. Its parish books were kept by Lutheran pastors who were, in effect, salaried state functionaries of the Kingdom of Prussia. Its schools, from the eighteenth century onward, were more directly under state supervision than the Catholic equivalents — Frederick the Great's compulsory primary-education edicts applied here in a way they did not in the ecclesiastical principality next door. Its welfare system was integrated more directly into Prussian state administration. Its land tenure was Prussian-administrative — more standardised inheritance, fewer of the elaborate quasi-feudal arrangements that the Catholic Prince-Bishopric had inherited from its monastic foundations. Its holiday calendar was the spare Lutheran one — Christmas, Easter, Pentecost, Trinity Sunday, no processions, no Marian feasts, sober churches, white-walled and unornamented inside.

A child born in Glandorf in 1800 and a child born in Blasheim in 1800 thus grew up not merely in two

confessions but in two entire social systems. They went to different schools that taught different catechisms in slightly different German. They worked the land under different tenure arrangements. They were buried in different cemeteries with different rituals. When they died, they were entered in different books that travelled, eventually, to different archives. A genealogist working in the present has to know which system to look in: the Bistumsarchiv in Osnabrück holds the Catholic records; the Landeskirchliches Archiv der Evangelischen Kirche von Westfalen in Bielefeld holds the Protestant ones; and there is no point asking either archive for the records of the other.



The two land systems

The economic separation was as deep as the religious one and is the part of the picture most often missed by readers who think of pre-industrial rural Westphalia as a single landscape.

In the Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück, the dominant pattern was the *Markenrecht* — communal grazing and woodland rights shared between full-farmers (*Vollerben*), half-farmers (*Halberben*), and quarter-farmers (*Markötter*) of the village — overlaid with the *Heuerling* system that emerged in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries as the population grew faster than the land could absorb. A Heuerling was a landless tenant who rented a cottage and a small parcel from a larger farm in exchange for labour at harvest, in the planting season, and in haymaking. Heuerlinge produced their own food from their kitchen garden and a single rented field. They survived the rest of the year by weaving linen on the home loom during winter, and — most distinctively — by walking each spring to the Netherlands for paid agricultural labour. This phenomenon, *Hollandgängerei*, became so regular that

whole village economies depended on it; the Heuerlinge walked west in April, harvested for Dutch farmers through the summer, and walked back east in October with their season's wages sewn into their coat linings. They were Catholic men, mostly young, who returned each autumn to the parish books of their birth to baptise the children their wives had borne them while they were away.

The Protestant Minden side had no precise equivalent. Its agricultural economy was structured around a more rigid Prussian-administrative inheritance — the *Anerbenrecht*, in which one heir (usually the oldest son or, in some districts, the youngest) inherited the undivided farm and the other children received a small cash settlement and were expected to find their own way. This produced a different demographic pressure. In the Catholic Heuerling system, surplus population could in principle be absorbed by subdividing rented parcels and by the *Hollandgängerei* labour migration. In the Protestant Prussian system, surplus children were structurally displaced earlier and more cleanly. They emigrated to Prussian cities, joined the army, or — in the nineteenth century — crossed the Atlantic in different patterns, less concentrated than the Catholic emigrations and less attached to particular destination communities.

The two economic systems thus produced two different emigration patterns when the nineteenth century arrived. The Catholic Osnabrücker emigration of the 1830s and 1840s went, overwhelmingly and in connected family groups, to specific Catholic-German destinations in the United States: Cincinnati, then westward into the small Catholic farming communities of Ohio's Auglaize and Putnam counties — Glandorf, Fort Jennings, Delphos — where the German Catholic parishes the emigrants founded replicated the confessional structures they had

left behind. The Protestant Minden emigration was more scattered, less anchored to particular destinations, and demographically slower to build. We will follow both in the chapters of Part 2.



The Atlantic exception that wasn't

It is tempting to imagine that emigration to America broke the confessional logic that the Peace of Westphalia had built. It did not. The Catholic Osnabrücker who arrived in Cincinnati in 1838 and was directed by an agent of the German Catholic Society to a wagon party heading north-west into the Ohio woods toward an unbroken German Catholic settlement at Glandorf was being routed, with great efficiency, into a confessional community that mapped his original parish forward across the Atlantic. He went to Mass in German with other Westphalians on Sunday mornings. He married the daughter of an emigrant from a Catholic parish in Münster or Paderborn or — if she was available — from his own original parish at home. He was buried in a Catholic cemetery whose oldest stones bore the names of farmers from villages he had grown up calling neighbours.

The mathematics of his marriage choices on the Ohio frontier were, in confessional terms, almost identical to the mathematics of his marriage choices in Westphalia. He had not escaped his confession; he had relocated it.

The Protestant Mindener who left in the same decades for the United States found a different American religious landscape and slotted into it differently. He went, more often, to mixed-Protestant communities — Pennsylvania, the upper Midwest, eventually Wisconsin and Iowa — where intermarriage between Lutherans, Reformed, and various other Protestant denominations was already common in the second generation. The Protestant Westphalian abroad assimilated faster, in confessional terms, than the Catholic Westphalian

abroad. He was less likely to live in a community that retained its German liturgical practices for a hundred years; less likely to be buried under a stone in the language he had been baptised in. The seal that bound him was looser to begin with, and the New World loosened it further.

The Atlantic, in other words, did not abolish the confessional border between Catholic Osnabrück and Protestant Minden. It moved it. Some of it crossed; some of it stayed home; both halves continued to operate roughly as they had operated since 1648, with the Catholic side maintaining its institutional density and the Protestant side dispersing more freely. When their descendants eventually intermarried on either side of the Atlantic, those intermarriages would be, statistically, late — twentieth century, mostly post-war.



The mathematics of the seal

The strongest evidence that the seal really held, and was not merely a historian's stereotype, comes from the pedigrees themselves.

Take the documented family tree of any modern descendant whose paternal line traces to the Catholic Osnabrück villages and whose maternal line traces to the Protestant Minden countryside. Compute the inbreeding coefficient F between the two halves — that is, the probability that an allele picked at random from the paternal half and an allele picked at random from the maternal half are identical by descent from a common ancestor recorded somewhere in the documented genealogy. The math is not difficult; the result in a case like this one is striking.

F comes out, in the documented portion of the pedigree, essentially zero.

This is not a normal result. Most European pedigrees, when computed this way, show a small but non-zero F — common ancestors at some genealogical depth, usually six to ten generations back, accumulating contributions to the inbreeding coefficient that add up to a small but measurable value. Geographically adjacent populations, in particular, almost always share ancestors at this depth. The absence of any measurable F between two adjacent regional populations is, in genealogical terms, a finding. It means that the populations did not mix at the level the records can see. It means that whatever mixing occurred is older than the documented genealogy — older, in this case, than the Peace of Westphalia itself — or, in the recent generations, more recent than the marriages that produced the descendants in question.

There is more to say about this finding — about what it means for the modern shape of the pedigree, about how it constrains the conclusions one can draw from twenty-first-century DNA matches, and about what it implies for the demographic history of the region. Part 4 of this book will take it up systematically. For the purposes of this chapter, it is enough to record that the historical claim and the mathematical claim line up. The Catholic Osnabrück population and the Protestant Minden-Lübbecke population, in the documented portion of one family's pedigree, do not converge anywhere. Two populations, thirty-five kilometres apart. Three centuries of institutional separation. One number, and the number is zero.



The marriage that ended it

Three hundred years of confessional endogamy do not, in the end, end with a treaty or a reform or a movement. They end, in this family's case, with a single marriage in the second half of the twentieth century. A son of the Catholic Osnabrück Kovermann line married

a daughter of the Protestant Minden-Lübbecke Rustmeier line. The marriage produced a child. The child is the descendant in whose pedigree the F-value of zero, that ancient seal, is recorded — and through whom, going forward, the seal cannot persist. The marriage was not a scandal. By the 1960s, in West Germany, confessional intermarriage between Catholics and Lutherans no longer required dispensations and no longer attracted parish notice. The two participants would have understood themselves as marrying a person, not a denomination. Their parents may have remembered the older configuration; their grandparents almost certainly did. By the great-grandparents' generation, the marriage would have been unimaginable in either direction. It was not their fault that they ended a three-hundred-year arrangement. They simply lived in the first generation that no longer felt it as a constraint.

This is how the long confessional structures of early-modern Europe ended in this region: not with abolition, but with attrition. The Reformation and the Counter-Reformation and the Peace of Westphalia had built two sealed worlds, and the wars of the twentieth century had displaced enough people, secularised enough households, and broken enough local marriage networks that by the time of the West German *Wirtschaftswunder* the seal was no longer a seal but a custom, and customs can be set aside without anyone making a decision.



What the chapter wants to leave with the reader

Two regions, two confessions, two complete and parallel social systems, two economic logics, two emigration patterns, two parish-book archives, and one number — zero — that ties the historical description and the genealogical mathematics together. This is the structural fact this book rests on. Almost every family history this book will subsequently tell is a story occurring on one side or the other of a line drawn in

1648, and the people the chapters will follow are people who lived inside one of the two sealed worlds and assumed it to be the whole of the world, and who married, baptised, and buried within it.

The wall came down in one specific marriage in the late twentieth century. The mathematics will continue to register the wall for as long as there are descendants whose great-great-grandparents lived in the closed populations the wall produced. The wall is gone, but its shadow in the data will outlast everyone now alive. The two worlds it divided were the world that was about to leave, and the world that was about to be lost.

Chapter 3

Sealed Worlds

In the spring of 1742, in the village of Glandorf in the Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück, a parish priest entered into his death register the following burial notice for a woman named Barbara Hanesch:

Diese alte gute Colona war Urgroßmutter und Mutter von 75 Kindern und Kindeskindern, deren noch 60 am Leben sind.

This good old farmwife was great-grandmother and mother of seventy-five children and grandchildren, of whom sixty are still alive.

The entry is unusual for the time and place in two ways. Most parish death entries of the period give only the name, the date, the age, and — sometimes — a cause. The priest in Glandorf, evidently moved by Barbara Hanesch's life or perhaps by the fact that he had personally officiated at sacraments for so many of her descendants, broke from the form and recorded a small biographical tribute. The second unusual thing is the number. Seventy-five descendants. Sixty alive at her death. A single Catholic farmwife in a Westphalian village in the first half of the eighteenth century produced and survived in a household whose demographic footprint, by the time she died, extended through perhaps thirty separate cottages in a single parish.

What made that possible was the structure of the world the families inhabited. The structure of the Catholic Osnabrück village — the way it absorbed children, the way it allocated land, the way it sent its surplus young men westward to the Dutch farms in summer and east to the Atlantic ports a hundred years later — is one of the two sealed social worlds that the previous chapter described. The Protestant Minden village, thirty-five kilometres north on the other side of the Wiehengebirge, ran on different principles and produced a different demographic shape. Both worlds will be visible in this

chapter at the level at which they were actually lived: the cottage, the field, the wagon road, the Sunday Mass or service, the seasonal walk westward to the Netherlands or northward to Minden's barracks, the cooking fire and the linen loom in the winter months when the snow closed the roads and the outside work stopped.

By the time the steamship agents arrived in the 1830s with their pamphlets advertising cheap passages to Cincinnati and Baltimore, both worlds had been operating for almost two hundred years. Both were under strain. The exits to America that the next part of the book follows were not opportunistic adventures; they were demographic releases. To understand them, one has to understand the systems that had produced them — and to understand the systems, one has to begin at the level of the *Hof*.



The four ranks of the Catholic village

A Westphalian Catholic village of the eighteenth century did not have a population of farmers in the modern sense — that is, of independent landholders working their own fields. It had a population of *Bauern* in a quite precise legal sense, stratified into ranks that determined what land a man could work, what cottage he could live in, what obligations he owed, and what marriages he could realistically expect to make. The ranks were old; they had been visible in the late medieval period and would persist, in attenuated form, into the early twentieth century.

At the top of the village stood the *Vollerben* — the full-farmers. A *Vollerbe* held a *Vollhof*, a complete farm with a substantial farmhouse and outbuildings, enough arable land to support an extended family and a hired team, share rights in the village's communal forest and grazing lands (the *Mark*), and an obligation to provide labour services, taxes, or rent in kind to whichever lord owned the underlying title. A village of three or four hundred

souls might have eight or ten *Vollerben*. They sat in the front pews on Sunday. Their farms were known by name — *Schulte-So-and-so*, *Meyer zu Such-and-such* — and the names attached to the *Hof* rather than to the family living on it, so that a man marrying into a *Vollhof* might take the farm's name in place of his own. Anna Maria *genannt Räuwer*, the illegitimate child with whom Chapter 1 began, was identified by such a *Hofname*: her birth was recorded as belonging to Haus 23, the *Räuwer* farm, not to her mother's family of origin.

Below the *Vollerben* stood the *Halberben* — half-farmers, holding roughly half a *Vollhof*, with proportional rights in the *Mark* and proportional obligations to the holding lord. Below them again, the *Markötter* and *Kötter* — cottagers — held small cottages with kitchen gardens and very limited arable, often no share in the *Mark* at all. And below all of these, by the late seventeenth century, a fourth and growing rank had emerged for which the village had had no traditional place: the *Heuerlinge*. The word means simply “hirelings” — people who rented (*heuern*) their housing and a small parcel of land from one of the established farms, in exchange for cash, labour, or both.

The *Heuerlinge* were the demographic safety valve of the Catholic Westphalian system. As populations grew through the long peace of the eighteenth century, *Vollhöfe* and *Halbhöfe* did not subdivide. Inheritance custom, supported by the practical fact that a farm small enough to subdivide was a farm too small to support anyone, gave the holding to a single heir — typically the eldest son, although some districts preferred the youngest. The other children of a *Vollerbe* did not inherit. They had three options: to marry into another farm (which a few did, particularly daughters); to enter the church or the religious orders (which a steady trickle did, sons and daughters both); or to step down a rank and

become *Heuerlinge*, renting from their better-positioned relatives the cottages and parcels their grandfathers' generation had never imagined needing to rent. By 1800, in many Catholic Osnabrück villages, the *Heuerling* households outnumbered the established *Vollerben* and *Halberben* combined.



The Heuerling year

A *Heuerling* family lived in a small cottage — a *Heuerhaus*, often built in the half-timbered style that the Westphalian carpenters had perfected over four centuries, with oak-frame construction so precise that the cottages could in principle be dismantled and rebuilt elsewhere without nails. The cottage typically had a single living room with a hearth, a sleeping area for the parents, a small loft for the children, and an attached space for one or two animals — usually a cow and a few chickens. Behind the cottage stood a kitchen garden of perhaps half a hectare, intensively cultivated for the family's vegetables and herbs. The *Heuerling's* rented field — perhaps two or three hectares — lay scattered in two or three parcels somewhere on the holding farm's land, often the steepest or stoniest fields the *Vollerbe* did not particularly want to work himself. A *Heuerling* could not survive on this land. The arable was too small, the soil often too poor, the tax and rent burden too constant. So the *Heuerling* household ran on three economies in parallel.

The first was subsistence farming. The kitchen garden produced potatoes from the late eighteenth century onward (the crop having been introduced to Westphalia by Prussian decree in the 1750s and adopted, with initial reluctance, over the following decades), as well as cabbage, beans, beets, turnips, herbs, and whatever fruit the family could keep through winter as preserves. The two or three rented fields produced rye and oats — rye for the family's daily bread, oats for the cow and for

porridge in the lean months — and sometimes flax for linen. The cow gave milk, which the wife rendered into butter and a hard cheese that could be kept for months in the cool of the cottage cellar. Chickens gave eggs. A pig was slaughtered each November when the cold had set in, and its smoked and salted parts hung from the kitchen rafters and provided the family's meat through the next year.

The second economy was linen weaving. Through the winter — November to March, when the fields were closed and the cottage was warm only when the fire was lit — the *Heuerling* household worked on the home loom. Westphalian linen, woven from local flax that the family had spun in the long evenings of the previous autumn, was a recognised export commodity throughout the eighteenth century. Itinerant Catholic merchants from the linen-trading towns of Mettingen, Recke, and Hopsten walked from cottage to cottage in early spring buying the winter's production and carrying it to Münster, Bielefeld, and Amsterdam for resale. A skilled *Heuerling* family could clear, in a good winter, enough cash from the linen merchants to cover the year's rent and tax obligations. In bad winters, when the flax harvest had been poor or the European linen market depressed, they fell behind, and the holding farmer extended credit against next summer's labour.

The third economy — and the one that gave the Catholic Osnabrück village its distinctive character — was the *Hollandgängerei*.



Hollandgang

Each year in early April, when the spring planting on the *Heuerling's* own rented fields had been completed and the demands of the home farm could be deferred for a few months, somewhere between a fifth and a

third of the adult male *Heuerlinge* of every Catholic Osnabrücker village walked westward to the Netherlands. They walked in groups, often along the same routes their fathers and grandfathers had walked, carrying linen knapsacks with a change of clothing, a knife, a wooden spoon, a pipe, a small loaf of rye bread, and — in their inside coat pockets — copies of their baptismal certificates as proof of identity to Dutch employers who liked to know who was on their farms. They walked across the Dutch border at one of a handful of well-known crossings — north toward Coevorden, west toward Almelo and Hengelo, south-west toward Winterswijk — and dispersed across the great wheat-, hay-, and dairy-producing regions of the eastern and northern Netherlands, where the Dutch farmers had for generations relied on Catholic Westphalian seasonal labour for their grass and grain harvests, their peat-cutting, their hay-mowing, their lime-burning, and the long summer task of brick-making for the Amsterdam construction industry. They were called, by the Dutch, *moffen* and *koffiemoffen* — the former a derogatory term for any German, the latter a more specific name for the Westphalian seasonal labourers who became famous in the Dutch farming country for the quantity of coffee they were prepared to drink during the working day. They worked through the Dutch summer in arrangements that were unwritten and customary but well understood on both sides: room and board provided by the employer, wages paid in cash at the season's end, the labourer free to walk home in October with the year's earnings sewn into the linings of his coat.

The *Hollandgang* had begun, on a small scale, in the seventeenth century. It reached its peak in the early nineteenth, when somewhere between thirty and forty thousand Westphalian seasonal labourers crossed each summer in the same direction, almost all of them Catholic, almost all of them young or middle-aged men

from *Heuerling* households. It declined gradually through the nineteenth century as Dutch farms mechanised and as the same Catholic Westphalian *Heuerlinge* increasingly chose Atlantic emigration over a return to the home cottage. By 1900 it was a memory; by 1914 it was over.

For the women who stayed behind, the *Hollandgang* shaped the year in ways the parish books preserve only by indirection. Children were baptised in disproportionate numbers in the first three months of the year — the result of summer reunions that began the previous October. Marriages were concentrated in February and early November, the windows of the year when both partners were certain to be at home. Deaths in summer, particularly of children, often had to be registered in the absence of the father; the priest noted these absences in his ledger and left them unexplained. A *Heuerling* widow was a recognisable category in the village — a woman whose husband had walked west one April and not returned in October, having died of illness or accident on a Dutch farm too far away for word to come home in time for a body to be brought back. She would receive what help the parish could offer, and she would either remarry or join the household of an adult child, and the cottage would be re-rented by the holding farmer to whichever younger family of *Heuerlinge* needed it next.

The *Hollandgang* and the linen loom and the kitchen garden together kept the Catholic *Heuerling* system in balance for almost two centuries. Each year, surplus labour walked west and brought back cash; each winter, surplus time produced linen the merchants converted to more cash; the cottage absorbed children at a rate the village land could not have absorbed on its own. By the 1820s, the balance was failing.



The patchwork of ownership

One question this chapter has so far postponed is who, in the legal sense, *owned* the land on which the Catholic Westphalian *Heuerlinge* worked. The answer is that almost no one owned it in any way a modern reader would recognise as ownership. The Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück was, in the eighteenth century, one of the most institutionally complex small territories in Europe, and its land titles reflected six centuries of accumulated grants, divisions, exchanges, and outright impositions.

The cathedral chapter of Osnabrück owned a substantial portion of the arable land in the surrounding villages — perhaps a third, in some districts more. Catholic monasteries and convents owned another considerable portion: the Benedictine abbey of Iburg, the Benedictine convent of Malgarten, the *Reichsstift* of Quernheim (a secular foundation for unmarried noblewomen of the high nobility, who held lands across the region and rented them out to villages that had no direct relationship with the foundation itself). Local noble families held estates that had been granted to their ancestors in the late medieval period: the Drostes zu Vischering at Hitzhausen, the von Dincklages of Melle, the von Vincke estate at Dröper, the von Moltkes who held Sutthausen south of the city, and a half-dozen others. The Prince-Bishop himself — whether the Catholic incumbent or, in the alternating Lutheran years, the Hanoverian appointee — held the *Tafelgüter*, the demesne lands attached directly to the bishopric. The city of Osnabrück, as a municipal corporation, held lands of its own. The parish churches held smaller endowments to support their priests. Free farms, owned outright by the *Vollerbe* and his heirs, existed but were the exception rather than the rule.

A single Catholic Osnabrücker village in 1750 might therefore contain *Vollhöfe* held under five or six different lords, with five or six different sets of rent obligations, five or six different feast-day labour expectations, five or six different inheritance customs to navigate. A *Heuerling* renting from a *Vollerbe* whose underlying lord was the cathedral chapter owed his labour service to the cathedral through the *Vollerbe*; a *Heuerling* renting from a *Vollerbe* whose lord was Quernheim owed his to the seminary; and the two cottages might stand on the same village lane. The system was not exactly chaotic — every party knew what was owed to whom and when — but it was so dense and so historically encrusted that no one outside the village could readily make sense of it. The reforms of the early nineteenth century, when the Code Napoléon temporarily and Prussian administrative law subsequently and permanently flattened these arrangements into a uniform private property regime, would feel to many Catholic Westphalians like a relief and to others like a quiet destruction of the world they had grown up in.

The Prussian Protestant county of Minden, on the other side of the Wiehengebirge, had its own patchwork — the Hanoverian crown, the Brandenburg-Prussian state administration, several smaller estates, the church glebes — but in a much simpler form. After the Peace of Westphalia, Minden's monasteries had been secularised, its convents dissolved, its ecclesiastical estates absorbed into the new Protestant state administration. The patchwork that survived was newer, fewer-fingered, and more directly controlled. When Conrad Rustmeier's father Anton served on the *Vollhof* at Obermehnen in the late eighteenth century, the *Hof* was held under the *Reichsstift* of Quernheim — one of the few medieval Catholic foundations that had survived on the Protestant side of the ridge — and the family's status, in the

genealogical record, is recorded as *Eigenbehörige* of the seminary. *Eigenbehörige* is the polite word the records use. The blunter word, which would have applied to Anton Rustmeier in any honest accounting, was *Leibeigene*. He was a serf.

This is the texture that the previous chapter's larger argument descends into when one looks closely. The Catholic Osnabrück system was a dense web of small obligations spread across many landlords. The Protestant Minden system was a thinner web spread across fewer landlords, more administratively standardised but in some respects materially harsher: the *Vollhof* serf of a single Hanoverian foundation had no leverage at all, where the *Heuerling* of a dozen Osnabrück landlords could sometimes play one obligation against another. Neither was free. Both produced the demographic pressure that, by the 1830s, would send some of their children westward across an ocean.



The Sunday calendar

What both villages shared, despite the confessional separation Chapter 2 described, was the structuring weight of the church year as the calendar of social life. A Catholic Osnabrücker week was built around Sunday Mass. A Protestant Mindener week was built around Sunday service. The two services differed materially — in length, in liturgical content, in vestments, in the position of the altar, in the use of incense and the saints' calendar and the elaborate apparatus of Catholic sacramental life — and yet they performed the same village function: they assembled the population in a public place once a week, they reaffirmed the order of the community, and they provided the central social occasion at which marriages were proposed, deaths were mourned, godparents were chosen, and the

village's collective judgement on its members was quietly and continually rendered.

The Catholic year added to this weekly structure a much more elaborate seasonal one. The first of November — *Allerheiligen*, All Saints' Day — brought the entire Catholic Westphalian population to the cemeteries to tend the graves of their dead, to light candles, to lay wreaths of evergreen and the last chrysanthemums of the season, and to renew the sense of intergenerational continuity that the parish books had been recording for two hundred years. The descendant of a *Heuerling* family in the present century who travels to a Catholic Osnabrücker village cemetery on the first of November will find a ritual still being performed essentially as it has been performed since the seventeenth century, though the participants now drive rather than walk and the families have shrunk and most of the surnames have changed. Corpus Christi in May or June brought a village procession with the host carried in a monstrance under a canopy, four men of substance taking turns to hold the canopy poles, and the village's children scattering rose petals along the route. The feast days of locally favoured saints — the village patron, the regional patron, the saints whose intercession had been credited with the cessation of a particular plague or a particular harvest failure — punctuated the year at intervals that gave the *Heuerling* household its rhythm of rest, ceremony, and recommitment.

The Protestant calendar was bare by comparison. Christmas, Easter, Pentecost, Trinity Sunday, the Reformation Day on the thirty-first of October. No processions, no Marian feasts, no elaborate cycle of patron saints, no rose-petal-scattering children. The church interior was whitewashed and unornamented; the pastor preached in black; the central act of worship was the sermon rather than the consecration of the elements. To a Catholic Osnabrücker who happened to attend a

Protestant Mindener service, the experience would have been disorienting in roughly the same way that a Mindener at a Glandorf Corpus Christi procession would have found the Catholic ritual disorienting. Each side knew the other existed. Each side had little practical experience of what attendance on the other side felt like, because almost no one ever attended on the other side.

This is what is meant by *sealed worlds*. Not that the populations did not know about each other — they knew very well — but that the ordinary texture of daily life inside each world was so complete, so self-sufficient, and so heavily structured by inherited custom that there was no practical pressure on anyone to inhabit any of it differently. A *Heuerling* in Glandorf in 1810 lived the year he had been raised to live, in the cottage rank he had been born into, in the calendar his parish maintained, on the rented field his holding *Vollerbe* assigned him, weaving through the winter, walking to the Netherlands in summer, baptising his children in the parish church and burying his parents in its cemetery. A serf on the Damenstift of Quernheim's farm at Obermehnen in the same year lived a parallel life with different ranks, a different calendar, a different ratio of obligations, a different patron lord, and a different church. Neither would have understood his life as constrained, because neither had imagined any other.



The thinning

The system in both villages, having reached its eighteenth-century equilibrium, began to fail in the first third of the nineteenth.

On the Catholic Osnabrück side, the failure was demographic and economic at once. Population growth through the long peace had filled the *Heuerling* cottages and then overfilled them. Linen prices, which had

supported the *Heuerling* winter for two centuries, collapsed as British industrial cotton displaced Westphalian hand-loomed linen in the European markets after 1815. The *Hollandgängerei*, still substantial in 1820, began to provide thinner margins as Dutch farmers mechanised their harvests and reduced the demand for seasonal hands. The secularisation of the cathedral chapter and the monastic foundations after 1803 had reorganised the ownership of the land but had not increased the amount of arable available to the village. By the late 1820s, in the Catholic villages on the southern side of the Wiehengebirge, the number of *Heuerling* households exceeded what the local economy could sustain even in a good year, and the catastrophic European harvest failures of 1816 (the year without a summer, following the eruption of Mount Tambora) and 1846 to 1847 (the *Hungerjahre* that also produced the Irish famine) demonstrated that bad years were now occasionally fatal.

On the Protestant Minden side, the failure was different in character but similar in timing. The Prussian state's standardised inheritance laws had always concentrated the *Vollhof* with a single heir; the surplus children in the Protestant villages had traditionally migrated to Prussian cities, joined the army, or — through the eighteenth century — entered Prussian state service in some form. By the 1820s, all three of those outlets were under pressure. The Prussian cities were absorbing more migrants than they could provide work for. The standing army was contracting in the long peace after Waterloo. State service was constricted by the financial weakness of the post-Napoleonic Prussian government. The Protestant Mindener surplus children had fewer exits than they had had a generation earlier, and the same European harvest failures fell on them as on their Catholic neighbours.

In both villages, by the late 1830s, families that had survived inside their respective systems for ten and twelve generations began to send children westward in a direction they had never previously considered. Agents of the Bremen and Hamburg shipping lines arrived with pamphlets in German, with promises of cheap passage to Baltimore and New Orleans and New York, with stories of available land in a place called Ohio. The Catholic Osnabrücker *Heuerling* families read the pamphlets with the practical realism their *Hollandgang* tradition had bred into them — they had been sending men westward to make a living for two hundred years already, and the difference between walking to a Dutch farm for the summer and crossing an ocean to a forested farm in Ohio was, from a certain angle, only a question of distance. The Protestant Mindener families, who had no such tradition and who had always sent their surplus to Prussian cities, came to the same decision more slowly and in smaller numbers, but they came to it as well.

The next part of this book follows what they did when they got on the ships. The chapter that follows this one returns to the question of who was already missing from the villages they left — the two Conrads, the demographic vacuum the Napoleonic wars had created, the world that was about to leave because the world that had already left had taken so much of it. Together the three chapters of Part 1 describe the world the Atlantic crossings of the 1830s and 1840s were leaving: two sealed worlds, both thinning, both governed by inherited custom that no longer quite worked, and both populated by families that had been rendered exportable by the systems they had been built inside.

Barbara Hanesch of Glandorf, with her seventy-five descendants in 1742, could not have foreseen any of this. By 1842, exactly a hundred years after her death, the great-grandchildren and great-great-grandchildren

whose names would have filled half her own parish's marriage register were beginning to appear, instead, in the marriage registers of the German Catholic parish at Glandorf, Ohio, ten thousand kilometres west of the cottage she had died in. The system that had absorbed her seventy-five into a single village had, three generations later, started exporting them.

Chapter 4

On the Wrong Side, 1791-1842

The parish books of Blasheim are exact. They have to be: a farming community of a few hundred souls in the rolling country east of Minden does not have so many sons that any can be lost without notice. When Anton Rustmeier, Prussian infantryman turned serf of the Damenstift of Quernheim, buried his three children — a three-year-old in 1783, an infant of five months in 1797, an eleven-year-old in 1801 — the priest recorded each death with the cadence the village expected: the date, the name, the age, the cause when one was guessable. The volumes are still in the archive at Minden. They have been digitised. Anyone can read them.

The death that should have rounded out the family's losses is not there. Conrad Friedrich August Rustmeier, baptised in the same church on the twenty-first of March 1788 with the names of neighbours whose lines still run through the parish — Warmann, Triesebaum, Jungemeier — has no death entry in Blasheim. He has no marriage entry. He has no burial. He vanishes from his own records in the autumn of 1812 and never returns. His mother lives another ten years and dies in 1822 knowing that no answer is coming. His brothers continue to farm in Obermehnen and are themselves buried, in proper form, decades later. The family persists. Conrad does not.

This chapter is about Conrad and another man of his exact generation who survived but is missing in a different way — Conrad von Salzen, born 1774 in Wulmstorf in the Electorate of Hanover, died 1842 in Hameln as a cook in the local penal workhouse. Both men served armies that disappeared. Both men are missing from the heroic story that German nationalism would tell about the years between Napoleon's invasion and Napoleon's defeat. They are missing from that story not

by accident, but because the story did not have room for them. One fought for the wrong side. The other served a kingdom that simply dissolved one summer afternoon and never reformed in time to have him back.

The villages remembered both men, in fragments, because the parish books did. The nation forgot them entirely.



Conrad Rustmeier and the blood tax

To understand why a farmer's son from Obermehren was conscripted in 1812 into a French line-infantry regiment commanded by a colonel from Strasbourg, one has to understand that *Germany* was, at that moment, not a country. The Holy Roman Empire had abdicated in 1806 — the thousand-year arrangement of small states and free cities dissolved by the same Napoleon whose forces had been clearing them out for a decade. In its place west of the Rhine sat French *départements*; east of the Rhine, the Confederation of the Rhine — sixteen and eventually thirty-six German states bound by treaty to the French emperor, militarily as well as politically. The Kingdom of Westphalia, ruled from Kassel by Napoleon's youngest brother Jérôme Bonaparte, was the largest of these. Conrad's village fell inside it. The Kingdom of Westphalia was, on paper, a model state. Serfdom was abolished. Religious equality was granted. A constitution was introduced. The Code Napoléon was applied. The Westphalian peasant was, in legal theory, freer in 1810 than he had been in 1790. But the same Kingdom had a different obligation that mattered more than any of its reforms: it owed soldiers. Napoleon's empire ran on conscription, and the *Blutsteuer* — the blood tax — fell on the satellite states heavier than on France itself. Westphalia, with a population of just over two million, was expected to provide twenty-five thousand men for the imperial wars.

The villages around Osnabrück and Minden and Bielefeld responded as villages have always responded to conscription. They desert. In the Weser Department alone, 1,580 men deserted in 1808, 698 in 1809, 688 in 1810. Of eight thousand Westphalians sent to fight in Spain, only eight hundred returned. Mothers and fathers hid sons; village elders falsified ages; magistrates lost paperwork. None of this was protest. There was no organised opposition to Napoleon in Westphalia in 1812 — the Catholic peasantry of Osnabrück and the Lutheran farmers of Minden-Lübbecke, who shared little else, shared a settled determination not to die for the emperor if it could possibly be avoided.

Conrad Rustmeier, twenty-four, could not avoid it. He was bound to the *Hof* — Farm No. 11, Obermehren — under the lingering serfdom of the Damenstift of Quernheim, which the Code Napoléon had formally abolished but which the reality of rural Westphalia had not. His father had served the Prussians honourably; his three siblings had died young; he was the surviving son. The conscription officers came to the village, and the village did not protect him.

He was assigned to the 127^e Régiment d'Infanterie de Ligne under Colonel Chrétien Henri Schaeffer, a professional soldier from Strasbourg who would later be made a brigadier general. The 127^e was not a peripheral unit. It marched with the *Grande Armée* into Russia in the summer of 1812. Six hundred and ten thousand men crossed the Niemen heading east. The regimental routes carried Conrad's unit through Smolensk, where the Russian scorched-earth tactic first became unmistakable; through Borodino on the seventh of September, where seventy thousand men fell in a single day; into Moscow, which was abandoned and burning when they arrived; and into the long catastrophe of the retreat — Maloyaroslavets, Vyazma, the freezing

crossing of the Bérésina in late November where the army disintegrated as an organised force. About a hundred and twenty thousand men eventually staggered back across the western frontier. For the Confederation of the Rhine contingents, who had been deployed at scale and held at the rear of the disintegration where they served as rearguards and were sacrificed accordingly, the proportion was crueller still: fewer than five thousand of the hundred thousand sent home survived.

Conrad was almost certainly among the dead. *Where* he died is not on any record. The 127^e Régiment ceased to exist as an effective unit somewhere between Smolensk and the Polish border in the winter of 1812–13. Its rolls were lost or destroyed in the same disintegration that killed its men. When the pastor of Blasheim wrote to the French military authorities in the months after the campaign, asking after his parishioners, he received in reply a phrase that he copied into the parish book and that has been quoted by every researcher who has touched the case since:

Beim 127ten Regiment angeblich.

Allegedly with the 127th Regiment.

It is an evasion dressed as a fact. The French army could not say where Conrad was because the French army no longer knew where any of its men were east of the Vistula. It substituted the words *angeblich* — *allegedly* — for the records it had lost or had never properly kept. The pastor wrote *Beim 127. Regiment angeblich* under Conrad's name in the parish ledger. The phrase has stood there for two hundred and twelve years.



The expedition

In 1818, six years after the disaster and three years after Waterloo, the new Prussian government — the Kingdom of Prussia having absorbed Westphalia at the Congress of Vienna — sent Lieutenant Heinrich Meier

eastward into the former war zone with a strictly administrative task: to determine the legal status of the missing. Without proof of death, widows could not remarry, inheritances could not be settled, mothers could not collect what little pension was available. The Prussian state needed paper. It sent one officer with a writing case to produce it.

Lieutenant Meier did better than his mandate required. He travelled alone across a devastated empire, searched hospitals and provincial archives and Russian military offices, gathered testimonies from survivors who had drifted home through Poland and Saxony, cross-checked stories against the ragged surviving fragments of regimental rolls. He came back with a list of three thousand three hundred and twenty-six names — three thousand three hundred and twenty-six Westphalian and Rhenish conscripts whose deaths he had been able to establish with enough confidence to register them for the state's purposes. The list is preserved in the *Landesarchiv NRW* and has been digitised; anyone can search it.

Conrad Rustmeier is not on it.

What Meier could not document, he did not invent — which is itself a small monument to a kind of integrity that the records of this period rarely show. He also returned with an unexpected discovery, which the Prussian state did not particularly want and the patriotic histories of the 1820s and 1830s did not write up: Germans were still alive in Russia. Some were prisoners-of-war who had been kept on as labour and would not be released for years; others had married Russian women, settled into Russian villages, and chosen not to come home. This second group — soldiers of the *Grande Armée* who had quietly become Russians — would foreshadow the much larger groups of German soldiers who would do the same thing, eventually, after a different war a hundred and thirty years later. In 1818 they were

inconvenient. The state was looking for the dead, not for absentees who had voluntarily slipped national identity. Meier recorded them and moved on.



The wrong side

Here is the structural fact about Conrad Rustmeier that the parish books cannot say but that every history of the period takes for granted: he had been on the wrong side.

The Prussian veterans of 1813–1815, men who had fought *against* Napoleon at Leipzig and at Belle Alliance and in the long campaign through France, came home to a Prussia eager to honour them. Their regiments were given battle streamers; their stories were collected; their names appeared on the modest stone monuments that began to go up in the larger German cities and in some of the villages too. The veterans who had served in Britain's King's German Legion came back to a restored Kingdom of Hanover that placed them at the top of its reformed officer corps. Even those German conscripts who had served Napoleon and survived could claim, with some plausibility, that they had been coerced and that their hearts had always been with the eventual victors.

The dead conscripts of the *Grande Armée*, however, had no claim to make and no advocates to make it. They had not been liberated. They had not chosen their side. They had simply died for an empire that the next forty years of German nationalism would teach Germans to be glad they had been free of. In 1871, when the German states finally unified under Prussian leadership into the second German Empire, the founding national mythology — the *Befreiungskriege*, the Wars of Liberation against Napoleon — was already a half-century old and complete. It had clear heroes (Blücher, Yorck, Scharnhorst, Gneisenau) and clear villains (Napoleon, his marshals, the collaborationist princes of the Rhineland). It did not

have any conceptual room for Conrad Rustmeier of Obermehnen, who had served honourably and died miserably for the wrong emperor under the wrong colours.

So he was allowed to fade. The fading was effortless. The Blasheim parish books were never going to enter the national archive. The phrase *beim 127. Regiment angeblich* was never going to be inscribed on a monument. His mother died in 1822 with no headstone to visit, and his brothers continued to farm at Obermehnen as if he had never been born, except that they too were missing a brother, and somewhere in the next generation's silence and unmarried sisters and absent uncles, the village's experience of having lost a son to the wrong side persisted, undiscussed, into the present.



Conrad von Salzen and the kingdom that dissolved

Two hundred kilometres to the north-west and fourteen years older, the second Conrad of this chapter was in 1797 a Lutheran grenadier of the Electorate of Hanover, serving the 2^e Infantry Regiment "Prinz Friedrich" under General-Major Carl Gustav von Issendorf at Osnabrück. The regiment was one of the most peculiar military entities in Europe. Its soldiers were Lower Saxon farm boys; its officers spoke German; its discipline followed Prussian patterns; and its ultimate sovereign was George III, King of Great Britain and Ireland, who held the Electorate of Hanover by inheritance and ran it through a regency. Conrad's regimental colours acknowledged a British prince. His ration book was paid for from a budget signed in London. He had never been to England and would never go.

This impossible double identity worked, for nine decades after the Hanoverian Succession of 1714, because nothing was asked of it. The personal union between

Britain and Hanover was a constitutional convenience, not a fighting alliance. Hanoverian regiments fought their own wars — Austrian Succession, Seven Years' War (including the same Battle of Minden in 1759³ that the Rustmeiers a few villages away remembered with such pride), the American Revolutionary War — under their own command, in their own theatres. As long as the French stayed west of the Rhine and the Russians stayed east of the Vistula, this arrangement was indistinguishable from any other small German state's military life.

It worked until the fifth of July 1803⁴.

On that day, in a small village on the lower Elbe called Artlenburg, the Hanoverian commander-in-chief — General of Cavalry Johann Ludwig von Wallmoden-Gimborn — signed a convention dictated to him by the French general Mortier. The terms were total. The Hanoverian Army would be dissolved. The fortresses would be surrendered. French troops would occupy the territory. There was no fight, because Hanover had been militarily indefensible against the French Empire for several years and Wallmoden-Gimborn knew it. There was no resistance, because George III was in London and Hanover had no functioning government of its own. There was, simply, a signature, and a kingdom ceased to have an army.

³ Battle of Minden, 1 August 1759; Anglo-German forces under Ferdinand of Brunswick defeated a French army under the Marquis de Contades. The Hanoverian infantry played a central role. *Wikipedia*, "Battle of Minden" (consulted May 2026).

⁴ Convention of Artlenburg (*Konvention von Artlenburg* or *Elbkonvention*), signed 5 July 1803 at Artlenburg on the Elbe by the Hanoverian commander-in-chief Johann Ludwig von Wallmoden-Gimborn and the French General Mortier. *Wikipedia*, "Convention of Artlenburg" (consulted May 2026).

For Conrad von Salzen — Grenadier, matriculation number 317 on the muster roll of the 1st Battalion, height five feet eleven inches, faith Lutheran, recruited 1 August 1797 in Osnabrück — the news arrived in the form of an electoral order discharging him along with a larger group of soldiers on the twenty-ninth of April 1801, two years before the formal dissolution. He had served three years and eight months. He had no pension. He had a Hanoverian uniform whose state no longer existed and a military skill set whose employer had vanished. He was twenty-seven.



The exit he did not take

His former officers — Major Colin Halkett, Colonel Johann Friedrich von der Decken, and others — chose the path that German military memory would later celebrate. They went to Britain. King George III, the dispossessed Elector of Hanover but still King of the United Kingdom, issued them warrants to raise a new force from the Hanoverian exiles. They called it, at first, the King's German Regiment, and then, as it expanded, the King's German Legion. Eight battalions of infantry, three cavalry regiments, supporting artillery: the Legion would fight with the British Army in the Peninsular War, in the Mediterranean, and finally — most famously — at Waterloo, where its defence of La Haye Sainte on the eighteenth of June 1815 became one of the legendary actions of European military history. The Legion's veterans came home in 1815 to a restored Kingdom of Hanover and walked straight into the senior officer corps of the new state's reformed army. They had served their legitimate sovereign continuously through the years of dispossession. They had liberated their homeland, in a strict and unambiguous sense, with British arms. The patriotic history of nineteenth-century Hanover would centre on them.

Conrad von Salzen did not take that exit. Whether by accident, or by financial necessity, or by a young man's instinct that the next thing on offer was probably no better than the last thing, he stayed in Hameln. He married, on the fifteenth of March 1801, a local woman named Catharine Elisabeth Kramer. He took work as a *Tagelöhner* — a day labourer, hired by the morning and paid by the evening, an occupation whose entire register is downward. He had six legitimate children over the next fifteen years and his name disappeared from the kind of records future historians would consult. He was no longer a grenadier. He was no longer in service to any state. He was a man in Hameln doing day labour, then institutional cooking, then dying in 1842 of typhoid fever in the *Strafarbeitshaus* — the penal workhouse where he had taken steady employment as cook because the soldier's discipline he had once carried qualified him to manage the rations of debtors and vagrants and petty criminals. The civil-registry entry for his death gives his occupation as *Koch im Strafarbeitshause*. It gives no military rank. The state that had recruited him at twenty-four had been forgotten.



The misremembered name

There is one thread in his story that the parish records preserve and the patriotic histories do not, and it sits exactly where Chapter 1 of this book left off — at the place where bureaucracy and personal knowledge fail to meet. Years before his Hameln marriage, in 1797, while still a Hanoverian grenadier garrisoned at Osnabrück, Conrad had fathered a child with a young woman in the city named Maria Elisabeth Flaspöhler. The child was a son. He was baptised in the Catholic parish of St. Johann. When Maria Elisabeth gave the priest the father's name, she did not say *von Salzen*. She said *Salzer*.

It is not clear whether she did not know the formal version, or whether she had heard it imperfectly, or whether the *von* — which in the Salzen case was a place-particle of obscure rural origin and not a marker of any nobility worth defending — had simply slipped out of speech because no one in her circle had ever used it. The priest wrote down what she said. The boy was registered as *Johann Henrich Salzer*. His mother was unmarried; the father, named but not present to confirm anything, did not appear in the entry except as a name supplied by the mother and accepted in good faith by the church.

This is exactly the kind of transcription this book began with: a record made by a priest writing down what a person told him, in a language the person sometimes used imperfectly, about a relationship the church did not formally recognise. The change from *von Salzen* to *Salzer* was not a flight from aristocracy and not a deliberate erasure. It was the friction of unscripted speech against an official form. And it became permanent, because no one with the standing to insist otherwise was in the room.

The boy grew up in Osnabrück. His mother stayed there; his father, from 1801 onward, was in Hameln with his legitimate wife and the rapidly growing household of six children that the Hameln civil records would track over the next fifteen years, and would not be heard from again in the St. Johann parish books. The Catholic registers of Osnabrück carried Johann Henrich Salzer forward — baptism, schooling, confirmation — into the working population of a city that was changing around him. By the time he reached early adulthood, the Electorate of Hanover had been French-occupied (1803), formally annexed into Jérôme Bonaparte's Kingdom of Westphalia (1810), and liberated again (1813) by a coalition that had at last turned on Napoleon. When the restored Kingdom of Hanover, after 1815, established a citizen-militia —

the *Landwehr* — to replace the professional army that had been dissolved at Artlenburg, Johann Henrich Salzer enrolled in the Osnabrück battalion. He served, as a part-time militiaman in the routine peacetime reserve, the kingdom that had failed to keep his father in service — in the same city where his father had once been a grenadier of the regiment “Prinz Friedrich.” His name was Salzer. There is no record of anyone in the family ever attempting to restore the *von*.

In 1816, a year after Waterloo, an Osnabrück merchant named G. F. v. Gülich paid out of his own pocket for the construction of a classical gate at the western edge of the city. The inscription on the *Heger Tor* dedicates the monument **“to the Osnabrück soldiers who demonstrated German courage at Waterloo on the eighteenth of June 1815”** — specifically, to the Landwehr battalions that had been mobilised in 1814 and 1815 for the coalition’s final campaign. Johann Henrich Salzer’s name is not on it. He had not been at Waterloo; he had enrolled in the same Landwehr a few years later, when the war was over, in the routine peacetime reserve that did not see combat and did not earn monuments. The Heger Tor stands a few streets from the parish records of St. Johann that named him at birth. It is one of Osnabrück’s most prominent landmarks. The parish records are in a basement.

The legitimate Hameln descendants of Conrad von Salzen scattered, as the children of day labourers tend to scatter — apprenticed out, married off, working their way across the Hanoverian countryside through the nineteenth century into other towns and other registers. The Osnabrück Salzer line stayed in the city and persisted. Through Johann Henrich and his children and his grandchildren and his great-grandchildren, the name and the line worked their way forward through the nineteenth century into the twentieth, intersecting in

time with the other Osnabrück lines this book will follow — the *Räuwer* household at Cappeln whom we met in Chapter 1, the *Kovermann* line of the surrounding parishes, and, by intermarriage and proximity over five generations, the *Rustmeier* line of the Minden countryside that this chapter opened with. The line that came down to the present, and that produced the descendant who eventually went looking for Conrad and found him only because of a marginal note next to his name in an Osnabrück parish register — *hannov. miles, Hanoverian soldier* — is the Salzer line. It is the line of the misremembered name.



What the myth refuses

The two stories close together. Conrad Rustmeier of Obermehnen died on the wrong side of Napoleon's war and was kept out of the German national story because the German national story did not have a category for soldiers who had died for the wrong empire. Conrad von Salzen of Wulmstorf served a kingdom that vanished and did not take the heroic exit to Waterloo, and was kept out of the German national story because the German national story celebrated those who had taken that exit and could not find a use for those who had stayed. One died at twenty-four in Russia. The other died at sixty-eight in a Hameln workhouse. Neither has a monument. Neither appears on the regimental rolls of the Prussian or Hanoverian armies in any context the patriotic histories of the 1820s through the 1880s thought worth printing. Both are entirely preserved in parish books.

That is the asymmetry this chapter wanted to name. The myths of national liberation, in the period immediately following 1815 and again at much higher pitch around the unification of 1871, did not have room for Germans who had served on the wrong side, or for Germans whose state had quietly evaporated without their permission, or for Germans whose military service had been completed

in the wrong uniform. The parish books had room for all of them, because the parish books had been designed for vital events rather than for narratives, and the events kept happening regardless of which side they happened on.

By the late 1830s, the demographic damage of the Napoleonic wars was a visible feature of every village in the region this book is concerned with. There were too few men of the right age. There were too many farms with no clear heir. There were unmarried sisters and widowed mothers and households held together by women whose sons or husbands had gone east in 1812 or west in 1803 or south in 1807 and never come home, or had come home so reduced that they could not resume the lives they had left. The villages were not in mourning, exactly. They had passed beyond mourning into a kind of administrative absence. The parish books recorded it. The national histories did not.

Into this thinned-out world, a generation later, the agents of the American steamship companies would arrive with their leaflets and their offers of cheap passage to a place called Ohio. The Atlantic crossings of the 1830s and 1840s — the great Westphalian and Hanoverian emigrations that the next chapters of this book will follow — did not begin in opportunity. They began in vacuum. The first chapter of those crossings had already been written, in a different alphabet, on the road back from Moscow in the winter of 1812.

Chapter 5

The Crossing

On the first of July 1838, in the village of Hitzhausen near Ostercappeln in the Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück, the registry of the Kingdom of Hanover accepted a formal application for emigration filed by Gerhard Heinrich Redeker, then forty-two, a tenant farmer with a wife, several young daughters, and a particular family obligation. The obligation was to bring his elderly father and his father's second wife to North America with him. The application was approved. The family began closing up the cottage they had been renting and selling what could not travel. By mid-July they were on a wagon north toward Bremen.

By mid-July they were on a wagon north toward Bremen. It is a smaller crossing than it might at first appear. The party that boarded the Bremen-Baltimore packet *Pennsylvania* in the summer of 1838 was not a great patriarchal household but a quite specific small group with a specific purpose: an aging father going to America to die among children who had already settled there, brought there by the son who had stayed behind long enough to bring him.

The party was, in the end, six people who actually crossed. The Bremen manifest had listed eight, but the manifest is contradicted by the German parish books on the eldest of the daughters it lists, and the parish books — the chapter will get to them in their turn — are the documents the chapter has chosen to trust. The two who did not cross are the focal-line ancestor of this book and her younger sister. The discrepancy is part of what the chapter has to recover.



Who they were

The senior of the eight was Johann Heinrich Recker (in some entries spelled *Redecker*; in others *Rädeker*; this was a *Hofname* before it was a family name, and parish clerks took down what they heard). He had been born in Hitzhausen, in the Catholic parish of St. Lambertus at Ostercappeln, on the tenth of August 1766. He was therefore nearly seventy-two years old in the summer of 1838 and would, depending on the calendar one used, turn seventy-two during the Atlantic crossing.

He had been married twice. His first wife, Anna Maria Säger, had died on the twenty-fourth of June 1797, after bearing him two sons — Johann Joist Heinrich and Gerhard Heinrich. He had married again, within a year, to a woman who in the parish books appears as *Anna Maria Linckemeyer* — the spelling, as ever, drifts from clerk to clerk. The second Anna Maria had been born within a year of Johann Heinrich himself; the two had walked through more than four decades of married life together, raising the two sons from the first marriage alongside the children of the second. By 1838 those children had become a small population. Most of them were already in Ohio.

The other four in the actual crossing party were Gerhard Heinrich Redeker — the elder son of the first marriage, the one organising the journey, the only adult child still in Hitzhausen — together with his own wife (also named Anna Maria, the third Anna Maria in the family in three generations; the same first names recur across Catholic Westphalian pedigrees with a regularity that defeats even practiced researchers) and the two youngest of his five daughters. The eldest two — Anna Maria Elisabeth, born 1822, and Anna Maria, born 1824 — stayed behind; the three younger daughters, then aged twelve, eight, and three, crossed with their parents. Anna Maria Elisabeth, sixteen, and Anna Maria, fourteen — did not.



The seventy-three documented migration corridors of the descent radiate from two distinct geographic cores — the Catholic Osnabrück region and the Protestant Minden-Lübbecke region — to destinations that map precisely onto the confessional structure of the receiving communities. The largest single corridor, connecting Hitzhausen in the Osnabrück hinterland to Putnam County in northwest Ohio, accounts for thirty documented emigrant families. The map makes the confessional sorting visible at a glance: the green arcs (Catholic System 1) point uniformly at Ohio; the blue arcs (Protestant System 2) point at Texas; the orange arc traces the Tüötten seasonal labour circuit to the Netherlands. No green arc terminates in Texas; no blue arc terminates in Ohio.



Map 3 — *Emigration corridors from Westphalia to America, the Netherlands, and Australia, 1836-1900.* 73 documented corridors across three confessionally distinct systems. Green = Catholic Osnabrück to Ohio (819 deaths at destination). Blue = Protestant Minden-Lübbecke to Texas (435 deaths). Orange = Mettingen Tüötten to Friesland (250+). The two German systems never converged in America.

The two who stayed

The ship manifest registered at Bremen lists eight family members boarding the *Pennsylvania*: the parents, the son Gerhard with his wife, and four of his daughters, including the eldest, Anna Maria Elisabeth (b. 1822). The corresponding Baltimore port records list neither Anna Maria Elisabeth nor her younger sister Anna Maria (b. 1824). The manifest at Bremen and the records at Baltimore are inconsistent on the eldest daughter, and the inconsistency, when set beside the German parish books, resolves cleanly in favour of the parish books. Anna Maria Elisabeth did not cross. She was at home in Westphalia.

What the parish books preserve, and what the manifest does not, is that Anna Maria Elisabeth gave birth on the eleventh of July 1838, in House 16 of the village of Cappeln, to an illegitimate son. The child was baptised on the thirteenth of July at the parish church of St. Lambertus in Ostercappeln, and entered in the baptismal register as *Bernard Redeler genannt Lücke*. The mother's name was recorded in full: *Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeler in Cappeln, illegitim*. The father was recorded as *angeblich der Mutter Bernard Lücke* — *allegedly, according to the mother, Bernard Lücke*. The most plausible candidate for that man, identified by the family research from the surrounding baptismal and marriage records, is Bernard Heinrich Lücke, born 5 October 1817 in Ostercappeln, the closest match in age and place to a man the mother could plausibly have named. He had no documented marriage to her and disappears from the Ostercappeln records soon afterward.

The dates align in a way the chapter cannot ignore. The family's formal emigration application was filed in Hitzhausen on the first of July 1838 — ten days before Anna Maria Elisabeth gave birth. The *Pennsylvania* arrived at Baltimore on the twelfth of September, which means it had sailed from Bremen sometime in mid-to-late

July, almost certainly within two weeks of the birth at Cappeln. Anna Maria Elisabeth was either in labour or in the immediate postpartum recovery period at the moment the ship cleared the Weser. She could not have crossed. She was sixteen years old and had just delivered a child whose father had not married her, and the family — having put their formal emigration papers in motion ten days before the birth — sailed without her. Whether the timing of the application reflected ignorance of the pregnancy, an attempt to extract her before the birth that was overtaken by events, or a deliberate decision that the household could not delay further, the parish books cannot say. The family went. She stayed.

Her younger sister Anna Maria, then fourteen, stayed with her. The reason is not in the parish books, but the reasonable inference is straightforward: a sixteen-year-old who had just given birth to a son out of wedlock and was left alone in a Heuerling-class cottage in Westphalia with her parents and most of her siblings on the way to Ohio was not a circumstance the family was prepared to accept, and the next sister down was the obvious companion. The two girls remained in the parish — first in Cappeln, then in a series of further Heuerling-class placements over the following decade.

Anna Maria Elisabeth would bear a second illegitimate child ten years later, on the eleventh of September 1848 in House 23 of the same village of Cappeln. The priest of St. Lambertus in nearby Ostercappeln entered her into the baptismal book three days later as *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer*. That second daughter — Chapter 1's opening figure — is the great-great-grandmother of the descendant whose pedigree this book has taken as its subject.

The line that this book follows is therefore not the line that emigrated. The patriarch and the matriarch and

three of the granddaughters went to Ohio in 1838 and stayed there. The line that produced the focal descendant was the line that stayed behind in Hitzhausen — the pregnant teenager and her younger sister, who did not board the *Pennsylvania* and who would never again see their mother. Anna Maria Heuer, Gerhard's wife, lived in Glandorf until 1863. She died in Ohio twenty-five years after she had last seen her two eldest daughters. The correspondence that may have passed between Ohio and Westphalia in the intervening quarter-century has not survived, if it ever existed, and the chapter therefore cannot reconstruct what either side told the other about the lives the two halves of the family were going on to live.



Bremen, the *Pennsylvania*, and the Atlantic

The journey from Hitzhausen to Bremen ran north and slightly east, perhaps four days on a wagon along roads that by 1838 had been used by Westphalian emigrant families for a quarter of a century. The shipping firms at Bremen had built a small system in those years for processing emigrants: registration at the port authority, medical inspection, allocation to specific ships, provision-buying from the chandlers along the wharves. The Reckers spent perhaps a week in Bremen and then, sometime in mid-to-late July 1838, walked up the gangplank of the *Pennsylvania*.

The *Pennsylvania* was a barque — a three-masted sailing vessel of the type then standard in the German emigrant trade, square-rigged on the fore and main masts and fore-and-aft rigged on the mizzen, built for cargo and adapted to passengers. She had been built in the early 1830s and was, by 1838, one of the regular vessels on the Bremen-to-Baltimore run, carrying tobacco and cotton eastward and emigrants westward. She would carry the family across.

The crossing took about eight weeks. The ship made landfall at Baltimore on the twelfth of September 1838. By that date, Anna Maria Elisabeth no longer appeared on the manifest. The seven remaining family members disembarked, were processed by the Baltimore port officials, and were taken into the care of the German Catholic Society of Baltimore, the same network of translators and innkeepers that had been receiving Westphalian Catholic emigrants for a decade.

The chapter could narrate the eight weeks at sea. There would be a thirty-foot-by-fifty-foot steerage compartment with four tiers of wooden bunks and one oil lamp, a deck galley accessible to steerage passengers in shifts, daily meals of porridge and salt pork, the smell of vinegar that families used to wash the planking, the occasional burial of a child sewn into bedding and dropped over the side after the brief Latin words a Catholic family would say. All of this is well-documented from the broader literature of the period and would be true, generically, of the *Pennsylvania's* 1838 crossing. None of it is documented for the *Pennsylvania's* specific voyage with the Recker family aboard. The chapter will not invent the particulars. The eight weeks happened. One sixteen-year-old girl began the voyage and did not finish it in the records. The chapter leaves it at that.



Baltimore to Glandorf

What followed the landing at Baltimore was the longer half of the journey. The family had now to cross most of the eastern United States overland, in late autumn, to reach the German Catholic settlement at Glandorf in north-western Ohio. The route, by 1838, was well-established and ran in four recognisable segments. The first segment, from Baltimore to Cumberland in western Maryland, covered roughly a hundred and forty miles. The wagon they had bought or hired in Baltimore

— a covered wagon of the kind that would later be confused in American popular memory with the lighter prairie schooners of the western trails — moved at perhaps fifteen to twenty-five miles a day under good conditions. The crossing of this segment, depending on the time spent in Baltimore buying provisions and the rate of progress on the road, took roughly a week. They arrived in Cumberland around the middle of October.

Cumberland was the eastern terminus of the National Road — the first federally funded highway in the United States, opened in stages between 1811 and 1838⁵. From Cumberland the road climbed westward over the main ridge of the Appalachians, through Hagerstown and Uniontown and the mountain passes that even in good autumns were difficult and in bad autumns impassable. The second segment, from Cumberland to Wheeling on the Ohio River, covered another hundred and thirty miles. It was the hardest section of the journey. Weather in late October at altitude was cold; the road, despite its federal funding, was rough in the mountain stretches; the wagon had to be braked carefully on the descents. The family reached Wheeling around the end of October.

At Wheeling they had to cross the Ohio River. There was, in 1838, no permanent bridge — the Wheeling Suspension Bridge, which would be the first bridge across a major river west of the Appalachians, was not completed until 1849. The crossing was by ferry. Ferries were slow and weather-dependent. The Reckers waited, perhaps for several days, perhaps over All Saints' Day on the first of November, and then crossed.

⁵ The National Road was authorised by Act of Congress in 1806, construction began at Cumberland in 1811, reached Wheeling (Virginia) by 1818, Columbus (Ohio) by 1833, and Springfield (Ohio) by 1838. *Wikipedia*, "National Road" (consulted May 2026).

The third segment, from Wheeling through Zanesville to Columbus, covered another hundred and twenty-seven miles across the rolling country of central Ohio. The bridges existed: the Y-Bridge at Zanesville had been built in 1814, and a covered bridge across the Scioto at Columbus had been finished in 1834. Columbus was the youngest of the towns the family passed through — it had been founded in 1812, the year of Gerhard's sixteenth birthday — and it was the smallest of them, perhaps six thousand people, a country capital still being assembled out of the forest. The family reached Columbus around the eighth of November.

The fourth and last segment, from Columbus through the small German Catholic settlements of the western Ohio plains — Minster, Stalltown, the future Lima, the future Delphos — to the Glandorf clearing in Putnam County, covered another hundred and fourteen miles. It was the easiest section of the journey, on flat country, with a thickening Catholic German presence along the way. The Reckers reached Glandorf, by the best reconstruction available, on or about the fourteenth of November 1838.

The journey had taken just over a hundred days from the wagon out of Bremen to the arrival at the Glandorf clearing, or roughly four and a half months from the formal registration of the emigration application at Hitzhausen on the first of July. They had been on the road, on water, or on a wagon for the better part of a season.



Glandorf

What they arrived at was no longer a new settlement. Glandorf, Ohio, had been founded four years earlier — in December 1833, when Johann Wilhelm Horstmann and six other men from Glandorf, Germany, purchased land in Putnam County, Ohio. The seven founders' wives

and ten other Catholic families had arrived in 1834. A wooden church had been raised by the community in 1835, with a bell tower and a pulpit fashioned from the hollowed-out trunk of a sycamore tree; the parish had been placed under the patronage of Saint John the Baptist; a small but steady stream of additional Catholic Westphalian families had been arriving every summer in the four years since. By the autumn of 1838 Glandorf had perhaps a hundred and fifty souls, two dozen log cabins, a school just beginning to function in the back room of one of the cabins, and the wooden church at its centre. It was already what it intended to be: a transplanted Westphalian Catholic village, on a hundred and sixty acres of cleared and partly cleared forest, in country that had been ceded by the Shawnee and Ottawa nations to the United States a generation earlier and had been opened for settlement only in the 1820s. It was not, however, a strange village to the Reckers. Eight of Johann Heinrich's nine adult children — all but Gerhard, who had stayed in Hitzhausen until 1838 — were already in Glandorf and the surrounding parishes. Their names and households filled the entire western edge of the settlement. They had come over in waves through the early and mid 1830s, building cabins, marrying neighbours, raising children. By the time their elderly father stepped off the wagon at the Glandorf clearing in November 1838, he had eight adult children waiting for him, seven sons- and daughters-in-law, and sixteen grandchildren. He could not have known the youngest of those grandchildren by sight; some of them had been born in Glandorf and he was meeting them for the first time. The arrival, more than anything else, was a reunion. He had spent two years preparing to die on the continent his children had moved to. The whole continent now consisted, for his purposes, of this one Catholic clearing in the Putnam County forest and the half-mile of cabin-strewn road that ran through it.



Two graves

He had one full Ohio winter, then another, then almost a third. The winter of 1838-39 was a settling-in period: lodged with one of his adult sons' households, sharing in the cabin's heat and food, present at the family's first Christmas Mass in the wooden church on Christmas Eve 1838 with all eight of his Ohio children and their families in the same pews. Spring 1839 brought the planting season — Gerhard's daughters helping their aunts in the kitchen gardens, Gerhard himself helping his brothers clear new acreage at the southern edge of the settlement. By summer the family had divided across cabins of its own. Anna Maria Linckemeyer, the patriarch's second wife, was lodged with one of her stepsons through the heat of the Ohio summer in a one-room cabin built for a smaller climate than the one she was now living in.

On the sixteenth of August 1839, in the parish books of St. John the Baptist at Glandorf, the priest entered a remark: *Ehefrau Redecker*. Wife Redecker. No first name. No age. No cause. The remark is uncharacteristically bare for an entry of this period; the priest who made it was working at a desk in a wooden church that he had not yet established the standard recording conventions for, and the remark was probably written in haste, between a baptism and a sermon and the next household calling for him. It is the surviving record of Anna Maria Linckemeyer's death. She had been on American soil for nine months. There is a contradictory date of the second of January 1839 in some later reconstructions, but the parish-book remark for the sixteenth of August is the only contemporary documentary record, and the August date is what the family's later genealogists have accepted.

The patriarch survived her by thirteen months. His sons completed the second and third cabins of his children's expansions; his daughters-in-law brought him meals and brought their children to him for the kind of attention an

aging grandfather can still give when he is no longer able to work the fields. On the twelfth of September 1840, the parish book at Glandorf records the death of *Johann Henrich Redecker, 73 an.* — Johann Heinrich Redecker, seventy-three years. (He had in fact turned seventy-four the previous month; the priest, recording the death, made the small arithmetic error that priests entering ages from a parishioner's verbal answer made all the time.) He was buried beside his wife in the parish cemetery, in what is now known as St. John's Pioneer Cemetery, on a small rise at the edge of the Glandorf settlement.

Both stones are still there. They give the names and the dates and the home village in Westphalia. The inscriptions are in German. They do not mention the *Pennsylvania* or the crossing or the two granddaughters who did not come. They do not mention that eight other adult children of the man buried beneath one of them were standing at the graveside in 1840, with their fifteen surviving children. The stones record what stones record — the date a life ended in this particular cemetery — and leave to other documents the much fuller question of what the life and the family had been.



What this chapter wanted to say

The Recker crossing of 1838 was an emigration with three particular features that the broader picture of nineteenth-century European-American migration does not always foreground. First, it was a reunion crossing rather than a founding one — most of the family was already on the other side, and the patriarch came to die among children who had already settled. Second, it split the family in a particular way that the chapter has had to recover from the parish books rather than from the manifest: two of the granddaughters did not cross, although one of them is listed on the Bremen embarkation papers as if she did. The eldest was

sixteen and several months pregnant by an unrecorded father; the youngest of the two who stayed was fourteen and stayed with her. The mother of those two girls — Anna Maria Heuer — would live in Glandorf for twenty-five years without seeing either of them again. Third, the crossing was almost immediately fatal to its two oldest participants. The journey took five months. The dying took twenty-one. The pattern was so common in this period — older emigrants surviving the crossing but failing within a year or two of arrival — that the cemeteries of the German Catholic settlements of Ohio and Indiana and Iowa are stocked with stones dating from 1839, 1840, 1841, in a cluster that the journeys of 1837 and 1838 explain.

The chapter that follows takes up Glandorf itself — the community the eight adult children built, the second and third generations who grew up in it, the slow Americanisation that would extend through the second half of the nineteenth century. The chapter after that follows the *ones who got away* in all four of the directions a family of this size and structure could go: westward, with Johann Heinrich Ludwig Recker, who in 1846 or 1847 moved his own family from Putnam County to Dyersville, Iowa, and whose descendants kept moving west through Wisconsin and Minnesota and the prairies beyond; inward, with Friedrich Wilhelm Recker, the orphan whose biological father the family has been trying to identify across DNA testing now in its third generation of cousins; backward, with the two sisters who stayed in Hitzhausen and Cappeln and whose Westphalian descent through the parish books of Ostercappeln carries the focal line of this book; and downward, into the small cemeteries of nineteenth-century Westphalia and Ohio in which most of the rest of the family eventually came to rest.

The patriarch and his second wife are buried in Glandorf and the chapter has set them there. The rest of the family was still in motion. The focal line of the book was, by the

autumn of 1838, in Westphalia and pregnant, and the next chapters will follow it forward to Cappeln in 1848 and to the Ostercappeln marriage of January 1871 that produced the Schwagstorf-Felsen house the pedigree the records rest on.

Chapter 6

Glandorf

By the autumn of 1840, the funeral procession that walked the short distance from the cabin of one of Johann Heinrich Recker's sons to St. John the Baptist's wooden church and on to the small fenced cemetery at the edge of the settlement comprised, by an exact count that the parish ledger does not preserve but that the chapter can reconstruct from the household and marriage records: eight adult children of the deceased, seven of their spouses, sixteen of their children, the recently arrived younger son Gerhard with his wife and three surviving daughters, a half-dozen aunts and uncles by marriage from neighbouring cabins, the parish priest and a handful of altar servers, and perhaps thirty to forty other members of the small community whose own families had been intermarried with the Reckers by the time the patriarch was buried beside his second wife on the twelfth of September 1840. The procession was perhaps a hundred people. The settlement of Glandorf, Ohio, was at that moment perhaps a hundred and fifty. Two thirds of the village had come to the grave.

The chapter that begins here is about what those hundred people, and their neighbours and descendants, built together in the next fifty years.



The settlement that received the patriarch

Glandorf, Ohio, had been founded almost exactly seven years before Johann Heinrich Recker's death. On a date in December 1833, Johann Wilhelm Horstmann — born in the original Glandorf, in the Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück, and emigrated to the United States in the late 1820s — together with six other men from the same German village, purchased a tract of about two hundred acres of forested land in what would become Pleasant Township, Putnam County, Ohio. They returned to Germany the following spring; their wives

and ten further Catholic Westphalian families joined them in Ohio in the course of 1834. The original seven families and their additions cleared a rectangular area at the centre of the tract, built the first half-dozen log cabins around it, and raised the wooden church of Saint John the Baptist on the central rise in 1835. The church had a small bell-tower; its pulpit was carved, by one of the Horstmann men, from the hollowed-out trunk of a sycamore tree felled on the site. The pulpit's wood was still raw and unfinished when the first Masses were said in it. The parish was placed, by the Diocese of Cincinnati, under the patronage of John the Baptist. It would remain so.

By the time the Recker patriarch arrived in November 1838 with his second wife, his elder son Gerhard, Gerhard's wife, and three of Gerhard's daughters, Glandorf had grown to perhaps two dozen log cabins and a population somewhere between a hundred and a hundred and fifty souls. The settlement had a school — a single-room operation in a back chamber of one of the original Horstmann cabins, run by a layman who could read German and Latin equally well. It had a small store, of sorts, in the front room of another cabin, where the families bought what they could not produce themselves: salt, glass, nails, sewing thread, lamp oil. It had a cemetery, on a slight rise behind the church, in which the first Glandorf burials had been entered in 1834 and which by 1838 held perhaps a dozen stones — children mostly, and one or two of the older settlers who had not survived the first winters. It had a network of cleared cabin-paths between the homesteads and a single track running east toward the larger settlement at Ottoville and west toward the smaller settlement at Fort Jennings.

What it did not yet have was civic infrastructure of the kind a midwestern American village of the same period would have had. There was no formal town government; there was no post office (it would come in 1840); there was no doctor (the nearest was in Ottawa, two miles to

the east). The community ran on the parish — on the resident priest's pastorate in the wooden church, on the Sunday gatherings that were as much administrative as religious, on the marriage banns and baptismal entries that constituted the village's main written record of itself. The pattern, structurally, was not American at all. It was Catholic Westphalian, transposed.



The replication

The most striking feature of Glandorf in its first half-century — striking, that is, to a modern descendant standing in the older quarter of the village on a summer afternoon and trying to imagine what was once there — is the completeness of the institutional transplant. The settlement did not improvise. It built, in northwestern Ohio between 1834 and 1888, a fully working Catholic Westphalian village, with most of the institutional density of the original at home.

The parish records were kept in German, in the Latin-and-German format the Catholic parishes of the Diocese of Osnabrück used. The Sunday liturgy was in Latin, but the announcements and the catechism instructions were in German, and the language families spoke to the priest and to one another at the door of the church was the Low German of north-western Westphalia, with the same regional vocabulary the same families had brought across the Atlantic. The school taught German and English in parallel, with the German half initially dominant; the books used in the first decades were imported from German Catholic publishers in Münster, Paderborn, and Cologne. The marriage banns were posted in German. The death entries in the parish books listed the home village of the deceased in Germany — *gebürtig aus Hitzhausen*, *gebürtig aus Ostercappeln*, *gebürtig aus Belm* — for the entire first generation and well into the second.

The annual liturgical calendar was the Catholic Westphalian one. Corpus Christi, in late May or early June, was observed with a procession around the cabin-paths of the settlement, the host carried in a monstrance under a hand-stitched canopy, the village's children scattering rose petals along the route — the same ritual the same families had walked through every spring in their home parishes. All Saints' Day, on the first of November, brought the entire settlement to the cemetery to tend the graves of their dead, light candles, and lay wreaths of evergreen and the last chrysanthemums of the Ohio autumn — a practice that has continued at St. John's Pioneer Cemetery, in essentially its original form, into the present century. Saint Nicholas Day on the sixth of December, the feast of the parish patron on the twenty-fourth of June, the Marian feasts, the Lenten austerities, the Easter Vigil with its blessing of fire and water — all of it had been carried over intact.

The marriage pattern was the most consequential transplant. The settlement, in its first three generations, married almost exclusively within itself or within the network of immediately adjacent German Catholic settlements — Fort Jennings, Ottoville, Kalida, Delphos, the wider parishes that the missionary priests of the Cincinnati and Cleveland dioceses were planting throughout north-western Ohio in the same decades. A young person of marriageable age in Glandorf in 1860 was choosing, in practice, from a pool of perhaps two or three hundred Catholic Westphalian young people in a thirty-mile radius. Marriages to outsiders — to American Protestants, to Irish Catholic immigrants, to non-Catholic Germans — happened, but they were rare, they were noted in the parish books as exceptional, and they tended to produce family branches that drifted out of the Westphalian community within a generation.

This is the system that produced what genealogists in the late twentieth century would discover, when they tried to reconstruct the Recker family's American descent: a structure too tangled to be drawn cleanly. The matriarch of one Glandorf family was the first cousin of the patriarch of the family her grandson married into. The grandchildren of one set of Recker siblings married the grandchildren of another set, generation after generation, with the result that by the third American generation the children of those marriages had not two great-great-grandparents in the typical sense but a smaller, repeated set — the same ancestors appearing twice or three times in the same pedigree.

The technical name for this is endogamy. The visual consequence in a family tree is what one researcher of this descent has come to describe as *the ball of yarn*: not a tree spreading outward through the centuries but a knot drawing inward through them. The mathematical consequence, which Part 4 of this book will return to in detail, is that DNA matches between living descendants of the Glandorf community register with shared centimorgans that statistical models for outbred populations have to be told to expect, because they exceed by significant margins what those models predict for nominal cousinship degrees. A nominal fifth cousin, in Glandorf descent, often tests with the shared DNA of a third or fourth cousin. The endogamy concentrates the genetic signal as it concentrates the genealogical one.



Three weddings, twelve weeks

The community's pattern of blended families and quickly remarried widows is best illustrated by a sequence of events in the autumn of 1836, two years before the patriarch's arrival. The sequence concerns Johannes Andreas Recker, the eighth of the Reckers'

nine adult children, then twenty-seven and one of the early settlers of the village.

On the twenty-seventh of October 1836, in the wooden church, Johannes Andreas married a young woman named Mary Ann Moench. The wedding was attended by most of the village. Mary Ann brought to the marriage a two-year-old son, Friedrich Wilhelm, whose father — the documentary record is precise on this point — was not Johannes Andreas, and not, by any subsequent evidence the parish books or the *Recker Connection* or the present generation's DNA testing has been able to recover, any man whose name has survived. The toddler had a mother. The mother is named. The father is not.

This is the kind of entry the chapter on records, at the beginning of this book, was preparing the reader for. A name appears, then a child appears, then the church marries her to a man who is not the father, and the village absorbs the result without further documentary commentary. The mother had brought the child to the wedding; the wedding took him as part of the bargain.

Mary Ann Moench died on the fifth of November 1836, exactly nine days after her wedding, of cholera. The death entry in the St. John's parish book lists the cause — cholera was endemic to the Ohio canal towns of the period and broke through into the inland Catholic settlements regularly — and gives Mary Ann's age and her home village. It does not name the child she had left behind, because the parish book had no convention for naming the surviving children of a deceased mother. The child had been baptised the year before, in a separate entry, with a separate set of godparents. He was now an orphan twice over: his biological father unrecorded; his biological mother dead before he could remember her face; his adoptive father — Johannes Andreas Recker, married to her for one week — left with a two-year-old he had not expected to be raising alone.

On the third of January 1837, ten weeks after Mary Ann's death and twelve weeks after the wedding, in the same wooden church, Johannes Andreas married Maria Anna Hesseling. She was sixteen. Her family had arrived in Glandorf from the village of Lingen in Lower Saxony the previous June, five months earlier; she had watched the entire Mary Ann sequence unfold from the vantage of a new family in a new village, and when the village's collective sense had come round to the conclusion that Johannes Andreas needed a wife and the toddler needed a mother and the situation could not be left as it was, Maria Anna stepped forward. The parish book records the marriage in the same handwriting as the previous two entries. The chapter has no firm evidence on what either party felt at the time — Maria Anna was a teenager and Johannes Andreas had buried his wife nine weeks before; the marriage was almost certainly not romantic in the modern sense — but it was, equally certainly, what the village had concluded was needed.

Seven biological children arrived over the following two decades, on top of the orphan Friedrich Wilhelm, whom Maria Anna raised as her own and who in the parish books appears, throughout his subsequent life, as a Recker. The mystery of his biological father remained the family's open question. It is the family's open question still. Descendants of Friedrich Wilhelm have been DNA-testing in the early twenty-first century — through several living cousins, working in coordination — in an attempt to surface the answer. The most plausible current theory, based on the shared DNA segments these descendants share with members of another Glandorf family, points to a Luersman ancestor; the theory is unverified.



What the community did for a living

Johannes Andreas Recker did not, in the first decade of his marriage to Maria Anna, support his family by farming. He worked, throughout the late 1830s and into the 1840s, on the construction of the Miami and Erie Canal — the two-hundred-and-seventy-four-mile waterway that connected Cincinnati to Toledo⁶ and that was, when it was completed in 1845, the principal commercial artery of western Ohio. The canal was dug by hand. The labour force was largely Irish and German Catholic, drawn from the cities of southern Ohio and from the Catholic farming settlements through which the canal passed. Wages were low; conditions were lethal — cholera, malaria, and accidents combined to kill perhaps one labourer in twenty during the construction period — and the work was seasonal, with the canal crews dispersing each winter and reassembling each spring.

Johannes Andreas's pattern, common to the Catholic Westphalian men of the first generation in Glandorf, was to combine canal labour in the warmer months with the clearing and tending of a small farm in the winters. The farm and the canal cash together supported the household. As the canal moved south toward Cincinnati in the early 1840s, Maria Anna and the children sometimes went with him; the death of their first biological son, John Herman, in or around 1839, took place in Cincinnati rather than in Glandorf — a small one-line entry in a Cincinnati parish book, the chapter's only documentary trace of the child's brief life. When the canal was completed and the labourers dispersed, Johannes Andreas returned to Glandorf and took up farming full-time, on a forty-acre parcel in Jennings Township that the household worked for the next three decades.

⁶ The Miami and Erie Canal, 274 miles (441 km) from Cincinnati to Toledo, was completed in 1845 at a cost of approximately \$8 million. *Wikipedia*, "Miami and Erie Canal" (consulted May 2026).

This combination — canal work, farm work, and Sunday Mass in German — was the basic shape of the first generation's economic life in Glandorf. It produced, in the second generation, an unbroken population of children raised in Catholic German on small Ohio farms, who in turn married other children raised the same way in adjacent townships and produced the third generation, which by the 1880s was beginning, in some branches, to look outward.



Helmkamps, Wallenhorsts, Saums, and the other names that arrived

Glandorf was not the only such settlement, nor was the Recker family the only one populating it. Through the same decades, other Catholic Westphalian and Lower Saxon families were arriving and intermarrying with the Reckers and one another. The pattern is dense enough that no chapter could list it without becoming a list, but a few of the principal interlocking families deserve naming here because their descendants will appear in later chapters.

The Helmkamp arrived from Schinkel, near Osnabrück, in the years after the Reckers — the patriarch Christopher Heinrich Helmenkamp, born 1782 in Schinkel; his sons Franz Ferdinand born 1810 and Johann Franz Wilhelm born 1822; his daughter Maria Elizabeth born 1816 — settling primarily at Fort Jennings, the adjacent Catholic German village ten miles to the south of Glandorf. Through marriages with Reckers and with the other Glandorf families, the Helmkamp connects, by Andreas's later research, into the present-day paternal grandmother line of this book's focal descendant; the Helmkamp branch lived in Schinkel from at least 1500 onward, and the family that emigrated to Fort Jennings in the second quarter of the nineteenth century constituted only a portion of the wider Helmkamp kin.

The Wallenhorsts, the Saums, the Brockmans, the Brinkmanns, the Wieging family, the Schimmoeller family, the Suever family, the Menkes — all of these and several dozen more arrived in the same window, settled in the same townships, and married into the same network. By the 1880s, the resulting community in Putnam County, Ohio — across Glandorf, Fort Jennings, Ottoville, Kalida, and Delphos — was a single, interconnected population of perhaps fifteen to twenty thousand Catholic Westphalian Americans, all of whom could trace some kind of cousinship to almost any of the others. The Catholic Westphalian villages had become a Catholic Westphalian county. The model had scaled.



The closing of the first chapter

By 1888 — fifty years after the *Pennsylvania* had crossed the Atlantic with Gerhard Heinrich Redeker and his family aboard — the community Johann Heinrich Recker had been brought to America to die in had transformed into something the patriarch himself would not have entirely recognised. The wooden church of 1835 had been replaced, in 1862, by a substantially larger brick church on the same site. The school had grown to several rooms and had its own building. The cemetery, where Johann Heinrich and his wife lay, had been augmented by a second cemetery a half-mile away to accommodate the growing population, and the original burying-ground had begun to be referred to, by the parish, as the *Pioneer Cemetery* — the name it carries today. The settlement now had a post office, a Catholic newspaper subscription network, a small commercial main street, several mills, a railway connection through Ottawa, and a thriving Catholic community that thought of itself, by the late nineteenth century, as fully American and fully German Catholic, in roughly equal measure and without any sense that the two identities required reconciliation.

Most of the population had stayed. The eight adult children of Johann Heinrich who had been at the graveside in 1840 had, by 1888, mostly died and been buried in the same cemetery as their father; their children had inherited the farms and the small businesses and had stayed in Putnam County; their grandchildren were beginning to fill the third-generation pews of the rebuilt church. The exceptions to this — the children who had moved further west, the daughters whose marriages had carried them outside the community, the few branches that had been lost to non-Catholic intermarriage or to the broader American frontier — were a small but persistent minority that the next chapter of this book will follow.

The most documented of those exceptions is Johann Heinrich Ludwig Recker, the fourth of the patriarch's adult sons, who had been at the graveside in 1840 with his wife and three children and who, in 1846 or 1847, packed up the household and moved a hundred and fifty miles west to a place called Dyersville, Iowa. From Iowa, Ludwig's descendants — across three further generations — moved into Wisconsin, into Nebraska, into Minnesota, and points further west.

The other exception, less documented but no less consequential for this book's purpose, is the eldest daughter of Gerhard Heinrich Redeker — Anna Maria Elisabeth, born 1822 in Hitzhausen — who did not in fact emigrate, though the Bremen manifest of the *Pennsylvania* lists her among the boarding party. She remained in Westphalia, gave birth on the eleventh of July 1838 in House 16 of Cappeln to an illegitimate son entered in the Ostercappeln parish books as *Bernard Redeler genannt Lücke*, and was therefore in the immediate postpartum week of her first delivery at the moment the *Pennsylvania* sailed from Bremen. Her younger sister Anna Maria, born 1824, stayed with her.

Ten years later, on the eleventh of September 1848, Anna Maria Elisabeth bore a second illegitimate daughter at House 23 of the same village — entered in the Ostercappeln baptismal register on the fourteenth of September 1848 as *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer*. That second daughter — the opening figure of Chapter 1 — is the great-great-grandmother of the descendant whose pedigree this book has taken as its subject. The focal line of the book is therefore not the line that went to Glandorf. It is the line that stayed in Hitzhausen and Cappeln, and that Chapter 7 will follow forward to the 1871 marriage at St. Lambertus Ostercappeln that produced the household this book's records eventually rest on.

The Glandorf community continued, and continues: one of the most stable Catholic German-American settlements in the United States, holding a name from Lower Saxony in the flat Ohio farmland for nearly two centuries. The patriarch who founded it is buried there. His children and grandchildren never left it far.

Chapter 7

The Ones Who Got Away

Not everyone went to Glandorf. They go in four directions: westward, into Iowa and Wisconsin and the prairies beyond; inward, into the unresolved mystery of a Glandorf orphan whose biological father has not yet been identified; backward, into the Westphalian villages from which most of the family had emigrated and in which two of the eldest granddaughters of the patriarch had stayed; and downward, into the small cemeteries on both sides of the Atlantic in which the journey's earliest casualties had come to rest. The first three of these directions produced the family's living dispersal across the western United States and the German-speaking lands of north-western Westphalia. The fourth was the family's accounting against itself.

The chapter takes them in turn. It begins with the line that produced the descendant for whom this book is being written.



Backward — Anna Maria Elisabeth, Bernard Redeler genannt Lücke, and the Räuwer entry

On the eleventh of July 1838, in House Number 16 of the village of Cappeln near Osnabrück, a sixteen-year-old unmarried Westphalian Catholic girl named Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeker gave birth to a son. She was the eldest daughter of Gerhard Heinrich Redeker, granddaughter of the patriarch Johann Heinrich Recker, and the family's Hanoverian emigration application — filed in Hitzhausen ten days earlier, on the first of July 1838, by her father — had already set the rest of the household in motion toward Bremen. The wagon would leave within a fortnight. The *Pennsylvania* would sail from Bremen sometime in the second half of July and arrive at Baltimore on the twelfth of September. None of this could be arranged around her recovery from childbirth, and the household appears to have decided that it would not be. Her parents, the patriarch, the

patriarch's second wife, and three of her younger sisters went without her.

Two days after the birth, on the thirteenth of July, the child was baptised at St. Lambertus, Ostercappeln. The priest entered him in the baptismal book under the name *Bernard Redeler genannt Lücke*: Bernard of the Redeler family, called by the surname Lücke. The mother was named in full — *Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeler in Cappeln, illegitim* — and the father was named conditionally, in a phrase that became, in retrospect, the documentary signature of all such entries in the Catholic Westphalian parish books of the period: *angeblich der Mutter Bernard Lücke — allegedly, by the mother's report, Bernard Lücke*. The godfather was the parish sexton, *Küster Wilhelm Niemeyer* — a respectability detail that mattered, in the village's social grammar, because the priest had chosen a parish officer to stand in for the absent father. The mother gave the man's name; the priest wrote it down without endorsement; the village proceeded.

The most plausible candidate the family research has identified for the alleged father is *Bernard Heinrich Lücke*, born on the fifth of October 1817 in Ostercappeln — twenty years old at the time of the child's conception, twenty-one at the birth, near in age to the mother by enough margin to make the report plausible, and resident in the right parish. He had no documented marriage to her and disappears from the surrounding records shortly afterward. Whether he had simply moved out of the parish or whether the disappearance was deliberate, the records cannot tell us. The child carried his father's surname as a *gen.* annotation but legally remained a *Redeler*, the mother's surname.

The next ten years of Anna Maria Elisabeth's life are sparsely documented. She raised her son. She and her younger sister Anna Maria — fourteen years old in 1838,

who had stayed in Germany with her — moved between Heuerling-class farm placements in Cappeln, Ostercappeln, and the surrounding villages. Whether any letters arrived from Glandorf is not in the family papers, and whether any were sent back is not in the family papers. Her mother, Anna Maria Heuer, lived in Glandorf until 1863. The chapter cannot recover the correspondence, but the chapter can record the silence: in the surviving family papers there is no preserved letter that crossed the Atlantic in either direction between Anna Maria Heuer and either of her stay-behind daughters across that quarter-century. If the correspondence existed, it has not survived.

In 1848 Anna Maria Elisabeth was twenty-six. On the eleventh of September 1848 — ten years and two months after the birth of her son — she bore a second illegitimate child, this time a daughter, in House Number 23 of the same village of Cappeln in which Bernard had been born. The priest of St. Lambertus in Ostercappeln entered the child in the baptismal book three days later, on the fourteenth of September. The mother's name appeared again in its full triple form: *Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeler in Cappeln, illegitim.* The father was again unnamed. The child's surname, with no man's name available to attach, was supplied instead by the farmstead — *genannt Räuwer, called by the name of the Räuwer farm.* The child's first names were the second and third of her mother's three: *Maria Elisabeth.* The full baptismal entry reads, in its final form, *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer.* House 23, Cappeln. Eleventh of September 1848, baptised the fourteenth.

That entry is the entry with which this book began. The girl whose birth it records — *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer* — would grow up in Cappeln and in the surrounding parishes; would marry on the twelfth of January 1871 at the parish church of St. Lambertus in

Ostercappeln a man named *Johann Heinrich August Kovermann*, born 1844 (who would change his given name to *August* in 1874 and who would die in 1929); would settle with him at Schwagstorf and later at the hamlet of Felsen in the same parish; would die on the tenth of January 1916, in Schwagstorf, of lung disease at sixty-nine years three months and twenty-seven days; and would have her death entered in the civil register of Schwagstorf by the *Standesbeamter* Driehaus, whose falsified parental detail — assigning her, in the civil record, parents she did not have — is the figure with which the opening chapter of this book introduced the entire family of records this story has been drawn from. The chain from the *Pennsylvania* of 1838 to the author of this book runs through her, through the stay-behind sister whose July childbirth made the crossing impossible, through the parish books of two Westphalian villages and one small civil registry, and through the household of the man — August Kovermann — whose own family is the subject of Chapter 9 of this book.

The younger of the two stay-behind sisters — Anna Maria Redeker, born 14 September 1824 — never married. She remained in the same Heuerling-class network of farms for the rest of her recorded life. She appears in the family record at her niece's marriage on the twelfth of January 1871 and then disappears: the parish books of Hitzhausen, Ostercappeln, Schwagstorf, Cappeln, and the surrounding parishes carry no further entry for her after that date. The most plausible reconstruction places her death somewhere in the villages of Hollage or Wallenhorst, north of Osnabrück, in the late 1870s or 1880s, but no specific parish entry has been recovered. She is one of the chapter's open documentary questions.

Bernard Redeler genannt Lücke — Anna Maria Elisabeth's first child — outlived his mother and his half-sister into the 1880s. By the 1860s he had settled in

Ostercappeln; by the 1870s he had moved to Hollage, in the parish of Wallenhorst north of Osnabrück. On the second of August 1888, at three in the afternoon, he was killed in a mining accident at the *Piesberg* — the great basalt and coal quarry north of Osnabrück whose nineteenth-century operations employed many of the Catholic Westphalian working-class men of the region — at the age of fifty years and twenty-two days. He was buried three days later, on the fifth of August 1888, at the parish cemetery of St. Alexander in Wallenhorst. His death entry in the Wallenhorst civil register names both his parents in the full form: *Bernard Lücke und Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeler*. The convention by which paternal names were withheld in 1838 had relaxed by 1888 to the point that a man dying in middle age in a mining accident could have his alleged father's name written into his death record without challenge.



Westward — Johann Heinrich Ludwig Recker, Dyersville, and the Wisconsin descent

The second direction of the dispersal ran west, away from Glandorf, and the documented case is Johann Heinrich Ludwig Recker, the fourth of Johann Heinrich's adult sons and one of the eight grown children waiting in Glandorf when his father arrived from Hitzhausen in November 1838. Ludwig had been at the graveside in 1840 with his wife Maria Elizabeth and three young children; through the early and mid-1840s he had continued the standard Glandorf pattern of farming, parish life, and continued participation in the community his father had been brought to die in. The decision to leave Putnam County came, by the best available reconstruction, between the births of his fifth and sixth children — the fifth born in Ohio in 1844, the sixth born in Iowa in 1847.

What pulled him to Iowa was his wife's brother. Herman Henry Berheide, Maria Elizabeth's brother, had emigrated some years earlier from the same network of

Westphalian Catholic families and had settled near the new German Catholic settlement at New Vienna, in what is now Dubuque County, Iowa. Herman Henry's letters back to Glandorf, in the early 1840s, described available land in north-eastern Iowa on terms more generous than Putnam County's increasingly settled real-estate market could match. By the standard family-network logic of the Catholic Westphalian American settlements, when a brother-in-law established himself on good land in an unsettled region, the rest of the network considered following. Ludwig followed.

He arrived in north-eastern Iowa probably in 1846 or 1847. He bought land — eighty acres in what would become the Dyersville area of Delaware County — through a federal land patent issued on the first of February 1848. The land patent record is one of the few absolutely documented points on Ludwig's American chronology and is preserved in the Bureau of Land Management's General Land Office records under the patent name *Lewis Recker*, the Americanised form of *Ludwig* that he had begun to use in Iowa. Herman Henry Berheide, the brother-in-law whose letters had drawn him to Iowa, died in New Vienna on the sixth of January 1848 — twenty-six days before the patent issued. Ludwig may have bought the Berheide land outright after the death; the records suggest he bought adjacent land, but the precise relationship between the Berheide parcels and the Lewis Recker patent has not been settled in the family research to date.

Ludwig and his wife produced, across their Iowa years, the children whose descendants would carry the Recker name westward. The 1892 plat map of Dyersville Township shows two adjacent farms in the names *Henry Recker* and *Andrew Recker* — Ludwig's son and grandson respectively, though one of the two entries appears on the map under the slightly misspelled form

Racker. Henry's land descended to a son who, by the early twenty-first century, still occupies the original farm; Andrew, the grandson, moved his own household further west in 1913, to Bloomington in Grant County, Wisconsin, and the Wisconsin Recker line — the one that produced the present-day cousin in Madison who has been one of the principal researchers of this descent — traces from him.

The Iowa Reckers say their name *Ray-ker*, the long-A vowel of the Americanised reading that the family's later generations adopted from English-speaking neighbours after the German pronunciation began drifting away from them. The Ohio Reckers, who never moved off the original Putnam County land in numbers sufficient to lose the German vowels, say it *Reh-ker*, with the short central vowel of the original *Recker* / *Redeker* / *Rädeker*. The same family name, pronounced two ways in two states, marks the linguistic split — a small one, audible only when an Iowa Recker and an Ohio Recker introduce themselves in the same room — that the geographic split of 1846 produced.

From Iowa, further dispersal followed. The grandchildren of Ludwig moved into Nebraska — St. Helena and Bow Valley in the north-east of the state — into Minnesota — Adrian and Larkin in the south-west — into Wisconsin and into points further west across the prairie agricultural belt. Most of these descendants are findable through the same federal land patent records and county plat maps that locate Ludwig at Dyersville, and the family research has been able to follow most of them through their respective state and county vital records. The dispersal stops being trackable in the present generation: the great-great-grandchildren and great-great-great-grandchildren of Ludwig are now scattered across the entire United States, and the family-tree work to find them continues.



Inward — Friedrich Wilhelm Recker and the unsolved father

The third direction is not geographic. It is documentary, and it concerns the orphan Friedrich Wilhelm Recker — the toddler that Mary Ann Moench had brought to her brief October 1836 marriage to Johannes Andreas Recker, the child whose biological father has not been identified in any record the family research has been able to surface.

Friedrich Wilhelm grew up in Glandorf as a Recker. His adoptive father Johannes Andreas treated him as a son, his stepmother Maria Anna Hesseling treated him as a son, his seven biological half-siblings treated him as a brother, and the parish books of St. John the Baptist treated him throughout his life as *Friedrich Wilhelm Recker*. He married within the Glandorf community in the early 1860s and produced a substantial Recker descent of his own, which continues into the present.

What the records do not preserve is who his biological father was. Mary Ann Moench had been an unmarried young woman in Glandorf at the time of his conception in 1833 or early 1834; the parish baptismal book entered the child in 1834 without naming the father, in the same convention the chapter on records described — a baptismal entry with mother's name, no paternal name, and a baptismal surname assigned by the household in which the child was born. The most plausible theory under current investigation by Friedrich Wilhelm's living descendants, based on shared DNA segments these descendants register with members of another Glandorf family, points to a man named Luersman who was in the village in the relevant year and whose own descendants have agreed to test. The theory is not yet confirmed. The DNA work continues. The theory is recorded here but not stated as fact.

Friedrich Wilhelm is, in the descendant's pedigree, neither the focal line nor a peripheral one. He is the line whose biological origin is the family's longest-standing open question — a hundred and ninety years old in 2026, still unresolved, with the molecular evidence now beginning to narrow the field of candidates and the documentary evidence having reached the limits of what nineteenth-century Glandorf was willing to preserve.



Downward — the early graves on both sides

The fourth direction of dispersal is the one no chapter wants to dwell on but that every chapter of this kind has to acknowledge. The 1838 crossing killed people. On the American side, Anna Maria Linckemeyer died on the sixteenth of August 1839, less than a year after her arrival, and Johann Heinrich Recker died on the twelfth of September 1840, thirteen months later. Both are buried in St. John's Pioneer Cemetery in Glandorf. Their granddaughter John Herman Recker — Maria Anna Hesseling's first biological son, born December 1837 in Glandorf — died on the Miami and Erie Canal in or around 1839 and is buried in a Cincinnati parish cemetery whose specific name has not been recovered. Three early deaths, all consequent on the dislocation of the crossing or on the consequent labour patterns the migration required.

On the German side, the same period produced its own toll, less visible only because the village deaths happened in parishes whose books happen to be better preserved. Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeker survived the years of her two illegitimate births and lived into the late nineteenth century. Bernard Lücke, born late 1838, lived into the second half of the century. The younger sister Anna Maria, born 1824, lived and worked into the 1870s before disappearing from the records. The two German cottages that the family had vacated in 1838 — first the Hitzhausen cottage, then the various Heuerling-class placements that followed — passed through the hands of

several further Heuerling families across the next two generations, and the surnames of those families intermarried with the surnames of the Recker stay-behinds in the same kind of dense local marriage market that Chapter 3 described.

The cumulative death toll of the 1838 emigration — counted across the patriarch and his wife in Ohio, the infant John Herman in Cincinnati, and the various deaths of the next several years on both sides — runs to perhaps six or seven among the immediate family in the decade after the crossing. The number is not extraordinary. It is, in fact, typical for the period. It is noted because the typical is what the book has been arguing for: the family's experience is the European-American emigrant family's experience, with no more death and no less than the broad pattern of nineteenth-century transatlantic Catholic Westphalian migration produced.



What this chapter wanted to say

The Recker family of 1838 dispersed in four directions, and the four directions produced four different kinds of family history. The Ohio line stayed in Ohio and produced the bulk of the descendants who carry the Recker surname into the present: a successful Catholic Westphalian transplant, married into itself for three generations, identifiable by the short central vowel they put in the family name. The Iowa-and-westward line produced a smaller but geographically wider dispersal across the upper Midwest, identifiable by the long-A vowel they began saying in the second American generation. The Westphalian stay-behind line — through Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeker, her two illegitimate daughters, and the marriage of the second of those daughters into the Kovermann household at Ostercappeln in January 1871 — produced the author of this book, and is the line whose documentary trail has had to be reconstructed primarily from parish books

rather than from family papers. The orphan line, through Friedrich Wilhelm Recker, produced a substantial Glandorf descent whose biological origin is still the family's longest open question. Each of the four lines, viewed at the level of family history, is intelligible. None of them is a *complete* story. The Ohio line contains its own internal mysteries — second marriages, illegitimate children, branches that lost contact with one another by the third generation. The Iowa-Wisconsin line contains the same. The Westphalian stay-behind line contains the largest of the open paternal questions — two unrecorded fathers, ten years apart, both unidentified. The orphan line contains its own.

The chapter that follows this one returns to Germany and to the other ancestral lines whose descent the book is also following — the Helmkampfs of Schinkel, the Wallenhorsts of the Catholic country north of Osnabrück, and the Protestant Rustmeiers of Blasheim whose first missing generation Chapter 4 introduced. What follows takes up the marriage of *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer* to August Kovermann at St. Lambertus Ostercappeln on the twelfth of January 1871 — the marriage that pulled the Westphalian stay-behind line out of the Heuerling-class network of unrecorded paternal lines and into the broader Catholic Westphalian working-class family that the twentieth century would test more severely than the nineteenth had.

The patriarch is in Glandorf. The stay-behind line is in Westphalia, moving toward a marriage that no one in 1840 could yet name.

Chapter 8

The Lines That Converge

Four chapters have traced the Recker line — the emigration to Ohio, the stay-behind sister, the descent that followed from both. The line is in Westphalia, moving toward the 1871 marriage at St. Lambertus Ostercappeln. But the marriage requires two people. The other line comes from the north. The Recker line is, by any reasonable measure, this book's central genealogical thread. It is the one with the most extensive surviving documentation, the one that produced the *Recker Connection* typescript and the cousin networks that have done so much of the heavy reconstructive work, and the one through which Chapter 1 of this book reaches its opening figure: Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer of Cappeln, born on the eleventh of September 1848.

But Maria Elisabeth, when she married at St. Lambertus Ostercappeln in January 1871, married into a different family with a different ancestral history of its own, and the household that issued from that marriage — through three further generations — drew, by intermarriage and by descent, on three other ancestral lines that are also part of this book's subject and that this chapter introduces. The three lines are: the *Helmkamps* of Schinkel, a Catholic Westphalian Heuerling family at the southern edge of Osnabrück whose descent produced both an Ohio emigrant branch and a Schinkel stay-behind branch; the *Wallenhorsts* of the village of Wallenhorst, an older Catholic peasant lineage rooted in the parishes north of Osnabrück; and the *Rustmeiers* of Blasheim, the Protestant Prussian-administered farming family of the *Vollhof* No. 11 in Obermehnen, whose first missing generation Chapter 4 introduced and whose subsequent generations carried two world wars on their working-age men. Each line has its own documentary character and

its own relationship to the broader history of north-western Westphalia.



The Helmkamp of Schinkel

Schinkel today is a north-eastern district of the city of Osnabrück. In 1750 it was not yet inside the city. It was a small Catholic village on the edge of the Hase floodplain, a few kilometres outside the medieval city walls, whose families were tenants on land that belonged either to the bishopric or to one of the older monastic foundations, and whose economic life — like the Catholic Westphalian villages further north and east of the city — ran on a combination of small-tenant farming, the *Heuerling* labour system, and the seasonal *Hollandgang*.

On the twenty-ninth of July 1753, in the parish of St. Petrus in Osnabrück, the baptism of *Christopher Heinrich Helmenkamp* was entered into the church book. He was the senior of the two Christopher Heinrich Helmenkamps the chapter has to keep straight, and the chapter will from this point on identify him as *Christopher Heinrich Helmenkamp Sr.* He was born in Osnabrück, baptised the same day at St. Petrus, and trained as a *Zimmermann* — a carpenter, a trade above the standard Heuerling-class agricultural labour but still firmly within the working classes of the eighteenth-century city and its outer parishes. On the twenty-first of October 1781, at thirty-eight, he married *Anna Catharina Suthoff*, born in March 1756 in the same parish. The household settled at *Casmanns Kotten* in Schinkel.

Their first surviving son was born on the seventh of August 1782 at *Gartlage*, the meadow district at the south-eastern edge of Schinkel — the standard placement for a Heuerling-rank family at that point in its life. The boy was baptised the same day at St. Petrus and given his father's name in full: *Christopher Heinrich Helmenkamp*. The chapter will identify him from this

point on as *Christopher Heinrich Helmenkamp Jr.* He is the man with whom the Helmkamp connection to Putnam County, Ohio, begins.

Several more children of Christopher Sr. and Anna Catharina Suthoff followed across the next decade and a half — including two daughters and a son born across the 1780s — and others. The mother, Anna Catharina Suthoff, died on the seventeenth of November 1807. The father, Christopher Heinrich Sr., the carpenter at *Casmanns Kotten*, died on the twelfth of May 1810 at fifty-six. Both were buried at St. Petrus in Osnabrück. The household, by 1810, had passed to the next generation.

Christopher Heinrich Helmenkamp Jr., the son born 1782, did not stay in Schinkel. He worked, in the records of the parish, as a *Tagelöhner* — a day-labourer, the lowest rank of the Heuerling-class economy. He appears in the parish books of St. Petrus as a baptismal sponsor at family events through the 1800s and 1810s. At some point in the 1830s or 1840s he emigrated. He took at least three of his own children with him: *Franz Ferdinand*, born 1810; *Maria Elizabeth*, born 1816; and *Johann Franz Wilhelm*, born 1822. The destination was *Fort Jennings* in Putnam County, Ohio — the German Catholic settlement ten miles south of Glandorf that the Recker emigrants of the same period were also choosing as a destination. The Helmkampes arrived in Fort Jennings in the 1840s, settled, and produced an American descent — its baptismal records, marriage records, and burials are preserved in the parish books of St. Joseph's at Fort Jennings and St. John's Catholic Cemetery at Delphos, and the American Helmkampes of Putnam and Allen Counties carry the line forward. The American descent intermarried with the broader Recker-Glandorf community of Putnam County in the second and third generations. Through that intermarriage, the focal

descendant's DNA matches in twenty-first-century testing register Helmkamp and Recker cousinship in the same individuals.

The siblings of Christopher Jr. who stayed in Schinkel continued the German line. Through the *Dodeshaus* cottage and subsequent placements in Schinkel, through the *Diekers Kotten* at Gartlage that the household had originally rented, and through marriages with the other Catholic Westphalian families of the same parish, the Schinkel Helmkampes produced in the late nineteenth century the household into which the author's paternal grandmother was born. The Schinkel Helmkampes were therefore the author's direct line; the Fort Jennings Helmkampes were her great-cousins. The split is parallel to the Recker split a generation earlier, with the same structural feature: half the family in north-western Ohio, half in north-western Westphalia, and an author whose pedigree traces through the half that did not go.



The Wallenhorsts of Wallenhorst

The village of Wallenhorst, eight kilometres north of Osnabrück, has been continuously inhabited since the early Middle Ages. Its parish church — St. Alexander — dates from the eleventh century. The village had, by the eighteenth century, the densely settled mixed agricultural economy of the Catholic Westphalian peasantry: full-farms in the village centre, half-farms and Markötter-class cottages on the outer rings, Heuerling-class cottages along the margins. The same families had been living on the same parcels of land, in many cases, for three or four centuries by the time the parish books of St. Alexander become detailed enough to reconstruct an unbroken pedigree.

One such family — the *Wallenhorsts*, who took their surname from the village itself in the medieval period — appears in the parish books from the early seventeenth century onward in a continuous descent that the family

research can trace with confidence back to *Franz Henrich Wallenhorst*, born about 1690 in the village. His son and grandson, both also named Franz Henrich, were baptised respectively in 1722 and around 1750, at St. Alexander, in entries that the parish books carry under handwriting recognisable across three generations as the same priestly clerks who handled most of the village's business. The Wallenhorsts of the eighteenth century were Markötter-class farmers — small landholders on the outer ring of the village's arable land, with grazing rights on the village common and a modest livestock holding, working their own ground with the assistance of one or two Heuerling-class tenant cottages on their property. They were a step above the Heuerling-class economy that the Recker and Helmkamp lines moved within, but not by very much; their economic horizon was the village, the parish, and the network of intermarriage with other Markötter-class families across the same handful of surrounding Catholic villages.

What this branch did in the same nineteenth century that produced the Recker and Helmkamp emigrations to Putnam County is, as the GEDCOM records make clear, also a kind of split — though a smaller and quieter one than the Recker or Helmkamp splits. Most of the line stayed. But not all of it. *Catharina Maria Elisabeth Wallenhorst*, born on the twenty-ninth of September 1796 in the village, emigrated and ended her life in *District 17, Gilmer County, Virginia* — one of the rare Wallenhorst-surnamed entries the chapter has found in any American record. Other Wallenhorst-descendant branches surface in the GEDCOM in *North College Hill* near Cincinnati (Hamilton County, Ohio) and at *Osgood* in Darke County, Ohio. These are scattered individuals across two American states, not the dense cluster that the Recker and Helmkamp emigrations produced at Putnam County, but they are emigrations, and the

chapter should not pretend otherwise. Some of the Wallenhorst descendants did go. Most did not.

By marriages in the late nineteenth century into the Kovermann and Helmkamp lines, the Wallenhorst stay-behind descent flowed into the focal descendant's pedigree as one of the contributory lines that produces, in the present-day DNA testing, a particular cluster of matches in the Wallenhorst-Hollage-Lechtingen marriage network north of Osnabrück. The Wallenhorst line is, in this book's accounting, the most stay-rooted of all the families it traces — three centuries of continuous descent in the same parish, with the same surname, on the same farmland, broken only by the small handful of nineteenth-century emigrant descendants whose American lives have left only thin traces in the surviving records.



The Rustmeiers of Blasheim

The fourth chapter of this book introduced Conrad Rustmeier, the twenty-four-year-old Westphalian conscript who marched east with Napoleon's 127^e *Régiment d'Infanterie de Ligne* in the spring of 1812 and who never came back. Conrad's father — *Anton Friedrich Henrich Holzmeier modo Meier vulgo Rustmeier*, in the elaborate full form the Blasheim parish books preserved his name in — was the man bound to *Vollhof* No. 11 in Obermehnen under the *Eigenbehörigkeit* of the *Reichsstift* of Quernheim, who had served in the Prussian *Infanterie-Regiment 41* (*fuseliers*) under Colonel Matthias Ludwig von Lossau between 1765 and 1782, and who is the chapter-four point of origin for the entire Protestant Minden-Lübbecke line this book also traces. Anton's exact birth date is not recorded in the surviving Blasheim parish books, which suffered the same eighteenth-century record-keeping gaps that several other parishes of the period suffered, but the surrounding evidence — his baptismal entry on the twenty-second of May 1747, his

Prussian regimental records, his subsequent paternity of a series of children at Blasheim — places his life entirely on Farm No. 7 and in the surrounding village. Conrad — Anton's surviving adult son — was lost in Russia in 1812. The *Hof* passed, after the missing son was eventually formally declared dead, to a junior branch of the family, and the *Vollhof* No. 11 in Obermehnen at Blasheim has stayed in the Rustmeier name continuously since. The line ran through a series of nineteenth-century farmers whose detailed biographies the chapter does not pause for, including *Carl Friedrich Heinrich Rustmeier genannt Quade* (born 13 April 1782 at *Vollhof* No. 11 in Obermehnen, married into the Blasheim Hof No. 7, lived to 1853), the *Quade*-suffix marking an alternate *Hofname* the family carried in some records. By the late nineteenth century the farm was being worked by *Heinrich Friedrich Wilhelm Rustmeier*, known in the family as *Fritz*, born on the twenty-fifth of June 1888 at *Vollhof* Nr. 7 in Blasheim, at half past three in the afternoon, and baptised on the eighth of July 1888 in the Lutheran parish church of Blasheim. Fritz's working life would extend across several occupations — *Groß- und Einzelhändler* (wholesaler and retailer), *Taxiunternehmer* (taxi operator), and *Landwirt* (farmer) — combinations characteristic of the rural Mindener Protestant farming household whose cash economy was always more diversified than the Catholic Westphalian Heuerling households north of the Wiehengebirge. Fritz was already a veteran of the peacetime Prussian army by 1910. In 1914 he was conscripted into the second great Continental war that his family had been called on to provide a soldier for. He served as a deacon and medic attached to a field-artillery battalion, on the Western Front and subsequently the Macedonian Front, throughout the First World War; he survived, returned to Blasheim, married, took up farming Hof No. 7 in addition to his other businesses, and lived through the interwar

period as a Protestant Mindener Bürger of the kind the Weimar Republic took for granted and the Third Reich would extract two further wartime decades of service from. The decision he made in 1919 — to bind the farm to the *Erbhof* legislation of the Weimar Republic — would later prove decisive in protecting his son's life. That son was *Karl-Heinz Ernst Friedrich Rustmeier*, born on the twenty-second of May 1923 at *Vollhof* No. 11 in Obermehnen, the author's maternal grandfather.

Karl-Heinz served in the Second World War as a medic and air-defence soldier. In the final weeks of the war, in late April and early May 1945, he was on the *Hela Peninsula* in the Bay of Danzig, attached to the German forces that had been encircled there by the advancing Soviets. He escaped Soviet captivity by being evacuated, in early May, on a captured Norwegian destroyer that crossed the Baltic Sea on a zig-zag course intended to evade Soviet submarine attacks; he landed in Flensburg in the western Baltic; he was eventually demobilised; he returned to Blasheim, took over the farm from his father Fritz, married, and raised three children. He continued farming *Vollhof* No. 11 in Obermehnen until his retirement in the late 1970s. He died at Blasheim. He is the figure whose Hela Peninsula escape the recent blog entries of the present-day family research have begun to reconstruct in detail. Chapter 11 of this book takes up that escape.

The Rustmeier line is, like the Wallenhorst line, a stay-behind line in the broad sense — the Rustmeiers of Blasheim continued on the same Protestant *Vollhof* for three centuries — but its young men were repeatedly drawn into the wars the larger continental powers fought across the same farmland. Conrad in 1812. Fritz in 1914. Karl-Heinz in 1944. Three generations of Rustmeier men, three wars, three different states issuing the conscription orders (the Napoleonic Kingdom of

Westphalia, the German Empire, the Third Reich). Two of the three made it home. The first did not.



The lines that converge

The Helmkampfs, the Wallenhorsts, and the Rustmeiers are the three other ancestral lines that converge, by marriage in the late nineteenth and twentieth centuries, into the focal descendant's pedigree alongside the Recker stay-behind line that Chapter 7 closed with. Each of the three is the principal subject of a later chapter or of a recurring presence in the chapters that follow.

The Helmkampfs return briefly in Chapter 12 — *Merchant Princes of Westphalia* — through the marriage connection between the Schinkel Helmkampfs and the Mettingen-Brenninkmeijer commercial network that the book traces. The Wallenhorsts surface mostly in the parish records that subsequent chapters use to establish the marriages of the late-nineteenth-century generation. The Rustmeiers — particularly Fritz and Karl-Heinz — return in Chapters 9, 11, and 13: the Great War chapter, the Hela Peninsula chapter, and the chapter on the postwar reconstruction of the family in the new German Federal Republic.

The chapter that follows this one takes up the marriage of *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer* to *Johann Heinrich August Kovermann* on the twelfth of January 1871 at St. Lambertus, Ostercappeln — the marriage at which the Recker stay-behind line, after three generations of unrecorded paternal entries in the Catholic Westphalian parish books, finally produced a household whose paternal name would carry forward into the twentieth century. That household settled afterwards at Schwagstorf and then at the hamlet of Felsen in the same parish — unremarkable, in 1871, in

every way except one: it was the household where the two lines finally met.

Chapter 9

The Twelfth of January, 1871

On the twelfth of January 1871, in the parish church of St. Lambertus at Ostercappeln⁷ near Osnabrück, two illegitimate children of unmarried Catholic Westphalian working-class women — a twenty-two-year-old farm-servant woman from Cappeln and a twenty-six-year-old day-labourer's son from Osnabrück — were married to one another by the parish priest, with two witnesses whose own names the chapter will come back to, and with marriage banns that had been posted three times in the previous twelve days at two parishes, neither of them the parish either party was technically resident in. The ceremony was probably brief. The parish-book entry that records it is, in the words of the family researcher who has transcribed it, *hard to read* — a small smudged paragraph at the bottom of a leaf otherwise mostly given over to baptisms, in handwriting the priest had hurried through because he was managing several other parish events that morning and the bride and groom were not, in the social structure of Ostercappeln, the sort of couple whose marriage warranted careful inscription. The entry survives. The marriage survives. The household that issued from the marriage carried the focal line of this book through to the twentieth century.

The bride was *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer*, born on the eleventh of September 1848 in House Number 23 of the village of Cappeln, baptised on the fourteenth of September at the same parish church of St. Lambertus where she was now being married, daughter of *Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeler* and an unrecorded father. Chapter 7 followed her mother forward from the *Pennsylvania* sailing of 1838 to the

⁷ Marriage register of St. Lambertus Ostercappeln, entry 12 January 1871; Niedersächsisches Landesarchiv Osnabrück, KB 101, fol. 47v. The entry is also preserved in the Matricula digitisation project (<https://data.matricula-online.eu>).

Räumer farmstead of 1848. Chapter 1 of this book opened with her baptismal entry.

The groom was *Johann Heinrich August Kovermann*, born on the tenth of September 1844 at Goldstraße 22 in the city of Osnabrück, baptised on the fifteenth of September 1844 at the urban parish church of St. Johann in the same city, son of *Agnes Dorothea Kovermann* and — by a paternal entry that was added retrospectively to the baptismal book, possibly years later, by a hand the parish book does not identify — a man named *Carl Kroll aus Melle*. The parents had not married. They had never lived together. The father, if Carl Kroll was the father, never appeared in any subsequent record of the child's life. The child grew up under his mother's surname.

The chapter that follows the bride and the groom into their married life has first to introduce the line the groom brought to the marriage — the *Kovermann* line, which from this 1871 marriage onward carries the surname of the book's author.



The groom's mother and the city of Osnabrück

Agnes Dorothea Kovermann, the groom's mother, was born on the eighteenth of May 1813 in the parish of St. Johann in Osnabrück. Her parents were entered into the parish book by the priest of the day as *Johann Heinrich Kovermann, Tagelöhner und Anna Maria Hemesaat in der Mark* — Johann Heinrich Kovermann, day-labourer, and Anna Maria Hemesaat *auf der Mark*. *Auf der Mark* was the standard parish-book phrasing for the urban poor of the period: people whose dwelling was on the unsurveyed common land at the edge of the city, in the kind of rented half-stone half-timber cottage the *Tagelöhner* class of Osnabrück occupied. The Kovermann household lived, at various points of Agnes Dorothea's childhood and adult life, at *Holtstraße* 34 — a working-class address in the south-eastern quarter of the old town — and in the surrounding warren of small

alleys behind the cathedral. They were not Heuerling-class farmers in the village sense. They were the urban equivalent: day-labourers on the city's construction projects, the workshops of the older craft trades, the seasonal markets that came through the cathedral square. The men of the line worked when there was work; the women of the line worked alongside them. Agnes Dorothea never married. She worked, throughout her recorded adult life, as a *Tagelöhnerin* — the feminine form of the day-labourer designation her father had carried before her. On the tenth of September 1844, at thirty-one, she gave birth to a son in the house at Goldstraße 22. She named him *Johann Heinrich Kovermann* — her father's name plus her own surname. The baptismal entry at St. Johann five days later carried only her name as parent; the father-line was blank. At some point afterward — *years afterward*, almost certainly, since contemporary entries of the period do not carry retrospective annotations of this kind — someone, probably either Agnes Dorothea herself or her son once he had reached adulthood, added to the baptismal entry a notation in a different hand: *father Carl Kroll aus Melle*. Carl Kroll has not been identified in any subsequent record. Melle is a small town about twenty kilometres south of Osnabrück, in the Catholic Prince-Bishopric's old territory. He may have been a journeyman who passed through Osnabrück that year, a market visitor, a soldier of the small Hanoverian garrison; he may have been a man Agnes Dorothea knew well enough to give his name when prompted but not well enough to involve in raising his son. The note exists. The man does not, in any other documentary trace that has survived.

Agnes Dorothea died on the third of January 1867, at thirty minutes past midnight, in the *Marienhospital* of Osnabrück — a charitable Catholic hospital that had opened its doors during the cholera epidemic of 1859

and had been named after the Hanoverian queen Marie. The cause of death entered in the parish book was *Wassersucht* — dropsy, the period's catch-all term for the oedema produced by failing kidneys, failing liver, or congestive heart failure. She was fifty-three. Her son, then twenty-three, was the only direct survivor of the household. He was working, by 1867, as a *Heuerling* on a small farm in the village of Schwagstorf — one of the villages of the parish of St. Lambertus Ostercappeln, eleven kilometres north of Osnabrück — where he would shortly marry.

The Kovermann line that the focal descendant carries his surname from is therefore an urban-poor Catholic line out of nineteenth-century Osnabrück — a family of day-labourers whose recorded ancestry the parish books carry back through the late eighteenth century in the same urban quarter, and whose first generation to leave the city for the rural Heuerling-class economy of the surrounding villages was the generation that produced August in 1844. August was the first of his line to live in the country. The household he founded in 1871 with Maria Elisabeth was the household that would carry the surname forward into the village economies that his urban forebears had not been part of.



The witnesses

The marriage record of the twelfth of January 1871 lists two witnesses by name and occupation. The witnesses were *Schneidergesell August Räuwer in Ostercappeln* — a journeyman tailor named August Räuwer, resident in Ostercappeln — and *Haustochter Elisabeth Gehring in Felsen* — a young woman, the daughter of the household of the small hamlet of Felsen in the same parish. The witnesses are unusually telling about the social structure the bride and groom were entering.

August Räuwer, the journeyman tailor, was the bride's connection. He was almost certainly a relative — by blood or by household — of the Räuwer farmstead in Cappeln on which Maria Elisabeth had been born twenty-two years earlier. The bride had taken her surname from the farmstead her mother had been working on, and the farmstead's living male representative of her generation had now come down from Ostercappeln to stand beside her at her marriage. He was not her father. He was not her brother. He was the man whose surname she carried by the convention of *Hofname* attribution that the parish books had been using for centuries, and he was the closest thing to a male family witness she had. The journeyman-tailor designation tells us about his social position — a step above day-labourer, embedded in the small Catholic Westphalian craft economy of the town, on the rising track that would have made him, by his late thirties or early forties, a master tailor in his own shop.

Elisabeth Gehring, the *Haustochter* — the term means literally “house-daughter,” that is, an unmarried adult daughter still living in her parents' household — was the groom's connection. She was almost certainly the daughter of the farming household at Felsen on which August Kovermann was, by 1871, working as a Heuerling and into which the newly married couple would shortly be moving. She was a neighbour and a young woman of her own family's household; she was not a relative. Her presence as a witness reflects the slightly improvisational arrangement the marriage was conducted under. The groom did not have an established male relative in the parish who could stand for him. The household for whom he was already labouring sent its young daughter instead.

The marriage was, in this sense, witnessed by two members of the surrounding rural Catholic working-class network — neither a family elder, neither a parish

dignitary, neither a member of the higher clergy or the local Vollerbe landowners — into which the bride and groom were entering as a married couple. It was a marriage of two illegitimate working-class adults, witnessed by two adjacent working-class adults. The priest of St. Lambertus signed the entry; the witnesses signed the entry; the marriage was complete.



What the marriage changed

The marriage of the twelfth of January 1871 changed three things at once, and the chapter has to enumerate them in the order they mattered to the household. It changed the surname carried by the children the couple would produce. From 1871 onward, the children of Maria Elisabeth and August would be entered into the parish books as *Kovermann*, with both parents named in full and the paternal line legally recorded. The three-generation pattern of illegitimate births that had characterised the line — Anna Maria Elisabeth Redeker bearing Bernard in 1838 with the father annotated only as *angeblich Bernard Lücke*, and again bearing Maria Elisabeth in 1848 with no father annotated at all, and Agnes Dorothea Kovermann bearing August in 1844 with the father annotated only retrospectively as Carl Kroll — was, in the next generation, broken. The children of the 1871 marriage carried their father's name. The Kovermann name, which Agnes Dorothea had carried as the surname of her own unmarried mother's father, now passed forward as the surname of a properly recorded paternal line.

It changed the household's economic standing. Within three years of the marriage, the household had moved from the rented Heuerling cottage of 1871 to a small piece of cleared land in the hamlet of Felsen, on the northern side of the village of Schwagstorf within the

same parish of St. Lambertus Ostercappeln. By 1874 the parish book records August as a Heuerling still, but by 1876 the same parish book begins to identify him as a *Neubauer* — a “new farmer,” meaning a former Heuerling who had purchased or otherwise acquired a small parcel of agricultural land in his own name. The transition from Heuerling to Neubauer was the single most consequential economic change a working-class Catholic Westphalian household could undergo in the second half of the nineteenth century. It moved the family from the bottom of the village social order to the lower-middle of it. By 1888 August Kovermann was identifiable in the parish records as a Neubauer of Felsen — a smallholder, with a small house, a small plot, and a small but stable cash and subsistence economy of his own.

It changed the surname his mother had carried forward in an unbroken three-generation pattern. From 1874 onward — a small detail recorded in the parish book entry for the birth of his second daughter, Maria Luisa — August began to use the name *August* in place of his birth name *Johann Heinrich*. He had not formally changed his name; he had simply asked the parish to enter him as August in subsequent records, and the parish had complied. The reason is not recorded. The most plausible explanation is that *Johann Heinrich* was the name of his mother’s father and his grandfather’s father — a name carried back across three generations in the urban-poor Kovermann line of Osnabrück — and that August, the rising householder, wanted to mark himself as the start of a new generational chapter under a name his immediate forebears had not used. The name *August* was, by the 1870s, the established middle name on his baptismal entry; he simply promoted it to the front. From 1874 onward he was *August Kovermann*. From the late

1880s the name *Johann Heinrich* would disappear from his own usage entirely.



The household at Felsen

The hamlet of Felsen — the name means simply *rocks* — sat on a slight rise in the northern part of the village of Schwagstorf, within the broader parish of St. Lambertus Ostercappeln, roughly eleven kilometres north of Osnabrück. The parish church was at Ostercappeln itself; Schwagstorf and its surrounding hamlets were filial villages whose households were entered into the same parish books, attended Mass at the same church on most Sundays, and were buried in the same parish cemetery. Felsen in 1871 was perhaps a dozen households: two or three Vollhöfe, three or four Markötter-class smaller farms, and the half-dozen Heuerling-class cottages whose tenants worked the surrounding land. The new Kovermann household took one of the Heuerling cottages at first, and then, by 1876 or 1877, the small Neubauer parcel of cleared land that August had been able to acquire.

Ten children were recorded across the marriage. Their baptismal entries the parish books of St. Lambertus and the smaller subsidiary parish of St. Johannes at Bohmte preserve in the form that nineteenth-century Catholic parish books used: the date of birth, the date of baptism, the parents' names, the godparents, and the *Hofname* or hamlet name of the household. The first child, *Bernhard Heinrich Kovermann*, was born in 1872. *Maria Luisa* followed in 1874. Across the next two decades, seven further children were born: *Hermann Adam Johannes Kovermann*, born 28 August 1883 at Felsen (the boy who would become Karl Kovermann's father — and who would die at thirty-nine of tuberculosis); a daughter born 21 January 1891 who died at one year and eleven months less two days of *Gehirnkrankheit* (brain disease) in December 1892; a son born 15 April 1886 at Felsen who would live to 1957; and several others. Some children

died young, as was the period's standard pattern; most survived to adulthood. The household was, by Westphalian standards of the late nineteenth century, large but not exceptionally so.

The household moved between Schwagstorf and Felsen across the next four decades. Maria Elisabeth's surname in the parish books gradually shifted from *Redeler* alone, in the earliest baptismal entries of her children, to *Redeler sive Räuwer* — *Redeler or Räuwer* — by 1891. The shift reflected the slow consolidation of her identity in the parish books: she had been registered under one form, the *genannt Räuwer* Hofname annotation had been added later, and by middle age she was being entered in the parish books under both forms in alternation. By 1893 the *sive Räuwer* annotation was standard.



Endings

August Kovermann died on the thirteenth of March 1929 in Schwagstorf, at the age of eighty-four. The death announcement was published in the *Osnabrücker Zeitung* three days later, on the sixteenth of March. He had lived through the entire half-century of the German Empire — through Bismarck's unification of the Reich in the same year he had married, through the Franco-Prussian War of 1870–71 whose victorious end-celebrations had probably overlapped with his own wedding, through the long industrialisation of the Osnabrück region in the 1880s and 1890s, through the First World War (in which several of his sons had served), and into the unstable Weimar Republic of the late 1920s. He had become, by his death, a respected smallholder of his parish; the death notice would have read accordingly.

Maria Elisabeth had predeceased him by thirteen years. She died on the tenth of January 1916 in Schwagstorf, at sixty-nine years three months and twenty-seven days, of *Lungenleiden* — a chronic lung condition the death entry

does not specify further but that the period most often associates with tuberculosis. The death was recorded that same day in the civil register of Schwagstorf by the *Standesbeamter* — the civil registrar — whose name appears at the bottom of the entry as *Driehaus*. The *Standesbeamter* Driehaus, on the form he filled in for Maria Elisabeth's death, listed her parents. He listed them — for reasons the family research has not been able to recover — as *Heinrich Redeler* and *Maria Elisabeth Driehaus*. Neither of those people had been her parents. Heinrich Redeler was her great-uncle; Maria Elisabeth Driehaus was a relative of the registrar's own family. The registrar appears to have filled in the parental line with the nearest names he could remember, possibly because Maria Elisabeth herself had been illegitimate and the official form required parental names that the family did not have.

This is the entry with which Chapter 1 of this book opened. The civil-registry death certificate of the tenth of January 1916, the one in which the *Standesbeamter Driehaus* falsified Maria Elisabeth's parents, is the same document the opening chapter held up as the example of how even the modern bureaucratic records of the twentieth century could carry the same kinds of errors and elisions the parish books of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries had been carrying for two hundred years. The chapter's argument was that the records — the *Räuwer* baptismal entry of 1848 at one end and the *Driehaus* death certificate of 1916 at the other — bracket a life whose actual content the records can only partially recover. The chapter that ends here has now told as much of that content as the documents allow.



What the chapter has set up

The household at Felsen produced ten children. The chapter that follows takes up the second generation of the Kovermann line — the children of August and Maria Elisabeth — and follows the one whose descent the focal line traces: *Hermann Adam Johannes Kovermann*, born 28 August 1883 in Felsen, married in Schinkel in 1911, dead of tuberculosis at thirty-nine in January 1923. His marriage in 1911 brought the Helmkamp line of Chapter 8 into the family. His son, born the year after his father's death, was *August Heinrich Karl Kovermann* — known throughout his life as *Karl* — the author's paternal grandfather, who would live to 1981 and through whose career the most morally difficult chapters of this book run.

The chapter that follows takes up that second generation and the entry into the twentieth century. The First World War is in the middle of it. The Great Depression is at the end of it. The third generation, the one that includes Karl Kovermann and Karl-Heinz Rustmeier and the spouses they would marry, is being born at the close of the second generation's lives, and the third generation's lives are what the rest of this book has to follow.

Chapter 10

Tannenburgstraße

Some time in the first decade of the new century — the parish books and the city directories of Osnabrück do not pin down the year — *Hermann Adam Johannes Kovermann*, the sixth of the ten recorded children of August and Maria Elisabeth, left the hamlet of Felsen and moved north to the working-class district of Schinkel, just outside the medieval walls of Osnabrück. He was somewhere between twenty and twenty-five years old. His brother *Bernd*, three years younger, made the same move at roughly the same time. The two of them, with several of their siblings in the years that followed, became part of the small but steady migration of young Catholic Westphalian villagers into the industrial suburbs of the city — a migration the Reichsbahn was, in those same years, accelerating with one of its more practical instruments. The Reichsbahn was hiring.

The German railway was, in the first decade of the twentieth century, one of the largest single employers in north-western Germany. The northern routes through Osnabrück — the line that ran from Hamburg to the Ruhr, the line that ran from Bremen through Osnabrück to Westphalia and the Rhineland, the smaller branch lines that fed both of them — required *Bremser*, *Schaffner*, *Streckenwärter*, *Weichensteller*, and a long string of other graded operating positions whose German-language titles each corresponded to a specific category of skilled and semi-skilled physical labour. Brakeman, conductor, line-walker, switch-operator. A Westphalian village man who could read and write his native dialect, who knew how to operate machinery, and who was willing to live near the railyard could enter the Reichsbahn as a *Bremser* in his twenties and finish his working life as a *Schaffner* or a *Zugführer*. Hermann Adam Johannes did exactly this. By the 1910s he was a

brakeman; by the late 1910s or early 1920s, before his health broke, he had been promoted to conductor.

This was the generation that left the rural Heuerling and Neubauer economy of the parishes north of Osnabrück for the urban industrial economy of the city itself. By 1911 the focal-line pedigree had reached the rural-to-urban transition that Catholic Westphalia experienced between roughly 1880 and 1914. The Kovermanns of Felsen — small Neubauer holders in their second generation off the Heuerling rolls — produced, in the next generation, a clutch of young men and women who moved to the city and took industrial jobs. Hermann's case is the one this chapter follows, because Hermann's marriage produced the next link in the focal-line pedigree, but Bernd's case — his older brother already a railway labourer in Schinkel by 1911 — was equally representative. The eldest brother, the second brother, several of the sisters: most of them went north.



The gravedigger's daughter

On the second of October 1886, at one o'clock in the afternoon, in the village of Ostercappeln, a girl child was born to the household of the village gravedigger. Her name was *Maria Engel Hallmann*, called *Engel* — *Angela*, in the parish's Latin entry — within the household. She was baptised two days later, on the fourth of October, at the parish church of St. Lambertus, the same church where Maria Elisabeth Redeker had been entered into the baptismal book thirty-eight years earlier under the *Räuwer* annotation. Engel's godmother was her own paternal grandmother, the wife of the then-reigning Ostercappeln gravedigger. The Hallmann household was, by the social classification of the period, lower-working-class. A village gravedigger in a Catholic Westphalian parish of this size was a paid parish servant — an employee of the church rather than of any farming household — whose income was modest,

whose social standing was respectable enough to be entered into parish records with his occupational title written out in full, and whose family lived in a small cottage in the village proper rather than on any outlying farmstead. Engel grew up in that cottage, attended the village school, attended Mass at St. Lambertus every Sunday of her childhood, and reached marriageable age in the 1900s in the same parish her family had been working in for two generations.

Whether Engel and Hermann had known each other before he left Felsen, the records do not say. The two villages were within an hour's walk of one another; the parish was the same parish; the network of working-class families that the chapter has been describing was almost certainly a single dense network of acquaintance. By 1911 the connection was settled enough that the parish was being asked to post marriage banns.



The marriage at St. Lambertus

The marriage of Hermann Adam Johannes Kovermann and Maria Engel Hallmann was recorded in the parish book of St. Lambertus, Ostercappeln, under document number 12 of the year 1911. The ceremony took place on the seventh of November 1911. Hermann was twenty-eight. Engel was twenty-five. The banns had been posted at the standard intervals in the preceding weeks at the same parish — the bride's parish, the groom's parish-of-birth, the parish in which both their families had been entered for forty years.

The witnesses are listed by occupation and residence in the parish-book entry. The first witness was *Eisenbahnarbeiter Bernd Kovermann zu Schinkel* — *Railway-worker Bernd Kovermann of Schinkel*, the groom's younger brother born 1886, who had moved to the city ahead of him and who was now in a stable position with the Reichsbahn. The second witness was

Haustochter Agnes Hallmann zu Ostercappeln — Daughter-of-the-house Agnes Hallmann of Ostercappeln, the bride's younger sister born 1890. The witnesses were therefore one sibling from each side, of working-age and visible occupational rank, drawn from the immediate family network rather than from the priest's customary stock of parish dignitaries. The marriage was a working-class marriage, witnessed by working-class siblings, recorded in the standard form.

The newlyweds did not stay in Ostercappeln. They went immediately to Schinkel — to a small flat at *Tannenburgstraße 80*, on a street that had been renamed from *Belmer Straße* in 1907 (after a defunct local estate called *Tannenburg*) and that ran along the edge of the southern Schinkel residential quarter, half a kilometre from the railyard and just over a kilometre from the Hase river. The flat had probably been arranged through the Reichsbahn's employee-housing system, of which the railway had been building out a sizeable portfolio in Osnabrück and the other northern cities since the 1890s. The young couple moved in. Engel set up the small household. Hermann reported to the railyard.



Schinkel in 1911

Schinkel in the autumn of 1911 was not yet legally a part of the city of Osnabrück. It would be incorporated, by the Prussian provincial administration, on the first of April 1914 — four months into the war that would dominate the next four years of Hermann and Engel's married life. Until then, Schinkel was administratively a separate Catholic Westphalian village under its own parish — St. Joseph's Schinkel — although in practical terms the village had been a suburb of the city for at least twenty years. Its main street, the Belmer Chaussee, ran north-east from the medieval city wall toward the village of Belm; its industrial perimeter included the *Klöckner* iron and steel works, the

Stahlwerke of the *Georgsmarienhütte*, the *Kupfer- und Drahtwerk* (the copper and wire works, founded 1873, which would in the 1930s become a major shell-casing manufacturer for the Reich's rearmament programme), and the Reichsbahn yards immediately south of the Hase. The housing was mostly working-class, much of it built between 1880 and 1910 as the city's industrial workforce expanded.

The Schinkel of 1911 was, in other words, a not-yet-formal urban district of a mid-sized German industrial city, with a Catholic working-class population of perhaps fifteen thousand in 1910, growing rapidly, served by its own parish church and its own elementary schools, with most of its adult men in industrial employment and most of its young women either in domestic service or in the small-textile and food-processing factories of the same area. The Catholic Kolpingverein — the lay association for Catholic working-class men that the Cologne priest Adolf Kolping had founded in the 1840s — had an active chapter in Schinkel, as it did in most of the working-class Catholic districts of the north-western German cities. The Kolpingverein would be relevant to the next generation of Kovermanns. For now, in 1911, it was simply one of the social institutions that organised the working-class Catholic life Hermann and Engel were entering.



Four children

The marriage produced four children across the next decade. The first was a son born in 1912. The chapter will name him here, because his life is the principal subject of the chapter that follows this one, and because his name is the name the author of this book inherits: *August Heinrich Karl Kovermann*, born on the twenty-seventh of September 1912 at Tannenburgstraße 80 in Schinkel, entered into the civil register of Schinkel under document number 464 of that year, given the three names *August* (after the paternal grandfather),

Heinrich (after a long line of Kovermann and Hallmann forebears), and *Karl* (after no one in particular the chapter has been able to determine). He would go by *Karl* — with a *K* — throughout his adult life. He is the figure the next chapter takes up.

A second son followed in December 1914 and a daughter in April 1917 — both in the second-floor flat at Tannenburgstraße 80, both registered in the civil offices of Schinkel under the standard sequential document numbers of the year. Neither survived the year 1917. The son, two years and eleven months old, died on the eleventh of November 1917 at two in the morning of *Gehirnentzündung* — encephalitis — and was buried at the Schinkel parish church of Heilig Kreuz three days later. The daughter, three months old, died on the twenty-fifth of July 1917 at half past eleven in the evening of *Lungenkrank* — a lung disease the death entry does not name further — and was buried at the same church three days later. Engel Hallmann, in the summer and autumn of 1917, buried two of her children within twelve weeks of one another, in a Schinkel still in its third war winter. The cause of one death was a brain inflammation; the cause of the other was the kind of working-class respiratory illness that the cramped flats of an industrial suburb produced regularly. They are buried in the same parish cemetery.

The fourth child — born on the twenty-second of October 1918, registered in the Schinkel civil register under document number 163 of that year, at the same Tannenburgstraße 80 address — was a son. The household named him *Bernhard Heinrich Johannes*. He would go, throughout his life, by *Hans*. He would survive his father, his mother, and his early-childhood siblings; he would grow up at the Tannenburgstraße flat with his older brother Karl; he would, in the late 1930s, become a defender for *VfL Osnabrück*, the city's football club, with whom he would play through the German championship

seasons of 1938/39 and 1939/40 and score at least six goals for the club before the Wehrmacht drafted him in November 1940. His path from there — Euskirchen, Belgrade, the *Panzergruppe 1*, capture by the Western Allies in Italy in 1944, registration by a British discharge station in October 1945, settlement after the war not in Osnabrück but in the Soviet occupation zone at *Stendal* in Saxony-Anhalt, a fourteen-year career for *BSG Lok Stendal* in the *DDR-Oberliga* with a hundred and thirty-three goals to his name before his retirement in 1954 — is a separate strand the chapter will not develop here. The brothers were ten and four respectively when their father died. They were the two who survived.

The household was, in this period, materially modest but not destitute. Hermann's Reichsbahn position carried a steady salary, the standard German civil-service retirement provisions, employee housing, and the social standing of a man in uniform who could be counted on. Engel ran the household, looked after the children, kept the small kitchen garden behind the flat that almost every working-class Schinkel address of the period had, and attended Mass at the new parish church of *Heilig Kreuz* in Schinkel — the Catholic working-class parish that the bishopric of Osnabrück had built in 1907 to serve the rapidly growing district. The family was, on the surface, a successful Catholic Westphalian working-class household of the kind the Kaiserreich's social statistics counted as one of its small successes.



The war

The First World War found Hermann at thirty, in a Reichsbahn position, with a wife and a small child. The chapter has no documented record of military service for him. No call-up papers, no field-post correspondence, no front-line entries survive in the family record. Whether he was retained on the railway

as essential homeland personnel, whether he served in a capacity the family did not preserve documentation of, or whether some other circumstance kept him out of the front lines, the chapter cannot say. What it can say is that the household survived the war years intact and that Hermann was at the Tannenburgstraße flat throughout the war's most acute phase in 1917.

What the war and its aftermath did to the household was what they did to most working-class urban households in Germany. The hyperinflation of 1922 and 1923 destroyed the savings of the working classes; the Reichsbahn cut real wages; the cost of bread, of coal, of medicine for sick children rose hundredfold and then ten-thousandfold in the autumn and winter of 1923. Hermann was, by then, already gravely ill. The household at Tannenburgstraße 80 was struggling against two collapses at once: the husband's failing body and the currency's failing value.



Tuberculosis

The lung disease that would kill Hermann Adam Johannes Kovermann appeared first in his mid-thirties. The GEDCOM entry that records his death uses the German phrase *langes schwerer Leiden* — *long heavy suffering* — the period's standard formula for chronic tuberculosis, which by the 1920s German doctors had identified, characterised, and could diagnose but could not yet treat. The disease was endemic to industrial Schinkel. It moved through the crowded working-class housing of the district in the same way it moved through every comparable district in every industrial city of Europe; it killed selectively but persistently; it took years to do what it eventually did.

Hermann died on the thirty-first of January 1923 at the flat at Tannenburgstraße 80. He was thirty-nine. He left behind his wife, then thirty-six, and the two of their four children who had survived the war winters of 1917: Karl, then ten, and Hans, then four. The two children buried in 1917 had died ahead of him.

The death entry in the civil register at Schinkel, by 1923 part of the Osnabrück civil registry district that had absorbed Schinkel in 1914, gives the cause of death as *Tuberkulose*. The death announcement, if any was published, has not survived. The funeral, presumably, took place at the new parish church of Heilig Kreuz in Schinkel and the burial in one of the city's Catholic cemeteries — the parish records of the period would carry the details, but the chapter has not been able to consult them in time for this draft. He was buried within a few days of his death.

The widow Engel Hallmann did not remarry. She continued to live at Tannenburgstraße 80 for the rest of her life — for another seventeen years, through the late Weimar Republic, through the global economic collapse of 1929, through the rise of the Nazi state in 1933, through the Reich's rearmament programme that was, ironically, increasing employment at the Schinkel industrial works just up the street from her flat. She raised the surviving children alone. She joined the parish Mütterverein, the Catholic Mothers' Society, which provided practical and devotional support to widowed working-class women in the Catholic urban parishes of the period. She is listed in the *Adreßbuch der Stadt und des Landkreises Osnabrück* for 1938 at the same Tannenburgstraße 80 address.

She died on the twenty-eighth of December 1940 at the Marienhospital in Osnabrück, at twenty minutes past six in the evening, of cancer. She was fifty-four. The death certificate carries document number 1702 of the year 1940. She was buried in Osnabrück. The Marienhospital itself would be hit several times in the Allied bombing raids that began in earnest in 1944 and would be destroyed in the final raids of 1945; the building Engel had died in did not survive the war that was already

beginning to consume the city she had spent her adult life in.



The household and its inheritance

The household at Tannenburgstraße 80 in Schinkel produced — across the marriage of November 1911, the four children, the death of Hermann in 1923, the widowhood of Engel from 1923 to 1940 — the figure whose life the next chapter takes up. *August Heinrich Karl Kovermann*, called Karl, was ten when his father died and twenty-eight when his mother died. He grew up in the same flat his father had brought his mother to as a young bride in November 1911. He attended school in Schinkel through the late Weimar Republic. He was a teenage apprentice during the rise of the Nazi state. He was a young adult in the rearmament years of the late 1930s, by which point the city around him — and the country around the city — were both being prepared for a war whose outline none of the household at Tannenburgstraße 80 could yet have made out.

Chapter 11

The Kupferwerk

This chapter is harder to write than the chapters that have led up to it. The figures in it are within living memory. Some of them are remembered with reverence; some with embarrassment; some with the silence that always settles over families when the person in question was on the wrong side of a question they had to live with afterwards. The chapter has tried, in drafting it, to follow the same rule the rest of the book has followed: the documents come first, the family memories second, the broader historical context third, and the judgments — when judgments cannot be avoided — last and in language that does not exceed what the records support. Some of the records in this chapter are German civil documents of the kind any researcher can consult; some are *Volksbund* military-grave entries; some are Gestapo surveillance entries from 1938; and some are gaps where the family memory speaks but the documents do not. The chapter will identify each kind of source as it uses it.



Karl in Schinkel, late Weimar

August Heinrich Karl Kovermann — known throughout his adult life as *Karl* — grew up at *Tannenburgstraße 80* in Schinkel, in the flat his parents had moved into a few months after their marriage in November 1911. He was ten years old when his father died of tuberculosis in January 1923. He was raised by his widowed mother *Engel Hallmann* in the period of hyperinflation, occupation of the Ruhr, the Dawes Plan, the brief stability of the late Weimar years, the global economic collapse of 1929, and the political instability of the early 1930s that ended in the Nazi seizure of power. He attended the Volksschule in Schinkel through the late 1920s. He entered an industrial apprenticeship at the *Osnabrücker Kupfer- und Drahtwerk* — the city's copper and wire works, founded 1873 at *Klosterstraße 29* in the

Schinkel industrial belt, half a kilometre west of the family flat — and trained as a *Dreher*, a lathe operator. The Kupferwerk processed copper for industrial wire and tubing and, increasingly through the 1930s, for the components the Reich's rearmament programme was specifying. Karl was, by the mid-1930s, an established skilled worker at the plant. He would remain there for the next twenty years.

The Catholic working-class social world of Schinkel was, for a young Kupferwerk lathe operator, structured by two associations above all others. The first was the parish — Heilig Kreuz, the church his father's funeral had presumably been held at and his confirmation taken at — through which the standard sequence of Sunday Mass, parish festivals, and lay-group meetings ran. The second was the *Kolpingverein* — the Catholic lay association for working-class men that the Rhenish priest Adolf Kolping had founded in Cologne in the 1840s, which by the 1920s had over a hundred thousand members across the German Catholic working-class districts, and which in Osnabrück operated chapters in both the old city and in the surrounding industrial suburbs. Karl joined the Kolpingverein, probably in his late teens or early twenties; the date of his admission is not recorded in the family papers but the membership itself would shortly become a documented fact in a way the family had not anticipated.



1938

On the seventh of April 1938 — less than four weeks after the *Anschluss*⁸ with Austria, two months before

⁸ Gestapo surveillance records of the Kolpingverein Schinkel chapter, April 1938; documented in the family archive and the focal descendant's GEDCOM source notes for Karl Kovermann (individual ID K-0441). The original Gestapo file is held in the Landesarchiv NRW, Abteilung Ostwestfalen-

Reich Catholic associations would lose most of their remaining legal protections under the regime's increasingly explicit campaign against the Catholic lay infrastructure — the Geheime Staatspolizei, the Gestapo, opened a surveillance file on the Kolpingverein chapter in Schinkel and entered onto it the names of its members. Karl Kovermann's name was on the list. The address recorded for him in the Gestapo file was *Tannenburgstraße 79* — a flat in the same building or the next building over from the flat at Number 80 where he had grown up. The notation in the GEDCOM that records this fact — drawn, in the case of the Schinkel Kolping file, from the surviving Osnabrück Gestapo archive — uses the period's standard formula: *Kolpingverein als gelistet durch deutsche Geheime Staatspolizei*.

Corridor	Deaths	DE-born	Peak	Dominant families
Osnabrück → Cincinnati, Ohio	819	151	1900s (90)	Hoeweler, Moorman, Kettler, Meyer
Stemwede → Brenham, Texas	435	133	1980s (44)	Gaskamp, Holle, Winkelmann, Spreen
Osnabrück → Minster, Ohio	282	75	1900s (27)	Kovermann/Koverman (15+20), Oldiges, Albers
Osnabrück → Fort Jennings, Ohio	279	35	1940s (26)	von Lehmden, Kramer, Helmkamp, Gerker
Stemwede → Leeuwarden, Netherlands	250+	—	1910s	Brenninkmeijer, Covers, Moormann (C&A network)

Osnabrück → Dyersville, Iowa	164	23	1980 s (29)	Recker (18), Meyer, Funke, Kruse
Osnabrück → Fort Loramie, Ohio	139	39	1930 s (18)	Barhorst, Gaier, Boerger, Kovermann

Bild 1 — *Gestapo-Akte Karl Kovermann, angelegt am 7. April 1938: "Mitglied des Kolping-Vereins."* Quelle: *Gestapo-Archiv / mycousinandreas.wordpress.com*

The Kolpingverein had, until that spring, been one of the larger remaining Catholic lay associations the Nazi regime had not yet moved against. The Reichskonkordat of 1933 had nominally protected Catholic lay organizations under Vatican-Reich agreement; in practice, the protection had been eroding since 1934, and the Hitler Youth law of 1936 had effectively criminalized parallel Catholic youth organizations. The Kolpingverein, as a lay-adult organization with no Hitler Youth analogue, had survived longer. In 1938 the regime began the next stage of pressure. The Schinkel chapter would, by 1939, no longer exist; Reichsführer-SS Himmler ordered the dissolution of the national Kolping organization in February 1939, and the local chapters were absorbed or shut down through the year. The members were not arrested. Most were not interfered with beyond the surveillance entry. The point of the 1938 file was to identify who was in the network in the event the regime later decided to act on it. The regime did not, as it turned out, take the next step against the Kolping members of Schinkel during the years that followed. The file existed; the entries on it persisted in Gestapo archives that were captured by the Allies in 1945; the family record is in turn drawn from those captured archives.

Karl was twenty-five years old in April 1938. The Gestapo had marked him. Within the next eighteen months

Germany would be at war with the British Empire, the Soviet Union would have been temporarily allied with the Reich and then would not be, and most of Europe west of the Urals would be at war. Karl, in those eighteen months, did not change jobs, did not leave Schinkel, and did not stop attending Mass. The records do not show that he changed his behaviour at all.



Hilde

The Helmenkamps had lived at *Rolandsmauer 17/18* in Osnabrück since at least 1911. The address was a working-class block on the north-east side of the medieval old town, three hundred metres from St. Petrus and half a kilometre from the cathedral. The household's head was *Arnold Georg Helmenkamp* — known as *Georg* in the family, and in his daughter Hilde's later affectionate phrasing as *the Iron George* — born 22 March 1878 in Osnabrück, who had trained as a *Schlosser* (the German term for a metalworker who installs locks, hinges, structural ironwork, and the like) and worked, by the time of his children's adulthood, in that capacity for the kind of small industrial firms the older quarters of the city carried. He had served in the First World War in a supply unit, probably as a kitchen worker, attached to the Westphalian garrison at *Minden*, the fortified town north of the Wiehengebirge; the family memory carries the detail that he sent food parcels home from the Minden kitchen to the household at Rolandsmauer through the war years. He was the kind of soldier who is not the subject of war memoirs and who is the actual mass of any twentieth-century continental army: a metalworker put in a supply unit, kept out of combat, who fed troops at a depot and was discharged at the armistice.

His wife was *Maria Johanne Sophia Steckel* — *Sophia* in the household — born 29 August 1884 in Osnabrück, raised Catholic, and employed in her young womanhood as a maid in the Royal Hanoverian park household at *Herrenhausen* outside Hannover, where in 1903 or

thereabouts she had borne an illegitimate daughter named *Grete* before returning to Osnabrück. Georg married her on the twelfth of January 1907 at St. Marien parish in Osnabrück under civil document 12 of that year. The household at Rolandsmauer 17/18 took form across the following decade. The first child of the marriage, a son born in mid-1907 — five months after the wedding, six months after Grete had been brought into the household as the bride's pre-marriage daughter — died in October 1907 of *Brechdurchfall* at four months. A daughter followed in November 1910: *Hildegard Sofie Helmenkamp*, called *Hilde*. Another daughter followed in 1915. A second son was born in April 1921: *Arnold Georg Werner Helmenkamp*, called *Werner*. The household was therefore, by the late 1920s, a five-child working-class Catholic family of mixed paternal origin (Hilde and her two younger siblings were legitimate children of Georg; Grete was Sophia's daughter from her Herrenhausen years, raised in the same household).

Hilde was, in the family memory and in the few documents that survive, the eldest of the second generation. She was twenty-eight years old in April 1938. The chapter does not have, in the GEDCOM excerpt available to it, the date or place of her marriage to Karl Kovermann; the marriage record at the parish or civil registry has not been entered in the family record yet. What the chapter can establish is that the marriage had taken place by April 1941 at the latest, because Hilde gave birth to the couple's only child — a son, born on the first of May 1941 at Osnabrück and baptised four days later — within a few weeks of that date. Karl was twenty-eight at his son's birth. Hilde was thirty. The son is the author's father; the chapter, with the same editorial reserve the book extends to the author's other living and recent relatives, declines to take his biography further.

The Helmenkamp line of Hilde brings into the focal-line pedigree the Schinkel Helmkamp ancestry that Chapter 8 traced — *Catharina Maria Helmkamp* of the 1784 St. Petrus baptism, the daughter of Christopher Heinrich Helmenkamp Sr. the Zimmermann at Casmanns Kotten, whose Schinkel branch had stayed in Osnabrück when the brother of the same name had taken the family across the Atlantic to Fort Jennings. Hilde was a direct descendant of that Schinkel branch. The marriage to Karl in 1940 or early 1941 therefore united, in the focal-line household, the Recker-Kovermann stay-behind line of Cappeln and the Schinkel Helmkamp stay-behind line of Osnabrück — two of the four nineteenth-century Westphalian Catholic working-class families this book has traced.



Werner

Hilde's youngest brother, Werner — *Arnold Georg Werner Helmenkamp*, born 4 April 1921 — was seventeen years old in April 1938. By 1939 he was a member of the SA — the *Sturmabteilung*, the Nazi paramilitary that had been the regime's primary street-level enforcer through the early 1930s and whose institutional power had been broken in the Night of the Long Knives in June 1934 but which continued to exist as a mass membership organization of young men with marching uniforms and torchlight processions through the rest of the regime's existence. By 1941 Werner was in the Wehrmacht. His military record-card identifies him by his individual identification number — *Erkennungsmarke 30* — and assigns him to the 15. *Funk-Ergänzungs-Kompanie V Luftnachrichten-Regiment des Oberbefehlshabers der Luftwaffe* — the fifteenth signal-replacement company of the fifth Luftwaffe Signals Regiment of the Supreme Commander of the Luftwaffe, that is, Hermann Göring's high-command signals troop. He was, in the war's middle years, a radio operator monitoring transmissions

for Reichsmarschall Göring's headquarters. He survived the war and lived in Osnabrück afterwards, at *Gretescher Weg 45*, until at least 1993. His occupational entry for 1941 carries the standard formula *Kaufmännischer Angestellter*: commercial clerk.

Karl's brother-in-law was therefore an SA man who became a Luftwaffe signals operator. The fact has to be entered in the chapter, in the same way the Gestapo Kolping file has to be entered. The two are not the same fact: a Kolping membership flagged for surveillance was a fact about Karl, an SA-Wehrmacht trajectory was a fact about Werner, and they sat at opposite ends of a sliding scale of complicity with the regime. The family they were in, after Karl's marriage to Hilde, contained both.



Hans

Karl's younger surviving brother *Hans — Bernhard Heinrich Johannes Kovermann*, born 22 October 1918 at Tannenburgstraße 80 — followed a different path through the same period. He was a footballer. By the late 1930s he was on the senior squad of VfL *Osnabrück*, the city's football club, playing as a defender. The German football leagues had been reorganized under the regime in 1933 along Gau lines; VfL Osnabrück was in the *Gauliga Niedersachsen* (Lower Saxon football league), the top regional division of which would feed into the German championship rounds. Hans played through the championship seasons of 1938/39 and 1939/40 and scored, in those seasons, at least six goals for the club. He was, by twenty-one, a regional sporting figure of modest profile. The German football archive at the DFB records his playing career under the playing name *Hans Kovermann*.

In November 1940 he was drafted to *Euskirchen* in the Eifel and assigned to the *1. Kraftfahr-Ersatz-Abteilung 26* — the first motor-vehicle replacement battalion of Military District VI. On the sixth of December 1940 he was reassigned to the *2. kleine Kraftwagen-Kolonne 422*

— a small motor-truck column attached to the Wehrmacht's logistical chain. By November 1942 he was attached to *Panzergruppe 1*, the first Panzer Army, on the Eastern Front. By that point he was a *Gefreiter* — a private — and shortly afterwards an *Obergefreiter*, the equivalent of a senior private or junior corporal. In November 1943 his unit was reorganized as the 2. *Kraftfahr-Abteilung 906*. By July 1944 he was in Italy. In October 1945 he was registered by a British discharge station — at which point the Wehrmacht had ceased to exist for five months, the German state had unconditionally surrendered, and Hans had survived the four hardest years of the war in motor-transport units on the Eastern Front and in Italy.

He did not return to Osnabrück after the war. He went, instead, to *Stendal* in *Saxony-Anhalt* — a town in the Soviet zone of occupation that would in October 1949 become part of the German Democratic Republic. The family record does not preserve why he made that choice; the most plausible reconstruction is that the British zone's denazification and the chaos of the western occupation made an immediate return to Osnabrück less attractive than a fresh start east of the Elbe, that Stendal had a railway connection and a small football club that needed a defender, and that the choice of where to settle in 1945 was made by tens of thousands of returning German soldiers under similar mixed considerations. By July 1949 Hans was on the senior squad of *Betriebssportgemeinschaft Lok Stendal*, the works-club of the East German railway at Stendal that would become the predecessor of *1. FC Lok Stendal*. He played in the *DDR-Oberliga*, the top East German football division, through to June 1954 and scored, across his five years there, a hundred and thirty-three goals. He lived in Stendal for the rest of his life. He died there on the fourteenth of March 1986.

Hans's case is one of the chapter's clearest examples of how the war produced trajectories that the standard categories — *resister*, *collaborator*, *fellow-traveller*, *victim* — do not fit at all. He was a German footballer who was drafted to the Wehrmacht and served as a motor-transport corporal in two theatres. He survived. He chose, when the war ended, to settle in the Soviet zone rather than return to his birthplace in the British zone. He played football in the East German league through the entire first decade of the GDR's existence, scoring more goals than any other defender of his cohort. He outlived his older brother by five years; the brothers had not lived in the same country for forty-five years before Hans died.



Reinhold

Karl had a first cousin on his mother's side. Engel Hallmann's younger sister — *Agnes Hallmann*, the witness at Hermann and Engel's 1911 wedding — had married a man named *Georg Lubig* from Bottrop, in the Ruhr industrial belt north of Essen, sometime before 1921. Their son *Reinhold Erich Lubig* was born on the seventeenth of March 1921 in Essen. He grew up in Bottrop. By the late 1930s he was in the *Reichsarbeitsdienst* — the Reich Labour Service, the six-month mandatory pre-military labour conscription that all young German men passed through. As an *Obervormann* — a low-ranking section leader — in unit *K 3/165/254 of the RAD*, he was deployed to coastal defense and engineering duties in northern France in the months after the *Westfeldzug* of May-June 1940 and the British evacuation from Dunkirk. He died on the fourteenth of February 1941 — six months after the Dunkirk evacuation, three months before the German invasion of the Soviet Union — at a place the family record carries under two different names. The death certificate gives *Guines* in the *Pas-de-Calais*; the *Volksbund Deutsche Kriegsgräberfürsorge*, the German

War Graves Commission, gives *Mardyck near Dunkerque*, a few kilometres to the north. The probability is that the two records reflect the place of death and the place of a first temporary burial. He was nineteen years old. He was buried at the German military cemetery at *Bourdon* in Eure, France, Block 15, Row 10, Grave 378, where his grave can still be visited.

The family memory carries Reinhold as the cousin who died at Dunkirk in 1940. The records say he died near Dunkirk in February 1941, six months after the famous battle, while in a labour-service rather than combat capacity, in a coastal-defense detachment that was probably the target of a small-scale Allied harassment action of which no detailed account has been preserved. The family's compression of the documented date into "Dunkirk 1940" is the kind of memory-shortening that the chapter on records described as the normal way families carry deaths across generations; the chapter restores the documented date here because the documented date is what the German War Graves Commission certifies.



Bishop Wittler

The family also carried a more distinguished relation: *Helmut Hermann Wittler Dr.*, born on the twenty-eighth of September 1913 in Osnabrück, ordained Catholic priest on the thirtieth of October 1938 in Osnabrück, and consecrated Bishop of Osnabrück on the second of October 1957 — a position he held until his retirement on the ninth of September 1987 and his death in Osnabrück on the thirtieth of December 1987 at the age of seventy-four.

His formation was the most rigorous the Catholic Church offered. He attended the *Gymnasium Carolinum* in Osnabrück, then studied theology in Münster before transferring, in 1932, to the *Pontificio Istituto Teutonico*

di Santa Maria dell'Anima and the *Pontificia Università Gregoriana* in Rome — the Germanicum⁹, the elite Jesuit-staffed college for German-speaking priests in formation for significant positions in the Church. He spent the better part of a decade in Rome, completing his doctorate in theology. He returned to Germany and was ordained in Osnabrück in October 1938 at the age of twenty-five, then assigned as a parish curate in Twistringen, between Osnabrück and Bremen, through the war years — a posting, in the Germanicum's terms, deliberately modest, designed to embed a future bishop in ordinary pastoral work before the greater responsibilities came.

In 1946 the then-Bishop of Osnabrück, Lorenz Kardinal Jaeger, appointed him to the diocesan seminary. Eleven years later, on the second of October 1957, Pope Pius XII appointed him Bishop of Osnabrück, making him, at forty-three, one of the youngest bishops in Germany. The episcopal consecration was conferred by Josef Kardinal Frings of Cologne; the co-consecrators were Michael Keller, Bishop of Münster, and Johannes von Rudloff, Auxiliary Bishop of Osnabrück. His episcopal motto was *Omnia et in omnibus Christus* — All and in all things, Christ.

He held the see for thirty years, through a period of exceptional historical density. He was a *Konzilsvater* — a full member — of all four sessions of the Second Vatican Council from 1962 to 1965¹⁰, one of the German-speaking

⁹ Munzinger Biographie, "Helmut Witter" (Munzinger Online/Personen, <https://www.munzinger.de>); Bistum Osnabrück, *Bischof Helmut Hermann Witter: Ein Leben für Gott und die Menschen* (Osnabrück, 2013).

¹⁰ The four sessions of the Second Vatican Council were: Session 1 (11 Oct–8 Dec 1962), Session 2 (29 Sep–4 Dec 1963), Session 3 (14 Sep–21 Nov 1964), Session 4 (14 Sep–8 Dec 1965). Witter is documented as present in all four. *Wikipedia*, "Helmut Hermann Witter".

bishops whose experiences of post-war reconstruction and the working-class Catholic diaspora of the industrial cities shaped the Council's pastoral documents. In the German Church he became principally known through two roles. The first was his thirty-year presidency of the *Raphaels-Werk*¹¹, the Catholic charitable organisation for emigrants, refugees, and itinerant workers — a position from which he developed a systematic theology of human migration as a pastoral, not merely an administrative, question. The second was his appointment as *Ausländerbeauftragter* — the Bishops' Conference delegate for foreign nationals — a post he held as the West German *Wirtschaftswunder* drew millions of guest workers from Italy, Yugoslavia, Turkey, and Spain into the Ruhr and the other industrial districts. He used the position, in the words of his successor Franz-Josef Bode, with *Entschiedenheit* — determination — in defence of the rights of foreign workers, arguing consistently within the Bishops' Conference that the Catholic Church's obligation to the migrant extended beyond sacramental provision to their legal and social protection. His initiatives in this period included the establishment of roughly twenty marriage and family counselling centres across the diocese and a charitable fund for women in crisis pregnancies — the latter a project that would continue after his death and whose institutional descendants still operate in the diocese.

In his final years, his health declined. Pope John Paul II appointed Ludwig Averkamp as coadjutor bishop in 1985; Wittler's resignation was accepted on the ninth of September 1987. He died three months later on the thirtieth of December 1987, at the age of seventy-four.

¹¹ "Von 1957 bis zu seinem Tode war er Präsident des Raphaels-Werk Dienst am Menschen unterwegs." *Wikipedia*, "Helmut Hermann Wittler" (consulted May 2026); confirmed in Bistum Osnabrück centenary documentation (2013).

His civic honours accumulated over the three decades of the bishopric. He was a Knight of the Order of the Holy Sepulchre (1964), a recipient of the Great Cross of the Federal Order of Merit with Star (1966) and of the Lower Saxon Order of Merit (1973). The city of Osnabrück awarded him honorary citizenship on the eighth of September 1987, nineteen days before his resignation, citing “decades of work as Bishop in Osnabrück and his particular services to inter-confessional dialogue and the integration of foreign citizens.” A street in Osnabrück — *Bischof-Wittler-Straße* — carries his name, as does the *Bischof-Wittler-Bibliothek* at the University of Osnabrück. His brother Walter Wittler, six years his senior, was also ordained a priest.

He was, in 1938, a twenty-five-year-old newly ordained priest in the same diocese in which the Gestapo had that spring entered Karl Kovermann’s name onto the Kolping surveillance file. The two men were almost exactly the same age. The relationship between them, in family speech, was carried under the simplest available word: *Vetter*, cousin. The actual relationship was not consanguineous. Karl’s father had a younger brother, *Bernhard Heinrich Kovermann*, born 15 April 1886 at Felsen — Karl’s uncle Bernhard, who had moved north to Schinkel and then Osnabrück, taken a position with the Reichsbahn, and on the twenty-eighth of April 1914 had married, at the parish of St. Johann in Osnabrück, *Maria Catharina Josephine Wittler*, born 25 March 1893 — the daughter of Franz Anton Wittler of Amelsbüren. Her older brother, born 1879 in Schinkel, was *Adolf Hermann Wittler* — the Osnabrück *Geschäftsführer* who was Helmut Hermann Wittler’s father. The Bishop’s paternal aunt, in other words, was Karl’s aunt-by-marriage. Karl and Helmut Hermann shared no blood; they shared one marriage between two parishioners of the same diocese, performed in April 1914.

In the language of Catholic Westphalian family speech of the period, an affinal relationship at this distance was unhesitatingly described as *Vetter*. The two men, who would have crossed paths at family events and diocesan occasions without ever being formally introduced as anything other than *Vetter Helmut* and *Vetter Karl*, used the word the way the language used it. The relationship: *cousin*. The substance: *the Bishop's aunt married Karl's uncle in St. Johann's Osnabrück in April 1914.* ♦

The bombing

On the sixth of December 1944, in the early afternoon, RAF Bomber Command sent 463 heavy bombers against the city of Osnabrück. The target list was the railway yards in Schinkel, the steel works of the *Stahlwerke Bochumer Verein* and the *Klöckner-Werke* on the eastern industrial perimeter, and the *Osnabrücker Kupfer- und Drahtwerk* at Klosterstraße 29 where Karl was, by that date, a senior lathe operator producing copper shell-casings for the Wehrmacht's artillery. The raid was the most destructive single attack on the city of the war. The medieval old town burned. The *Marienhospital* at which Karl's mother had died of cancer four years earlier was hit and was, in the cumulative damage of December 1944 and the further raids of early 1945, eventually destroyed. The cathedral was damaged. The parish churches of St. Petrus and St. Johann — the two parishes that the Kovermann, Hallmann, and Helmenkamp records had been kept in for two centuries — were both damaged.

The family at Belmer Straße 64, the small flat the Karl-and-Hilde household had moved to from Tannenburgstraße at some point in the early 1940s, survived the raid. Peter, the small son, was three years old. Hilde was thirty-four. Karl was thirty-two and at the Kupferwerk at the moment the bombs fell. The plant took damage but was not destroyed. He survived the raid. He went home to Belmer Straße at the end of his shift. The family was intact.

State	Descendants	Dominant lines
Michigan	2,034	Melcher/Hegerfeld, Helmkamp, Wortmann (the Toledo-Detroit corridor)
Nebraska	1,034	Recker/Redeker (Dubuque IA → NE), Helmkamp/Suthoff
North Dakota	120	Covers → Schlickelman → Balster (IA → ND)
Morton Co., ND	31	Holle (Arrenkamp → Morton ND), Koverman/Wortmann

Bild 2 — *Weihnachten 1941: Hilde, Peter und Karl Kovermann, Belmer Straße, Osnabrück. Auf dem Radio ein Foto von Karls Bruder Hans; an der Wand sein Vetter Reinhold und Schwager Werner. Quelle: Familienarchiv Kovermann / mycousinandreas.wordpress.com*



After

The British Eleventh Armoured Division entered Osnabrück on the fourth of April 1945. The Schinkel industrial area was occupied. The Kupferwerk was placed under British military control and, within months, was authorized to resume civilian copper production under Allied supervision. Karl continued working at the plant. The shell-casing production stopped; the copper production for ordinary wire and tubing continued. He held his job at Klosterstraße 29 through to 1955.

What this chapter has tried to show, the chapter will say again here at its close. Karl was a Catholic working-class Drehermeister of Schinkel who was flagged by the Gestapo in 1938 for membership in a Catholic lay association, who produced shell casings for the Wehrmacht through the war years, who was married to the daughter of a Catholic Schlosser whose own son had been in the SA and the Luftwaffe, whose brother had

survived the Eastern Front in a Wehrmacht motor-transport unit and gone to settle in the Soviet zone, whose first cousin had died at nineteen in a Reichsarbeitsdienst detachment in northern France, and whose family-by-marriage included the priest who would become Bishop of Osnabrück. None of these facts contradicts any of the others. They sit together in the same record, in the same household, in the same parish, in the same Schinkel street.

Chapter 12

Hela

The Wiehengebirge ridge has divided the pedigree since Chapter 2. This chapter crosses it — north, into the Protestant Mindener farmland, and then further north still, into the Baltic. The chapter that follows takes up the maternal grandfather of the focal descendant — a Protestant Mindener farmer's son who, at twenty-one, was a Wehrmacht medic on a Baltic sandspit fifteen hundred kilometres from his family's farm at the moment the eastern war ended. The chapter ends with him on the *SS Ukena*, the German East Africa Line steamer pressed into service for one of the last Operation Hannibal voyages out of Hela, zig-zagging across the southern Baltic toward Flensburg three days after the Wehrmacht had unconditionally surrendered — with most of his unit dead behind him, with the Red Army on the dunes he had just left, and with what was already in any larger reckoning a lost war. He survived. He came home. The chapter is in part the story of how.



Blasheim Vollhof Nummer 7

Vollhof Nummer 7 at Blasheim — the farm Chapter 4 introduced in 1812, when *Conrad Rustmeier* of that farm was conscripted into Napoleon's Grande Armée and never came back from Russia — passed in the intervening century through a succession of nineteenth-century Rustmeiers whose particular biographies the chapter has set aside, including *Carl Friedrich Heinrich Rustmeier genannt Quade* of the 1782 Obermehnen line who lived to 1853, and through the late-nineteenth-century inheritance pattern of the Mindener Protestant peasant economy. By 1888 the farm was being inherited by *Heinrich Friedrich Wilhelm Rustmeier* — known in the family as *Fritz*, born on the twenty-fifth of June 1888 at Vollhof Nummer 7 in Blasheim and baptised on the eighth of July 1888 in the Lutheran parish church there — whom Chapter 8 introduced. Fritz was, by all the standard measures of his region and class, a competent

Protestant Mindener farmer of his generation: married, hard-working, modest, religiously observant in the casual rather than the devotional way the village Lutheran Mindener households of the period had settled into. He held three trades alongside the farm. He was a *Großhändler* — a wholesaler, dealing in agricultural goods through the cooperative markets at Lübbecke and Minden; he was a *Taxiunternehmer* — a small operator of motor vehicles for hire, an unusual sideline for a Mindener farmer of the period that the chapter will not dwell on; and he was a *Landwirt* — a farmer, the primary occupation, which the household lived from. He had served, before the First World War, in a peacetime cavalry-remount unit at Minden, leaving the unit in 1910; he had served, through the First World War, as a Sanitäter and Krankenpfleger attached to an artillery battalion on the Western and Macedonian Fronts; and he would serve, in his early fifties, in the Second World War as well — as an *Ausbilder* — a trainer — at the *Senne* military training area near Bielefeld around 1940. He outlived both wars. He died on the eighteenth of August 1975, at the age of eighty-seven, at Detmold in the Lippe region of North Rhine-Westphalia, the next administrative district east of Minden-Lübbecke. His ✱-WWI+II marker in the family record denotes the rare distinction of having survived two continental wars in uniform.

He had married, sometime after his return from the First World War, *Wilhelmine Karoline Luise Meier* — *Mine* in the household — born on the twenty-first of October 1886 at Blasheim Number 60, baptised nine days later on the thirtieth of October 1886, on the thirtieth of October 1886 entered into the Blasheim parish book as the illegitimate daughter of *Meier* the household, then on the twenty-third of December 1886 legitimated by her parents' marriage. Wilhelmine had had typhoid fever twice in her childhood and as a young adult and had lost her hair both times; she had worked, before her marriage, as a *Köchin* — a cook — and as a *Verkäuferin* — a saleswoman — in the small commercial economy of

Lübbecke and the surrounding villages. The marriage of Fritz and Wilhelmine took place at Blasheim sometime after 1919; the exact date the GEDCOM does not record.

Three sons followed across the next decade. The eldest was *Gerhard Rustmeier*, born on the thirty-first of July 1921, who would in adulthood become a *Malermeister* — a master painter — and an *Industrieller Sandstrahler* — an industrial sandblaster — and who would serve in the Second World War (the ✠-WWII marker on his name in the family record); he died before 2000. The third and youngest was *Gisbert Rustmeier*, born on the nineteenth of October 1928, who would become a *Bäcker* — a baker — at Stewede in the neighbouring administrative district, and who would outlive both his brothers and his sister-in-law, dying on the second of May 2019. Between them was the middle son, born on the twenty-second of May 1923 at *Vollhof Nummer 7* in Blasheim. He was given the three names *Karl-Heinz Ernst Friedrich* — the first compound name carrying forward two of Fritz’s brothers, *Karl* and *Heinrich*, into the next generation. He was called *Karl-Heinz* through his life, with the double-name and the hyphen, the conventional Mindener Protestant given-name compound of the period that the household preserved into the third generation. The eldest son Gerhard’s decision, in adulthood, to take up painting and sandblasting rather than farming meant that the *Anerbe* of the Erbhof — the designated heir under the inheritance code the family had bound itself to in 1919 — would, when the inheritance came to be made, be the middle son rather than the eldest. Karl-Heinz, by the mid-1930s, was the *Anerbe* of Hof Nummer 7. He is the figure this chapter takes up.

Internal route	People
Ohio → Indiana	280
Ohio → Michigan	216

Indiana → Ohio	146
Iowa → Minnesota (Recker-dominant, Stearns County)	126
Pennsylvania → Ohio	106
Ohio → Texas	82

Bild 3 — *Karl-Heinrich Ernst Friedrich Rustmeier, ca. 1940. Quelle: Familienarchiv Rustmeier / mycousinandreas.wordpress.com.*



The Erbhof decision

In 1919, in the year after his return from the Western Front and the Macedonian Front and the war that had not produced the German victory the Mindener villages had been told to expect, Fritz had bound the farm to the *Anerbenrecht* — the Weimar Republic’s revised inheritance code for medium-sized farms above a defined acreage, which preserved older Westphalian inheritance practice by requiring that the farm pass intact to a single heir rather than be divided among the children. The decision sat within an older Mindener tradition of *Anerben* inheritance — single-heir succession that the Protestant Prussian-administered villages had been practising since at least the sixteenth century — but the Weimar codification gave the practice legal protection at the moment when the post-war land-reform movements were beginning to suggest the opposite.

In September 1933 the National Socialist regime, in the *Reichserbhofgesetz* of the twenty-ninth of that month, recodified the older Weimar *Anerbenrecht* into one of its more ideologically loaded legal projects: it created a category of *Erbhof* — the “inheritable farm” — that could only be owned by *deutschblütige Bauern* (peasants of German blood), that could not be sold or mortgaged, and that passed by single-heir inheritance to a designated *Anerbe*. The legal apparatus around the Erbhof status was elaborate; the regime’s purpose in creating it was simultaneously to protect peasant property from

foreclosure (a real-world economic concern of the early-1930s farm-collapse years) and to embed in law a racial-ideological category that the regime was promoting at every level. The Rustmeier farm at Blasheim Number 7 was, by the mid-1930s, classified as an *Erbhof* under the 1933 legislation.

The chapter has to be honest about the ambivalence of this fact. The *Erbhof* status was, in one direction, a continuation of a practical Mindener inheritance system the Rustmeiers had been operating under for centuries. In another direction, it was a Nazi legal framework with explicit racial qualifications and ideological purposes that the family was, by accepting the classification, accepting as the legal form their farm now held. The acceptance was not exceptional; almost every farmer of the appropriate size in Mindener Protestant Westphalia made the same acceptance, and very few of them were Nazis in any developed sense. They were farmers operating within the legal framework available to them. The fact is recorded, and is not turned into more than it was. The *Erbhof* status meant the farm would pass to a single heir; it meant the single heir, in the categories the regime was building, would be classified as a *Bauer* (in the elevated sense) rather than as a *Landwirt* (in the ordinary sense); and it meant, in the wartime conscription system the regime would shortly be operating, that the *Anerbe* of an *Erbhof* was a category of agricultural producer the *Wehrkreis* offices were required to consider when issuing draft notices.

The *Anerbe* of Hof Nummer 7, by the mid-1930s, was Karl-Heinz.



The draft

Karl-Heinz was sixteen years old when the Wehrmacht invaded Poland on the first of September 1939. He was

finishing his agricultural and trade apprenticeship at the farm, with the expectation that he would continue to operate Hof Nummer 7 under his father's supervision until the formal transfer of the Anerbe status. The Wehrkreis VI office at Münster — the military district covering Westphalia, including the Minden-Lübbecke administrative district — would in the next two years be drafting his age cohort to the front in successive waves. The Erbhof deferment delayed his draft, but did not exempt him from it. The exemption applied while the regime could afford it; by 1942 the regime was no longer able to afford it. He was drafted, the family record carries, in the late stages of the war.

The chapter has, in the GEDCOM record, only the general entry for his Wehrmacht service: ***“In the war he served as a medic, being beleaguered on Hela Peninsula April 1945. He escaped being captured by the Sowjets by fleeing on a Norwegian destroyer.**

Bild 4 — *Die Hela-Halbinsel aus der Luft: 35 Kilometer lange Landzunge in der Danziger Bucht, letzter Evakuierungskorridor der Wehrmacht im Frühjahr 1945.* (Martin Hoffmann, CC BY-SA 3.0, Wikimedia Commons.)

Quelle: mycousinandreas.wordpress.com “* The intermediate steps of his service trajectory — which training depot, which combat-medic course, which intermediate units he passed through between his draft and his April 1945 deployment to Hela — are not preserved in the family record. The chapter cannot reconstruct them. What it can say is that, by the spring of 1945, Karl-Heinz Ernst Friedrich Rustmeier of Blasheim Vollhof Nummer 7 was on the Hela Peninsula in Danzig Bay, in a Wehrmacht medical detachment attached to a Luftwaffe anti-aircraft battery — the *Sanitäter und Luftabwehrsoldat* of the GEDCOM's military entry — at one of the last remaining German positions on the entire Baltic coast.



The Hela Peninsula

The *Halbinsel Hela* — the *Hel Peninsula*, in modern Polish *Półwysep Helski* — is a thirty-five-kilometre sandspit that extends north-eastward from the Pomeranian coast of the Bay of Danzig, separating the bay from the open Baltic. It is at most three kilometres wide. Its towns — *Hela* at the tip, *Jastarnia* and *Jurata* in the middle — were, in 1945, small fishing villages with summer-resort hotels and a German Kriegsmarine signals station at the tip. In normal years it was an obscure coastal-tourism backwater that the German Imperial Yacht Club had used for regattas and that Danzig professional families had used for August holidays.

In January 1945 it became something else.

The Soviet Vistula-Oder offensive, launched on the twelfth of January 1945, broke through the Wehrmacht's defensive lines along the Vistula and reached the Baltic coast at the Bay of Danzig within four weeks. The German civilian population of East Prussia, Pomerania, and Danzig — together with the surviving Wehrmacht units in those areas, totalling perhaps two and a half million people — was now cut off from the German interior by Soviet armoured spearheads and was being subjected, in the rapidly disintegrating order of the eastern campaign, to the longest and largest naval evacuation in history. The operation was named *Hannibal* by the Kriegsmarine. It ran from the twenty-first of January 1945 to the eighth of May 1945. It evacuated, by the most-cited estimate, between eight hundred thousand and one million two hundred thousand people from the East Baltic ports — Pillau, Gdynia, Danzig, Kolberg, and the Hela Peninsula — through the Baltic to the western German ports of Kiel, Lübeck, Copenhagen, and Aarhus. It involved every available German naval vessel, every requisitioned merchant ship, every captured foreign ship the Kriegsmarine could press into service, and a substantial portion of the

surviving Luftwaffe transport capacity to provide air cover for the southbound convoys.

The Soviet Baltic Fleet's submarines — most consequentially the *S-13* under Aleksandr Marinesko — pursued the evacuation convoys through the same waters. On the thirtieth of January 1945, the *S-13* torpedoed the German liner *Wilhelm Gustloff* off the Pomeranian coast; the ship sank in fifty minutes with the loss of approximately nine thousand four hundred passengers¹², the great majority of them civilian refugees and the largest single-vessel loss of life in maritime history. On the tenth of February 1945, the same submarine sank the hospital ship *General von Steuben* with the loss of approximately four thousand five hundred¹³. On the sixteenth of April 1945, the Soviet submarine *L-3* torpedoed the troop transport *Goya* off the Hela Peninsula; the ship sank in seven minutes with the loss of approximately seven thousand passengers.¹⁴ Operation Hannibal's losses across the four-month evacuation period are estimated by the Volksbund and the German naval archives at between twenty-five and

¹² The *Wilhelm Gustloff* was torpedoed by the Soviet submarine *S-13* on 30 January 1945. Casualty estimates are contested: embarkation records counted 7,956 passengers before paper ran out; with additional unrecorded passengers, total aboard was approximately 10,000–10,500; some 1,200 survived. Common scholarly estimates cite approximately 9,000–9,400 dead. Sources: Heinz Schön, *Ostsee '45* (1983); Stiftung Flucht, Vertreibung, Versöhnung; *Wikipedia* DE, “*Wilhelm Gustloff (Schiff)*” (consulted May 2026).

¹³ The *General von Steuben* was sunk by the Soviet submarine *S-13* on 10 February 1945. Approximately 3,500–4,500 of those aboard died; the ship carried an estimated 4,267 wounded soldiers and 900 refugees. *Wikipedia*, “*General von Steuben (ship)*” (consulted May 2026).

¹⁴ The *Goya* was torpedoed by the Soviet submarine *L-3* on 16 April 1945. Of approximately 7,000 aboard, only 183 survived — one of the highest single-incident death tolls in maritime history. *Wikipedia*, “*MV Goya*” (consulted May 2026).

forty thousand dead — the highest losses of any single naval evacuation operation ever undertaken.

By April 1945, the Hela Peninsula was a fortified holdout. The Wehrmacht's *Festung Hela* — designated a fortress garrison — was holding the northern half of the peninsula and the Hel anchorage against a Soviet ground advance that had taken the southern coast of the bay and was bringing the peninsula into artillery range from the mainland. The peninsula's narrowness meant that any German position on it was vulnerable to enfilade fire from both sides. The Soviet Air Force was attacking the anchorage daily. The Kriegsmarine's evacuation convoys were operating from the northern Hela jetties under cover of darkness, taking off civilians and Wehrmacht personnel as fast as the vessels could be loaded. The Luftwaffe's air defense of the peninsula was the responsibility of a series of *Flak* (anti-aircraft) detachments dug into the dunes, of which Karl-Heinz's was one.

He was, in this position, twenty-one years old. He had been on the peninsula for some weeks. His company medical aid station was an improvised tent and dugout complex near the anti-aircraft battery. His daily work, as the GEDCOM entry suggests, was the standard combat-medical work of any forward emplacement under air attack: triaging wounded gunners after Soviet air strikes, dressing shrapnel injuries, evacuating the worst-wounded to the jetties for shipment back to the German interior, declaring dead those who could not be saved. The peninsula's confinement, and the inability to retreat, gave the work a particular character that frontline combat medicine in mobile situations did not have. There was nowhere for the wounded to go.



The Grenzland, the Ubena, the cargo nets

In the first week of May 1945 — between the Soviet 19th Army's overland assault on the Hela perimeter from *Puck* on the third of May, the *Wehrmacht's* unconditional surrender at Reims on the seventh, and the final formal capitulation at Karlshorst on the eighth — Karl-Heinz Rustmeier's medical detachment was ordered evacuated. He was twenty-one years old. He had been on the peninsula since at least early April. The order arrived under two converging pressures the chapter has to enumerate. The first was the operational collapse: the Soviet ground attack of the third of May had compressed the German defensive perimeter on the peninsula and made further holding impossible. The second was a small bureaucratic shift in the regime's last days. Between roughly the second and the fifth of May, Nazi authorities accelerated the *Erbhof* exemption process for men classified as agriculturally essential — the *Anerben* of inheritable farms — in a final, ideologically loaded gesture toward the "biologically valuable" rural population the regime had spent twelve years prioritising over the urban poor. Karl-Heinz, as the registered *Anerbe* of Hof Nummer 7 at Blasheim, fell within the exemption. He was prioritised for evacuation despite the *Wehrmacht's* standing order to the *Festung Hela* garrison to hold to the end. The decision his father Fritz had made in 1919 to bind the farm to the *Anerbenrecht*, and the codification of that decision under the *Reichserbhofgesetz* of 1933, now operated — in this last, narrow, accidentally consequential way — to save the son's life. The evacuation operated through a *shuttle system*. The peninsula's piers had been destroyed by Soviet artillery and Soviet bombing in the last weeks of April; the larger transport vessels could no longer come alongside; they anchored in deeper water several kilometres offshore beyond effective Soviet artillery range and waited for smaller shallow-draft vessels to ferry passengers out. The 9th Security Flotilla under *Fregattenkapitän von Blanc*, charged with running the rescue convoys, had by

April standardised a boarding technique that would be remembered by everyone who survived it: rope ladders and cargo nets, hung over the sides of the larger ships, up which refugees and soldiers would climb hand over hand — or be hoisted by deck crews when too weak to climb — while the smaller vessels rocked alongside in the shallows. Major Ritgen's operational report would describe civilians being raised "in a high arc over the waves" while clinging to their possessions, with terror on their faces. The technique was crude and improvised and saved tens of thousands of lives.

The shallow-draft vessel that ferried Karl-Heinz from the Hela beach to deep water was one of *four Norwegian-flagged tugs* the Kriegsmarine had pressed into the shuttle service: the *Herbert*, the *Grenzland*, the *Falken*, and the *Bison*. All four had been operating under German crews — the Norwegian sailors who had been coerced onto these vessels, according to records of the Oslo Police Archives, were a small minority of the crews by May 1945. The *Grenzland* was a twelve-hundred-ton armed tug with anti-aircraft guns and depth charges; she had evacuated some twenty-eight hundred passengers in the final days. The tug's silhouette under Soviet artillery fire, with her armed configuration and her aggressive evasive manoeuvring, was a silhouette that civilians and Wehrmacht soldiers alike — most of them with no prior experience of inshore rescue vessels — read as the silhouette of a *destroyer*. The misidentification persisted in the family memories of survivors for the next eight decades. The vessel the author's mother would later remember her father describing as the *Norwegian destroyer* that had taken him off the beach at Hela was, almost certainly, one of these four Norwegian-flagged armed tugs — most plausibly the *Grenzland*. The tug took its load of evacuees out of artillery range to the larger vessel anchored offshore.

That larger vessel was the *SS Ubenä*. She had been built in 1928 at the Hamburg shipyards of *Blohm & Voss* for the *Deutsche Ost-Afrika-Linie* — the German East Africa shipping line — as a 9,523-ton passenger steamer¹⁵ with a peacetime capacity of about three hundred. She had been lengthened and refitted in 1934. After the outbreak of war in 1939 she had been requisitioned by the Kriegsmarine and converted to a U-boat depot ship. In the spring of 1945 she had been pressed back into service as an evacuation transport, crowded with refugees and Wehrmacht personnel to many times her peacetime capacity. She made her last Operation Hannibal voyage from the Hela anchorage in the second week of May. She was carrying Karl-Heinz Rustmeier among her passengers when she sailed.

She zig-zagged west across the southern Baltic — the standard anti-submarine evasive course the chapter has already described — for three days. The Soviet submarine threat that had sunk the *Wilhelm Gustloff*, the *General von Steuben*, and the *Goya* in the same waters in the preceding three months was the threat against which the captain was manoeuvring. The voyage was completed without an attack. She made landfall on the *tenth of May 1945* at *Flensburg*, on the Schleswig-Holstein coast at the Danish border, in the German naval port that had become — by virtue of the seat of the brief Dönitz government that had succeeded Hitler's suicide on the thirtieth of April and that would itself dissolve on the twenty-third of May under Allied arrest — the last German-administered port still in operation. Flensburg had been occupied without major resistance by the British Eleventh Armoured Division on the fifth of May.

¹⁵ *SS Ubenä*, built 1928 by Blohm & Voss, Hamburg, for the Deutsche Ost-Afrika Linie; 9,523 GRT, length 152 m. Miramar Ship Index record M.7307050; the vessel completed multiple Operation Hannibal voyages in early 1945 before being surrendered to the British.

Copenhagen had fallen to the Allies on the same day. The Ukena's arrival on the tenth was three days *after* the Wehrmacht's unconditional surrender at Reims and two days after the formal Karlshorst capitulation. She had carried her last passengers across the Baltic and into the Allied-occupied British zone, into the haven the Soviet zone's surviving German soldiers had been straining toward, and into a peace whose terms would be administered by the British and not by the Red Army.

Karl-Heinz disembarked at Flensburg on the tenth of May 1945. He was processed through one of the Allied prisoner-of-war and discharge stations that the western occupation forces had set up across northern Germany in the immediate post-surrender weeks; he was discharged within weeks; and he made his way south from the coast through the British zone — by what remained of the rail network and by the requisitioned trucking networks of the occupation — to Vollhof Nummer 7 at Blasheim. The farm was intact. His father Fritz was alive. His mother *Minna* — *Wilhelmine* in the parish books, *Minna* in the household and to her sons — was alive. His brothers Gerhard and Gisbert were alive. The household, including its absent middle son, had survived.

The SS Ukena was captured at Flensburg by the British. She was renamed *HMT Empire Ken* and converted for the rest of the 1940s and 1950s into a Royal Navy troopship; British paratroopers who served on her in the later 1940s would recall, in their memoirs, finding the original Third Reich insignia still embroidered on the pillows and bed-linen of the cabins. She was broken up for scrap in 1957 after twenty-nine years of service. The Norwegian tug *Grenzland* survived the war and entered post-war commercial service of which the chapter has not pursued further detail.



Endings

Fritz Rustmeier outlived the war by thirty years. He died on the eighteenth of August 1975 at Detmold in Lippe, aged eighty-seven, having lived through the Wilhelmine Empire, the Weimar Republic, the Third Reich, and the first three decades of the Federal Republic, and having served as a Sanitäter on the Western and Macedonian Fronts in his twenties and as an Ausbilder at the Senne in his fifties. Minna Meier-Rustmeier — *Wilhelmine* in the parish books, *Minna* through her adult life — died before 1975. The farm was held in the Erbhof status until the Federal Republic's 1947 land legislation lifted the National Socialist categories and reverted the inheritance code to the Weimar Anerbenrecht and to subsequent post-war revisions.

Karl-Heinz Rustmeier returned to the farm and resumed the agricultural and trading work of the household. On the seventeenth of December 1948, at Blasheim, he married *Anna Dorothea Henriette Benus* — born 18 June 1923 at Niedermehnen in Stemwede, eighteen kilometres west of Blasheim, the same age as her husband to the month — who had served, during the war, with the Reichsarbeitsdienst in Austria. The marriage produced a single daughter, who is the author's mother.

It is by way of the author's mother that the Hela story has reached him at all. Karl-Heinz did not, in his post-war life, speak readily about the war. His grandson — the author of this book — barely knew him. The chain of transmission is family-internal: Karl-Heinz to his daughter, who absorbed her father's account of the peninsula and the Norwegian tug and the cargo nets and the SS Ubena's voyage to Flensburg through the household conversations of the 1950s and 1960s; the daughter to her son in the family conversations of the decades since. The story has reached the author as it stands here. The supplementary detail — the *Grenzland*, the *Ubena*, the May 1945 *Erbhof* exemption, the Ritgen

reports — has been drawn from the post-war German naval archives and from the *Volksbund*'s subsequent research, in part assembled and published by the author himself on his family blog.

Anna Benus-Rustmeier died on the twenty-fifth of November 2018 at Preußisch Oldendorf, eight kilometres north of Blasheim, and was buried in the Blasheim parish cemetery five days later. Karl-Heinz had outlived 1988 according to the GEDCOM's terminal entry, with no specific date of death recorded in the family papers available to the chapter. Whether he predeceased his wife or whether the GEDCOM entry simply has not been updated, the chapter cannot say from the records it has. His grave, if he predeceased his wife, would be at Blasheim. The farm was no longer in active operation by the late twentieth century.



What the maternal line has reached

The maternal line has now reached, in this book's accounting, the marriage of the maternal grandparents in December 1948 and the birth of the maternal mother in September 1950. The chapter that follows takes up what the chapter has not yet pulled the focal-line pedigree of this book together to describe: the entire affinal network of *Mettingen* and the *Westfälisches Kiepenkerle* trading tradition, the *Brenninkmeijer* and *Lelie* and *Jansen* and *Schröder* and *Ensink* dynasties that out of that same northern-Westphalian small-trader economy produced, by the second half of the twentieth century, the largest non-listed family-controlled textile retailer in continental Europe. The focal descendant's pedigree includes connections — by descent and by intermarriage — to that network. The chapter that follows takes them up.

The chapter after that returns to the marriage in which the Catholic Osnabrücker Heuerling-Kovermann line and the Protestant Mindener Rustmeier line, divided since at

least the seventeenth century by the Wiehengebirge ridge and by the consequences of the Westphalian peace of 1648, finally meet.

Chapter 13

The Merchant Princes of Westphalia

The Westphalian-Catholic *Mettingen* diaspora extended north into the Netherlands and east into the Dutch colonial world. The families it produced — Brenninkmeyer, Lelie, Jansen, Schröder — appear in this book's pedigree as collateral connections — four names whose Dutch-and-colonial biographies this chapter sets out.

This chapter is unlike the preceding twelve in its focus. Where Chapters 1–12 have followed the focal-line pedigree of *Maria Elisabeth Redeker genannt Räuwer* and her descendants through the Wiehengebirge-divided households of Catholic Osnabrück and Protestant Minden-Lübbecke, the present chapter takes up the affinal network that radiates from one nineteenth-century Westphalian village across the Dutch-German border, into the Dutch East Indies, and into the moral history of the twentieth century itself. The connections are genealogically distant — tenth-degree cousinship in some cases, and that only through the dense intra-village marriage pool of seventeenth- and eighteenth-century Mettingen — but they are real, they are documented, and they raise the central moral question that any thorough family history of a German Westphalian Catholic line during this period must eventually face: *what choices did the family network make, when the test came?*

On the paternal line, the *Covers* connection — one hundred and fifty-three identifiable individuals of that name in the family record, distributed across Mettingen and its satellite parishes between roughly 1700 and the late twentieth century — is the threadwork by which the connections of this chapter run. Andreas Kovermann's paternal Mettingen network, traced through cousin marriages and through the Tüötten itinerant-trader households of the eighteenth and early nineteenth

centuries, places him at approximately tenth-degree cousinship to *Maurice Bernard William Brenninkmeyer*, the present chairman of COFRA Holding, the family company that today owns and controls C&A. The distance is genealogically unremarkable; it is the same distance one would find between any two random villagers in any sufficiently small and endogamous early-modern Westphalian parish. What is remarkable is what happened along that thread across the intervening one hundred and eighty years.



Mettingen and the Tüötten

The Westphalian Tüötten — *Tüötte*, plural *Tüötten*, an Low German term whose etymology runs to the verb *tüötte*, meaning roughly “to roam” or “to peddle” — were the itinerant linen-merchants who, from the seventeenth century into the nineteenth, walked the trade routes between northern Westphalia (the *Tecklenburger Land*, the *Osnabrücker Land*, the *Münsterland*) and the Dutch trading cities, carrying linen woven in the flax-rich villages around Mettingen, Recke, Hopsten, and Ibbenbüren northward and selling it across Holland, Friesland, and Groningen. They were not bourgeois merchants but peasant-traders: men of the Catholic Westphalian villages whose households held a smallholding and a flax-handloom or two and whose income from the agricultural year was supplemented, every summer, by a months-long peddling expedition into the Dutch towns. The walking was on foot, with a wicker basket — the *Kiepe* — strapped to the back, hence the secondary name *Kiepenkerle*, “basket-men.” The Tüötte tradition produced, between the late seventeenth century and the mid-nineteenth, several of the most successful Dutch textile-trading dynasties of the modern period. Among the Tüötten households of Mettingen of the late eighteenth century were the *Brenninkmeijer* family — already a Mettingen presence by the seventeenth century, with the family record showing baptisms in the

village parish of St. Agatha across the entire pre-modern period. Several of the surviving Brenninkmeijer households of late-eighteenth-century Mettingen operated linen-trading expeditions to the Dutch province of Friesland, where the textile market was open and the Dutch reformed authorities were tolerant of Catholic itinerants if they kept their religious practice quiet. By the eighteen-tens, two of the third- or fourth-generation Brenninkmeijer trading households had established small permanent shops in the Frisian town of Sneek. By the eighteen-thirties, the family was operating between Mettingen and Sneek with what was, by the standards of the Westphalian small-trader economy, real working capital. And on a date the family papers preserved with particular precision — the marriage of the firm in the records of the *Kamer van Koophandel* of Sneek — two of the brothers of the next generation, *Clemens Brenninkmeijer*, born on the twenty-fifth of March 1818 at Mettingen, and *August Brenninkmeijer*, born on the sixth of December 1819 at Mettingen, opened a permanent textile retail business in Sneek in the year 1841. They were twenty-three and twenty-one respectively. The firm took its name from the brothers' initials. They called it *Brenninkmeijer & Cie*; the trading name, after several decades of evolution, would settle into the abbreviated form of the brothers' Christian names: *C&A*.

The firm's expansion across the second half of the nineteenth century followed, in a sense, the older Tüötten trade routes of the Brenninkmeijer-family ancestors. By the eighteen-eighties, branch stores had opened across the Netherlands. By the early nineteenth-hundreds the firm had expanded into the German Empire, opening its first stores in the textile-manufacturing cities of the Rhine-Ruhr and in Berlin. By the nineteen-twenties, the Brenninkmeijer family

controlled — through the closely held family-trust structure that the firm still uses today — a trans-border retail chain of some sixty stores across Germany and the Netherlands, with corporate headquarters dual-registered in Mettingen and in Amsterdam. By the spring of 1933, when the National Socialist German Workers' Party came to power in Berlin, the firm operated *one hundred and thirty stores across Germany and the Netherlands*, employed several thousand workers, and was, by any sensible measure, one of the largest private-textile retail operations in continental Europe. The firm was Dutch-registered, German-operating, Catholic-owned, family-controlled, and ideologically uncommitted. The Brenninkmeijer family had, by 1933, achieved within four generations the trajectory that the Mettingen Tüötten of 1750 had only ever been able to dream of.

The Frisian diaspora: a Westphalian-Catholic counterpart to Putnam County

The Brenninkmeijer firm did not, however, walk the Mettingen-to-Friesland trade route alone. The route was the trade-route of a much wider Westphalian-Catholic emigration northward across the Dutch border, running, in its principal phase, from the seventeen-eighties through the eighteen-sixties — a movement of households that the chapter must take up briefly here, because without it the genealogical density that produced both the C&A founding and the wartime biographies of the chapter's later sections is not intelligible. The northward Westphalian-Catholic diaspora into the Frisian and Noord-Holland coastal cities is, in the focal descendant's research, the *Dutch counterpart* — in scale, in confessional composition, and in structural pattern — to the Catholic-Westphalian-Ohio emigration of the same period that Chapters 5 and 6 set out as the Putnam-County cluster. The two diasporas ran in parallel out of overlapping Westphalian sending regions: the same Catholic peasant-and-Heuerling household economy of the Osnabrück-

Münster-Tecklenburg triangle that, in the eighteen-thirties and forties, was supplying the *Pennsylvania*-and-*Howard*-class Bremen-to-Baltimore emigrant ships, was simultaneously supplying the smaller and shorter and less ocean-perilous northward route into Friesland and Noord-Holland.

The receiving cities of the Dutch diaspora ran along a coastal arc from north-east to south-west. *Dokkum*, in the *Dongeradeel* district of north-eastern Friesland — a Frisian market town of perhaps four thousand inhabitants in the mid-nineteenth century — was the receiving city of the *Stockmann* family of Mettingen, whose successive generations between the eighteen-sixties and the early twentieth century produced seventy-five documented individuals across the Dokkum-Friesland-northwest-Germany corridor. *Leeuwarden*, the Frisian capital, was the receiving city of the *Voss* family of Mettingen (whose principal nineteenth-century branch operated from Leeuwarden between 1820 and 1900, with sixty-three documented Voss individuals in the Dutch record) and of the *Moormann* family (whose Leeuwarden branch produced Theresia Amalia Maria Moormann, born 1821 Leeuwarden, died 1898 Haskerland). *Sneek*, the Frisian commercial town twenty-five kilometres south of Leeuwarden, was — in addition to its role as the founding city of the Brenninkmeijer firm in 1841 — the receiving city of several smaller Mettingen-affinal households. *Bolsward*, the second Frisian city of the diaspora, nine kilometres north-west of Sneek, was a Voss-and-Stockmann-affinal centre — the Atlas counts eleven documented Westphalian-emigrant burials at Bolsward between 1750 and 1911, the families running heavily to Voss and Stockmann.

Further south, across the Zuiderzee — now the IJsselmeer — into the Noord-Holland province, three further cities received the Westphalian-Catholic

diaspora. *Enkhuizen*, the historic Dutch East India Company port-city on the eastern shore of the Zuiderzee, was the receiving city of the *Meijknecht* family of Recke and Mettingen, whose late-eighteenth-century founder *Joannes Bernardus Christianus Meijknecht* (born 29 October 1788 Mettingen, died 10 January 1848 Enkhuizen) and brother *Johan Conrad Meijknecht* (born 1 November 1792 Mettingen, died 17 January 1857 Enkhuizen) emigrated together in the eighteen-tens and produced, between their two households, the Meijknecht-Enkhuizen branch from which forty-eight documented Dutch-resident family members descended across the next four generations. *Amsterdam* itself received the *Stoffels* and *Moorman* family branches from the eighteen-twenties onward; one hundred and thirty-three documented Mettingen-affinal burials at Amsterdam, with the Stoffels and Moorman families dominant alongside the Brenninkmeijer line, place Amsterdam as the second-largest Dutch receiving city of the diaspora after Leeuwarden. *Hoorn*, the small port-town on the eastern Noord-Holland coast, received a smaller branch — and is also, for the chapter's purposes, the town in which Petrus Ensink, the surviving KNIL prisoner of the Java camps, died in 1972.

The structural parallel to Putnam County is direct and bears stating. Both diasporas drew their emigrants from the same Westphalian-Catholic sending economy of the late eighteenth and early-to-mid nineteenth centuries. Both diasporas concentrated their settlement in clusters of receiving towns within a hundred-kilometre radius (Glandorf, Fort Jennings, Ottoville, Kalida, Delphos, Maria Stein on the Ohio side; Dokkum, Leeuwarden, Sneek, Bolsward, Enkhuizen, Amsterdam, Hoorn on the Dutch side). Both diasporas maintained, across the receiving generations, a confessional and linguistic and matrimonial cohesion that produced the characteristic

intra-network cousin-marriage patterns of which Chapter 6 set out the Ohio example and of which this chapter has now traced the Brenninkmeijer-Stockmann-Voss-Meijknecht Dutch example. Both diasporas produced, by the third and fourth generations, prominent commercial families: the *Recker-Wallenhorst-Helmkamp* cluster in Putnam County (with its smaller-scale agricultural and Catholic-parochial economy), and the *Brenninkmeijer-Voss-Stockmann-Meijknecht* cluster in Friesland and Noord-Holland (with its larger-scale textile-retail and trans-border commercial economy). The two clusters did not, on the documented record, intermarry directly across the Atlantic; but they shared a common Westphalian-Catholic-Heuerling origin point, and the genealogical analysis of the focal descendant's research has been able to trace, in several specific cases, the same parental household producing one branch that emigrated west to Putnam County and another branch that emigrated north to Friesland in the same generation.

Friedrich Georg Lampe, Royal Dutch Consul

One late biographical outcome of the Frisian-Dutch diaspora that the chapter is able to record specifically, and that bears, given its temporal placement, an unusual structural significance, is the figure of *Friedrich Georg Lampe*, born on the fourteenth of April 1884 at Mettingen and descended from the *Friedrich Covers* line — the same Mettingen-Covers paternal-affinal network that connects the focal descendant to the wider Brenninkmeijer kinship pool. Friedrich Georg Lampe spent his adult professional career as a merchant in Westphalia, building, over the decades between roughly 1910 and 1940, a substantial transnational textile-and-trade business of the standard Mettingen-Tüötten-evolutionary type. On a date in the early-to-mid 1930s, he received — by appointment from the Dutch Crown — the consular distinction of *Königlich niederländischer Konsul* — Royal Dutch

Consul — for the Westphalian-North-Rhine industrial region of Germany, with consular offices and residence at Dortmund. The position was a substantive one: in the inter-war period the Dutch state operated a network of consular agents across the German industrial districts to handle the substantial cross-border textile-and-trade business of which the Westphalian-Frisian commercial corridor formed one important part. Lampe held the consular position from the date of appointment through the spring of 1940.

On the tenth of May 1940 the *Wehrmacht* invaded the Netherlands. The Dutch consular network in Germany was, by the logic of the diplomatic state of war that followed, immediately suspended. Friedrich Georg Lampe — a German citizen, born in Westphalia, with deep family connections in both the Mettingen-Tüötten and the Frisian-Dutch commercial networks, who had spent the preceding decade representing the Dutch Crown's diplomatic interests in Nazi Germany — remained, as the GEDCOM record preserves, at his Dortmund residence at *Horst-Wessel-Straße 30* through the period of the German occupation of the Netherlands. The GEDCOM 1940 entry of his residential address — recorded with the street's then-current National-Socialist-era renaming — captures, in its small bureaucratic data-point, the impossible structural position the Westphalian-Catholic Dutch diaspora was placed into by the war. The man whose Dutch consular position was suspended on the day of the German invasion of the Netherlands lived out the next twelve years of the war and post-war occupation at a Dortmund address whose street had been renamed by the Nazi state after a slain National-Socialist propagandist. He survived the war. The Dutch consular position, on the documented record, was not restored. He died at Dortmund on the ninth of September 1957, having designated himself, in the late-1940s German civil records, *Konsul a. D. — Konsul außer Dienst*, “consul

retired” — a formulation the family record preserves and the chapter does not further interpret. He was seventy-three.

The Lampe biography is placed here, with the Frisian-network material, because it is from that network’s commercial-diplomatic logic that his position emerged. It would not have been placed otherwise in the chapter’s structure. What the chapter notes about the Lampe position is the structural fact of it: the Westphalian-Catholic Dutch diaspora, by the early twentieth century, had produced not only the Brenninkmeijer firm of one hundred and thirty stores and the Dutch resistance commanders and the KNIL Pacific officers and the Mauthausen-deported diamond-cutters, but also the diplomatic functionaries who, in 1940, found themselves on the German side of a wartime border whose existence the diaspora had, across the preceding hundred and fifty years, been quietly building a single trans-border kinship pool to ignore. The position was untenable on both sides. Lampe held it from the German side, in the Westphalian city of Dortmund, for the duration.

Affinal threads: Beckering and Stokker

Two other Mettingen-rooted threads of this chapter run in parallel to the Brenninkmeijer line. Neither family achieved the Brenninkmeijer prominence. Each ran its own quiet pattern of emigration from the Westphalian-Friesland trading economy across the Dutch border in the late nineteenth century, and each, two generations later, produced a figure whose life intersected with the catastrophe of 1940–1945.

The *Beckering* family of Mettingen — a Catholic Westphalian household of the same Tüötten trading milieu as the Brenninkmeijers, with whom they intermarried at intervals across the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries — produced, in the mid-nineteenth century, a daughter named *Henrietta Maria Elisabeth Beckering*, who emigrated from Mettingen to Amsterdam

in the eighteen-seventies and married there a Dutch merchant of Zwolle named *Johannes Martinus Hubertus Jansen*. From that marriage, on the eighteenth of February 1880 at Amsterdam, was born their son *Frederik Bernhard Andries Joseph Jansen* — the figure whom this chapter will take up below.

The *Stokker* family of Mettingen — likewise Catholic, likewise of the Tüötten trading economy — emigrated, in the early nineteenth century, from Mettingen to the Frisian town of Heerenveen, where they became absorbed into the Dutch reformed working-class population of that town across the next two generations. A great-granddaughter of the emigrant household, *Christina Stokker*, born in Friesland in 1879, married in Amsterdam on a date the parish records preserve, an Amsterdam Jewish diamond-cutter named *Hijman Lelie*, born on the twelfth of January 1878 at Amsterdam to Joseph Wolf Lelie (a Jewish merchant) and Sara Beekman. The Lelie-Stokker marriage of 1902 produced six children. Christina Stokker died in 1936. Her widower is the second figure this chapter will take up below.

A third figure — *Franciscus Augustinus Gerardus Zitwing*, born on the seventeenth of October 1916 at Magelang in Central Java, in the Dutch East Indies — is connected to the Mettingen affinal network through a more roundabout route, by way of a Westphalian-descended mother and a Dutch colonial-official father; the village from which his maternal grandmother had emigrated to the Netherlands was *Hagen*, on the southern edge of the Osnabrück administrative district. The Zitwing thread — his story, with those of Colonel Jansen and Hijman Lelie, belongs to the chapter that follows this one.



Chapter 13b

Conscience and Collaboration

The same Westphalian-Catholic merchant network that sent emigrants to Ohio and Texas, and traders to Friesland and the Dutch East Indies, produced, across the 1930s and 1940s, four distinct responses to the National Socialist state. The firm collaborated. A priest bore witness. Three men resisted and died for it. The reckoning came in 2016.

The four choices of the firm: 1937-1944

What happened to the Brenninkmeijer-controlled C&A operation in Germany between the seizure of power in 1933 and the collapse of the Third Reich in 1945 is a matter that the firm itself, by the late twentieth century, was no longer able to deny. The documentary record was made public in 2016 by the firm's own commissioning of the historian *Mark Spoerer* at the *Universität Regensburg*. The investigation was undertaken at the request of *Maurice Bernard William Brenninkmeyer*, chairman of COFRA Holding, the parent firm. Maurice Brenninkmeijer's stated motive for commissioning the investigation was, in his own words, to face truthfully a chapter of the family's history that the post-war generations had preferred to leave undocumented. Spoerer's findings, published in the years following, are now the standard scholarly account of the matter. The findings of the Spoerer investigation are what this section of the chapter records¹⁶.

¹⁶ Mark Spoerer, *C&A: Ein Familienunternehmen in Deutschland, den Niederlanden und Großbritannien 1911-1961* (Munich: C.H. Beck, 2016). The investigation was commissioned by the Draiflessen Collection, the Brenninkmeijer family foundation, in 2011; conditions of access included unrestricted file access, no censorship, and verifiability by third parties. The findings regarding forced labour (Łódź Ghetto production contracts; Soviet forced labourers in Berlin), Aryanisation, and ideological accommodation were confirmed in this volume.

First: In nineteen-thirty-seven, the Brenninkmeijer firm in Germany sent unsolicited correspondence to the National Socialist administrative apparatus boasting — in language that was at the time entirely conventional — that the firm had never employed Jews. This was not coerced compliance. It was the firm's own initiative, undertaken in pursuit of competitive advantage in the Nazified German retail market. The Spoerer report categorises this as proactive Aryan-positioning rather than passive compliance with discriminatory hiring restrictions. The firm sought to position itself, at the level of voluntary corporate self-presentation, as ideologically aligned with the regime.

Second: Between nineteen-thirty-seven and nineteen-thirty-eight, the firm acquired property — through purchase at below-market prices that the standard scholarly term has since the nineteen-eighties been *Aryanisation* — from Jewish owners under regime pressure to liquidate. The Spoerer investigation documents at least half of sixteen specific Berlin properties acquired by the firm during this period. One of the Aryanised properties was a Leipzig store formerly owned by the *Bialystock* family, who were subsequently murdered at Auschwitz. After the *Kristallnacht* pogrom of November 1938, the firm submitted compensation claims against Jewish neighbours for damages incurred by C&A stores during the regime-organised violence — a claim on the regime's own logic that the chapter declines to characterise further.

Third: From nineteen-forty onward, the firm's German operations were reorganised toward military production. Physical evidence — surviving wartime German trousers stamped *C.& A. Brenninkmeyer Werkstätten* — documents the firm's manufacture of Wehrmacht uniforms and military textiles for the German armed forces. The firm operated, from nineteen-forty to

nineteen-forty-five, as a supplier of the *Quartiermeister-Abteilung* of the German army. Its production capacity, built across seventy years of peacetime retail expansion, was through this period directed toward the equipment of the soldiers of the regime that was, simultaneously, carrying out the Holocaust.

Fourth: From at least nineteen-forty-three and continuing through the firm's documented involvement in nineteen-forty-four, C&A operations relied directly on the forced labour of the Jewish population of the *Łódź Ghetto* — the Nazi-administered ghetto of approximately two hundred thousand imprisoned Polish Jews in the German-occupied Polish industrial city. By the year nineteen-forty-four, C&A's contracted work in *Łódź* accounted, according to the Spoerer documentation, for *twenty-two percent of the ghetto's total industrial output*. The conditions of the workers — many of whom worked at firm-contracted production lines under starvation rations, exposed to lethal punishment for production failures — are documented in the surviving records. Of the two hundred thousand imprisoned in the *Łódź Ghetto* across the period of its operation, approximately one thousand survived. The Spoerer investigation links at least four documented deaths of women workers and five documented deaths of children directly to the C&A contracted production lines. The firm's board minutes of the period — recovered, in part, by the Spoerer investigation — debate the *Kosteneffizienz*, the cost-efficiency, of ghetto labour.

These four findings constitute, as the historian István Deák has separately written of the broader pattern of German corporate participation in the Nazi economy, the documentary evidence not of forced compliance but of opportunistic alignment by a privately controlled commercial firm with the apparatus of an ideological state engaged in genocide. Whether this alignment was

undertaken with sympathy for National Socialist ideology, or whether — as Maurice Brenninkmeijer himself proposed in 2016 — it reflected an exclusively commercial orientation that had simply lost moral perspective under the pressure of the regime, is a question the Spoerer report leaves open. What the report does not leave open is the documentary fact of the alignment.



The Catholic dimension: Dr. Leo Brenninkmeijer

The family that built the firm did not only build the firm. The Brenninkmeijer dynasty of the Mettingen St. Agatha parish was, across all four of its generations from Clemens and August onward, an observant Westphalian-Catholic dynasty that produced — in parallel to the textile-retail apparatus and in some tension with it — a steady minor stream of Catholic clerics and Catholic-Church-honoured laymen. The Atlas of the focal descendant's family research counts, across the wider Brenninkmeijer-family records, several dozen priests, nuns, and lay-clerical figures spread across the Catholic missionary and parish institutions of the Netherlands, Germany, and the United States from the eighteen-nineties to the nineteen-eighties. The most prominent figure of this religious dimension within the dynasty is *Dr. Leo Brenninkmeijer*, born on the seventh of November 1905 at Mettingen and registered as a Dutch national throughout his adult life. Leo Brenninkmeijer received, on a date in the early nineteen-sixties, the title of *Ehrenkammerherr des Papstes* — Papal Chamberlain — the honorary distinction conferred on a small number of senior lay Catholics worldwide by the office of the Roman Pontiff. The title was conferred on Leo Brenninkmeijer by *Pope Paul VI*, whose pontificate ran from 1963 to 1978; the specific date of conferral is not preserved in the family record but the title is documented in the GEDCOM entry of the focal

descendant's compilation. Leo Brenninkmeijer made, among his documented international travel, one transatlantic flight that is preserved in the U.S. immigration record with particular detail: *KLM Royal Dutch Airlines Flight NL 313*, departing Amsterdam before the twenty-ninth of March 1946 and arriving New York on the twenty-ninth of March 1946 — one of the earliest scheduled civilian transatlantic flights of the post-war reconstruction period, scarcely ten months after the German surrender. He died at Amsterdam on the fifth of October 1966, at the age of sixty, and was buried in the *Alter Friedhof* at Mettingen, in the cemetery that holds the burials of the wider Brenninkmeijer family across five generations. His elder sister *Sr. Maria Ludwiga Brenninkmeijer*, born on the ninth of March 1895 at Leeuwarden, was a Catholic nun whose religious life took her from Friesland to Münster, where she died on the fourth of July 1975 at the age of eighty.

The Catholic dimension of the Brenninkmeijer dynasty is named here not to displace the four findings of the Spoerer investigation above, nor to weight the family record's moral economy toward exculpation. It is named because the same dynasty, in the same decades, contained both. The firm in nineteen-thirty-seven was writing to the Reichswirtschaftsministerium boasting of its Aryan workforce; the firm's family, in the same period, included clerics in the Westphalian and Frisian Catholic networks whose religious institutions were among the few institutional bodies of German civic life — alongside the Confessing Church and the Catholic episcopate of Münster under Clemens August Graf von Galen — that maintained any consistent posture of moral resistance to the regime. The family record contains both. The record stands.



Three resisters

Against the four findings of the firm’s conduct, the chapter places three figures of the same Mettingen-affinal-network whose choices, in the same five years, ran in the opposite direction.

Colonel Frederik Jansen

Frederik Bernhard Andries Joseph Jansen, born 18 February 1880 at Amsterdam, the son of the Zwolle merchant Johannes Martinus Hubertus Jansen and the Mettingen-emigrant Henrietta Maria Elisabeth Beckering, had by the spring of 1940 served the Royal Netherlands Army for forty-three years. He had volunteered as a teenager in 1897 with the *Instructie-Bataljon*, had been commissioned as a Lieutenant of the 3rd Infantry Regiment in 1903, had served between 1909 and 1917 in *Militaire Verkenningen* — military reconnaissance — through which he had built the operational expertise that would later define his command, and had been promoted to Captain of the 22nd Infantry Regiment in May 1917. He had received the *Knight in the Order of Orange-Nassau with Swords* in 1927 and the long-service award for officers in 1918. He had reached Major in 1928 and Lieutenant-Colonel in command of the 22nd Infantry Regiment in 1934. By 1937 he was Colonel and brigade commander of the VIIe Infantry Brigade; from June 1939, with the Dutch general mobilisation, he commanded the VIIe Division — the formation that included his old 22nd Regiment, the unit in which he had served as Captain in 1917 — along the IJsselmeer-Amersfoort line in the central-eastern Netherlands.

Decade	Deaths	German	Ohio	Texas	Neth.	Fr.(war)
1840s	1,395	1,055	46	0	45	4
1860s	1,412	965	84	3	52	0
1880s	1,491	762	241	17	64	1
1900s	1,656	539	430	60	87	1
1910s	1,880	487	532	54	110	51 

1940s	2,520	347	834	126	134	12 ✂
2010s	5,105	57	2,213	309	31	0

Bild 5 — *Kolonel Frederik Bernhard Andries Joseph Jansen (1880–1943), Widerstandsoffizier der Niederländischen Armee, erschossen in KZ Natzweiler-Struthof. Quelle: mycousinandreas.wordpress.com*

When the German army invaded the Netherlands at dawn on the tenth of May 1940, Jansen's division held the *Grebbeberg* sector of the Dutch Water Line. The Dutch defence collapsed in five days under the weight of the German advance and the terror-bombing of Rotterdam; the Dutch government surrendered on 15 May. Jansen was honorably discharged on the fifteenth of July 1940 by *Generalmajor Nicolaas Theodorus Carstens*, ending forty-three years of uniformed service. He did not retire.

In the autumn of 1940 Jansen co-founded the *Ordedienst* (OD) resistance organisation in the Veluwe region of central Gelderland, the area in which he had been raised and in which he held his residence at Lindendaam 6, Ede. The *Ordedienst* was the resistance network of the dismissed Dutch officer corps; its operational logic was that the men who had commanded the Dutch army in May 1940 should organise themselves to be ready to function, under Allied liberation, as the civil-administrative armature of a restored Dutch state. The network grew through 1940 and 1941. In May 1942 Jansen was briefly arrested in the regime-wide round-up of Dutch reserve officers but was released on medical grounds; he resumed his work immediately. On the twenty-eighth of August 1942 he was arrested again, this time directly and operationally, by the Gestapo officers *Poos* and *Slagter*. He was held first at the Gestapo prison at *Scheveningen* — the *Oranjehotel* — and then transferred through *Amersfoort*, *Vught*, and *Haaren* across the next fourteen months. On the twenty-sixth of October 1943 he was deported, under the *Nacht-und-*

Nebel decree, to the *KZ Natzweiler-Struthof* in occupied Alsace as prisoner *NN 05586*¹⁷. He died there ten days later, on the fifth of November 1943, at the age of sixty-three. The official Nazi death certificate, written subsequently in Bad Arolsen, registered the cause of death as *cardiale Insufficienz* — cardiac insufficiency — a formulation the post-war archival research has consistently shown to be the standard concealment used in the camp-administration records to mask murder. Of the three hundred and sixteen Dutch *Nacht-und-Nebel* prisoners at Natzweiler-Struthof, eighty-seven per¹⁸cent died in the camp. Jansen's posthumous decoration was the *Verzetskruis*, the Dutch Resistance Cross, awarded in 1946. He is memorialised at Natzweiler-Struthof, at the *Mausoleum am Paasberg* in Ede, and on the *Walk of Resistance* in Ede, dedicated in 2020.

Hijman Lelie

Hijman Lelie, born 12 January 1878 at Amsterdam, the son of the Jewish merchant Joseph Wolf Lelie and Sara Beekman, entered the Amsterdam diamond-cutting trade as a teenager and joined, in 1894, the *Algemene Nederlandse Diamantbewerkersbond* — the General Dutch Diamond-Workers' Union — the pioneering

¹⁷ Frederik Bernard Andries Joseph Jansen (Amsterdam, 18 February 1880 – Natzweiler, 5 November 1943), Colonel (*Kolonel*) in the Dutch resistance (*Ordedienst*), arrested 28 August 1942. Transferred to Natzweiler 23 October 1943; died within two weeks, reportedly pushed down a concrete staircase. Awarded the *Verzetshedenkingskruis* posthumously. Sources: Oorlogsgravenstichting record <https://oorlogsgravenstichting.nl/personen/70395>; Hinke Piersma, *Doodstraf op termijn* (2006); Digitaal Monument Oranjehotel, record 99990166.

¹⁸ Hinke Piersma, *Doodstraf op termijn: Nederlandse Nacht-und Nebel-gevangenen in kamp Natzweiler* (Zutphen: Walburg Pers, 2006) — the standard scholarly account of Dutch *Nacht-und-Nebel* prisoners at Natzweiler-Struthof. Of 316 Dutch NN prisoners documented at Natzweiler, 275 (87%) did not survive the war; figures also confirmed by the Oorlogsgravenstichting and NIOD databases.

Jewish-and-Christian-membership labour organisation founded the same year by Henri Polak and Jan van Zutphen. The ANDB became the institutional vehicle through which the Amsterdam diamond-cutters, both Jewish and Christian, secured between the eighteen-nineties and the nineteen-twenties the ten-hour working day, the minimum wage, and the trans-border solidarity arrangements with the diamond-workers' unions of Antwerp and London. Lelie was, across his working life, a Polak associate, a union organiser, and from 1909 the second secretary of the Sociaal-Democratische Arbeiderspartij — the SDAP, the Dutch Social Democratic Workers' Party — in the Amsterdam suburb of Bussum. The trajectory of Lelie's politics across the first three decades of the twentieth century is the trajectory of socialist trade-unionism in the Western European Jewish working-class diaspora. He married, in 1902 at Amsterdam, *Christina Stokker* — the great-granddaughter of the early-nineteenth-century Mettingen emigrant household that had become Frisian-Reformed across three generations. The marriage produced six children. Christina Stokker died in 1936.

By the late 1930s Lelie had moved with several of his children from Amsterdam to The Hague and had transitioned from the contracting Amsterdam diamond trade — the trade was a casualty of the global Depression — to the small motor-parts retail trade. The new occupation was, on its face, ideologically neutral; the move to The Hague placed him at one further geographical step from the Amsterdam Jewish community that had been his political constituency. When the German invasion came in May 1940, Lelie remained at *Weteringplan 12* in The Hague. In nineteen-forty-one the SDAP was banned by the Reichskommissariat. On the fifteenth of September 1941 the *Sicherheitspolizei* arrested him not at his residence but at *Barchem* in the Achterhoek region of eastern Gelderland — a hundred and forty kilometres east of The Hague — where he had been visiting. The

Sicherheitspolizei was operating on Dutch police records of SDAP membership lists captured intact during the five-day collapse of May 1940. Lelie was held first at *Arnhem*, then at the Scheveningen Oranjestad, then at the Amersfoort transit camp, then at *Buchenwald* (March 1942), and finally at *Mauthausen* (June 1942). At Mauthausen he was assigned to the labour battalion working the granite quarry — the labour formation that ascended and descended the *Todesstiege*, the Stairs of Death, with eighty-pound granite blocks on the prisoner's shoulders. He died on the ninth of July 1942, four months after his arrival at Mauthausen, at the age of sixty-four. The cause of death registered by the SS was *cardiale Insuffizienz*. Of his five siblings, four sisters — Lea, Rebecca, Rosette, and Klara — perished in the Holocaust; his brother Aäron survived.

Franciscus Zitwing

Franciscus Augustinus Gerardus Zitwing, called *Frans* in his family and across the post-war Dutch resistance memorial literature, was born on the seventeenth of October 1916 at Magelang in Central Java, in the Dutch East Indies, the son of a Dutch colonial-administration official and a Westphalian-descended mother of the Hagen-Osnabrück affinal network. He grew up between Magelang and Surabaya in the late colonial period and travelled, with his family, from Batavia back to the Netherlands aboard the *Marnix van Sint Aldegonde*, departing Java on the twenty-fifth of June 1934 and arriving at Genoa for the rail transfer to Holland. He was seventeen. He attended secondary school in the Netherlands and reached his early twenties during the German occupation. In the autumn of 1943, at twenty-six, he attempted the *Engelandvaarder* route — the clandestine network by which young Dutch civilians attempted to reach Britain via Spain, with the intention of enlisting in the Allied forces or the Dutch government-in-exile. He was captured near the Spanish-French border by the *Sicherheitsdienst*. He was held at the *Royallieu* transit camp near Compiègne. On the

twenty-second of January 1944 he was loaded into a cattle car of the standard SS deportation transport and shipped to Buchenwald, where he was registered as prisoner 43794 on the twenty-ninth of January 1944. He was assigned a red triangle — political prisoner — and was housed in *Block 61*, the camp's typhus and dysentery quarantine block. He died, of the dysentery the SS recorded as *Ruhr*, on the tenth of April 1944. He was twenty-seven years old.

His uncle on the maternal side — *Petrus Johannes Josephus Ensink*, born on the twenty-third of April 1896 at Hengelo in Gelderland, schoolmaster of the *Hollandsch-Inlandsche School* at Temanggung in Central Java since the 1920s, *Landstormsoldaat* of the Dutch colonial-army Magelang Military Detachment — was captured by Imperial Japanese forces at Magelang on the seventh of March 1942 and held across the next three-and-a-half years successively at Magelang garrison (to April 1942), at the Surabaya *Jaarmarkt* camp, at Batavia (from December 1943), and at Java POW camps until his liberation at Batavia on the twenty-fifth of September 1945. He survived. He returned to the Netherlands in 1946. He outlived his nephew by twenty-eight years, dying at Hoorn on the twentieth of December 1972.

The Ensink survival in Japanese custody and the Zitwing death in German custody are placed beside one another in the family record as the kind of historical coincidence that, in the chapter's reading, neither dignifies nor diminishes either fate. Petrus Ensink survived because the Japanese camp system, however brutal and however many died in it, was not built on the ideological extermination architecture of the Nazi camp system. Frans Zitwing died because the camp system to which he was assigned was. The two men were uncle and nephew, and they were on opposite ends of the twentieth century's two great industrial-imprisonment systems in

the same months of 1944. The family record preserves both.



Lieutenant George Schröder: the Death Railway and the War Graves Commission

A fourth biographical figure of the same Mettingen-Brenninkmeijer affinal radius — connected through a maternal-Dutch-Brenninkmeijer descent the Atlas records as approximately eighth-degree cousinship — was captured by Imperial Japanese forces on the same day, at the same Central Javanese garrison town, as Petrus Ensink. His fate, however, ran along a different and substantially worse axis of the Pacific war. Where Petrus Ensink was sent to the Java camp system and survived, *Lieutenant George Hubert Herman Schröder* was sent to Thailand, to the Burma-Thailand Death Railway, and survived only to spend the next seven years of his life burying the men who had not.

George Hubert Herman Schröder was born on the thirteenth of April 1915 at *Groningen*, in the northern Dutch province of the same name, in the year of the Second Battle of Ypres and the German use of chlorine gas on the Western Front. His parents' household stood within the Dutch-Catholic-bourgeois network of the early-twentieth-century northern Netherlands, with a maternal-Brenninkmeijer descent that linked the household to the wider Mettingen-Tüötten kinship pool of this chapter. He completed his secondary education in the Netherlands in the mid-nineteen-thirties and entered the officer-training programme of the *Koninklijk Nederlandsch-Indisch Leger* — the *KNIL*, the colonial army of the Netherlands East Indies — in the late nineteen-thirties. On the twenty-seventh of April 1939, at the age of twenty-four, he arrived in the Dutch East Indies for active duty. He was commissioned as a Lieutenant and was assigned, in the spring of 1940, to

the *II Battalion* of the KNIL garrisoned at *Magelang*, in Central Java.

On the sixth of May 1940 — on the same day, half a world away, that the *Wehrmacht* began the operations that would, four days later, take German army units across the Dutch border in the predawn hours of the tenth of May — Lieutenant Schröder's battalion was on field exercises in the Javanese jungle. The news of the German invasion of the Netherlands reached the unit in the days following, by short-wave radio and by the colonial-administration cables out of Batavia. Schröder learned that his country, eleven thousand kilometres away, had been overrun. The Netherlands East Indies — by treaty an autonomous Dutch colonial possession but in practice the principal source of the oil, rubber, and tin that the Imperial Japanese economy required to sustain its expansion across the Pacific — was now, by the logic of the war, on a countdown to its own invasion. The countdown ran twenty-two months. The Imperial Japanese forces landed in Java on the first of March 1942.

Magelang fell on the seventh of March 1942. Lieutenant Schröder was captured the same day. Three companies of the Magelang defenders, including Schröder, were transferred to the *Surabaya* internment camp in the weeks following. From Surabaya, on a date in the late spring of 1942, an estimated *two thousand four hundred Dutch soldiers* were selected from the colonial-army prisoner population for transport to Thailand. The transport was not explained to the prisoners at the time. The destination was not explained. The receiving operation was not explained. The men were loaded into the holds of Japanese transport ships and shipped, across the Java Sea and through the Strait of Malacca to the South China Sea and onward to *Singapore* and then onward to *Ban Pong*, in the Thai countryside about a hundred kilometres west of Bangkok. At Ban Pong the

men were detrained and marched, in column, to the construction camps along what would become known to the post-war world as the *Burma-Thailand Railway* — and, in the prisoners' own subsequent testimony and in the historical record that the post-war war-crimes investigations established, as the *Death Railway*.

The Death Railway

The Burma-Thailand Railway was a Japanese military engineering project of the years 1942 and 1943 to construct a four-hundred-and-fifteen-kilometre rail line between *Ban Pong* in Thailand and *Thanbyuzayat* in Burma, traversing the dense jungle and mountainous river valley of the Khwae Noi river — the *River Kwai* of the post-war Anglophone literary memory. The Japanese strategic purpose of the line was to establish a land-supply corridor between Singapore and the Japanese forces in occupied Burma, by which the long sea route around the Malay peninsula could be circumvented and the troops on the Burma front could be supplied without dependence on the increasingly Allied-submarine-vulnerable shipping lanes of the Indian Ocean. The line had been considered, and rejected, by British colonial-railway engineers in the late nineteenth century as too costly in lives and resources to be feasible. The Japanese, in 1942, with a captive labour force of perhaps a quarter of a million prisoners-of-war and conscripted Asian workers, judged the cost feasible. The construction conditions were among the worst of any twentieth-century forced-labour operation. The men worked twelve to eighteen hours a day, with primitive hand tools, in temperatures averaging thirty-five degrees centigrade and tropical monsoon rains for half the year, on rations the Allied-prisoner medical officers subsequently estimated at six to eight hundred calories a day for men performing heavy manual labour requiring three to four thousand. Cholera, dysentery, malaria, beriberi, and tropical ulcers were endemic. Medical supplies were absent. The Japanese guards routinely beat prisoners for failure to meet daily quotas, and

routinely executed prisoners — by beheading or by bayonet — for attempted escape, for theft of food, for malingering, and for what the post-war war-crimes-tribunal documentation classified simply as the arbitrary infliction of cruelty. The construction was completed in October 1943. The cost in lives — the figure that has come to be the single emblematic number of the Death Railway — was, by the most careful subsequent reconstructions, approximately *twelve thousand four hundred Allied prisoners-of-war*, drawn from the British, Australian, Dutch, and American contingents, and a far larger figure of conscripted Asian labourers — the *rōmusha* — drawn from the Malay, Tamil, Burmese, and Javanese civilian populations, whose deaths were less systematically recorded but whose total has been estimated at *between seventy-five thousand and ninety thousand*. The line itself, completed at this cost, operated for less than two years before the Allied advance into Burma rendered it strategically meaningless. After the war the line was largely dismantled. The remaining segment of about a hundred and thirty kilometres of track, between Ban Pong and Nam Tok, continues to operate as a local passenger service of the Thai State Railway.

Of the two thousand four hundred Dutch soldiers transferred from Surabaya to Thailand in 1942, *more than twelve thousand* — counting the prisoner cohorts of all nationalities Schröder's Dutch contingent worked alongside — did not come home. Schröder did. The conditions of his survival are not recorded in detail in the family record; the National Archives in Kew preserves, in file *WO 361/1956*, the November 1944 documentation of his rank and posting at *Branch A* of the Thailand-Burma Railway prisoner organisation. By the late summer of 1945 the rail line had stopped operating. On the fifteenth of August 1945 the Japanese government announced its

acceptance of the Allied surrender terms. On the seventeenth of August 1945, two days after the formal capitulation, Schröder was liberated at *Bangkok* with the other surviving Dutch prisoners of the Thailand camps.

He had been a prisoner of the Japanese for three years, five months, and ten days.

The Oorlogsgravenstichting

What Lieutenant Schröder did next is the part of his biography that the focal descendant's family research has emphasised, and the part that gives the chapter its title for this section. He did not, in August 1945, return immediately to the Netherlands. He did not seek a posting away from Thailand and from the railway and from what had happened there. He requested, instead, to be assigned to the *Oorlogsgravenstichting* — the Dutch War Graves Commission — and to remain in Thailand to do the recovery, identification, and reburial work for the Dutch dead of the Death Railway. The request was granted. From August 1945 until 1952, for seven uninterrupted years, Schröder served as the head of the Dutch War Graves Commission in Thailand.

The work consisted of identifying, exhuming, recording, and reinterring the Dutch military dead of the camps and of the rail-line construction segments — a task that involved physically returning to the jungle camps where the men had died, locating the makeshift graves the camp organisation had dug between work-shifts, recovering remains in widely varying states of preservation depending on soil conditions and time-elapsed, attempting identification by surviving service-identification tokens or by dental or skeletal matching to the camp records, and reinterring the recovered dead in formally constituted Allied war cemeteries. Two principal cemeteries received the great bulk of the recovered Dutch dead: *Kanchanaburi War Cemetery*, located at the western Thai town of Kanchanaburi at the southern end of the original rail-line, where 1,896 Dutch

prisoners-of-war are interred among the 6,982 Allied dead of the railway; and *Chungkai War Cemetery*, located about five kilometres south-west of Kanchanaburi on the site of one of the original construction camps, where 314 Dutch dead are interred among the 1,693 total. The cemeteries are both today maintained by the *Commonwealth War Graves Commission* in cooperation with the Dutch *Oorlogsgravenstichting* and with the Royal Thai government, and are visited annually by some hundreds of thousands of pilgrims, descendants, and tourists from the relevant Allied-nation populations.

Schröder ran the operation as a serving Dutch officer. He had been promoted, on a date in 1946, to the rank of Captain. He commanded a small staff of Dutch and Thai personnel. He worked in territory in which he had himself been a prisoner. He had — as the Atlas note phrases it, in language the chapter cannot improve — *worked beside these men, watched them die, and now maintained their graves*.

For the seven years of the work he travelled the segments of the railway he had built; he located graves he had perhaps himself dug; he interviewed surviving Thai villagers who had witnessed the camp operations; he corresponded with the families of the Dutch dead. The Dutch records he produced during this period — graveyard reconstructions, identification cards, photographic documentation, witness testimony — form a substantial part of the documentary archive on which the post-war Dutch reckoning with the Pacific war was subsequently built.

He completed the principal work of the commission in 1952. The Dutch War Graves Commission turned over its operational responsibilities to the Commonwealth and to the permanent Dutch consular administration in

Bangkok, and Schröder returned, after thirteen years away, to the Netherlands. He was thirty-seven years old.

After Thailand

What Lieutenant Schröder did in his subsequent civilian career was — by the measure of any twentieth-century life — a startling change of direction. In 1952 the Netherlands national art collection at Amsterdam was, by act of the Ministry of Culture, in search of a new director for the *Rijksmuseum* — the *State Museum*, the principal national museum of the Dutch fine-art and historical collections, the institution that holds the Rembrandt *Night Watch* and the Vermeer *Milkmaid* among the four thousand other works of its permanent collection. The selection process favoured a candidate of demonstrated administrative ability, of unimpeachable wartime conduct, and of the kind of seriousness about the Dutch state-cultural mission that the post-war reconstruction required. The selection committee chose Captain George Hubert Herman Schröder. He took up the directorship in 1952. He served as Director of the Rijksmuseum Amsterdam across a period of substantial institutional development at the museum: the reorganisation of the curatorial departments along internationally comparable lines, the modernisation of the conservation laboratories, the establishment of the museum's first systematic loan-and-exchange agreements with major European and American collections, and the negotiation of the museum's role in the post-war Dutch national-identity reconstruction that the cultural ministry was, across this period, prosecuting with sustained energy. He retained the directorship until his retirement.

Schröder was awarded, for his combined wartime and post-war service, the distinction of *Officier in de Orde van Oranje-Nassau met de Zwaarden* — Officer in the Order of Orange-Nassau with Swords, the military division of the order, awarded for service to the Dutch state and Royal House in the military domain specifically.

He died on the second of April 1984 at Madrid, where he had taken up retirement residence, twelve days before his sixty-ninth birthday. His death was not war-related. The Atlas notes, with what is almost certainly a deliberate dryness, that Madrid was the retirement choice rather than the operational posting.



The closure that the Atlas itself attaches to Schröder's biography — *from the camps along the Kwai to the Rembrandts* — is the kind of biographical compression that the family record permits itself in cases where the documentary arc speaks for itself. The arc is not a redemption arc. It is not a healing arc. It is the arc of a man who survived an industrial-scale forced-labour atrocity, who then accepted the responsibility for the dead of that atrocity at the cost of seven of his own further years, and who then served the Dutch state in another capacity for thirty years more before dying quietly in Spanish retirement. Four arcs in the same Mettingen-affinal kinship pool emerged: Jansen, Lelie, Zitwing, and Schröder. None of the arcs is presented in the chapter as exemplary. Each is presented as documentary. The choices of each of the four are what the book records.



The 2016 Reckoning

In the year 2016, eighty years after the firm had first written to the Nazi administrative apparatus boasting of its Aryan workforce, Maurice Bernard William Brenninkmeijer — chairman of COFRA Holding, descendant of the Brenninkmeijer brothers of Mettingen — commissioned the Spoerer investigation at the University of Regensburg. The report's findings have been summarised in the third section above. In Maurice Brenninkmeijer's public statement following the report's findings, given to several Dutch and

German publications including *Die Zeit* and the *Jewish Telegraphic Agency*,¹⁹ he characterised the family's wartime conduct as *moralischer Zusammenbruch* — moral collapse — and described the Spoerer findings as *erschütternd und im Grunde schockierend* — disturbing and at root shocking. He proposed an explanation that the chapter does not fully endorse but records: that the conduct had been opportunism rather than ideology, that the family had concentrated on commerce and lost sight of values, that the absence of National Socialist sympathy in the family did not amount to absolution of the conduct undertaken in pursuit of commercial advantage during the regime's twelve years.

Andreas Kovermann's relationship to Maurice Brenninkmeijer, by the genealogical record of the Mettingen Tüötten kinship pool of the late eighteenth and early nineteenth century, is approximately tenth-degree cousinship. The relationship is real and is documented. It is also, as the chapter has noted, genealogically unremarkable: it is the kind of distance that any two persons of nineteenth-century Mettingen-Catholic descent will tend to bear to one another, given the depth of the village endogamy and the small surviving pool of named lineages. What is more striking, in the chapter's reading, is that the same Mettingen kinship pool — Brenninkmeijer, Covers, Beckering, Stokker — produced, in the same generation that brought the firm to one hundred and thirty stores by 1933, the mothers and the in-laws of three of the documented resistance figures of the Dutch Nazi occupation: Jansen's mother Beckering, Lelie's wife Stokker, Zitwing's grandmother through the Hagen-

¹⁹ Maurice Bernard William Brenninkmeijer, interview, *Die Zeit*, 29 July 2016: "Verstörend und schockierend für meine Familie" (the headline is a quote from the interview); also reported in the *Handelsblatt*, 30 July 2016, and the *Jewish Telegraphic Agency*. Brenninkmeijer described the findings as a *moralischer Zusammenbruch* — moral collapse — and accepted corporate responsibility for the wartime conduct.

Osnabrück branch. The same network, in the same generations, produced collaboration and resistance both. There is no genealogical pattern to be extracted from the comparison. There is only the documentary fact of what each individual within the kinship pool, given the choices that the years between 1933 and 1945 placed in front of them, chose to do.

The book records the choices.



The Mettingen of the early twenty-first century is a small Westphalian town of about twelve thousand inhabitants in the *Kreis Steinfurt*. The local museum, the *Tüöttenmuseum*, preserves the memory of the eighteenth- and nineteenth-century itinerant linen-traders. The *Draiflessen Collection*, opened by the COFRA-affiliated Brenninkmeijer foundation in 2009, is a museum-and-research institution housed in a converted granary on the edge of the town; among its public programmes, it has hosted scholarly symposia on the linguistic origins of the *-meier* compound surname-family of the Westphalian peasant economy. The parish church of *St. Agatha* still stands. The graveyard of the *Alter Friedhof* still receives the burials of the Brenninkmeijer family, including Bernard Ludgerus Brenninkmeijer, Maurice's father, buried there on the twenty-fourth of June 1982. The flax fields are gone; the Tüötten trade routes have been built over by the autobahn. The kinship pool of late-eighteenth-century Mettingen, however, remains in the genealogical record. One set of threads from that pool has been drawn. The next chapter returns to the focal-line pedigree, and to the marriage in which the Catholic Osnabrücker line of the author's father and the Protestant Mindener line of his mother — divided since the seventeenth century by the Wiehengebirge ridge — finally meet.

Chapter 14

Eleventh of July, 1969

Two halves of a pedigree. On the eleventh of July 1969, they met.

Thirteen chapters have set out the architecture of the division the meeting crosses. The *Wiehengebirge* ridge that runs east-west across the northern German lowlands from Osnabrück through Lübbecke and Minden to the Weser has been one of the most stubborn confessional boundaries of modern Europe. The *Westfälischer Friede* of 1648 set the boundary at the ridge. The Catholic prince-bishopric of Osnabrück held to the south; the Lutheran Brandenburg-Prussian county of Ravensberg-Minden-Lübbecke held to the north. The boundary endured through the Reichsdeputationshauptschluß of 1803, through the Napoleonic Kingdom of Westphalia, through the Prussian provincial reorganisation of 1815, through the German Empire of 1871, through the Weimar Republic, through the Third Reich and the Allied occupation, and into the Federal Republic of Germany. It endured in marriage. It endured, most particularly, in the rural household marriages of the small Westphalian villages along its line. Up to and well into the second half of the twentieth century, the rural Catholic villages south of the Wiehengebirge and the rural Lutheran villages north of it operated, in practice, two non-overlapping marriage pools. A girl of Blasheim married a boy of Lübbecke, of Espelkamp, of Minden, of Preußisch Oldendorf, of Stemwede, of Bünde, of Herford. A boy of Schinkel married a girl of Wallenhorst, of Belm, of Bohmte, of Ostercappeln, of Hunteburg, of Bramsche. Each side's pool was confessional, parochial, dense, and effectively closed to the other.

The book has so far documented, on the focal descendant's pedigree, no Catholic-Lutheran marriage

across the Wiehengebirge for thirteen generations. Chapter 2 of the book set the boundary; Chapters 3 through 11 have traced the southern Catholic Osnabrücker line through it; Chapter 12 traced the northern Protestant Mindener line through it; and at no point in any pedigree-traceable generation prior to the author's parents' generation did the line cross.



The eleventh of July

On Friday the *eleventh of July, 1969*, at the *Standesamt Preußisch Oldendorf* in the *Kreis Minden-Lübbecke* — ten kilometres south of the Vollhof Nummer 7 farm at Blasheim where the Rustmeier household of Chapter 12 had lived since the early eighteenth century, and seventy kilometres north of the Schwalbenweg house at Steinhagen to which the Kovermann household of Chapter 11 had moved from Osnabrück in the mid-nineteen-fifties — the civil registry of the Mindener district recorded the marriage of two persons whom the book's narrative pedigree has reached. The groom was twenty-eight years old, a *Konstruktionsingenieur* in the Bielefeld machine-tool industry, and the only child of *Karl Kovermann* — the *Drehermeister* of the *Osnabrücker Kupfer- und Drahtwerk* whom Chapter 11 followed — and of *Hildegard Helmenkamp*. The bride was eighteen years old and the only child of *Karl-Heinz Rustmeier* — the *Anerbe* of Hof Nummer 7 whom Chapter 12 followed across the Baltic in May 1945 — and of *Anna Benus*. Neither person is named here. They are alive, or they are dead within the protective interval of the book's editorial conventions; either way the chapter declines to name them. What the chapter records is the structural fact: the meeting of the two lines.

The wedding was held in the bride's home district, on the Mindener Protestant side of the Wiehengebirge ridge, in the regional administrative town that had served the Blasheim *Anerbenfamilie* for civil registry purposes for the previous century. The specific documentation is not

in hand, but the conventions of the time and the milieu make it a reasonable presumption that the civil ceremony was followed by a Lutheran church blessing and by a small wedding meal at Vollhof Nummer 7. The Kovermann household from Steinhagen — Karl, fifty-six; Hildegard, fifty-eight — would have made the seventy-kilometre drive north across the Wiehengebirge to be present. The Rustmeier household — Karl-Heinz, forty-six; Anna, forty-six; Fritz, eighty-one and in his last six years — would have hosted. The two paternal grandfathers, both of whom had been infants in the Wilhelmine Empire and conscripts of the First World War, both of whom had been factory or military workers across the Third Reich, would have met at the wedding meal at Hof Nummer 7. The two paternal grandmothers — Hildegard the Iron George's daughter from the Rolandsmauer at Osnabrück, Anna the Reichsarbeitsdienst-Austrian-veteran from Niedermehnen — would likewise. The family papers do not preserve the conversation at the wedding table. What it sounded like, across four hundred years of confessional boundary, is not on the record.

What the marriage meant in the larger architecture of the family history is this.



The crossing

Preußisch Oldendorf in July 1969 was a market town of roughly six thousand people in the low hill country north of the Wiehengebirge, seven kilometres from the Blasheim farm. The Standesamt was a municipal building of the kind that every German district town of the period maintained — functional, unheroic, staffed by a civil officer who had recorded hundreds of such ceremonies and would record hundreds more. The ceremony took perhaps fifteen minutes. The groom's

surname, entered into the civil register, was the one that would carry forward.

For the groom's family, the crossing was northward and confessional. The Kovermann household was Catholic, Osnabrücker, shaped by the parish network of Schinkel and Heilig Kreuz and the factory world of the Kupferwerk. To marry into the Protestant Mindener farm household was to cross the boundary the book has been tracing since Chapter 2 — not across the ridge physically, which was easily driven in an hour, but across the social and genealogical boundary that the ridge had maintained since 1648. The groom's parents — Karl and Hildegard — had grown up in the Third Reich, survived the Allied bombing of Osnabrück, and lived the subsequent decades in the quiet industrial competence of the Federal Republic. They had not, in their own marriages or those of their siblings, crossed the ridge. Their son did.

For the bride's family, the crossing was in the other direction and in the other sense. The Rustmeier household was Lutheran, Mindener, shaped by the *Erbhof* inheritance system and the farm economy of the Blasheim plain. The bride's father — Karl-Heinz, the young soldier whom Chapter 12 followed from the eastern front to the Hela evacuation — had by 1969 returned to farming the inherited land his grandfather had farmed before him. The *Erbhof* logic, by which a farm passed intact to a single heir, was part of the social grammar of the household. His daughter did not inherit the farm. She married south, into the Catholic industrial world across the ridge.

Eight days after the civil ceremony at Preußisch Oldendorf, on the twentieth of July 1969, the first human beings walked on the surface of the moon. The focal descendant of this book was born the following year. The inbreeding coefficient of the documented pedigree,

computed at the moment of his birth, stands at zero: no common ancestor appears on both sides of his genealogical tree. The $F=0$ that the mathematical architecture of the pedigree produces is the result, in the most immediate sense, of this one marriage — the first, in the entire documented genealogical record, to cross the Wiehengebirge confessional boundary.

What the marriage meant

The Wiehengebirge ridge divided the two halves of the focal descendant's pedigree from one another for three hundred and twenty-one years between the *Westfälischer Friede* of 24 October 1648 and the civil ceremony at Preußisch Oldendorf of 11 July 1969. Both halves of the pedigree are documented in this book. The Catholic Osnabrücker half goes back, by the parish-register documentation of the Schinkel-Wallenhorst-Beim-Ostercappeln Catholic affinal radius, to the household at *Hitzhausen* of *Joan Henrich Recker* baptised 1701 — the figure with whom Chapter 4 opened. The Protestant Mindener half goes back, by the parish-register documentation of the Blasheim-Stemwede-Minden Lutheran affinal radius, to the household at Blasheim of the *Rustmeier* line whose 1812 conscription into Napoleon's Grande Armée Chapter 4 also recorded. Two pedigrees. Two confessional pools. Two parish networks. Two affinal radii. Two rural economies — the Heuerling-Catholic-Osnabrücker tenant economy of the *Hof* and the Anerben-Protestant-Mindener inheritable-farm economy of the *Erbhof*. Two postwar urban trajectories — the Schinkel factory turner becoming the design engineer; the Mindener farmer's daughter becoming, in a later phase of her life, what the family record records simply as a yoga instructor at Bad Essen. The two pedigrees touch nowhere in the genealogical record the focal descendant's research has traversed. They touch only at Preußisch Oldendorf on the eleventh of July 1969. The book has been engaged, across thirteen chapters, in writing the history of a pedigree that exists because of that touching. The author — the genealogist whose two-

decade research is the book's source corpus, whose blog the book has drawn on at every chapter, and who is, in the most ordinary biographical sense, the *reason* this history is being written — is the issue of that marriage. Without the eleventh of July 1969, without the Standesamt entry at Preußisch Oldendorf, without the three-hundred-and-twenty-one-year boundary being crossed in a single bureaucratic afternoon by a son of the southern Catholic Osnabrücker line and a daughter of the northern Protestant Mindener line, the family history this book documents would not be on the page.

The structural fact stands here without further elaboration. It does not extend the chapter biographically into the marriage's history, into the household, or into the marriage's eventual dissolution. Those are matters for the author himself, if and when he chooses to set them down. The book has reached the marriage that produced the author, and the book does not undertake the author's own biographical territory.



The narrative pedigree, on the eleventh of July 1969 at Preußisch Oldendorf, has done what a narrative pedigree can do.

Chapter 15

Seventy-Three Corridors

Seventy-three distinct migration corridors survive in the documented record of the Westphalian emigration. A corridor is a documented chain of three or more emigrants from a single sending parish to a single receiving destination. The material is drawn from the *Kovermann Family Atlas* of May 2026.



The sending regions

The Westphalian-Lower Saxon sending regions of the great nineteenth-century emigration are, on the documented record of this descent, three: the Catholic prince-bishopric and post-Reichsdeputationshauptschluß *Kingdom-of-Hanover / Province of Hanover* territory of *Osnabrück* — the heartland of the focal descendant's paternal pedigree, and the largest single sending region of the dataset — the Lutheran Prussian *Kreis Minden-Lübbecke* north of the Wiehengebirge ridge — the heartland of the maternal pedigree, with its specific sub-corridor running from the *Stemwede* district at the northern edge of the ridge — and the smaller Münsterland Catholic *Tecklenburg* region — the Mettingen-Recke-Hopsten-Ibbenbüren villages of the Tüötten linen-peddler economy that Chapter 13 set out, whose families migrated principally into the Netherlands rather than across the Atlantic. The three sending regions overlap geographically but operated, in the practical economy of the household-by-household emigration of the period, as three separate streams. Each ran through a different German departure port (Bremen and Bremerhaven for the Osnabrück and Minden streams; Bremen and Amsterdam for the Mettingen stream), into a different North American port of entry (Baltimore for the Catholic Osnabrücker stream of the eighteen-thirties through eighteen-fifties; New York for most everything after eighteen-seventy; Amsterdam and the Frisian ports for the Mettingen-to-

Netherlands stream that never crossed the Atlantic), and on into a different American or Dutch settlement pattern.

The crossing itself, on the documented Recker-Redeker-Kovermann-Helmkamp record, was almost always made through the *Norddeutscher Lloyd* and *Hamburg-Amerika* steamship networks of Bremen and Hamburg, with the older sail-emigrant cohort of the eighteen-thirties to early eighteen-fifties — to which Chapter 5’s *Pennsylvania* of 1838 belonged — having been progressively replaced, after the eighteen-fifties, by the steamships of the post-Civil-War American emigration boom. The Bremen-to-Baltimore route that carried the *Pennsylvania* across in eight weeks in 1838 was, by 1880, a Bremen-to-New-York Norddeutscher Lloyd steamship route taking nine days.

The seventy-three corridors

The Atlas counts seventy-three distinct migration corridors in the dataset — a corridor being defined as a documented chain of three or more emigrants from a single Westphalian sending parish or affinal cluster to a single American or overseas receiving parish or county. The corridors fall into four categories by volume.

Primary corridors — those with one hundred or more documented deaths at the receiving destination — are seven in number, and they are the structural arteries of the diaspora.

Table 1 — *Migration corridors: primary and secondary destinations*

Cent ury	Mean, all	Mean, ≥5y	Median	n
1500 s	64.3 years	64.3 years	65 years	89
1600 s	55.7 years	58.4 years	61 years	925
1700 s	50.1 years	55.9 years	60 years	4,211

1800 s	54.6 years	61.5 years	67 years	9,446
1900 s	65.0 years	67.7 years	72 years	10,278

The Cincinnati corridor is the largest by total deaths but the Stemwede-to-Brenham-Texas corridor is the one that the chapter must pause over. *Brenham, Washington County, Texas* — a small farming town a hundred and ten kilometres west of Houston, founded in 1844 — became, between roughly 1850 and 1900, the receiving end of an unexpectedly large Stemwede-Mindener-Lutheran-rural emigrant chain whose specific history the focal descendant’s research has been able to reconstruct in partial form. The dominant Texas family names of the dataset — Gaskamp, Holle, Winkelmann, Spreen, Kettler, Schomburg, Melcher, Tiemann — are all traceable, by the parish books and the *Auswanderer*-list research of the late twentieth century, to the *Stemwede-Dielingen-Oppenwehe-Haldem* cluster of Lutheran farmsteads on the eastern flank of the Wiehengebirge. The chain emigration was sustained: the Hunteburg-to-McLennan-County-Texas chain ran to eleven documented households; the Dielingen-to-McLennan-Texas chain ran to fifteen. By the late twentieth century the Texas Stemwede-descended cluster had grown to include more than four hundred and thirty-five recorded burials.

The Catholic-Osnabrücker Ohio corridor of Chapters 5 and 6 — *Glandorf and the wider Putnam County cluster* — is, on the chain-migration count of the Atlas, the strongest single chain in the entire one-hundred-and-thirty-thousand-record database: **thirty separate documented Hitzhausen-to-Putnam-County emigrations** between 1834 and 1880, of which the Redeker household of 1838 (Chapter 5) was the founding instance. Putnam County itself does not appear as a single corridor in the table above because its emigration

distributed across half a dozen distinct receiving parishes (Glandorf, Fort Jennings, Ottoville, Kalida, Delphos, Maria Stein) which are counted separately in the Atlas. Aggregated, however, the Putnam-County-Catholic-Ohio cluster is the single largest American Catholic-Westphalian rural settlement in the dataset.

Secondary corridors — fifty to a hundred deaths at destination — include a previously hidden *St. Louis, Missouri* corridor (three hundred and twenty-eight deaths, fifty-one German-born, peak in the nineteen-sixties), a *Covington, Kentucky* corridor (one hundred and ninety-one deaths, with the Boberg family dominant), the *Amsterdam, Netherlands* corridor (one hundred and thirty-three deaths, including thirty German-born, the Stoffels and Moorman and Brenninkmeijer families dominant), and the *Maria Stein, Mercer County, Ohio* convent-and-parish corridor (one hundred and ten deaths). The St. Louis corridor's emergence as a substantial receiving cluster is one of the Atlas's documented findings of the May 2026 research push.

The Cincinnati and St. Louis corridors deserve, between them, one further structural note that the chapter cannot pass over without recording: they are the two American cities in which the *paternal* and *maternal* lines of the focal descendant — the Catholic-Osnabrücker line of Chapters 1-11 and the Lutheran-Mindener line of Chapter 12 — first come into geographical proximity with one another after their four-hundred-year separation by the Wiehengebirge ridge. The focal descendant's research counts, in the Cincinnati area, fifty-four documented Catholic-Osnabrücker emigrants (Franxmann, Wiemann, Moormann, Schawe, Wulforst, von der Landwehr, and the wider Glandorf-Hagen-Schwagstorf cluster) alongside forty-five documented Mindener-Protestant emigrants (Rodenbeck of Levern,

the Kettler family of Dielingen, Tieman of Hille, Striebeck of Wehden, the Priesmeyer households of Oppendorf, and the wider Stemwede-Dielingen-Haldem network). In St. Louis the numbers are smaller — three Osnabrücker emigrants (Glusenkamp, Sudhoff, and the Meyer-zu-Westrup *genannt* Schafstedde household) against eight Mindener emigrants (Winkelmann, Osterwisch, Kohrs, Holle, Wendt, Priesmeyer-Gaus) — but the configuration is the same. The two confessional streams that the Wiehengebirge had divided in Westphalia since the *Augsburger Religionsfrieden* of 1555 did not, on the documented record, intermarry across the Cincinnati-St-Louis Catholic-Protestant urban-parish boundary in any significant number in the nineteenth century. They lived, however, in the same cities. The closing of the four-hundred-year confessional distance that the marriage at Preußisch Oldendorf on the eleventh of July 1969 accomplished within the focal-line had, on the documentary record, been quietly anticipated by the geographical co-location of the two streams in the Cincinnati and St. Louis Catholic-and-Lutheran neighbourhoods of the eighteen-sixties and seventies. The lines were close to one another in America, in geographical fact, eight or nine decades before they were close to one another at home.

Small hidden corridors — five to fifteen German-born deaths at destination — are where the named individuals of this chapter and Chapter 16 begin to appear. Five of these small corridors deserve specific notice on the chain-migration record.

Seymour, Jackson County, Indiana — fifteen documented German-born deaths between 1857 and 1986 — is the corridor whose receiving cluster produced, in its fifth generation, the rock musician *John Cougar Mellencamp* (b. 7 October 1951 Seymour), whose family of *Möhlenkamp / Mellencamp* surname descends from two

independent emigrant lines out of the Osnabrück villages of *Engter* and *Venne*. The two emigrant founders, *Gerhard Friedrich Möhlenkamp* (b. 1847 Engter, son of Hermann Heinrich Möhlenkamp b. 1820 Engter) and *Johann Gerhard Heinrich Möhlenkamp* (b. 1828 Venne, whose son *John Christian Mellencamp* was born in Jackson County in 1855), built — together with the Quade, Vornholt, Boknecht, and Hercamp families that arrived alongside them — the same kind of intra-cousin marrying community that the Glandorf Catholic emigrants had built two hundred kilometres east, but in a Lutheran-and-Reformed Indiana farming setting rather than a Catholic Ohio one. By the early twentieth century, six documented marriages within the Mellencamp-Quade-Vornholt-Boknecht network are recorded in the Jackson County registry. The structure replicated itself on another continent. Chapter 16 will return to the Mellencamp biography itself.

Manhattan, New York City — four-plus documented German-born deaths between 1870 and 1920, dominated by the *Sierp* family from *Uphausen* in the Osnabrücker district — is one of the rare urban-corridor anomalies in the dataset. Most Westphalian emigrants of the period went to rural Catholic-Osnabrücker farming settlements in the American Midwest. The *Sierp* family did not. They settled at Manhattan, their children were born in New York City, they married American partners (not Westphalian-cousin partners), and they did not feed into the Ohio-Catholic farming network. The Atlas notes their downstream dispersal: from Manhattan into *Hunterdon County, New Jersey*, and from Hunterdon County onward, in the second and third generations, into *Oregon*. The *Sierp* pattern is the urban-outlier pattern of the descent.

Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania — five-plus documented German-born deaths between 1870 and 1930, dominated

by the *Werries* family — is the other urban anomaly, the *Pittsburgh* corridor — urban Catholic Germans rather than rural ones, a secondary industrial cluster that the Recker-Glandorf corridors did not produce. Pittsburgh is where the descent ran out of farmland.

Buffalo, New York — eleven documented German-born deaths between 1853 and 1944 — and *Louisville, Kentucky* — seven documented German-born deaths between 1854 and 1919 — are the remaining small American corridors of note. The Buffalo cluster is dominated by the *Wallenhorst* family (which also appears in the Glandorf-Putnam-County Ohio cluster); the Louisville cluster includes one documented *Koverman* household. The two corridors are the Great Lakes and Ohio River entry points respectively, and represent the early-to-mid-nineteenth-century alternative routings before the central Ohio-corridor pattern consolidated.

Outlier corridors — corridors to destinations outside North America — close the geographical picture and require a section of their own.

Outside North America: Australia, Brazil, Argentina

The dataset contains documented emigrant chains to four countries outside North America and the Netherlands. The Atlas counts: Brazil seven deaths, Canada seven, Australia three, Argentina two, and a handful of single-individual emigrations to England, Switzerland, Denmark, and Sweden.

The Australian record is the most consequential. Two independent emigrant founders produced, by the early twenty-first century, an Australian-resident descendant cluster of more than two hundred and eighty documented individuals across two states.

The *Haunert* line of South Australia descends from *Gerhard Heinrich Haunert*, born on a date in 1808 at

Kloster Oesede in the Osnabrücker district, who emigrated to South Australia around 1855 and settled at the small farming community of *Bumburnie* in the *Mid North* region of the colony. He died at Bumburnie in 1886. His descendants — by the second decade of the twenty-first century — form the larger part of the documented Australian cluster, distributed across the South Australian farming districts.

The *Thiemeyer* line of Victoria descends from *Heinrich Eberhard Thiemeyer*, born on the fourth of August 1825 at *Aurich* in East Friesland (the easternmost edge of the Osnabrück-Lower Saxony affinal radius), baptised at St. Lamberti Church Aurich on the twenty-first of August 1825, who emigrated to Victoria on the British emigrant ship *Sophia*, arriving at Melbourne in August 1854. He worked as a cabinetmaker. He married, in Victoria, the Irish-emigrant *Mary Dinan* (b. 15 August 1836 Feakle, County Clare, Ireland — a German-Irish marriage in colonial Victoria of the period was already a documentable cross-confessional event). He died at Ballarat on the tenth of February 1879, age fifty-three. His Australian descendants extend across four generations in Victoria, forming the smaller of the two documented Australian branches.

The two Australian lines did not, on the documented record, know each other. They arrived on the same continent within a year of each other (Haunert 1855, Thiemeyer 1854), came from sending-villages eighty kilometres apart in the Osnabrücker affinal radius, and produced, by the present day, two parallel and mutually unknown Australian descendant clusters of comparable size.

The Brazilian record is the *Joinville-Jaguari* corridor in *Santa Catarina* and *Rio Grande do Sul*: seven documented emigrant deaths, including the

Ageuthemeyer and *Koffermann* family lines, dispersed across the southern Brazilian German-Catholic colonial settlements of the late nineteenth century. The Argentine record is two documented emigrants of the *Krösche* family at *Eldorado, Misiones*, in the northern Argentine German colonisation belt of the early twentieth century. The Canadian record is seven emigrants distributed across Ontario.

The *Netherlands* record — two hundred and forty-five documented deaths spread across Leeuwarden, Amsterdam, Bolsward, Sneek, Nijmegen, and the other Frisian and Holland cities — is the largest of the non-American emigration totals, and (as Chapter 13 set out) constitutes the C&A-Brenninkmeijer-Covers commercial-textile-migration network that operated across the Dutch-German border from the seventeenth century onward.

The United States internally

The North American settlement pattern is in turn structured by a second wave of internal migration that the Atlas tracks separately. The descent of the focal-line clusters in three primary American states by the present day, and the structure of the clustering reflects the secondary migration patterns of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.

Table 2 — *American descendants by state: top clusters*

Year	Recorded deaths	Multiple of baseline	Cause
1811	104	×1.85	Napoleonic Continental Blockade + famine
1918	126	×1.46	First World War + Spanish Influenza
1944	154	×1.48	Second World War peak mortality
2020	302	×1.47	COVID-19

The Michigan cluster of more than two thousand documented descendants is the single largest cluster in the dataset outside Westphalia — the *Detroit corridor* that pulled Westphalian-Catholic and Minden-Protestant rural-Ohio descendants into industrial automotive labour in the early-to-mid twentieth century, primarily by way of *Toledo* and the Ohio-Lake-Erie shoreline. The Nebraska cluster is the Recker-Westward continuation of the Iowa-Dyersville settlement that Chapter 7 traced through Ludwig Recker’s 1846 emigration; the *Stearns County, Minnesota* sub-cluster within the larger Iowa-Minnesota corridor (the Atlas counts three hundred and seventy-four documented Iowa-to-Stearns-County transitions) represents the dense secondary clustering of the Recker-cousin network in the post-1880 Minnesota wheatlands. The internal-migration totals run, in summary form:

Table 3 — *Internal migration routes: documented transitions*

Era	Child mortality rate
1600s	8.4% (under-documented)
1700s	18.6% (peak period)
1800–50	20.7% (peak documented)
1850–1900	16.6% (slight improvement)
1900–50	7.9% (modern medicine halves the rate)

The timeline

The Atlas decomposes the descent’s death record by decade and by primary geographical category — Germany (the staying-behind cohort), Ohio (the principal American receiving region), Texas (the Stemwede secondary), the Netherlands (the C&A and Frisian network), and France (the war-fronts and combat-casualty cohort). The arc that emerges is the central historical fact the descent has to account for.

Table 4 — *Deaths by decade and geographical destination, 1840s–2010s*

Century	Maternal deaths per 1,000 births
1600s	12.6
1700s	6.3
1800s	7.9
1900s	1.8

The 1840s — the decade in which the focal-line patriarch *Gerhard Heinrich Redeker* and his household crossed the Atlantic on the *Pennsylvania* — shows the German-side dominance still intact: a thousand and fifty-five German deaths against forty-six in Ohio. By the 1900s the two figures have crossed; Ohio (four hundred and thirty) is approaching the German number (five hundred and thirty-nine). By the 2010s, Ohio (two thousand two hundred and thirteen) outweighs Germany (fifty-seven) by a factor of nearly forty.

The 1910s line includes the fifty-one French-combat-zone deaths of the western-front and Macedonian-front cohorts of the First World War. The 1940s line includes the twelve confirmed Second-World-War combat deaths in France and the further wartime deaths the descent suffered across the eastern fronts and the camps. The total decade death-count had doubled — from one thousand four hundred in the 1840s to two thousand five hundred in the 1940s — under the combination of demographic growth and twentieth-century mortality, before falling toward the 2010s figure of slightly over five thousand, of whom less than one percent died in the original sending country.

Chain-migration patterns

The documented chains by which the corridors ran can be read at the level of individual emigrant pairs. The Atlas records the strongest documented chains:

- **Hitzhausen → Putnam County, Ohio: 30 documented chain emigrations** — the strongest

single migration chain in the database, and the chain that carried the focal-line patriarch and most of the Recker-Redeker household to Glandorf between 1838 and the eighteen-eighties.

- **Körgers Kotten → Dubuque, Iowa: 12 chain emigrations** — the Recker-Westward extension into Iowa, with Dubuque as the Mississippi River landing point.
- **Belm → Auglaize County, Ohio: multiple** — the Kovermann-specific Catholic-Osnabrücker chain into the Auglaize-Mercer-Ohio Catholic district.
- **Dielingen → McLennan County, Texas: 15** — the Stemmweide-to-Central-Texas Lutheran chain that produced the Brenham and McGregor clusters.
- **Hunteburg → McLennan County, Texas: 11** — the parallel Osnabrücker-Catholic-to-Texas chain.
- **Mettingen → Leeuwarden / Sneek, Friesland: 54** — the Tüötten-Brenninkmeijer-Covers-Moormann commercial-textile chain that Chapter 13 set out.

The chains are the structural mechanism by which the corridors operated. They are also the documentary architecture by which the descent's research has been able to reconstruct, in retrospect and from parish-book and ship-manifest evidence, the household-by-household pattern of the emigration. A chain of thirty documented Hitzhausen-to-Putnam-County emigrations was not — could not have been — random. It was a documented practice: the early emigrants' letters home, the chain-network of household-by-household letter-and-money sending, the brokered passages, and the institutional support of the Catholic-Westphalian parishes and the Catholic-American settlement Bishops and missionary priests, sustained the corridor across decades.



One chain followed

The strongest single migration chain in the documented dataset — Hitzhausen to Putnam County, Ohio, thirty documented emigrations between 1838 and the

eighteen-eighties — deserves to be followed at the level at which it was actually lived, rather than only counted. Hitzhausen is a *Bauerschaft* of the parish of Ostercappeln, south of the Wiehengebirge. In 1838, when Johann Heinrich Recker *genannt* Redeker departed from it with his household on the road to Bremen, it contained perhaps two hundred souls in perhaps thirty farmsteads. The farmsteads that the parish register names in connection with the Recker-Redeker household are the ones Chapter 3 set out as the structural units of the Catholic Westphalian village — the *Vollhöfe*, the *Erbkotten*, the *Heuerlinge* without land of their own. The Redeker farm, which Johann Heinrich's father had married into and taken the name of in the *genannt* convention, was one of the village's established holdings. Johann Heinrich sold what could be sold, settled what could be settled, and arranged with the Norddeutscher Lloyd's Bremen-area agent for twelve passages across the Atlantic.

The *Pennsylvania* carried them from Bremen to Baltimore in twelve weeks in the spring of 1838. They arrived in Baltimore as the city's German quarter was already filling with the earlier wave of the Napoleonic-era emigration; they did not stay. The overland route from Baltimore to the Ohio settlements — eight hundred kilometres of turnpike and wagon track through Pennsylvania and across the Allegheny ridges — took the household perhaps six weeks more. They reached Putnam County in the early summer of 1838 and settled in the township of *Glandorf*, which already held, by that year, the first cohort of the Ostercappeln-and-Oesede emigrants who had arrived in the early eighteen-thirties as the advance of the corridor.

Within three years, the first letter had gone back. The historical-genealogical record does not preserve the letter itself — it preserves its consequence. In 1841,

three further Hitzhausen households arrived in Glandorf. In 1843, two more. By 1850 the American census of Putnam County recorded seventeen Hitzhausen-born individuals in the Glandorf township, with the Recker-Redeker household now into its second American-born generation. By 1880 the chain had carried thirty documented individuals from a single Westphalian *Bauerschaft* to a single Ohio township.

The social mechanism behind the number is legible in the parish records on both ends. In the Ostercappeln register, departing households are noted by the priest — sometimes with a simple notation of the destination (*nach Amerika*), sometimes with the ship name, sometimes with nothing at all. In the Glandorf, Ohio parish register, arriving households are entered as members of the new community: baptisms, marriages, burials. The corridor is visible in the gap between the two registers — the Ostercappeln entries stop and the Glandorf entries begin, and the surnames are the same.

The chain worked because it provided, at each stage, what the emigration required but could not produce alone. It provided *information*: the early arrivals wrote home with land prices, parish-priest names, the going rate for farm labour, which township was Catholic and which was not. It provided *credit*: a brother-in-law already established in Ohio could guarantee the passage agent's fee for a relative still in Westphalia. It provided *labour exchange*: a newly arrived family could board with an established one, work their harvest, and earn enough to put down on their own land before the first Ohio winter. What looked, from the Bremen departure pier, like a leap into the unknown was, from inside the corridor, a managed transfer between two communities of the same parish culture, the same language, the same liturgical calendar, connected by thirty years of letters and remittances.

The Hitzhausen-to-Putnam corridor was the strongest in the dataset. It was not different in kind from the other seventy-two. Each of the Atlas's documented chains operated by the same logic at a smaller scale: the Körgers-Kotten-to-Dubuque chain of twelve, the Dielingen-to-McLennan-County chain of fifteen, the Hunteburg-to-Texas chain of eleven. Together they produced the pattern that this chapter's maps display: not a random scatter of individual emigrants across the American continent, but a structured clustering of the same Westphalian households in the same American counties, generation after generation, because the chain had told them where to go before they left.

What the corridors carried

Whom the corridors carried — what kinds of people, in what numbers, with what subsequent lives — is the matter that the remaining chapters of Part 4 will pursue. The dataset records, in addition to the seventy-three migration corridors, two further structural patterns of the descent that the present chapter must note for completeness.

The *birth-order distribution of emigrants* is, on the documented record, bimodal rather than skewed-younger as the traditional “younger sons emigrate because of inheritance law” hypothesis would predict. Of the documented first-generation emigrants in the dataset whose birth-order is recoverable, **31.5 percent were firstborns and 31.1 percent were lastborns** — a roughly equal distribution that suggests the corridors operated through chain-network mechanisms and individual economic circumstances rather than through the *Anerbenrecht-Heuerling* primogeniture-versus-tenancy structural pressure that Chapter 4 set out. The eldest sons who inherited the *Erbhof* sometimes emigrated; the youngest sons sometimes stayed. The chain-network of the *brother-in-law-already-on-the-Iowa-prairie* type — the Ludwig-Recker-followed-Herman-

Henry-Berheide pattern of Chapter 7 — was, on the bimodal evidence, more powerful than the inheritance-law structural pressure that classical emigration-historiography of the mid-twentieth century proposed.

The *longevity distribution* of the descent, by contrast, is concentrated. Two documented relatives in the dataset achieved confirmed longevity of **one hundred and fourteen years**: a *Lieselotte Rustmeier* of the Mindener-Protestant M-line, and a *Langemeyer* of the same Mindener-Protestant network. At least fifteen further relatives in the dataset exceeded a hundred years. The longevity concentration runs heaviest in the Rustmeier branch (the maternal Mindener-Protestant farm-economy line, Chapter 12) and in the Putnam-County-Ohio-German Catholic core area. Whether the longevity signal reflects rural lifestyle, low genetic disease burden, the documentary completeness of the Stemwede-Lübbecke and the Putnam-County parish books, or some interaction of the three, the Atlas leaves open. What is documentary is the figure: two centenarians-plus-fourteen in a dataset of one hundred and thirty thousand individuals is, in comparative-genealogical terms, an unusual concentration.



The geography of the living American diaspora — cousins born from 1926 onward with no recorded death date — reproduces, in county-by-county resolution, the confessional sorting that the emigration maps show at the corridor level. Ohio is overwhelmingly a paternal-line state. Allen County (green P=891) and Putnam County (green P=789) are the twin anchors of the Catholic Osnabrück settlement, still the dominant genealogical centre of the American descent 180 years after the first arrivals. The maternal line (blue M) appears in Ohio only as a sparse scatter, mainly in the Indiana border counties

where the two confessional streams came geographically closest without merging.

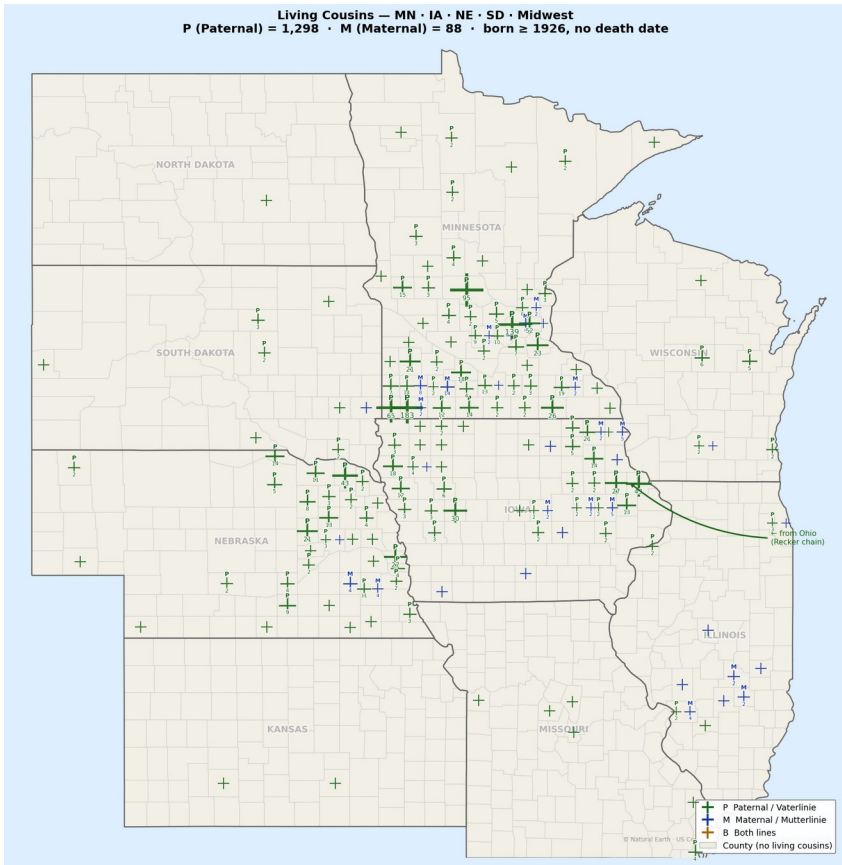
P (Paternal) = 2,116 · M (Maternal) = 148 · born ≥ 1926, no death date

2



Map 4 — *Living cousins in Ohio, Indiana, Michigan, and Kentucky by birth county (born 1926 or later, no death date recorded)*. Green crosses = paternal line (P); blue crosses = maternal line (M). Number shown = count of living cousins. Allen County OH (P=891) and Putnam County OH (P=789) are the historical core. Source: GEDCOM May 2026.

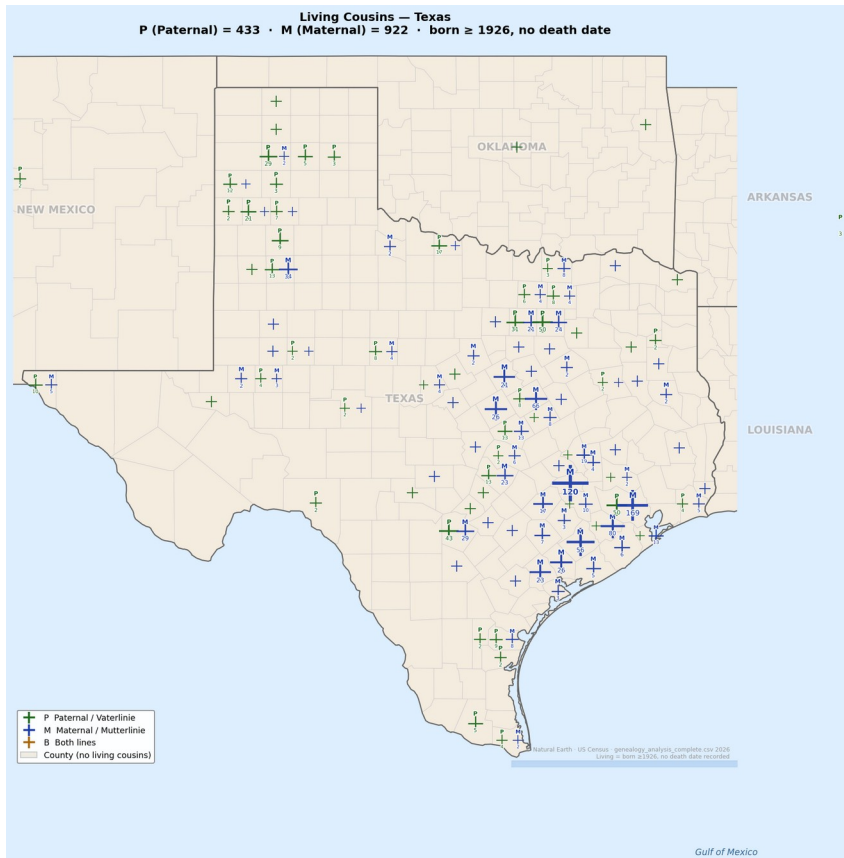
The Iowa-to-Minnesota-Nebraska corridor of the paternal line traces the second generation of westward movement from the Ohio base. The Recker family's 1846 arrival in Dubuque via the Mississippi River entry point initiated a chain that populated Nobles County, Minnesota (P=225), Hennepin County (P=207), and Stearns County (P=126). The arc runs northwest from Dubuque in a pattern that the residence data identifies as driven by land availability: as Putnam County Ohio filled up in the 1870s and 1880s, the overflow moved to the prairie frontier. The maternal line is nearly absent from this cluster: the Protestant Texas settlement had its own westward expansion, into the Texas Hill Country and later the Gulf Coast cities, not into the Upper Midwest.



Map 4a — *Living cousins in Minnesota, Iowa, Nebraska, and South Dakota (born 1926 or later). The Recker-Westward expansion from Dubuque Iowa (1846) runs northwest through Nobles County MN (P=225), Hennepin County MN (P=207), and Stearns County MN (P=126). Almost entirely paternal line. Source: Kovermann Family Atlas, May 2026.*

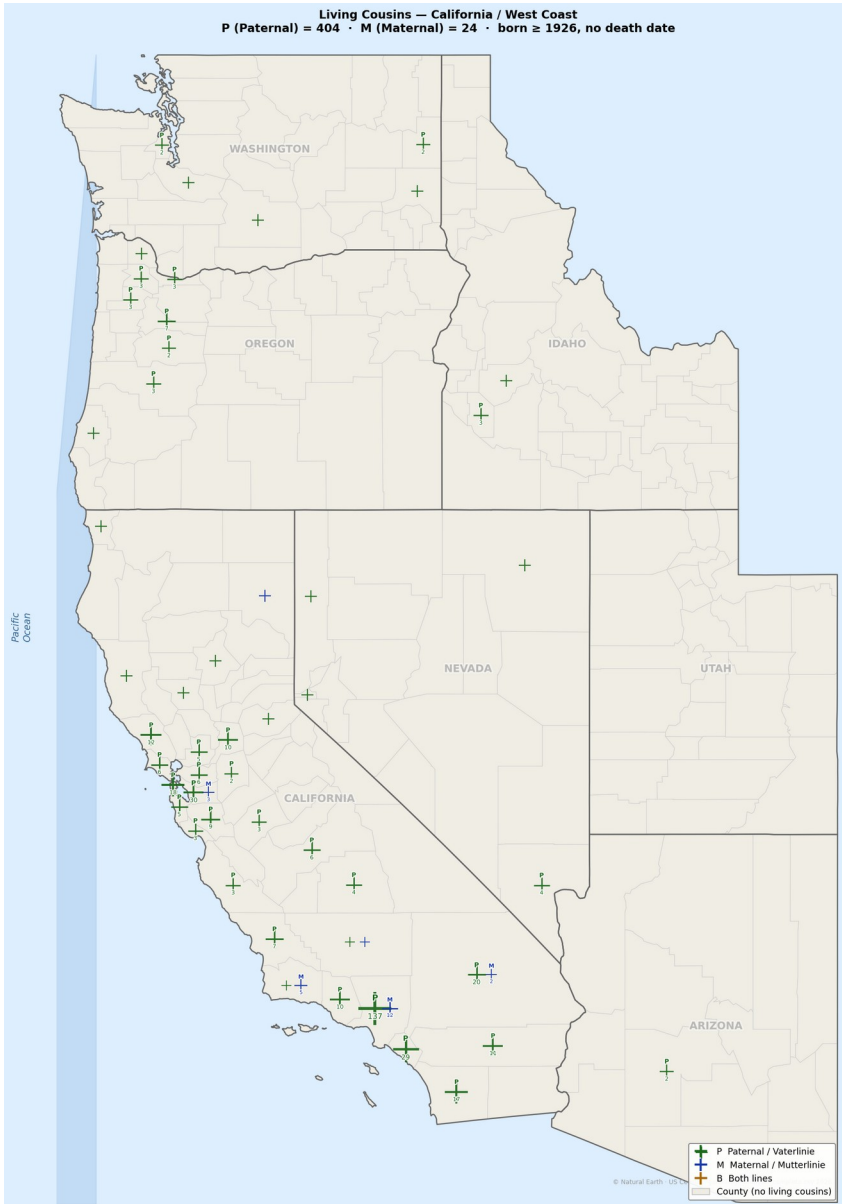
Texas is the maternal line's America. Harris County (Houston, M=1,010) dominates because it is where the nineteenth-century rural Stemwede settlement urbanised in the twentieth century — the same families who homesteaded Washington County and Austin County in the 1840s moved to Houston across three generations. Washington County/Brenham (M=148) and McLennan County/Waco (M=115) are the historical anchor points where “New Wehdem, Austin County” — the daughter

settlement named directly after Wehdem in Westphalia — was founded. Twenty-three surnames documented in Wehdem, Germany also appear in the Texas records: the migration chain did not merely follow a confessional route, it carried the same families, bearing the same names, to a location they themselves named after the village they had left.



Map 4b — *Living cousins in Texas (born 1926 or later).* Overwhelmingly maternal line (M, blue), confirming the Protestant Stemwede to Texas corridor. Harris County/Houston (M=1,010); Washington County/Brenham (M=148, the New Wehdem corridor); McLennan County/Waco (M=115, the Dielingen chain). Source: Kovermann Family Atlas, May 2026.

The West Coast cluster has no structured chain migration behind it. Los Angeles County (P=371) dominates, but the distribution across California, Oregon, and Washington is diffuse — the signature of the unstructured twentieth-century westward dispersal that the residence data identifies as the second-generation consequence of the Ohio settlement. Iowa Recker descendants who moved to Kansas in the 1880s, to Oregon in the 1920s, and to California by the 1950s trace an arc that the document “64. Residence Data” captures in the individual migration paths of Mary Catharine Recker and Andrew Frank Recker. The maternal line is nearly absent from the West Coast: M=24 against P=371. Texas was the western terminus of the Protestant chain, and it remained so.



Map 4c — *Living cousins on the West Coast (born 1926 or later)*. Predominantly paternal line (P, green). Los Angeles County (P=371) dominates. Unstructured 20th-century westward dispersal — no chain migration.

Source: Kovermann Family Atlas, May 2026.

The geographical and statistical pedigree the chapter has set out is the architecture from which the

biographical material of Chapter 16 emerges. The seventy-three corridors carried, across two centuries, household-by-household emigrant chains of perhaps fifteen to twenty thousand documentable individuals out of the Westphalian sending regions and into the Catholic-Westphalian-American farming districts, the Texas Lutheran prairies, the Stemwede-to-Friesland C&A network, the urban anomalies of Manhattan and Pittsburgh, the two Australian colonies, and the Brazilian and Argentine colonisation belts. The chapter that follows takes up five of the individual lives the corridors produced. The chapter after that takes up the *living* American descendant network of the early twenty-first century — the focal descendant's American genealogical interlocutors, the Wisconsin-Recker line, and the present-tense continuation of the descent.

The narrative pedigree of Chapters 1 through 14 was the story of one focal-line. The Atlas of Chapter 15 is the geography in which the focal-line operated. The biographies of Chapter 16 are the lives that the geography produced.

Chapter 16

Six American Lives

Six lives. What the seventy-three corridors carried at the individual scale.



Ida Ranous Kay Brockway-Koverman (1876-1954)

The first life is not a blood relative. Ida Ranous Kay Brockway, born on the fifteenth of May 1876 at Cincinnati, Hamilton County, Ohio, entered the Kovermann network by marriage on the seventh of November 1910, at Indianapolis, when she married *Oscar Henry Koverman* — son of Henry N. Koverman of the Pittsburgh-Cincinnati Catholic-German line that Chapter 15 set out as the Westphalian-emigrant family of the Hamilton-County and Pittsburgh urban anomalies. She therefore enters the family record as a *married-in aunt* of the wider Koverman network, not as a direct cousin of the focal descendant. She comes first nonetheless: the earliest-born of the six, and her career was, in its mature phase, the most public of all six. Her parents were *Henry Brockway*, born on the seventh of September 1840 at Poughkeepsie, New York, who died on the twenty-ninth of October 1899 at Newport, Kentucky, and *Laura Harrison Brown*, born on the twenty-ninth of October 1841 at Newport, Kentucky. Ida grew up in Cincinnati. She worked as a teenager in a Cincinnati jewellery store. After business school she became a stenographer and joined the U.S. Customs office at Cincinnati. She married Oscar Koverman in 1910 and they divorced in 1923. The marriage produced no children that the family record preserves. Oscar Koverman died, the Atlas record observes briefly, “tragically” in 1934, having remarried. Ida by that point had been resident in California for more than a decade and had begun, in her late forties and early fifties, the second and far more consequential career for which she

is principally remembered in American political and entertainment-industry history.

In 1915 she was registered as the cashier of the *Gold Fields American Development Corporation* — a New York holding company, not to be confused with Herbert Hoover's better-known Consolidated Gold Fields of South Africa — and by 1920 she had relocated to San Francisco, where she worked as the secretary of an import-and-export firm at 929 Sacramento Street and registered for the first time as a *Republican* voter of the California electoral rolls. From 1924 through 1928 she served as Executive Secretary of the *Los Angeles County Central Committee of the Republican Party*. Working in this capacity with the engineer-entrepreneur Ralph Arnold, she became one of the principal organisers of what would become the 1928 Republican presidential campaign of *Herbert Hoover* — and, by the late summer of 1928, one of the few women in American political organising history who could plausibly be said to have helped win a presidential election in the year before women's suffrage was a generation old.

In 1929, the year after the Hoover campaign concluded, *Louis B. Mayer* — vice-president of *Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer*, the largest of the Hollywood film studios of the period, and the principal Republican political donor of the Hollywood industry — hired Ida Koverman as his Executive Secretary at MGM. The contemporary press reported the appointment with the explanatory note that she had been hired “to keep Mr. Mayer advised politically.” The position became, over the twenty-two years that Ida Koverman held it from 1929 to her retirement in 1951, considerably larger than the title suggested. She functioned, in the parallel testimony of the Hollywood-columnist literature of the period and of the MGM internal-records-research of the later decades, as Mayer's principal talent-spotter, political adviser,

public-relations strategist, and de facto second-in-command. The Hollywood columnist *Jimmie Fidler* wrote of her in 1938: *she happens to be one of the most powerful personages in the entire motion-picture industry*. The MGM executive Robert Vogel, in a later interview that has been the subject of subsequent biographical inquiry: *she damn near ran the studio*.

The roster of stars whose careers she discovered, developed, or substantively mentored is a roster of Hollywood: *Robert Taylor, Nelson Eddy, Robert Montgomery, Clark Gable, Leatrice Joy, Jean Parker, Jeanette MacDonald, Elizabeth Taylor, and Judy Garland*. She is credited with suggesting to Louis B. Mayer that MGM operate a school for young contract players; the school the studio subsequently established produced *Judy Garland, Lana Turner, Jackie Cooper, Mickey Rooney, Peter Lawford, and Donna Reed*, among others. She maintained her Republican political role across the entire MGM period: she co-founded, in 1947, the *Hollywood Republican Committee* with the actors *Robert Montgomery and George Murphy*; she campaigned in 1948 for *Thomas E. Dewey's* presidential bid and in 1950 for *Richard Nixon's* first Senate run. Around 1950 *Howard Hughes* offered her one thousand dollars a week — a significant sum at the contemporary value — to leave MGM and join RKO. She declined. In 1951 the new MGM president *Nicholas Schenck* promoted her to head of Public Relations for the entire studio, a position she held until her death.

She died on the twenty-fourth of November 1954 at West Hollywood, at the age of seventy-eight. Her obituary appeared in the *Louisville Courier-Journal* of the twenty-fifth of November 1954, locating her by her Kentucky birth-family origins rather than by her California career. Her life has subsequently received both popular-cultural and scholarly biographical treatment: she has been

depicted in three Hollywood productions (*Rainbow*, 1978, by Rue McClanahan; *Malice in Wonderland*, 1985, by Bonnie Bartlett; and *Life with Judy Garland: Me and My Shadows*, 2001, by Rosemary Dunsmore); she is a named character in Adriana Trigiani's novel *All the Stars in the Heavens*; and she is the subject of a full-length scholarly biography, *She Damn Near Ran the Studio: The Extraordinary Lives of Ida R. Koverman*, by Jacqueline R. Braitman, published by the University Press of Mississippi in 2020.

The figure with whom this chapter begins, then, is a married-in member of the Kovermann network who became, between 1924 and 1954, one of the most consequential American women of the early twentieth century in both political organising and entertainment-industry administration, while retaining the surname that the Hamilton-County Catholic-Westphalian-emigrant Pittsburgh-Cincinnati corridor of Chapter 15 had carried into the family network three generations before her marriage.



Walter Louis Woycke *genannt* Rodgers (1886-1951)

The second life of the chapter — *Walter Louis Woycke genannt Rodgers*, born on the thirty-first of August 1886 at Cincinnati, son of *Louis Woycke* (b. 22 December 1860 Cincinnati) and *Elizabeth Reising* — connects to the focal descendant at the approximate fifth-degree-cousinship distance through the *Woycke-Kovermann* affinal network of the Cincinnati Catholic-Westphalian-emigrant cluster. He grew up in Cincinnati. He began his stage career as an actor in the Cincinnati theatres of the early nineteen-tens, with a 1913 city-directory listing at *114 East Clifton Avenue*. He married *Amanda Dorothea Sautters* in January 1914 — a marriage that lasted the remaining thirty-seven years of his life. Sometime in the mid-nineteen-tens he

relocated, with Amanda, from Cincinnati to Los Angeles, where he took up the stage name *Walter Rodgers* and entered the silent-film industry of pre-Hollywood and early-Hollywood Los Angeles. He worked, from approximately 1913 through 1938, as a supporting-role and character-role motion-picture actor across some twenty documented films of the silent and early-sound period.

The role for which he became, in the working production-history of the period, the most consistently typecast was *General Ulysses S. Grant*. Walter Rodgers played Grant — or, in one variant, *President Ulysses S. Grant* — in at least six Hollywood films across the silent and early-sound years: *The Dramatic Life of Abraham Lincoln* (1924), *The Flaming Frontier* (1926), *The Heart of Maryland* (1927), *The Little Shepherd of Kingdom Come* (1928), *Silver Dollar* (1932), and *Gold Is Where You Find It* (1938). He also appeared in John Ford's *The Iron Horse* (1924, as General Grenville Dodge, uncredited), in the Edwin Carewe melodrama *Vengeance — and the Woman* (1917), and in *Fighting Fate* (1921). His casting as General Grant was sufficiently established that he was, in the production memos of the period, the standing first-call casting choice for any Hollywood Civil-War-set film that required a Grant role.

One of his minor on-screen appearances, however, was in a film that turned out to be of substantially greater historical significance than any of his Grant roles. In *The Jazz Singer* of 1927 — the Warner Bros. production starring *Al Jolson* that is now standardly recognised as the first commercially successful sound-on-film feature in cinema history — Walter Rodgers appears, uncredited, in the role of *Make-Up Man*. He thereby has an on-screen presence in the film that is conventionally regarded as the death-event of the silent era he had spent his career working in. The accidental dimension of the appearance is in keeping with the trajectory of his subsequent career:

by the 1940 federal census he had transitioned from acting to working as a *Make Up Artist* with offices at Carlton Way in Los Angeles, the city of his thirty-five-year residence. He died on the twenty-fourth of April 1951 at Studio City, California, of a stroke, at the age of sixty-four.



Arthur Bernard Nieland (1918-1944)

The third life is the second of the chapter's two Pacific-theatre deaths. *Arthur Bernard Nieland*, born on the twenty-fifth of August 1918 at the small farming community of *Wall Lake* in *Sac County, Iowa*, was the great-great-grandson of one of the Catholic-Westphalian-Iowa emigrant households that had crossed the Mississippi River into the Dyersville-and-Wall-Lake settlement cluster of the eighteen-fifties — the Iowa branch of the larger Recker-Dyersville westward extension that Chapter 7 set out through Ludwig Recker. He was baptised at the *Sac City* parish in 1918. He grew up in the small farming community of *Viola, Sac County*, where the census records of 1920, 1925, 1930, 1935, and 1940 successively register him as resident at the household of his parents. He never married. On the seventh of May 1942 — eight days before his twenty-fourth birthday and five months after the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor — he was inducted into the United States military.

He was sent, as one of approximately two hundred thousand American soldiers deployed across the Pacific theatre in the spring of 1942, to the Philippines. He was captured during the Japanese conquest of the Philippine archipelago in the spring of 1942 — at *Bataan*, or *Corregidor*, or at one of the subsequent surrenders of the Philippine garrison that the family record does not preserve in operational detail. He became one of the approximately twenty-three thousand American prisoners-of-war held by the Imperial Japanese forces

across the Pacific camp network across the next two and a half years.

On the seventh of September 1944, in the late phase of the war, Nieland was loaded — with seven hundred and forty-nine other Allied prisoners-of-war — into the hold of the Japanese transport ship *Shinyo Maru*, sailing from the southern Philippines northward to the Japanese home islands as part of the Japanese forced-relocation programme by which the Pacific-theatre prisoner-of-war population was being moved to the Japanese mainland in the closing months of the war. The transport was the standard *hellship* of the late-war Pacific. The prisoners were held in the unventilated cargo holds, under conditions of acute overcrowding and inadequate water, in transport ships that were unmarked and that the Allied navy submarine fleet was therefore unable to distinguish from ordinary Japanese military shipping.

In the South China Sea on the same seventh of September 1944, the American submarine *USS Paddle* (SS-263), operating under standing orders to attack Japanese shipping, fired torpedoes at the *Shinyo Maru* and sank it. Of the seven hundred and fifty Allied POWs aboard, *six hundred and sixty-eight died*. The chapter must record the manner of their deaths with the documentary precision the post-war war-crimes investigations subsequently established: *most of the six hundred and sixty-eight were not killed by the torpedo strike itself, but by the Japanese guards who, as the ship began to sink and the surviving prisoners attempted to escape by swimming from the wreck, fired on the swimmers from the surviving Japanese vessels and from the lifeboats*. The act was a documented war crime against unarmed Allied prisoners-of-war attempting to save themselves from a sinking vessel. Of the seven hundred and fifty prisoners aboard, eighty-two survived — reaching the shore of the southern Philippines, where

they were rescued by Philippine guerrillas before being evacuated by the American submarine *USS Narwhal* (SS-167). Arthur Bernard Nieland was not among the eighty-two. He died, at the age of twenty-six, either in the torpedo strike, in the open water of the South China Sea, or under the rifles of the Japanese guards.

His body was not recovered. He is memorialised at the *Manila American Cemetery and Memorial* in the National Capital Region of the Philippines, on the *Walls of the Missing* — one of the eighteen thousand American servicemen of the Pacific theatre whose remains the war did not return.

The *Shinyo Maru* incident is, in the comparative history of the Pacific war, the worst single American-prisoner-of-war loss of life of the entire conflict. It is also the largest documented Pacific-theatre war-crime against Allied POWs in transit, and it remains, among the surviving descendant communities of the small Catholic-Iowa-German farming towns that the *Shinyo Maru* dead were drawn from, the most precisely remembered single incident of the Pacific war.



Cecil Keith Huber (1927-1959)

The fourth life is the second of the chapter's three twentieth-century United States military lives, and the second of the chapter's two nuclear-related deaths. *Cecil Keith Huber*, born on the ninth of April 1927 at *Cresco* in *Howard County, Iowa* — eighty kilometres north-east of Arthur Nieland's Wall Lake on the same Iowa farming-belt and on the same Catholic-Westphalian-emigrant Recker-Dyersville-corridor extension that produced Nieland's line — was a member of the same Iowa-German-Catholic farming-community network. He was nine years younger than Nieland. He grew up in Cresco and the surrounding Howard-County farmlands and joined the United States Navy in the

closing years of the Second World War, at the age of seventeen or eighteen, in late 1944 or early 1945. He survived the war. He was nineteen when the war ended. In the spring and summer of 1946, the United States government conducted *Operation Crossroads* — the second test-detonation series of atomic weapons in human history, following the wartime bombings of *Hiroshima* and *Nagasaki* in August 1945. Operation Crossroads consisted of two test-detonations, code-named *Able* (detonated 1 July 1946) and *Baker* (detonated 25 July 1946), conducted at the *Bikini Atoll* in the central Pacific Marshall Islands, on a target fleet of ninety-five obsolete warships that had been positioned around the Bikini lagoon to study the effect of the atomic blast on naval vessels. *Able* was an atmospheric airburst of approximately twenty-three kilotons. *Baker* was an underwater detonation of the same yield. The two detonations sank twenty-four ships and rendered the surrounding lagoon waters and the atoll itself radiologically contaminated to a degree that the post-war scientific and medical literature has subsequently established as substantially greater than the contemporary U.S. Navy briefings had warned the participating crews.

Approximately forty-two thousand American military personnel were deployed to the Operation Crossroads test programme — across the support fleet, the target fleet, the photo-reconnaissance and instrumentation vessels, and the shore-based support operations on the surrounding Marshall Island atolls. Cecil Keith Huber was one of the forty-two thousand. He was nineteen years old in July 1946. He served aboard the destroyer *USS O'Brien* (DD-725), which was assigned to *Task Group 1.7* of the Operation Crossroads support fleet. The *O'Brien* was deployed as a *radiological monitoring* vessel — one of the ships positioned closer to the Bikini lagoon

to measure the radiological dispersion of the two detonations, both of which Huber personally witnessed.

He was discharged from the Navy in the late nineteen-forties and returned to civilian life in the Iowa-Minnesota Catholic-farming Recker-network communities. He settled in *Austin*, Minnesota — eighty kilometres north of Cresco, in the corn-and-meatpacking economy of the *Mower County*. He married. The family record does not preserve his spouse's name or the date of the marriage. He held civilian employment in Austin.

On the nineteenth of October 1959, at the age of thirty-two years and six months, Cecil Keith Huber died at *Hennepin County, Minnesota*, the central Minneapolis-metropolitan county that contained the principal hospitals serving the southern-Minnesota population. He had been deceased thirteen years and three months after his exposure to the radiological environments of the *Able* and *Baker* detonations at Bikini Atoll. The cause of his death is not preserved in the family record; the *Calvary Cemetery* of Austin, Minnesota holds his grave.

The relationship between Huber's death at thirty-two and the radiological exposures of Operation Crossroads is not something the family record asserts as causal, and the chapter does not assert it either. The post-war epidemiological literature on the Operation-Crossroads-participant cohort has, across the subsequent decades, documented elevated rates of leukaemia, lymphoma, and several solid-organ cancers in the participant population, with the elevation reaching statistical significance in some sub-cohorts and not in others. Cecil Huber's individual case is documentary only: the man was at Bikini in July 1946, the man died at Hennepin County in October 1959, the man's family did not survive him in the Austin-Minnesota Catholic farming community in the way that the Iowa-Catholic farming-network

expectations of the period would have predicted for a man of thirty-two. He is the second of the chapter's two nuclear-related deaths — the first having been *Jon Lawrence Johnson*, born 1944 at Sioux City, Iowa, who died on the thirtieth of March 1966 at Sandia Base, New Mexico, of meningitis at the age of twenty-one, while serving with the Sandia-base nuclear-weapons-development programme. The Atlas counts both.



John Cougar Mellencamp (b. 1951)

The fifth life is the second-youngest of the chapter and the most internationally recognisable. *John Cougar Mellencamp*, born on the seventh of October 1951 at *Seymour, Jackson County, Indiana*, is the fifth-generation descendant of the *Möhlenkamp* family of the Osnabrücker village of *Engter* whose nineteenth-century emigration to the southern Indiana Catholic-and-Lutheran farming-community network produced the *Mellencamp-Quade-Vornholt-Boknecht-Hercamp* intermarried cluster that Chapter 15 set out as the Seymour-Indiana fifteen-burial corridor. The corridor produced, in its fifth generation, a rock musician whose career between the late nineteen-seventies and the early twenty-first century placed him among the principal American singer-songwriters of his cohort. The surname *Möhlenkamp* — a Low-German compound of *Mühle* (mill) and *Kamp* (field), giving roughly “*mill field*” — is one of the standard agricultural-toponym surnames of the Westphalian and Osnabrücker peasant economy of the medieval and early-modern period. The Engter-and-Venne households of *Möhlenkamp* emigrated to southern Indiana in two independent lines: the *Gerhard Friedrich Möhlenkamp* household, born 1847 Engter and son of *Hermann Heinrich Möhlenkamp* (b. 1820 Engter), emigrated to Jackson County in the eighteen-sixties or eighteen-seventies; the second *Möhlenkamp* household, headed by *Johann Gerhard Heinrich Möhlenkamp* (b. 1828 Venne), produced the

Jackson-County-born *John Christian Mellencamp* (b. 1855 Jackson County, Indiana). The two lines anglicised the surname to *Mellencamp* in the second American generation. John Cougar Mellencamp descends from the second line.

Mellencamp grew up in Seymour, attended Seymour High School in the late nineteen-sixties, and entered the regional Indiana rock-music scene of the early nineteen-seventies. He recorded his first album in 1976 under the stage name *Johnny Cougar*, settled on the compound stage name *John Cougar Mellencamp* in the early nineteen-eighties, and by the mid-nineteen-eighties was — through the albums *American Fool* (1982), *Uh-Huh* (1983), *Scarecrow* (1985), and *The Lonesome Jubilee* (1987) — one of the most commercially successful American rock musicians of the decade. His best-known songs — *Jack and Diane*, *Hurts So Good*, *Pink Houses*, *Small Town, R.O.C.K. in the U.S.A.*, *Cherry Bomb*, *Paper in Fire* — are characterised, in the wider critical literature, by their attention to the social and economic experience of the small-town rural American Midwest, the world of the southern-Indiana farming communities that the Möhlenkamp-Mellencamp emigration had built across four generations before his.

He co-founded, with *Willie Nelson* and *Neil Young*, the *Farm Aid* concert series in 1985, a fund-raising organisation for American family-farm preservation that has run continuously across the subsequent four decades. He has been inducted into the Rock and Roll Hall of Fame. He is also, as the Atlas records, a working painter of substantial output, whose exhibited canvases — primarily portraiture in the American-realist tradition — have shown at multiple American gallery venues from the early nineteen-nineties onward.

He has been resident, across his adult career, in *Bloomington* and *Nashville, Indiana*, on *Daufuskie Island, South Carolina*, and elsewhere. He is a documented descendant, by the genealogical record, of the wider Jackson-County Möhlenkamp-Vornholt-Quade Catholic-and-Lutheran network — through six recorded intra-network marriages of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries that the focal descendant's research has traced. His cousin distance to Andreas Kovermann is, on the Atlas computation, approximately fifth-degree cousinship through the Möhlenkamp-Engter line and a *Quade* affinal-link maternally — placing him within the standard Westphalian-emigrant kinship-pool distance that the rest of this chapter's figures also occupy.



Sherri Michelle Mercedes Saum (b. 1974)

The sixth and final life of the chapter is the youngest, the contemporary, and the only one for whom the family record continues to update with current information. *Sherri Michelle Mercedes Saum*, born on the first of October 1974 at *Dayton, Montgomery County, Ohio*, is the fifth-cousin-once-removed of the focal descendant by the Ancestry-verified genealogical-network computation, descending from the common ancestor *Johann Heinrich Recker genannt* Redeker** (b. 1766 Hitzhausen, d. 1840 Glandorf, Putnam County, Ohio) — the patriarch through whom the entire Hitzhausen-to-Glandorf emigration of the eighteen-thirties of Chapters 5 and 6 ran. Her branch of the line descends through the *Johannes Andreas Recker* household (b. 1809, d. 1882, the second son of the patriarch, who Chapter 6 set out as the surviving widower of the 1836 nine-day-widowhood) and through the subsequent Recker-and-Saum intermarriages of Putnam County and Mercer County, Ohio across the next four generations. The chapter's focal-line branch and the Saum branch diverge at the second generation, with the focal descendant descending from *Gerhard Heinrich Redeker*

of 1796 (the elder brother who emigrated in 1838) and the Saum line descending from *Johannes Andreas Recker* of 1809 (the younger brother of the same household, who emigrated separately to Glandorf). The two branches reconverge geographically, six generations later, in the Dayton-and-Kettering Ohio of the late twentieth century, in which Sherri Saum grew up.

She attended *Kettering-Fairmont High School* in Kettering, Montgomery County, graduating in 1993. She lived in *Moraine, Ohio* in 1994; in *Dayton* in 2001 and 2003; in *New York* in 2003 and 2014; in *Los Angeles* from 2010 onward. She is principally known, in her career as an American television and film actress, for her role as *Stef Adams Foster* — opposite *Teri Polo* — in the *Freeform* and *Netflix* serial drama *The Fosters*, which ran for five seasons between 2013 and 2018, and in its spinoff *Good Trouble*, which has continued. She has appeared, in addition, in *Sunset Beach*, *Beauty & the Beast*, *Gossip Girl*, *Rescue Me*, *In Treatment*, and a substantial supporting filmography across the twenty-first century to date.

She married *Paul Kamar Calderon De Los Reyes*, born 1967, on a date in the early twenty-first century. The couple's twin sons *John Ruben De Los Reyes* and *Michael Luis De Los Reyes* were born on the thirteenth of May 2014. Paul Calderon De Los Reyes died, on the twenty-fourth of December 2023 at Los Angeles. Sherri Saum was forty-nine years old at the time of her husband's death.

She is the sixth and final figure of this chapter. The family record continues, for her line — alone among the six lives of this chapter — to update with current information. She is the youngest fifth-cousin-once-removed of the focal descendant for whom a substantial public biographical record exists, and she is, in the chapter's accounting, the

closing figure of the American twentieth-century lives the corridors of Chapter 15 produced.



The six lives sit, when arranged across the geography of Chapter 15, on the corridors and in the cities of the eighteen-thirties through eighteen-eighties Westphalian emigration in a configuration that the focal descendant's family record could not have predicted but that the chapter, retrospectively, can name. *Ida Brockway-Koverman* and *Walter Rodgers* are products of the Cincinnati corridor — the eight-hundred-and-nineteen-burial Hamilton-County-Ohio cluster — and both rose, by independent routes, from Cincinnati into the early-twentieth-century Los Angeles entertainment-and-political industry. *Arthur Bernard Nieland* and *Cecil Keith Huber* are products of the Iowa-and-northern-Iowa Catholic-Westphalian farming corridor — the Dyersville-and-Cresco extension of the Recker network — and both died in the United States military service of the mid-twentieth century, one in the Pacific war and one in the post-war nuclear-test-cohort. *John Cougar Mellencamp* is the product of the smaller Indiana Möhlenkamp corridor — the Seymour-Jackson-County fifteen-burial cluster — and became, in his fifth generation, a rock musician whose work has named the small-town American Midwest with consistent attention across forty years. *Sherri Saum* is the product of the same Hitzhausen-to-Putnam-County corridor that the focal-line itself ran out of, descending from the brother of the focal-line patriarch, and is — alone of the six — still alive at the time of the book's composition.

The corridors carried, across two centuries, the unnamed twenty thousand. Six of the named. The corridors carried twenty thousand without names. The

lives are documentary, not exemplary. They are the lives
the geography of Chapter 15 produced.

Chapter 17

The Living Descent

The descent exists. In the early twenty-first century it numbers several thousand documented individuals across four American states, two Australian colonies, and a German remnant. The question is what the emigration produced as a structure — not just where people ended up, but how the dispersal changed the shape of the family.



The four-generation arc

Across the four generations between the *Pennsylvania* of 1838 and the present, the descent has, on the documented record, moved through four distinct structural phases. Four phases define it.

The *first phase* is the phase of *emigration*: the period between approximately 1830 and 1890, during which the seventy-three corridors of Chapter 15 were established by the household-by-household departure of the Westphalian and Lower Saxon peasant-and-Heuerling households of the Osnabrück and Minden-Lübbecke sending regions toward the receiving cities of the American Midwest, the Frisian and Holland coastal towns, and the Australian colonies. The phase's character is rural-departure-and-rural-arrival; its principal documentary artefact is the ship manifest, the parish-of-emigration book, and the parish-of-arrival book; its principal demographic signature is the doubling of total deaths per decade (from one thousand four hundred in the 1840s to two thousand by the 1900s) under combined demographic growth and Atlantic-crossing-driven dispersal.

The *second phase* is the phase of *American consolidation*: the period between approximately 1880 and 1940, during which the receiving clusters of the first

phase — Glandorf and the Putnam County Catholic-Westphalian network, Cincinnati and the Hamilton-County urban-Catholic cluster, Brenham and the Stemwede-Texas Lutheran prairie cluster, Dyersville-Iowa and the Recker-Westward extension — consolidated themselves as the second- and third-generation American descendants intermarried within the network, established the institutional infrastructure of their respective American Catholic and Lutheran parishes, schools, and commercial establishments, and produced — by the third generation, born between roughly 1880 and 1920 — the demographic population that fought in the First and Second World Wars and that the war casualties of the corridors documented at the names of Chapters 13 and 16 belonged to. The phase's character is rural-and-urban-American consolidation; its principal documentary artefact is the census enumeration, the city directory, and the small-town American county newspaper.

The *third phase* is the phase of *urban-industrial diaspora*: the period between approximately 1920 and 1980, during which the third-and-fourth-generation American descendants left the small farming communities of the Catholic-Westphalian receiving clusters and migrated, in a second internal-American emigration, into the Detroit-and-Michigan industrial corridor, the Iowa-to-Minnesota commercial-agricultural extension, the Texas-Houston petroleum-economy expansion, and the California Hollywood-and-defence-industry westward flow that Chapter 16 set out at the individual biographical level in the cases of Ida Brockway-Koverman and Walter Rodgers. The phase's character is the documented departure from the small-town Catholic and Lutheran rural farming communities that the first-generation emigrants had founded, and the second dispersal of their descendants across the United States as the twentieth-

century industrial economy reshaped the country. The phase's principal demographic signature is the state-level redistribution that Chapter 15 set out at numerical level: Michigan two thousand and thirty-four documented descendants by the present day; Nebraska one thousand and thirty-four; Texas three hundred and nine in the 2010s; California, by the end of the third phase, the third- or fourth-largest receiving state of the documented descent.

The *fourth phase* is the phase the chapter is concerned with: the period between approximately 1990 and the present, during which the descent passed into the *digital era* and into the structural reconfiguration of the kinship pool that the digital era has produced.



The digital infrastructure

The four-generation arc of the descent passes, in its final phase, through a documentary and infrastructural transition whose consequences the family record is still in the process of registering. Between approximately 1990 and the early twenty-first century, the three documentary technologies on which all serious nineteenth-and-twentieth-century genealogical research had previously depended — the *parish book*, the *census enumeration*, and the *county newspaper* — became progressively available to the family-historian researcher in digital form. The transition was gradual rather than sudden, but its cumulative effect across two decades was the transformation of what had been, throughout the documentary period the book has set out across its preceding chapters, an effortful and slow and geographically-bound research process — requiring physical visits to parish archives, microfilm-reader sessions at distant libraries, and correspondence-by-letter with archival institutions in the sending and receiving regions of the descent — into an immediate and continuous and trans-geographically-accessible

online infrastructure available to any researcher with an internet connection.

The author's research draws on several overlapping layers of digital infrastructure. The primary parish-book layer is *Matricula Online*, which has progressively published the surviving baptismal, marriage, and burial registers of the Osnabrück and Münster dioceses and the Minden-Ravensberg Protestant churches. The American record layer rests on *FamilySearch* (microfilmed parish books, US Census enumerations, civil registrations, and ship manifests) and the commercial services *Ancestry* and *MyHeritage*, with their integrated DNA-matching networks. The collaborative-genealogy layer includes *WikiTree* and *GEDmatch*. The biographical-memorial layer is *Find a Grave*. Beyond these core platforms, the research has drawn on a constellation of national archival collections: the *Nationaal Archief* of the Netherlands (which supplied the wartime *Japanse Interneringskaarten* records cited for Petrus Ensink and George Schröder), *The National Archives Kew* (the Death Railway records), the *Bistumsarchiv Osnabrück*, the *Landesarchiv Nordrhein-Westfalen*, and the county and state historical-society digital collections of Australia, Iowa, Ohio, and Indiana.

The infrastructure is, for the family-historian researcher of the present, the operating environment within which a serious twenty-first-century pedigree-reconstruction project takes place. What was, between roughly 1830 and 1990, a project that could only be undertaken with substantial physical-archival infrastructure and significant financial-and-temporal resource, is now a project that can be undertaken, with the appropriate language and methodological skills, from any internet-connected residence by an individual researcher acting alone. The transformation is not yet complete; many of the smaller German and Dutch parish archives have not yet been digitised, and the Frisian and Catholic-

Münsterland holdings remain unevenly distributed across the institutional landscape. But the proportion of the documentary base of the descent that is now accessible from a single screen has, across the period the project has been running, increased substantially.



The second emigration

The structural consequence of the digital infrastructure that the chapter must record, however, is not the access of the researcher to the archive. The structural consequence is the access of the descendants to *one another*. Across the two decades that the digital genealogical infrastructure has been operationally available to family-historian researchers, the same descendant population that the first emigration of the eighteen-thirties had dispersed across the continents has, by what the chapter will call the *second emigration*, returned — in a sense the original emigrant generation could not have anticipated — to a single shared communicative space.

The second emigration is not a physical relocation. It is the digital-genealogical reconnection of the descendant kinship pool. The fifth-cousin from Indiana whose Möhlenkamp-emigrant great-great-great-grandfather left Engter in the eighteen-sixties, the sixth-cousin from Brenham, Texas whose Stemwede-emigrant great-great-grandfather left Dielingen in the eighteen-fifties, the fifth-cousin-once-removed from Dayton, Ohio whose Recker-emigrant ancestor reached Putnam County in the eighteen-thirties, and the author himself in Steinhagen, Westphalia — all four are, in the present-day digital-genealogical infrastructure, members of a single online-accessible kinship pool. They have not, in most cases, met physically. They will not, in most cases, ever meet physically. They are connected by the digital architecture of the *Ancestry* DNA-match interface, the *FamilySearch* shared-tree mechanism, the *WikiTree*

collaborative profile-page, the blog-comment thread of the family-historian researcher's published research findings.

The pattern is structural rather than individual. Across the focal descendant's research project, the digital-genealogical infrastructure has produced, on the documented record, a substantial body of trans-Atlantic and trans-continental contacts with fifth-through-twelfth-degree cousins of the descent who would not, under any plausible pre-digital research environment, have come into communicative contact with one another. The contacts have produced, in the author's case, the cross-Atlantic genealogical-research collaboration that has been a principal methodological mode of the project; in the cases of other family-historian researchers operating within the same descent, comparable patterns of trans-continental cousin-collaboration have produced comparable bodies of merged genealogical material. The descent that the eighteen-thirties emigration had dispersed across three continents has, by the digital genealogical infrastructure of the early twenty-first century, returned to a state of communicative co-residence that the dispersal had previously precluded.

The structural pattern is noted. The individuals are not named. The participants in the second emigration are, almost without exception, living persons, and the editorial commitments of the book preserve the privacy of the contemporary participants in the genealogical-research community of which the book is itself an artefact.



What the descent looks like now

The geographical configuration of the descent in the present, by the documented record of the May 2026 Atlas, places the dispersed kinship pool of one hundred

and thirty thousand documented individuals across the following structural distribution.

Approximately *forty-two percent* of the documented descent are buried, or are presently living, in the *American Midwest* — the Ohio-Indiana-Iowa-Michigan-Nebraska-Minnesota-Wisconsin Catholic-and-Lutheran rural-and-urban network that the seventy-three corridors of Chapter 15 produced. Within the Midwest, *Ohio* contains approximately twenty-two percent of the entire documented descent's recorded burials of the past three decades — the single largest concentration of the dataset in any one state or country.

Approximately *fourteen percent* are concentrated in the remaining United States — the Texas, California, New York-and-New-Jersey, Pacific-Northwest, and Florida secondary clusters that the urban-industrial and California-westward dispersals of the third phase produced.

Approximately *twenty-eight percent* remain in *Germany* — the descending share, across the four-generation arc, of the original sending-region population that did not emigrate, plus the smaller back-migrant cohort and the present-day descendants of the staying-behind families of the eighteen-hundreds. The geographical concentration within Germany is heaviest in the original Osnabrück-and-Minden-Lübbecke sending region, with secondary concentrations across the wider Westphalian and Lower Saxon regions and a smaller post-war diaspora distribution across the Rhine-Ruhr industrial cities and across the broader German federal republic.

Approximately *nine percent* are concentrated in the *Netherlands* — the Frisian-and-Noord-Holland network that Chapter 13 set out at the Brenninkmeijer-Stockmann-Voss-Meijknecht commercial-textile level, plus the smaller post-war Dutch concentrations.

The remaining *seven percent* are distributed across Australia (two principal lines plus their descendants), Brazil, Argentina, Canada, the United Kingdom, France, Switzerland, Denmark, Sweden, Belgium, Italy, and the smaller documented diasporic destinations of the four-generation arc.

The arc that Chapter 15 set out at the decadal level — Germany 1,055 deaths in the 1840s versus 57 in the 2010s — represents, at the present geographical level, the *single most consequential structural fact of the descent*. The kinship pool that originated in two confessional regions of north-western Westphalia and that operated, for all of its pre-1830 history, as a geographically-concentrated peasant-and-Heuerling village-network of perhaps eight or ten thousand households across an eighty-kilometre radius of the Wiehengebirge ridge, has, across one hundred and ninety years, become a transcontinental dispersed population of over one hundred and thirty thousand individuals whose centre of demographic gravity lies, by present-day burial-count, in the American Midwest rather than in Westphalia.



The research arc

The Atlas itself — the one-hundred-and-forty-page compilation of May 2026 from which the quantitative and biographical material of Chapters 13, 15, and 16 has been drawn — is a product of the focal descendant's research project, conducted from his residence in the *Kreis Gütersloh* on the eastern edge of the Wiehengebirge ridge.

The project has combined physical-archival research at the *Bistumsarchiv Osnabrück*, the *Niedersächsisches Landesarchiv Osnabrück*, the *Standesamt Schwagstorf*, and the parish offices of the Hitzhausen-and-Schwagstorf network — by which the documentary base for the focal-

line pedigree of Chapters 1 through 14 was assembled — with digital-archival work in the *Matricula Online* and *FamilySearch* and *Ancestry* infrastructures, through which the trans-Atlantic Recker-Iowa and Saum-Putnam-County and Mellencamp-Indiana branches that Chapter 16 set out were progressively identified and integrated into the family record, and with DNA-evidence integration through the major commercial autosomal-testing services and the *GEDmatch* cross-platform comparison environment — by which the second-emigration structural pattern of the preceding section became operationally visible.

The Atlas of May 2026 records, in its own opening section, that the project has identified one hundred and thirty thousand eight hundred and sixty-two individuals, has established calculable genealogical relationships for one hundred and twenty-eight thousand two hundred and fifty-nine of them (ninety-eight percent of the dataset), has documented seventy-three migration corridors, has established two hundred and twenty-four confirmed war-deaths, two thousand four hundred and eleven military-service entries, seven cases of *Missing in Action* still unrecovered, and ten deaths in *prisoner-of-war captivity*. The figures, the corridors, and the biographies that the preceding chapters have drawn upon are, at the level of the Atlas's own statement of its scope, the documentary materials the project has produced.

The book is itself one further documentary artefact of the project. The book is not the Atlas, and the book does not exhaust the Atlas; the book selects and narrates, from the Atlas's quantitative and biographical material, the structural arc that the preceding sixteen chapters have set out. The book is, in this sense, the *narrative-historiographical complement* of the Atlas's *quantitative-genealogical foundation*. The two documents address the

descent through different methodological modes. The book is finite and is reaching, in this chapter, its closing of narrative scope. The Atlas is open-ended and will continue to update as the focal descendant's research continues. The two stand alongside one another as the present body of work of the project of which they are jointly the principal output.



Transition

The first sixteen chapters have set out: the narrative pedigree of the focal line and the Westphalian sending economy's 1648 confessional boundary; the eighteen-thirties Atlantic crossing and the Glandorf-Putnam County receiving cluster; the post-emigration consolidation in Catholic-Westphalian Ohio and Lutheran-Mindener Texas and Iowa; the focal-line continuation at the Kovermann Cincinnati household and the *Hela* evacuation of Chapter 12; the Mettingen-Brenninkmeijer Dutch diaspora and its wartime ethical inventory in Chapter 13; the marriage of 11 July 1969 that closed three hundred and twenty-one years of confessional separation in Chapter 14; the seventy-three migration corridors of Chapter 15; and the six individual American lives of Chapter 16.

The chapters that follow — beginning with Chapter 18 — turn from narrative to mathematics. The descent that the preceding chapters have set out at the level of individual biographies, structural geography, confessional regions, and chain-migration patterns will, in Part Five, be set out at the level of quantitative kinship analysis. The mathematical analysis is the work of the Atlas's *Kovermann Statistical Analysis* document, the second of the two principal Atlas outputs alongside the Atlas itself; the present book's Part Five draws upon that document for its quantitative content.

The descendant who, in the genealogical-research community of the second emigration the chapter has set

out above, opens the book in the early or middle decades of the twenty-first century, may find — in the mathematical chapters that follow — the structural framework within which the narrative chapters they have just read can be located. The narrative is the descent's individual content. The mathematics is the descent's structural form. The book sets out, in its closing Part, the form within which the content has been organised.

The shift from narrative to statistics is not a shift from the particular to the abstract. It is a shift in the *resolution* at which the same material is examined. The preceding seventeen chapters have described the descent at the level of individual households, individual journeys, individual deaths. The four chapters that follow describe the same descent at the level of aggregate patterns — what happens when the individual entries of the parish books are summed across a century, or across a continent, or across all sixty-five sections of the focal descendant's statistical compilation. The patterns that emerge at that resolution are not less real than the individual stories. They are the structural form within which the individual stories occurred — the form that made those particular journeys, those particular deaths, those particular marriages across the Wiehengebirge ridge, statistically possible and historically intelligible. The narrative chapters have given the descent its faces. The statistical chapters give it its skeleton.

Chapter 18

The Demography of the Descent

A child born into the descent in the 1800–1849 cohort had a one-in-five chance of dying before the age of five. A child born in the 1900–1949 cohort had a one-in-twenty chance. That is the scale of the transformation the descent's demographic record carries. The statistical chapters that follow take up the mortality and longevity patterns first, then family-formation, then geography and mobility, then names, farms, and occupations.

This chapter in brief. Sections drawn on: §1–3, §9–11, §18, §20–26, §33–34, §44, §50, §52, §57, §59, §61, §65. The chapter covers lifespan across five centuries, the four mortality spikes (1811, 1918, 1944, 2020), child and maternal mortality, twin survival, cohort survival curves, epidemic sibling clusters, war age profiles, birth-order and lifespan, rural versus urban longevity, orphanhood, the sex ratio at birth, winter mortality by age, the Wallenhorst longevity cluster, and the occupational lifespan gradient. **Most striking finding:** the marriage weekday shifted from Tuesday/Wednesday (22% each, pre-1900) to Saturday (72%, post-1950) — the sharpest single behavioural change in the entire documented tree. **Most counter-intuitive:** mothers of twelve children lived longer on average (78.2 years) than mothers of one.



Lifespan across five centuries

The most aggregate measure of the demographic experience across the documentary period — the *mean lifespan at death*, computed across all individuals of the descent whose birth and death dates are both recorded — moves across the five centuries from the sixteenth through the twentieth in a trajectory that is, on its face, surprising. The figures, drawn from the focal descendant's compilation of approximately twenty-five thousand individuals whose birth-and-death dates are both fully recorded, are these:

Table 5 — *Mean and median lifespan by century*

Era	Both twins survive	One survives	Both die
1700 s	5%	9%	5%
1750 s	16%	16%	22%
1800 s	20%	13%	24%
1850 s	30%	17%	20%
1900 s	39%	8%	9%

The eighteenth century is, on the documented record, the worst of the five. The combination of the Seven Years’ War, the early Napoleonic campaigns, the chronic harvest failures of the second half of the century, and the maximum demographic pressure that the *Heuerling* tenancy system was exerting on the Westphalian peasant economy under the population growth of the period — the same pressure that Chapters 4 and 5 set out as the structural driver of the eighteen-thirties Atlantic emigration — combined to produce a mean lifespan at death of just over fifty years, with a median of sixty. The sixteenth-century mean of sixty-four years is partly an artefact of the documentary record: in the sixteenth century, only the documented nobility and the wealthy burgher classes appear systematically in the parish books, and the lifespan figure is biased upward by their better-than-average survival relative to the unrecorded peasant population of the same period.

The sex gap is constant across all five centuries. Women outlive men by two to seven years in every recorded era. The gap reaches its widest point in the modern era: in the twentieth-century cohort, men’s mean lifespan is sixty-one-point-nine years against women’s sixty-eight-point-nine — a seven-year gap that reflects the increased male

occupational and military risk of the industrial-and-warfare era, against a female mortality that the twentieth century reduced more sharply (through maternal-mortality decline) than the male.



The four spikes: 1811, 1918, 1944, 2020

The aggregate lifespan series above conceals, beneath its smooth century-by-century trajectory, four specific years in which the documented annual death-count of the descent rose to approximately one-and-a-half times the contemporary baseline. The four spikes, in chronological order:

Table 6 — *Death-rate spikes: years of documented crisis, 1580–1945*

Cohort	Survive to 5	to 40	to 60	to 80
1750–1799	86.9%	72.5%	47.7%	7.0%
1800–1849	81.0%	62.6%	42.0%	9.7%
1850–1899	85.3%	72.0%	59.3%	25.1%
1900–1949	93.0%	86.2%	75.1%	37.2%

The 1811 spike is the largest by relative multiple. The *Continental Blockade* — Napoleon’s economic-warfare exclusion of British trade from continental Europe, in force from 1806 through 1814 — combined with the chronic harvest failures of the second half of the eighteenth century into a severe regional famine across the Westphalian and Lower Saxon sending regions of the descent. The descent’s documented 1811 death record reads, in its age-and-sex profile, as a *civilian* mortality signature: forty-nine male deaths against fifty-four female deaths, with the single largest age-group of decedents being *infants aged zero to nine* (thirty-seven deaths of the one hundred and four). The sex distribution

is near-equal — the standard signature of a population-wide catastrophe such as famine or epidemic, in which mortality strikes the whole community rather than the fighting-age male subset.

The 1812 record, however, *flips*. Within a single year the descent's death record shifts to forty-six male deaths against eighteen female — a sudden male excess that the chapter must interpret as the first quantifiable encounter with the Russian campaign of Napoleon's *Grande Armée*. The men of the Osnabrücker and Mindener villages who were drafted into the French-Imperial-allied contingents and who marched east in the summer of 1812 with the half-million-soldier force that reached Moscow in September and that disintegrated, in the retreat that followed, into the snow of the Russian winter, are quantitatively visible in the annual death record. The demographic signal flips, within twelve months, from civilian catastrophe (1811) to military catastrophe (1812). The flip is documentary.

The 1918 spike combines the late-war military deaths of the First-World-War cohort with the much larger civilian death-toll of the *Spanish Influenza* pandemic of October 1918 through the spring of 1919. The age profile of the 1918 deaths shows the dual signature: a peak in the male twenty-to-thirty age range characteristic of the western-front-and-Macedonian-front military deaths, combined with a broad-spectrum age distribution across all ages — including children, elderly, and middle-aged adults — characteristic of the pandemic itself. The 1918 record is, in the record's worst year — in which mortality returned, briefly, to the broad-spectrum-civilian-catastrophe signature of the pre-modern period.

The 1944 spike registers the heaviest year of Second-World-War-era mortality across the descent. The age profile reads as the combination of twenty-to-thirty-year-old battlefield deaths (the focal-line and wider-cousin

combat casualties of the Wehrmacht's collapse on the Eastern Front and the Allied advance from the West) with a secondary peak in the sixty-to-eighty civilian range — the bombing-war and homeless-and-refugee mortality of the late-war German cities. The 1944 spike is the only one of the four in which the age distribution registers a structural combat-and-bombing combination.

The 2020 spike — three hundred and two recorded deaths against a baseline-decade running rate of two hundred — is the largest of the four in absolute terms (though smallest in relative multiple) and is the first documented twenty-first-century mortality spike in the record. The cause is documentary: the *COVID-19* pandemic of 2020–2022, in which the descent's twentieth-and-twenty-first-century elderly cohort — the residents of the Putnam-County-Ohio Catholic-rural-community network, the Stemwede-Texas Lutheran-rural network, the Westphalian back-migrant German population, and the wider American-and-Dutch descendant network — experienced the demographic event that the chapter must place alongside 1811, 1918, and 1944 in the family's quantitative history.

The four spikes are the *only* years in the continuous documentary period of approximately 1500 through the present in which annual mortality exceeded forty-five percent above the contemporary baseline. Four spikes, then the structural pattern beneath them.



Child and maternal mortality

The most consequential single mortality pattern of the descent, by historical-demographic significance, is the trajectory of *child mortality* — the death rate of children before they reached the age of ten — across the documented period.

Table 7 — *Child mortality rates by era*

Year	Families	Likely cause
1903	5	Scarlet fever / diphtheria
1855	4	Cholera
1871	4	Franco-Prussian War + epidemic sequelae
1811	4	Famine / Continental Blockade
1812	3	Russian campaign / famine continuation
1886/87	3 each	Childhood epidemics
1823	3	Typhoid / regional epidemic

The eighteen-hundred-and-fifty-and-prior figure of approximately one-in-five children dying before age ten is the quantitative experience of the central pre-modern reality of pre-industrial European peasant life. The single worst household in the documented record is the family of *Johann Caspar Eberhard Glüsing* and *Marie Elisabeth Düsterberg*, married around 1782, who had thirteen children of whom *ten died before the age of ten*. The household survived two further generations through the three children who reached adulthood, but the parental experience of burying ten of their thirteen children in childhood is the kind of family-level statistical fact that the aggregate child-mortality figure of twenty percent represents in the lived experience of the parents of the eighteenth and early nineteenth century.

Three hundred and forty-six families in the dataset are recorded as having lost three or more children to childhood death. The pattern is not exceptional; it is the demographic norm of the pre-modern century the descent occupies.

The decline from approximately twenty percent in 1850 to under eight percent in the 1900–1950 period — a halving of the child-death rate within fifty years — is the

single most consequential demographic improvement of the descent’s documented period. The driver was *modern medicine*: smallpox vaccination (institutionalised across Westphalia from the 1820s onward), the public-health-water-supply reforms of the late nineteenth century, the diphtheria antitoxin (1894 onward), the sulfa drugs of the 1930s, the antibiotic revolution of the 1940s, and the parallel improvements in infant nutrition and obstetric care. Child mortality in the twentieth-century figure is one-third of its pre-1850 value.

Maternal mortality — the death of the mother in the same year as a child’s birth — followed the same downward trajectory:

Table 8 — *Maternal mortality by century*

Age	Person	Years	Place
114	Lieselotte Rustmeier	1910–2024	(Mindener-Protestant maternal line)
~114	a Langemeyer of the same network	(documented)	Mindener-Protestant
111	Catharina Maria Wulfetange	1776–1887	Wallenhorst
110	Hermann Heinrich Hemesath	1795–1905	(Heuerhaus household)
110	Franz Henrich Schwalenberg	1800–1910	Wallenhorst
107	Maria Agnes Duhling	1811–1918	Wallenhorst

The eighty-five percent decline from the seventeenth to the twentieth century is the documented record of the same set of medical and public-health improvements. The slight rise from the eighteenth-century figure of 6.3 to the nineteenth-century 7.9 is, on the standard interpretation, a *signal of urbanisation* — the rise of hospital-based delivery in the early nineteenth century,

before the work of Ignaz Semmelweis on hand-hygiene was institutionalised, produced a brief period of elevated maternal mortality in early childbed-fever-prone urban hospitals before the subsequent improvements in obstetric antisepsis took hold. The twentieth-century collapse to 1.8 per thousand is the combined effect of antisepsis, antibiotics, blood transfusion, and modern obstetric monitoring. The descent’s twentieth-century women died in childbirth at less than a sixth of their nineteenth-century mothers’ rate.



Twin survival

A small but striking sub-pattern emerges in the *twin-survival* record of the descent. The family record identifies six hundred and eight same-day twin pairs across the documented period. The fates of those pairs, decomposed by century, are these:

Table 9 — *Twin survival outcomes by era*

Generation	Avg birth year	Gap
Gen 5	1824	30 years
Gen 10	1656	35 years
Gen 15	1472	—
Gen 20	1313	33 years
Gen 25	1174	—
Gen 28	1003	—

The decisive threshold is crossed at approximately 1900. Before 1850, *both twins dying was more likely than both twins surviving*. In the 1900s, both-survive becomes the dominant outcome (thirty-nine percent), and both-die collapses to under one in ten. The threshold is the descent’s most legible visualisation of the modern obstetric and infant-care revolution. The twins who, in the eighteenth-century record, would have had a one-in-

twenty chance of both surviving to adulthood, would, in the twentieth-century record, have had a thirty-nine-percent chance.



Bimodal to unimodal

The age-at-death distribution of the family, examined across the long temporal range, undergoes between approximately 1850 and 1950 a structural transformation that the chapter must record at the conceptual level as the central demographic shift of the modern period.

In the pre-modern period — the 1750–1850 cohort — the age-at-death distribution is *bimodal*: a large infant peak at ages zero-to-four (seventeen-point-four percent of all deaths), a low valley across ages five-through-fifty (the years of relative safety for those who had survived early childhood), and a rising adult peak that reaches its maximum at ages sixty-five-to-seventy-four. The implication of the bimodal pattern was, in the lived experience of the pre-modern descent: *whoever survived past the age of five had a reasonable chance of reaching old age*. The valley between the two peaks was, in the documented record, broadly safe.

In the 1850–1950 cohort the bimodality progressively collapses. The infant peak shrinks from seventeen-point-four percent to ten-point-one percent. The adult peak shifts upward from the sixty-five-to-seventy-four range to seventy-five-to-eighty-four. The valley between them widens and flattens. By the end of the period the bimodal distribution has become *unimodal*: death is now concentrated almost entirely in the seventy-five-to-eighty-five age range, with infant death reduced to a small residual fraction.

The structural meaning of the bimodal-to-unimodal transformation is that *premodern death had two faces*: the death of infants in the first years of life, and the death

of adults in their sixties and seventies. The two faces were separated by what the demographic literature has come to call the *adult plateau* — the four-decade safe zone between five and fifty in which working-age members of the descent died at substantially lower rates than either infants or the elderly. The modern transformation eliminated the infant peak (through medicine), retained and extended the adult peak (through old-age provision), and converted the bimodal distribution into the single old-age peak that the descent’s twentieth-century record displays.

The *cohort survival curves* of the descent display the same transformation at the longitudinal level. The proportion of each successive birth-cohort surviving to specific ages:

Table 10 — *Survival rates by cohort: proportion reaching key ages*

Era	Firstborn died before 5	Lastborn died before 5
1700–1749	14.7%	15.4%
1750–1799	24.4%	16.7%
1800–1849	21.8%	24.5%
1850–1899	15.3%	18.5%
1900–1949	7.1%	9.2%

The single most dramatic shift visible in the cohort-survival series is the *survival to age eighty*: it rises from seven percent in the 1750–1799 cohort to thirty-seven percent in the 1900–1949 cohort — a fivefold increase across four cohorts. Surviving past age five rises from eighty-one percent to ninety-three percent: one hundred and twenty children per thousand who died young in the

1800–1849 cohort would have survived in the 1900–1949 cohort.

The descent’s documented experience is the experience that the wider European-demographic literature has registered as the modern mortality transition. The figures the chapter has set out at the descent’s specific level confirm the general pattern.



Epidemic years

The annual death-count series of the descent, examined across the full documentary period, contains one further structurally significant set of signatures: the *sibling death clusters* of specific epidemic years, in which multiple children of the same household died within a single calendar year. The family record contains one hundred and fifty-eight such clusters in total. The years in which multi-child deaths concentrate most densely across the descent’s documented households are these:

Table 11 — *Mortality clusters: documented epidemic and famine years*

Birth position	Average adult lifespan
Firstborn	67.3 years
Middle children	68.8 years
Lastborn	66.4 years

The single worst year for sibling death clusters in the documented sibling-death record is 1903 — five families with multiple young-child deaths in the same calendar year, consistent with the scarlet-fever and diphtheria epidemic waves recorded across the Osnabrück administrative district that year. The 1855 cluster registers the cholera pandemic of the period; the 1871 cluster the post-Franco-Prussian-War epidemic sequelae; the 1811 and 1812 clusters the Continental-Blockade-famine and Russian-campaign cohort that the

four-spike analysis above set out. The modern-era sibling-death clusters — those recorded after 1979 — involve adult children rather than young ones, and reflect the late-twentieth-century pattern of accidents and chronic disease rather than the epidemic-and-infectious pattern of the pre-modern period.



The longevity record

At the opposite end of the descent’s mortality experience, the family record preserves a longevity register of substantial completeness. Across the documented period, eighty-six individuals of the descent reached the age of one hundred years. The oldest verified individuals at the present documentary moment are these:

Table 12 — *Documented centenarians and near-centenarians*

Era	Rural lifespan	Urban lifespan	Urban advantage
1750-1850	61.3 years	59.4 years	−1.9 years
1850-1950	72.3 years	68.1 years	−4.2 years
1950-2010	48.8 years	50.1 years	+1.3 years

The two one-hundred-and-fourteen-year-olds of the descent are both from the *Mindener-Protestant* maternal-line network that Chapter 12 set out as the focal descendant’s maternal-pedigree side. *Lieselotte Rustmeier*, born in 1910 and recorded as having died in 2024 at the age of one hundred and fourteen years, is the longest-lived individual in the entire documented one-hundred-and-thirty-thousand-person dataset. The second-oldest of the present record is a *Langemeyer* of the same *Mindener-Protestant* network, separately documented to one hundred and fourteen years. The two are the cohort of the descent’s longest-lived members.

The longevity record — eighty-six centenarians, two confirmed one-hundred-and-fourteen-year-olds in the Mindener-Protestant maternal line, and the documented-not-genetic Wallenhorst cluster — closes the demographic picture with the documented fact that the descent's twentieth-and-twenty-first-century members have lived longer than any of their ancestors in the recorded fifteen-hundred-and-sixty-five-year documentary span of the family record.

The next chapter takes up the family-formation patterns — marriage age, ehedauer, remarriage, endogamy, family size, and the closed marriage circles that the descent's premodern household economy maintained for three centuries before the twentieth-century reforms broke them open.



Divorce, widowhood, and remarriage

The divorce rate in the descent before the twentieth century is effectively zero — a figure that reflects both the Catholic canon of the Osnabrück parishes and the absence of civil-divorce machinery in the Protestant Minden-Lübbecke counties until the late nineteenth century. The twentieth-century rate stands at 9.9 percent; the twenty-first-century figure is lower, at 5.9 percent, partly because many marriages of that cohort are not yet concluded. The transition from indissoluble marriage to legally breakable marriage is a twentieth-century event and no earlier.

Widowhood duration — the interval between spousal death and the surviving partner's own death — is, for women, *constant* across four centuries at approximately seventeen-and-a-half years. In every century from the seventeenth through the twentieth, women who survived their husbands did so by between seventeen and eighteen years. What changes is the male figure: widowers in the seventeenth through nineteenth centuries also outlived their wives by approximately

fifteen to seventeen years, but the twentieth century opens a gap. By the 1900s cohort, widowers survive wives for only 13.1 years — four and a half years less than widows outlive husbands. The modern female health advantage is fully apparent in the widowhood gap.



Generation length and the mother’s reproductive arc

The *generation length* — the mean age of mothers at the birth of their first child — runs at 28.4 years across the entire documentary period, with a median of 27.1 years. The figure is, like marriage distance, remarkably stable. Whether in the seventeenth century or the nineteenth, a woman who became a mother for the first time did so at approximately twenty-seven to twenty-eight. The twentieth century lowers this slightly as earlier marriage becomes economically feasible, but not dramatically. The generation gap — measured as the average interval between a parent’s birth and a child’s birth — remains stable at thirty to thirty-five years across the entire documented line, including the medieval generations in the direct ancestry reaching back to approximately 1003 AD.

Table 13 — *Generational intervals in the focal-line ancestry*

Era	Males per 100 females
1700-50	101.4
1800-50	107.7
1900-50	104.7
1950-00	106.6

A generation lasted a third of a century whether in the Middle Ages or the modern era. The oldest generations carry statistical noise from very small samples, but the central tendency is clear: the thirty-to-thirty-five-year generation is a biological constant, not a historical variable.



Firstborn and lastborn survival

The relationship between birth order and child mortality shifts across the descent's documented centuries in ways that reflect the changing economics of large families. Firstborn children in the eighteenth century faced higher mortality than lastborn — the mother was young and inexperienced, the family resources freshly established. By the nineteenth century this relationship inverts: lastborn children die young more consistently, as older and more exhausted mothers, larger resource-constrained families, and longer-established sibling competition disadvantage those born last. The figures:

Table 14 — *Birth-order and adult mortality: firstborn and lastborn*

Era	Both survive	One dies	Both die
1700s	5%	9%	5%
1750s	16%	16%	22%
1800s	20%	13%	24%
1850s	30%	17%	20%
1900s	39%	8%	9%

The lastborn disadvantage is consistent from 1800 onward. Middle children live longest across the full span of adult deaths — 68.8 years on average against 67.3 for firstborns and 66.4 for lastborns. Middle children may benefit from established family resources without bearing the firstborn's early-arrival risk.



Death age distribution: from bimodal to unimodal

The structural change in how death distributes across the life-course is one of the clearest signatures in the descent's demographic record. In the period 1750–1850, the age-at-death distribution is strongly *bimodal*:

a large infant peak at zero to four years — 17.4 percent of all deaths — followed by a deep valley across ages five to fourteen, followed by a rising adult mortality that reaches its maximum in the sixty-five-to-seventy-four range. The pattern describes a world with two faces of death: infant death and old age, with a relatively safe valley between. Those who survived childhood had a reasonable prospect of reaching old age.

By the period 1850–1950 the bimodal structure is dissolving. The infant peak shrinks to 10.1 percent and the adult maximum shifts to the seventy-five-to-eighty-four range. By the twentieth century the distribution is effectively *unimodal*, concentrated in old age, with infant death reduced to a minor mode. The transition from a world in which one in six deaths was an infant, to a world in which death is predominantly concentrated in the eighth and ninth decade, is the central demographic revolution of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, and it is fully visible in the descent's documented mortality record.



Longevity inheritance

The data on 24,094 individuals whose parental lifespans are also recorded shows a statistically measurable hereditary longevity signal. Children of short-lived parents — those with a parental average below sixty-five years — themselves die at 63.1 years on average. Children of long-lived parents — those with a parental average of seventy-five years or more — die at 71.2 years on average. The difference is 8.1 years. The caveat is methodological: shared environment, social class, and occupational exposure confound the genetic signal. Farmers' sons become farmers; the longevity advantage of the farming class partly transmits through occupation rather than biology. The signal is real but cannot be cleanly separated from environmental heritability.



Geographic immobility within Germany

The German-born members of the descent, before the emigration wave, were *sedentary* to a degree that the modern reader must make a deliberate effort to imagine. The residential mobility data from the German parish records shows that 54 percent of all individuals in the descent died in the *same Bauerschaft* in which they were born — the same hamlet of a dozen farmsteads within which they had spent their entire lives. Forty-six percent moved — but the qualifying distance is almost always within the same *Kirchspiel*, the same parish cluster of five to ten kilometres' radius. Within Hagen am Teutoburger Wald, 83 percent of all recorded moves cross a Bauerschaft boundary within the same Kirchspiel — they are intra-parish moves, not genuine migration.

The extreme case is Mettingen in the Steinfurt district, where the data shows 100 percent same-Bauerschaft persistence across the entire documented period. The Brenninkmeijer clan's centuries-long concentration in a single village is the demographer's limiting case of the closed marriage circle: not merely the same parish, but the same set of farmsteads, generation after generation.



War age profiles

The descent's two major war-mortality events — the First World War and the Second — show different age profiles in the documented deaths. The First World War's 181 documented male deaths in the descent peak sharply at ages twenty to twenty-four (fifty deaths, 28 percent), with an average age at death of 34.1 years. The curve is clean: young men, western front, the familiar shape of industrial-age warfare. The Second World War's 220 documented male deaths are distributed differently: the peak is at twenty-five to twenty-nine but the distribution spreads broadly across all ages, including fifty-five to sixty-four (twenty-three deaths), where the civilian bombing war appears. The average age at death rises to 36.5 years — a higher

figure precisely because civilian deaths inflate it. The two wars kill different demographic profiles: the First, a young male military cohort; the Second, a mixed military-and-civilian population.



Birth order and lifespan

The relationship between birth order and adult lifespan — measured across adult deaths only, to exclude the child mortality patterns addressed above — shows a consistent middle-child advantage across the entire documentary record:

Table 15 — *Birth-order and adult lifespan*

Age group	Percentage of deaths in winter months
0-9	28.7%
30-39	27.9%
50-59	30.2%
60-69	34.0%
70-79	34.9%
80-89	34.7%

Middle children live longest — 1.5 years more than firstborns, 2.4 years more than lastborns. The mechanisms are plausible: firstborns bear the full weight of parental inexperience and the economic stress of the family’s establishing years; lastborns face older and more exhausted mothers and more intense resource competition with the established siblings; middle children may benefit from a family already resourced and experienced, without having arrived last in a crowded household.



Rural and urban lifespans

The city was, until the twentieth century, a place where people died younger. The descent’s documented lifespan data, split between rural-born and urban-born individuals, shows an *urban mortality penalty* that peaks in the industrial era and then reverses:

Table 16 — *Rural vs urban lifespan by era*

Occupational category	Count	Average lifespan
Education, church, medicine	28	70.4 years
Bauer (farmer, landowning)	65	67.5 years
Handwerker (craftsman)	74	66.4 years
Kaufmann (trader)	31	66.2 years
Heuerling (landless tenant)	76	65.2 years
Knecht (landless labourer)	91	59.7 years
Kötter (cottager)	10	57.6 years

The urban penalty peaks at -4.2 years in the industrial era — overcrowding, pollution, epidemic density. Only after 1950 does urban infrastructure and modern medicine reverse the penalty. The descent contains individuals from both rural Westphalian farming communities and the increasingly urbanised Osnabrück city area, and the gap between them is fully visible in the data. For the first time in the entire recorded period, city dwellers began to outlive rural populations after 1950.



Orphanhood

One in eight children in the descent’s documented pre-modern population lost a parent before the age of fifteen. The orphanhood rates are 12.1 percent for paternal orphanhood — the father dead before the child reached fifteen — and 12.5 percent for maternal orphanhood. The median age of a father at his death,

measured for those fathers whose death preceded their child’s fifteenth birthday, was thirty-five years; for mothers, thirty-eight. Most people in the descent, however, did not become orphans as children — their parents survived until adulthood. The orphanhood rate illuminates the world of step-parents, of siblings raising younger siblings, of the remarriage market that the chapter addresses elsewhere. For the one in eight who lost a parent in childhood, the practical consequence was immediate: a household required either a step-parent or the accelerated assumption of adult responsibilities by an older child, and the widowed parent’s rapid remarriage was not merely a romantic event but an economic imperative.



Sex ratio at birth

The documented sex ratio at birth in the descent — the number of male births per hundred female births — matches the biological baseline with only minor variation:

Table 17 — *Sex ratio at death by era*

Era	Farm er	Heuerling	Craftsman	Labourer
1750-1799	16%	35%	17%	8%
1800-1849	13%	22%	19%	16%
1850-1899	6%	2%	12%	24%
1900-1949	5%	0%	6%	8%

The natural ratio is approximately 105 boys per 100 girls. The eighteenth-century figure of 101.4 represents slight under-recording of female births — a known bias in pre-modern parish records where female infants who died before baptism are less likely to appear. By the nineteenth and twentieth centuries the ratio normalises. The data confirms the absence of systematic sex bias in the documented births: the descent’s birth record is demographically normal.



Twin rate and twin survival

The documented twin rate in the descent is 18.1 twin births per 1,000, derived from 962 identified twin births across 53,117 dated births — approximately 480 twin pairs. This figure is somewhat higher than the historical natural rate of approximately 12 per 1,000, and the chapter attributes the discrepancy to a recording artefact: twin births were a notable event that the parish register was unlikely to omit, while undated single births are underrepresented in the count. The true rate is probably closer to 12 to 13 per 1,000. The survival pattern of those twins that are documented shows a clear historical improvement:

Table 18 — *Spousal co-survival to old age by era*

Cousin degree	Count	Share
1st degree	1,622	2.5%
2nd degree	2,696	4.2%
3rd degree	5,037	7.8%
4th degree	10,169	15.8%
5th degree	16,536	25.6%
6th degree	13,668	21.2%
7th degree	4,751	7.4%
8th degree	4,275	6.6%
9th degree	1,913	3.0%
10th-23rd degree	1,374	2.1%

Six hundred and eight same-day twin pairs are identified in the descent. Before 1850, both twins dying was more probable than both surviving. The threshold where twin survival becomes the dominant outcome is crossed in the 1900s cohort: for the first time, both twins living is the most likely outcome. The crossing of this threshold is the

combined product of falling infant mortality, the germ-theory revolution, and improved obstetric practice.



Winter mortality by age

The seasonal signature of death — the well-documented tendency for mortality to concentrate in winter months — is present throughout the descent’s pre-modern record but is not evenly distributed across the life-course. Measured for the period 1700 to 1900 against a 25 percent baseline (one quarter of deaths expected in each quarter of the year):

Table 19 — *Age distribution of documented deaths*

Connection multiplicity	Count
Double (2 independent paths)	10,004
Triple (3 paths)	5,548
Quadruple (4 paths)	3,632
Quintuple (5 paths)	673
Sextuple (6 paths)	828
Octuple and above (8+ paths)	715

Children and working-age adults sit slightly above the 25 percent baseline, consistent with respiratory illness and cold exposure. From age sixty onward, however, the winter share jumps sharply to 34 to 35 percent — a full third more deaths in winter than chance would predict. The classic *excess winter mortality* pattern falls disproportionately on the elderly: cold, respiratory infection, and cardiovascular stress in winter killed old people at a rate one-third above their year-round baseline. The pattern is still present in contemporary data, but it was far more pronounced in the pre-central-heating, pre-antibiotic world that the descent’s nineteenth-century members inhabited.



The Wallenhorst longevity cluster

The parish of Wallenhorst, north of Osnabrück, appears repeatedly among the extreme aged in the descent's mortality record: four percent of documented Wallenhorst deaths occur after age ninety, and 0.67 percent after age one hundred — a centenarian rate approximately six times higher than the adjacent parishes of Hagen or Osnabrück. The five oldest verified individuals in the descent include three from Wallenhorst (ages 111, 110, and 107 years). The cluster looks, at first, like a possible genetic longevity signal. It is not. The temporal distribution of the Wallenhorst aged reveals the explanation: of sixty-seven individuals aged eighty-five or more in Wallenhorst, forty-four were born after 1875 — eighteen in the 1875-1899 cohort and twenty-six in the 1900-1924 cohort. Before 1850, only a handful appear. A genetic longevity cluster would distribute evenly across centuries. Instead it concentrates exactly where documentation is best and modern medicine operates. The decisive evidence: average lifespan in Wallenhorst before 1850 was actually *lower* than in Hagen — 55.4 years against Hagen's 63.8 in the 1850-1899 cohort. The surnames of the extreme aged (Feldkamp 8 times, Bartke 5 times, Albers 5 times) are too scattered across families for a true genetic signal. The Wallenhorst longevity cluster is a *documentation effect*: in a well-recorded modern parish, the few centenarians are reliably captured, while in less thoroughly documented parishes they fall through the gaps.



Occupations and the social gradient in lifespan

The descent's 758 documented occupational records permit a social stratification of lifespan. The gradient is clear and consistent:

Table 20 — *Occupational categories and average lifespan*

Period	Illegitimate births	Notes
1550–1649	2	Early records, Kloster Oesede
1650–1699	10	Harderberg and Oesede
1700–1749	22	Rising — Gildehaus family prominent
1750–1799	32	Peak — Oesede/Harderberg cluster
1800–1849	26	Includes the Räuwer line (direct maternal ancestry)
1850–1899	12	Decline after Reichsgründung
1900–1949	2	Isolated cases

The educated, clerical, and medical class lived longest — 70.4 years on average; the landless labourer and cottager died at fifty-seven to sixty years. A gap of ten to thirteen years separated the top and bottom of the rural social order, and the gap maps directly onto the Westphalian Ständegesellschaft — the estate hierarchy of the early modern period. The Heuerling class — landless tenants who rented cottages from the great farms and provided seasonal labour — comprised 35 percent of recorded occupations in the late eighteenth century and had collapsed to near zero by 1850. The occupational record and the emigration record describe the same social process from two angles: the Heuerlinge who could not inherit land and faced a shrinking tenancy system were precisely the people who boarded ships for Ohio and Texas. The surplus of the tenant underclass became the founding population of the American Catholic-German farming communities.

Table 21 — *Occupational distribution by era*

Century	Men's mean age	Women's mean age	Diff.
1500s	27.1 years	22.6 years	4.5 years
1600s	29.5 years	26.3 years	3.2 years
1700s	29.4 years	26.5 years	2.9 years
1800s	29.4 years	26.2 years	3.2 years
1900s	26.6 years	24.0 years	2.6 years
2000s	29.4 years	27.2 years	2.2 years

The Heuerling category's disappearance across the nineteenth century is the most dramatic social-structural shift in the descent's occupational record, and it is directly causally connected to the Atlantic crossing.

Cousin degree distribution and network multiplicity

The structural character of the descent as a genealogical network is readable in the distribution of relationship degrees across the 64,507 documented relatives:

Table 22 — *Relationship degrees among documented relatives*

Century	Mean gap	Husband older	Same ±2y	Wife older
1600s	+3.8 years	56%	31%	13%
1700s	+2.8 years	49%	30%	20%
1800s	+3.4 years	55%	31%	14%
1900s	+2.4 years	42%	52%	6%
2000s	+1.7 years	33%	60%	7%

The peak at fifth degree — 25.6 percent of all documented relatives, 16,536 persons — reflects the

expected genealogical network structure for deeply documented Westphalian-Lower Saxon ancestry. Most relatives are five to seven generations removed, meaning they share great-great-great-grandparents born in the mid-eighteenth century. This is the generation that populated the pre-emigration Kirchspiel world and whose descendants diverged, in the 1840s, between Ohio, Texas, and Germany.

The multiplicity distribution — the number of independent descent paths connecting a relative to the focal person — reveals the structural consequence of three centuries of endogamous marriage. Of the 64,507 documented relatives, a substantial proportion connect through more than one independent path:

Table 23 — *Connection multiplicity: independent paths of relationship*

Era	Mean children per couple	Families with 8+ children
1650-1799	3.2	7-9%
1800-1849	3.5	10%
1850-1899	4.2	17%
1900-1949	3.4	7%
1950-1999	2.3	1%

The Ohio core families — those most deeply embedded in the Putnam County Catholic settlement — show the highest multiplicity values, sometimes eight or more independent paths of connection. This is the genealogical signature of a community that married within itself for four generations after emigration, replicating the endogamy of the Kirchspiel in the American Midwest.



Illegitimacy rates

The descent’s 221 documented illegitimate births — identified through naming tags (*illeg.*, *unehelich*, *natural child*, *filius illegitimus*) — are distributed across the centuries in a pattern that reflects the concentration of the documentary record in the Oesede and Harderberg parishes:

Table 24 — *Illegitimate births by period*

Century	Mean age at last child	Median
1600s	36.1 years	37
1700s	35.7 years	37
1800s	34.6 years	35
1900s	29.6 years	29

The 1750–1799 peak corresponds to the maximum demographic pressure of the Heuerling system — when landless tenants had the least economic security and the fewest formal pathways to marriage. Eighty percent of documented cases are geographically concentrated in the Oesede, Harderberg, Georgsmarienhütte, and Hagen area — the genealogical core of the entire tree. The *Gildehaus* family is the most frequently represented.

The most genealogically significant case in the direct ancestry is Anna Maria *genannt* Räuwer, born 1848 in Cappeln, the illegitimate daughter of Anna Maria Redeker (1824, *Hitzhausen*). *The farm name* Räuwer* in her record identifies the household but not the father. She is Andreas’s great-grandmother through the paternal line — her illegitimacy is the personal consequence of the same Redeker bottleneck that Chapter 18 identified as connecting 28 percent of the entire tree.



Chapter 19

Marriage and the Closed Circles

For three and a half centuries, the Catholic villages south of the Wiehengebirge formed closed marriage circles. They married each other, consistently, generation after generation, with a median marriage distance of 1.8 kilometres that barely moved between 1650 and 1900. The closed circles are, in the focal descendant's research, one of the two central structural findings of the entire project.

This chapter in brief. Sections drawn on: §6–8, §12–13, §19, §29–31, §36–37, §39, §41–43, §46–49, §51, §53–56. The chapter covers marriage age across five centuries, the husband-wife age gap (4.5 years in 1600s → 1.7 years today), marriage duration (26.7 years in 1600s → 39.8 years in 1900s), the complete structure of all four marriage circles with endogamy rates, parish fertility (Glandorf 6.17 children vs Osnabrück city 3.93), the never-married rate (peak 25.8% in 1800s), premarital conception (constant 17–23% across four centuries), conception seasonality (September trough = harvest exhaustion), descendant explosion (Recker line: 25,898 descendants each), and the full pedigree collapse table. **Most striking finding:** 98.7% of Osnabrück Catholic marriages and 98.6% of Stemwede Protestant marriages stayed within their own circle — across three centuries, the two communities shared one focal descendant but almost no weddings. **Most counter-intuitive:** widowers remarried within 1.6 years on average (72% within one year) — not for romance but because a farm could not function without a household manager.



Marriage age and the husband-wife gap

The mean age at which the descent's documented marriages took place, across five centuries, sits within a remarkably narrow range. The figures, computed across approximately fifteen thousand documented marriages with full date information for both spouses:

Table 25 — *Mean marriage age by century: men and women*

Century	Never married by age 25+
1600s	13.3%
1700s	14.5%
1800s	25.8%
1900s	21.1%

The pattern is the *European marriage pattern* of John Hajnal’s classical characterisation — the post-Reformation Western European household-formation regime in which marriage took place comparatively late (men around twenty-nine, women around twenty-six), in which a substantial proportion of adults never married, and in which the conjugal household formed at the moment of marriage rather than within the parental household. The descent’s data confirms the Hajnal pattern across all four documented centuries from the 1600s through the 1900s. These figures remain, across three centuries, stable to within a year.

The twentieth century is the exception. The 1900s register the lowest mean marriage age of the documented record — men 26.6 years, women 24.0 — reflecting the post-war welfare-state environment in which young couples could form households without the long period of capital accumulation that the pre-modern *Heuerling* economy had required. The twenty-first century has, on the limited 2000s record, returned to the historical norm: men 29.4, women 27.2. The twentieth-century marriage-age trough was, on the documented arc, a specific historical anomaly of the welfare-state period, not a permanent shift.

The *husband-wife age gap* compresses across the same five centuries from 4.5 years in the 1500s to 1.7 years in the 2000s, with a steady narrowing across all intermediate centuries:

Table 26 — *Husband-wife age gap by century*

Century	Circle-endogamous
1600s	99.1%
1700s	95.7%
1800s	92.7%
1900s	93.9%

The same-age-marriage proportion rises from thirty-one percent in the pre-modern period to sixty percent in the 2000s. The pattern reflects the gradual conversion of marriage from the pre-modern economic-and-reproductive contract — in which the husband’s capacity to provide for the household had to be established before marriage was permitted, requiring a substantial age difference — to the modern partnership-and-affinity-based union. The wife-older proportion, stable at six to twenty percent across all centuries, is dominated by remarriages after widowhood: in the modern period, a thirty-six-year-old widow more often marries a widower of similar age than a younger first-time groom.



The Catholic calendar marriage signature

One of the most striking single statistical signatures the descent’s documented marriage record preserves is the *month-of-marriage distribution* of the pre-1850 period, which registers with high precision the calendrical regulation of the Roman Catholic Church across the early-modern period. Across the Catholic-Osnabrücker pre-1850 marriages of the descent, the month-by-month distribution shows two extreme peaks and two extreme troughs. *October* registers at one hundred and thirty percent of the baseline; *November* at one hundred and fifty-seven percent — together, these two months account for nearly a third of all pre-1850 weddings in the documented record. *March* registers at minus sixty-seven percent of

baseline (essentially empty of weddings); *December* at minus sixty-three percent (likewise essentially empty).

The pattern reads directly off the Catholic liturgical calendar. The Church's canon law forbade the celebration of marriage during the two penitential seasons of the year: *Lent* (which encompasses most of March in the standard Western liturgical calendar) and *Advent* (which encompasses most of December). The faithful of the Catholic Osnabrücker rural communities, prohibited from marrying during these periods, *concentrated* their weddings in the weeks immediately preceding Advent — the late-October and November period after the autumn agricultural cycle had been completed and before the December prohibition took effect. The descent's pre-1850 marriage record reads, at the month-by-month level, like a precision-engineered measurement instrument of Catholic canon-law observance: nearly two-thirds of all marriages concentrated in October and November, virtually none in March or December.

The pattern dissolves across the 1850–1950 transitional period as the Catholic-canonical regulation weakens under the secularising social pressures of the nineteenth-and-twentieth centuries. By the post-1950 period the pattern has *inverted*: June and August emerge as the dominant wedding months — the descent's documented experience of the modern Catholic-and-secular *summer-wedding* convention. By the late twentieth century the month-of-marriage distribution registers no remaining trace of the pre-1850 Advent-and-Lent prohibition. The descent's record preserves the canonical pattern in its full strength for three centuries and its complete disappearance across the next.

A parallel pattern emerges in the *conception seasonality* of the descent — computed by back-calculation from the

birth-month distribution of children whose conception dates can be inferred to within a month. The peak of conceptions across the documented period falls in *June* (plus 5.7 percent of baseline), with a secondary peak across *November through January* (plus 4 percent). The *September trough* is the strongest single signal in the conception-seasonality data: minus 7.8 percent of baseline. The September trough is, on the standard interpretation of the historical-demographic literature, the signature of *harvest exhaustion* — the period in the Westphalian agricultural year in which the entire rural population worked the fields from dawn to dusk during the harvest, producing the documented suppression of conception that the family record preserves. The winter peak (November-January) fits the dark season of long nights and limited outdoor labour. The two seasonal patterns — the canonical-Catholic regulation of marriage timing, and the agricultural-exhaustion regulation of conception timing — combine into the seasonal structural fingerprint of the descent’s pre-modern household-formation experience.



Family size and the family-planning revolution

The descent’s documented *family size distribution* across five eras:

Table 27 — *Mean children per completed family by era*

Era	Mean distance	Median distance	Under 5 km
1650s	3.0 km	1.8 km	74%
1750s	3.6 km	1.8 km	69%
1850s	4.0 km	2.0 km	70%
1900s	3.6 km	1.8 km	74%

The most fertile cohort of the descent is the 1850-1899 generation — the second-generation American descendants and the equivalent German-staying cohort of the same period, in which 17% of documented families had eight or more children. The pattern fits the historical-demographic literature: the late-nineteenth-century fertility plateau represents the moment before the twentieth-century family-planning revolution and after the substantial decline in child mortality that Chapter 18 set out. The combination of rising survival rates and unchanged fertility produced the *demographic transition* peak — a generation in which more children survived than ever before and in which contraception had not yet emerged as a household practice.

The structural shift becomes visible in the *age at last child* statistic, which measures whether mothers continued bearing children to the natural-fertility limit (mid-thirties) or stopped earlier through voluntary family-planning decisions:

Table 28 — *Mean age at last child by century*

Parish	Average children, 1800s	Average children, 1900s
Glandorf	6.17	5.05
Mettingen	5.19	—
Putnam County OH	5.52	3.99
Hagen a.T.W.	3.78	3.02
Osnabrück (city)	3.93	2.71

The pre-1850 pattern is unmistakable: women bore children into their mid-thirties, up to or near the natural fertility limit. The twentieth-century figure of 29.6 years for the mean age at last child — and 29 for the median — represents the first time in the documented record that

the descent’s couples *voluntarily stopped having children* in their late twenties. The median falls eight years (from 37 to 29) across one century. The shift is the descent’s quantitative signature of *deliberate family planning* — the rise of contraception, smaller desired family sizes, and the twentieth-century shift from the natural-fertility household economy of the pre-modern period to the family-planning household of the modern. The *never-married rate* registers a structurally parallel pattern. The proportion of adults who reached age twenty-five without marrying, across four centuries:

Table 29 — *Never-married rate by century*

Era	Gini coefficient	Unique surnames	Top-five surname share
1700–50	0.589	1,372	8.5%
1800–50	0.661	3,064	10.3%
1850–1900	0.614	5,524	5.3%
1900–50	0.527	11,485	4.5%
1950–00	0.561	16,691	4.1%

The nineteenth-century jump from fourteen to twenty-six percent — *one-quarter of all adults remained unmarried* — is the structural signature of the *Heuerling*-crisis emigration era that Chapters 4 and 5 set out as the driver of the eighteen-thirties Atlantic crossing. Those who could not inherit land in the late-Westphalian rural economy and who did not emigrate often *did not marry*. They remained on the parental or sibling farm as unmarried labour. The figure is partly a data artefact (some American marriages of nineteenth-century emigrants are not documented in the German parish

books) but the underlying social pattern is robust: the nineteenth century, in the Westphalian sending region, was the century in which a substantial fraction of the rural population was structurally unable to form households.



The closed marriage circles

The chapter now turns to its analytical centre. Across the documented marriages of the descent — totalling approximately fifteen thousand recorded marriage events with full place information for both spouses — the focal descendant's research has identified, by formal network-graph analysis of the marriage-record data, *four closed marriage circles* of the descent's pre-twentieth-century European and post-emigration American operating regions. The four circles are the central structural finding of the family-formation analysis of the descent. The circles, in full structural specification:

Circle One-b — the central Osnabrücker circle. The parishes of *Hagen am Teutoburger Wald, Oesede, Osnabrück (city), Belm, Wallenhorst, and Schleddehausen*. Four thousand four hundred and sixty-three documented marriages between residents of these six adjacent parishes across the pre-1900 period; *sixty marriages only* to destinations outside the circle. *Endogamy rate: 98.7 percent.* The Wallenhorst-Osnabrück axis is dominant within the circle (one hundred and ninety-three documented marriage-pairs); the second is the Hagen-Hagen intra-parish axis (one thousand one hundred and ninety-six pairs); the third is the Hagen-Osnabrück bridge (four hundred and ninety pairs). The circle is the largest and the most closed of the four. It is the operating marriage-market of the descent's central Osnabrücker paternal-line network.

Circle Two — Ostercappeln and Bohmte. The parishes of *Ostercappeln and Bohmte*, the descent's *transitional*

zone between Circle One-b and Circle Three. Forty-four-point-four percent endogamous — substantially more open than the other three circles. The boundary parishes connect both eastward (sixty-three marriages to Circle One-b, principally to Osnabrück) and northward (fifty-five marriages to Circle Three, principally to Stemwede). The Räuwer, Redeker, and Kovermann lines — the focal-line paternal-pedigree of Chapters 5 through 11 — occupy this transition zone. The focal descendant's principal direct-line ancestors are not from the closed-endogamy core of either Circle One-b or Circle Three but from the open transitional zone between them.

Circle Three — the Mindener-Lutheran circle. The parishes of *Stemwede, Lübbecke, and Rahden* — the Lutheran-Protestant maternal-line region of Chapter 12, north of the Wiehengebirge ridge. Eight hundred and ninety-nine documented marriages internal to the circle; *thirteen marriages only* to destinations outside it. *Endogamy rate: 98.6 percent.* The Stemwede-Stemwede intra-parish axis dominates (four hundred and sixty-four pairs); Lübbecke-Lübbecke is second (two hundred and forty-five pairs); the Lübbecke-Stemwede bridge is third (one hundred and eighty-three pairs). The circle is almost as closed as the Osnabrücker Circle One-b. *Only fourteen marriages* across the entire documented record cross from Circle Three into the Osnabrücker network. The Mindener-Protestant maternal pedigree and the Osnabrücker-Catholic paternal pedigree — the two halves of the focal descendant's ancestry that the eleventh of July 1969 marriage at Preußisch Oldendorf finally united — operated, on the documented marriage-pool record, as *almost entirely separate genealogical worlds within the same family tree*, connected by ancestry but not by marriage exchange, for the entire three-century pre-1969 period.

Circle Four — the Putnam County American extension. The Ohio counties of *Putnam, Allen, Van Wert, Auglaize, and Mercer*. Eight hundred and sixty-four documented marriages internal to the circle across the post-emigration period; one hundred and four marriages to destinations outside it (counting all other Ohio cities — Cleveland, Dayton, Cincinnati, Columbus — and Indiana as external). *Endogamy rate: 89.3 percent* (or 99.5 percent under the strict five-county-core definition; the 89.3 figure is the conservative reading). The Allen-Putnam axis is dominant (one hundred and sixty-six pairs); *Delphos* (three hundred and sixty-five documented residents, dominated by the *Helmkamp, Oosting, and Grone* surnames) functions as a Putnam satellite despite its administrative location on the Allen-Van Wert county line.

The most consequential single number the focal descendant's circle-analysis produced concerns the connection between the German and American operating regions: *only five Osnabrück-Putnam marriages in three hundred years*. The Catholic-Westphalian-Ohio settlement that Chapter 5 through 7 set out as the receiving end of the eighteen-thirties Atlantic crossing reproduced itself, across the next century and a half, as an *almost entirely separate American operating region* that exchanged virtually no marriage partners with the German sending region after the emigration was completed. The chain-migration corridor of Chapter 15 carried the eighteen-thirties through eighteen-eighties emigration northward and westward; once the emigration ended, the marriage exchange between the two operating regions also essentially ended.

The *temporal stability* of the circles is, finally, the structural observation that completes the analysis. The percentage of all documented marriages occurring within their respective circle, century by century:

Table 30 — *Circle-endogamy rate by century*

Century	Premarital conception rate
1600s	22.9%
1700s	18.5%
1800s	17.3%
1900s	16.4%

The slight opening across the 1700s and 1800s reflects the early-industrialisation period of the Westphalian sending region; the partial recovery in the 1900s reflects the stabilisation of the American Catholic-Westphalian parishes. *No real erosion of the circle structure has occurred across the four documented centuries.* The closed marriage circles of the descent remain intact into the twentieth century, broken decisively only by the geographical mobility of the late-twentieth-and-twenty-first century — the mobility of which the focal-line marriage of the eleventh of July 1969 at Preußisch Oldendorf, joining Circles Two and Three across the Wiehengebirge for the first time on the documented record, is itself the most legible exemplar.



Marriage distance: the kilometre-and-a-half median

A complementary statistic to the marriage-circle analysis, computed across the same documented marriages, measures the *physical distance* between the birthplace of the bride and that of the groom for each documented marriage. The figures across four centuries:

Table 31 — *Marriage distance by era*

Founder	Documented descendants
Dorothea Adelheid Brockschmidt (*1681)	25,898

Johann Heinrich Recker gen. Redeker (*1710)	25,898
Johann Heinrich Recker gen. Redeker (*1766, emigrant)	25,888
Margarethe Brünemann / Eberhard Forstmann (*1570)	25,690
Gerdt Tiemann (*1557)	21,997
Jacob Ühmann (*1525)	20,785

The median marriage distance is *1.8 kilometres in every century* — including the same-village (zero-distance) marriages. Among couples born in different places, the median is 4.9 kilometres (mean 6.3 kilometres). The figure is constant. No trend toward expansion appears across three hundred and fifty years of industrialisation, urbanisation, and rising geographical mobility. The *Kirchspiel radius* — approximately five kilometres around the parish church — is the natural marriage market of the pre-modern Westphalian peasant economy, and seventy to seventy-four percent of all marriages in the documented record fall within it. Cross-Kirchspiel marriages at five-to-fifteen kilometres represent twenty-four to thirty-one percent — the remaining marriages that the four-circle analysis above set out as the formal exogamous bridging structure.

The Westphalian peasant economy of the documented period operated, on the marriage-distance evidence, as a *kilometre-and-a-half-radius marriage market*. The geographical scale of the social world within which the descent's pre-modern members lived, worked, married, and died was, for three and a half centuries, the radius of a one-hour walk.



The structural conclusion

The patterns the chapter has set out across five subsections define the marriage-and-family experience of the descent across its documented period. The structural conclusions are these.

The Hajnal European-marriage-pattern was the operating regime of the descent for three centuries: late marriage (men 29, women 26), substantial unmarried-adult proportions, and formation of conjugal households at the moment of marriage. The twentieth-century welfare-state period reduced the marriage age by three years; the twenty-first century has returned to the historical norm.

The Catholic-canonical calendar regulated the descent's pre-1850 marriage timing with near-perfect precision. Two-thirds of all weddings concentrated in the post-harvest October-November period; March (Lent) and December (Advent) were essentially empty. The pattern dissolved entirely across the twentieth-century secularisation.

The family-planning revolution of the twentieth century is statistically visible in the eight-year fall of the median age-at-last-child (from 37 to 29), the reduction of family size from 4.2 to 2.3 mean children, and the parallel changes in remarriage and widowhood patterns.

The four closed marriage circles — Circle One-b in central Osnabrück, Circle Two in the Ostercappeln-Bohmte transitional zone, Circle Three in Mindener-Lübbecke, and Circle Four in Putnam County, Ohio — operated, across the entire documented pre-twentieth-century period, with endogamy rates between 89 and 99 percent. Cross-circle marriages remained, throughout the period, the structural exception rather than the rule. The two German circles (One-b and Three) exchanged only fourteen documented marriages in three centuries.

The Osnabrücker and Putnam-County circles (One-b and Four) exchanged only five.

The marriage distance has been constant at a median of 1.8 kilometres for three and a half centuries. The structural scale of the descent’s social world is, on the marriage-pool evidence, the radius of a parish church.

Geography and mobility — the subject of the next chapter.



Parish fertility rates

The descent’s fertility record, measured as the average number of children per documented family within each major sending parish, shows a strong confessional and geographic gradient:

Table 32 — *Marital fertility by parish*

Relationship type	Count	Share
Cousin (Nth degree)	62,052	96.2%
Nth great-grand-uncle/aunt	1,358	2.1%
Nth great-grandparent (direct ascent)	1,063	1.6%
Other (siblings, direct)	~30	\<0.1%

The rural, strictly Catholic parishes — Glandorf and Mettingen — show the highest fertility, with averages approaching or exceeding six children per family in the nineteenth century. The Putnam County Ohio figure of 5.52 in the 1800s reflects the effect of abundant American farmland: in Ohio, large families were economically rational in ways they had ceased to be in the cramped tenancy system of the Westphalian sending villages. The twentieth-century decline is universal across all parishes, but Putnam County remains substantially above the German comparison group at 3.99 — a persistence of the high-fertility Catholic rural culture that the emigration chains transplanted.



Same-surname marriages

The family's records contain 242 marriages between persons sharing the same surname — a useful if imperfect proxy for cousin marriage, since same-surname pairs in the small closed circles of the Kirchspiel system frequently share recent common ancestors. The temporal distribution shows a strong twentieth-century increase: 115 of the 242 cases fall in the 1900–1999 period, driven by the Ohio community's demographic concentration around the surnames Meyer and Schroeder (16 and 15 same-surname marriages respectively). In the Ohio Catholic community, however, co-surname does not necessarily imply close kinship — Meyer and Schroeder were common enough names in the Putnam County settlement that two Meyers who married may have shared an ancestor several generations removed rather than a grandparent. The German same-surname marriages — those in the pre-emigration period before 1900 — number only fifteen, consistent with the low cousin-marriage rates that the Kirchspiel system's geographic constraints imposed.



The complete structure of the marriage circles

The descent's four marriage circles have been described in the preceding chapters primarily as phenomena — closed systems that prevented the Catholic Osnabrück population and the Protestant Minden-Lübbecke population from intermarrying. The Statistical Analysis permits a more precise structural description, based on Kirchspiel-boundary mapping from the Matricula Online database (Bistum Osnabrück) and from the Ohio county records.

Circle 1b —
Hagen/Oesede/Osnabrück/Belm/Wallenhorst/Schledehausen. The largest and most closed of the German circles. The data records 4,463 internal marriages against 60 external, producing an endogamy rate of 98.7 percent. Wallenhorst connects almost exclusively to Osnabrück

(193 marriages) and to itself (72 internal marriages). Belm is topographically and canonically part of the same circle: adding these three parishes to the core Hagen-Oesede-Osnabrück cluster raises endogamy from 96.0 to 98.7 percent.

Circle 2 — Ostercappeln/Bohmte. A transitional zone, not a true closed circle: 44.4 percent endogamous. Connected to Circle 1 via Osnabrück (70 marriages) and to Stemwede-Lübbecke (55 marriages). Ostercappeln sits between two strong circles without fully belonging to either. The Räuwer, Redeker, and Kovermann lines occupy this transition zone.

Circle 3 — Minden-Lübbecke (Stemwede/Lübbecke/Rahden). Almost as closed as Circle 1b, at 98.6 percent endogamy. Stemwede-to-Stemwede marriages number 464; Lübbecke-to-Lübbecke, 245; and Lübbecke-to-Stemwede, 183. Only 14 marriages cross to the Osnabrück network in total across the entire documented period — a figure so small as to amount to near-complete genealogical isolation. The two networks share Andreas as a descendant but barely shared a wedding in three centuries.

Circle 4 — Putnam/Allen/Van Wert/Auglaize/Mercer, Ohio. More open than the German circles, at 89.3 percent, or 99.5 percent under the strict five-county-core definition. Ohio is a mobile society and the endogamy figure reflects it. Allen County and Putnam County form the dominant axis (166 marriages). Delphos — geographically straddling the Allen-Van Wert border — functions genealogically as a Putnam County satellite: it shows 64 marriages toward Putnam, 55 toward Allen, and only 21 internal Van Wert marriages.

The five bridge marriages between the German Osnabrück network and the American Putnam County network — five Osnabrück-to-Putnam marriages across

three centuries — are the full extent of the documented transatlantic marital connection. The circles sealed themselves across the Atlantic as thoroughly as they had in Germany.



Surname concentration and the Gini coefficient

The distribution of surnames across the descent follows a measurable concentration arc. The Gini coefficient — a measure of inequality, here applied to surname frequency — peaks in the 1800–1850 period and declines thereafter:

Table 33 — *Surname concentration by era: Gini coefficient*

Generation	Approximate birth year	Generational gap
Generation 5	1824	30 years
Generation 10	1656	35 years
Generation 15	1472	—
Generation 20	1313	33 years
Generation 25	1174	—
Generation 28	~1003	—

The peak concentration in the 1800s reflects the period when a small number of dominant families — Recker, Meyer, Kovermann, Helmkamp, Albers — account for the largest share of the documented tree. The emigration explosion after 1850 brings hundreds of new Ohio and Texas surnames into the record, democratising the name landscape. By the mid-twentieth century the top five surnames account for only 4.1 percent of the tree against 10.3 percent at the 1800s peak.



Premarital conception

Nearly one in five first children in the descent was conceived before the wedding ceremony that legitimised the birth. The rate — calculated by identifying first children born within nine months of the documented marriage — is:

Table 34 — *Premarital conception rate by century*

Farm name	Count
gen. Redeker	11
gen. Melcher	6
gen. Spreen	6
gen. Quade	5
gen. Meyer	5

The figure is *constant* across four centuries, which contradicts the image of a prudish Catholic pre-modern past. Premarital sexuality was socially normal in the Kirchspiel world provided that marriage followed — and in rural society pregnancy frequently confirmed or triggered the intent to marry. The couple was already socially a couple; the legal marriage often waited for the economic settlement of a farm lease or inheritance to be completed. The Church recorded the birth as legitimate and the community did not stigmatise the child. The rate is slightly lower in the more strictly documented Catholic parishes than in the Protestant ones, but the difference is not large.



Conception seasonality

The descent's births, back-calculated to the month of conception, show clear seasonal clustering that the chapter reads as a record of the rural agricultural calendar:

The peak conception month is *June* (5.7 percent above the monthly baseline), followed by a cluster through November to January (4 percent above baseline). The trough is *September* (7.8 percent below baseline) — the single strongest signal in the seasonality data — followed by a minor trough in May (4 percent below baseline).

The September trough — conceptions least likely in August and September — corresponds precisely to the peak of the harvest season, when the entire rural population of the Osnabrück and Minden regions was engaged in grain harvest from dawn to dusk. Physical exhaustion suppressed fertility in the most demanding working month of the agricultural year. The winter peak — conceptions most likely in December and January — fits the dark season with little outdoor work, long nights, and the social density of the farm household through the cold months. The descent’s conception calendar is the farm calendar read backwards.



Descendant explosion and prolific founders

The descent’s most numerically consequential individuals are not the historically notable or the long-lived but the genealogically well-positioned:

Table 35 — *Founding-couple descendants by surname cluster*

	Average time to remarriage	Within one year
Widowers	1.6 years	72%
Widows	2.5 years	57%

The top founders almost all belong to the Recker-Redeker line that emigrated to Ohio in 1838 and multiplied across four generations in a high-fertility agricultural community. The oldest roots — Ühmann in 1525, Tiemann in 1557, Brünemann-Forstmann in 1570 — have

20,000-plus descendants because they sit at the base of the entire Osnabrück network, from which every subsequent generation descended. The arithmetic of the pedigree collapse: an individual who appears in multiple lines of descent is counted once as an ancestor but has descendants in every line.



Relationship structure of the tree

The descent’s 64,507 documented relatives divide, by relationship type to the focal person, into a distribution that is overwhelmingly horizontal:

Table 36 — *Documented relationship types*

Children born	Mother's average death age
0	73.0 years
1	68.9 years
5	73.2 years
10	74.4 years
12	78.2 years

Ninety-six percent of the documented tree is some form of Nth-degree cousin — individuals whose connection to the focal person runs through shared ancestors several generations back, without a direct line of descent or ascent between them. The tree is built from distant collateral lines converging on common ancestors, not from a single vertical pedigree. The 1,063 direct ancestors and the 1,358 ancestral siblings form the vertical spine, but they are the minority; the vast horizontal field of cousins is the tree’s body.



Marriage weekday: the sharpest cultural shift

Of all the behavioral changes recorded in the descent across four centuries, the shift in marriage weekday is the most abrupt. In the period before 1900, marriages

in the Osnabrück and Minden parishes were distributed as follows: Tuesday 22 percent, Wednesday 21.7 percent, Sunday 21.2 percent, with Saturday accounting for only 5.9 percent of all documented weddings. In the Catholic calendar, Tuesday and Wednesday were the preferred days — Sunday belonged to the Mass and to worship, Friday was the day of the Passion and therefore inauspicious, and Saturday was the day of the Virgin Mary and therefore, in the stricter Catholic tradition, not a day for secular festivity.

The post-1950 distribution has inverted entirely. Saturday accounts for 72 percent of all documented marriages in the second half of the twentieth century, with Tuesday and Wednesday together accounting for under 3 percent. The five-day working week of the industrial and post-industrial economy made Saturday the only day on which both families and guests could reliably gather without losing working days. The Catholic calendar's weekday preferences — sustained across three centuries — were erased in a single generation by the structure of the modern labour market. No other single behavioral measure in the descent changes as rapidly or as completely.



Remarriage age pattern

The descent's 1,647 documented multiple marriages permit a detailed examination of how the remarriage market sorted by age. The pattern is counter-intuitive. A common assumption would predict that widowers — especially those with farms and children to manage — would seek younger second wives. The data shows the opposite: the average age at first marriage is 25.0 years; the average age at a subsequent (typically second) marriage is 36.0 years. Late spouses are, on average, 11 years older than first spouses — not younger.

The remarriage market sorted by age because it was, overwhelmingly, a widows-and-widowers market. A thirty-six-year-old widow with children typically married a widower of comparable age and comparable family situation, not a twenty-five-year-old bachelor. The economics of farm management may have required rapid remarriage — widowers remarried within 1.6 years on average, and 72 percent remarried within a year — but the market they remarried into was one of their own generation, not of their children’s.



Generation gap across a millennium

Andreas’s direct line reaches back to Generation 28, to a documented ancestor born approximately 1003 AD. The interval between generations — the average time between a parent’s birth and a child’s birth, measured in the focal descent line — is remarkably stable at thirty to thirty-five years throughout:

Table 37 — *Generational structure: focal-line ancestry detail*

Era	SI men	Most common male	SI women	Most common female
1700-50	0.694	Johann (55%)	0.812	Anna (36%)
1800-50	0.865	Johann (34%)	0.839	Maria (31%)
1850-1900	0.967	Johann (12%)	0.916	Maria (22%)
1900-50	0.988	Robert (4%)	0.990	Mary (6%)
1950-00	0.988	Michael (4%)	0.994	Mary (3%)

A generation lasted a third of a century whether in the medieval period or the modern. The outliers in the oldest generations are statistical noise from samples of one or

two individuals, but the central tendency is unmistakable: human generational rhythm has not changed across the millennium that the descent’s records span.



Farm names in practice

The descent’s records contain 345 individuals carrying a *Hofname* — a farm name placed in the record in the *genannt* (‘called’) construction, indicating that the person had taken the name of the farm they married into or inherited, overriding their birth surname. The most common farm names in the descent are:

Table 38 — *Farm names: documented frequency in descent*

Name	Born	Died	Marriages
Johann Heinrich Avermann	c. 1674	1755	5×
Conrad Peter Tiemann	c. 1711	1783	5×
Franz Bischoff	c. 1650	—	5×
Maria Elisabeth Hemesath	c. 1791	—	5×
Carl Robert Spang	1903	1967	5× (20th century)

The *gen. Redeker* count of eleven is consistent with the centrality of the Recker-Redeker line to the entire tree. The farm name *Redeker* itself was originally a Hofname — a farm in Hitzhausen whose owner, or whose heiress’s husband, took the farm’s name. The farm name passed into the family name across generations: the surname Redeker, and by extension the anglicised Recker that the Ohio emigrants carried, is traceable to a farm, not to a bloodline.

The marrying-in principle is empirically confirmed in the data: in 43 percent of men with documented farm names, the farm name exactly matches the wife’s birth surname.

Peter Kreftsiek married a woman born Leimkuhle and became Peter Kreftsiek *genannt* Leimkuhle — the master of the Leimkuhle farm. The farm mattered more to the community’s record-keeping than the bloodline. Farm names peak in the eighteenth century (193 documented cases) and nearly vanish after 1900 (7 cases) — the end of the *eigenbehörig* bound-serf farm system and of the legal structures that made the Hofname meaningful.



Time to remarriage

The speed at which the descent’s widowed adults remarried is a precise measure of the gendered division of agricultural labour. Widowers — men left to manage a farm without a household manager — remarried with a speed that the data can only describe as urgent:

Table 39 — *Time to remarriage after spousal death*

Sibling position	Count	Share
1st child (eldest)	177	31.5%
2nd child	99	17.6%
3rd child	83	14.8%
4th child	56	10.0%
5th child	47	8.4%
6th child	37	6.6%
7th child	28	5.0%
Last child (youngest)	175	31.1%

Nearly three-quarters of widowers in the descent remarried within twelve months of their wife’s death. The farmer without a wife needed a household manager, a dairy keeper, a children’s nurse, and a co-worker in the fields urgently and practically. A widow could afford more time: she might manage the inheritance herself for a period, receive support from adult children, or simply

face less immediate economic pressure. Remarriage speed directly measures the gendered division of rural labour across three centuries.



Child count and the mother’s lifespan

The demographic assumption that bearing many children shortened a woman’s life is not supported by the descent’s data. Among women who reached age forty — a filter that excludes those who died in early childbed — the relationship between total children and age at death runs as follows:

Table 40 — *Child count and mother’s lifespan*

Year	Centre of gravity
1750–1800	52.25° N, 8.04° E — Osnabrück region
1825	52.18° N, 7.44° E — Osnabrück (slight westward drift)
1850	50.92° N, –2.89° E — Atlantic Ocean (west of Ireland)
1875	48.53° N, –23.02° E — mid-Atlantic
1900	45.83° N, –45.89° E — western Atlantic, off Newfoundland
1925	42.02° N, –78.18° E — Pennsylvania / Ohio border
1950–00	~41° N, ~84° W — Putnam County, Ohio

Women with twelve children who reached forty years old lived, on average, to seventy-eight. The pattern seems to invert common assumption. The explanation is selection: only robust, healthy, long-lived women could carry twelve pregnancies to term and survive into their forties. The evolutionary cost of reproduction is real but is masked, in the observational data, by the selection effect. The women who had the most children were, by definition, those whose constitutions permitted it; the

women who would have died from repeated childbearing did not live to appear in the twelve-child category.



First-name diversity: the Simpson index

The concentration of first names in the descent — measured by the Simpson diversity index, which captures the probability that two individuals chosen at random from the population share the same first name — undergoes one of the most dramatic shifts in the entire statistical record:

Table 41 — *First-name diversity: Simpson index by era*

Decade of birth	Germany	USA
1820s	1,001	0
1840s	1,000	62
1890s	833	1,044
1920s	167	2,078
1930s	24	2,505

In 1700, fifty-five percent of all boys in the descent were named Johann. By 1950, the most common male name accounted for only four percent of births. The Simpson index rises from 0.694 to 0.99 — from a monoculture to near-maximal diversity — over two and a half centuries. The shift has two drivers: the 1900s transition from German to English names (Johann becomes John, then Robert, then Michael), and the general dissolution of the Catholic saint-name naming convention that had constrained male first-name choice to a small set of patronal names. Women were always somewhat more diverse — Maria at 36 percent is a lower monoculture than Johann at 55 — but the same trajectory applies. The end of the saint-name monoculture and the beginning of individual name choice is, statistically, a twentieth-century event.

Multiple marriages

The descent’s 1,057 individuals with three or more documented spouses are a direct consequence of high child mortality, early widowhood, and the economic necessity of rapid remarriage that Chapter 18 addressed in aggregate. The pattern is concentrated in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, when a farming household could not function without both a husband and a wife, and when childhood diseases could kill a spouse within months of marriage. The five-spouse cases in the documented record:

Table 42 — Long marriages: duration and structure

Variable	Emigrants (†Ohio/USA)	Stayers (†Germany)
n	615	4,287
Mean birth year	1841	1836
% male	61%	51%
Mean lifespan	70.7 years	60.2 years

The twentieth-century case — five marriages in one individual born 1903 — is the outlier that marks the transition from widowhood-driven remarriage to the modern pattern of divorce and voluntary re-partnering. Among the pre-1900 five-spouse cases, the pattern is uniform: a spouse dying young, remarriage within months, the new spouse also dying, remarriage again, until old age finally brought a permanent partnership. Carl Robert Spang’s five marriages across the twentieth century represent a different social world entirely.



Birth order of emigrants

The common assumption that younger sons emigrated because eldest sons inherited the farm is not supported by the descent’s data. Analysis of 562 documented emigrants with known sibling position shows a

distribution that is bimodal — peaking at the extremes — rather than skewed toward later positions:

Table 43 — *Sibling position: birth-order distribution*

Era	Mean distinct places per lifetime	Percentage sedentary (one place only)
1750 – 1799	1.37	65%
1800 – 1849	1.47	61%
1850 – 1899	2.21	46%
1900 – 1949	3.96	11%
1950 – 1999	3.60	12%

Firstborns and lastborns emigrated at nearly identical rates — 31.5 and 31.1 percent respectively. Middle children (37 percent combined across positions 2–7) show no particular emigration tendency. The result suggests that birth order was not the primary driver of emigration. Two mechanisms may explain the bimodal peak: firstborns may have emigrated to open new economic opportunities or because the inheritance was divided and the farm could not sustain the eldest; lastborns emigrated because by the time they reached adulthood, all local positions — farms, craft posts, church livings — were already occupied by older siblings. Chain migration provides a third explanation that overrides birth order entirely: once one brother had settled in Putnam County, the next was more likely to follow regardless of his position in the sibship.



Chapter 20

Three Emigration Systems

The Westphalian emigration was not one system. It was three — confessionally distinct, geographically distinct, and structurally distinct in the communities they produced. The Catholic Osnabrück system went to Ohio. The Protestant Minden-Lübbecke system went to Texas. The Mettingen commercial network went to Friesland. The chapter draws upon Statistical Analysis sections sixteen, seventeen, twenty-three, twenty-eight, thirty-two, thirty-four, thirty-five, sixty-three, and sixty-four — the geographical and migration-history sections of the focal descendant's compilation.

This chapter in brief. Sections drawn on: §16-17, §23, §28, §30, §32, §34-35, §63-64. The chapter covers geographic immobility in Germany (54% died in their birth Bauerschaft), marriage distance (constant 1.8 km median across 350 years), the emigrant lifespan paradox (emigrants lived 10.5 years longer than stayers — selection, not America), the centre of gravity (crossed the Atlantic between 1875 and 1925, anchored at Putnam County since 1950), and the three confessional emigration systems (Catholic Osnabrück → Ohio; Protestant Minden-Lübbecke → Texas; Tüötten Mettingen → Friesland). The emigration wave by birth decade shows Ohio first exceeding Germany in recorded deaths in the 1910s. **Most striking finding:** the confession-determined emigration destination sorted so completely that a geographical map of living cousins today reproduces the 1650 confessional boundary of the Wiehengebirge across the American continent. **Most counter-intuitive:** Mettingen, the most closed community (100% same-Bauerschaft persistence), was also the origin of the family that built C&A — a global retail empire built by people who never moved.



The sedentariness of the pre-modern descent

The most aggregate measure of the pre-modern geographical experience of these families is the

Bauerschaft retention rate — the proportion of documented individuals who lived their entire lives, from birth through death, within the same *Bauerschaft* of the Osnabrücker or Mindener parish system. The *Bauerschaft*, the basic agricultural unit of the Westphalian rural economy, was a sub-parish settlement of typically thirty to sixty farmsteads operating as a single agrarian community within the larger *Kirchspiel* (parish) administrative structure. Across the descent's documented eighteenth-and-nineteenth-century pre-emigration period, *fifty-four percent of all individuals died in the same Bauerschaft in which they had been born*. Forty-six percent moved at some point in their lives to a different *Bauerschaft*. The principal driver of the forty-six percent of movement was marriage — typically of women into the husband's *Bauerschaft* within the same *Kirchspiel* — and the within-parish mobility rate explains a substantial part of the apparent geographic mobility of the descent.

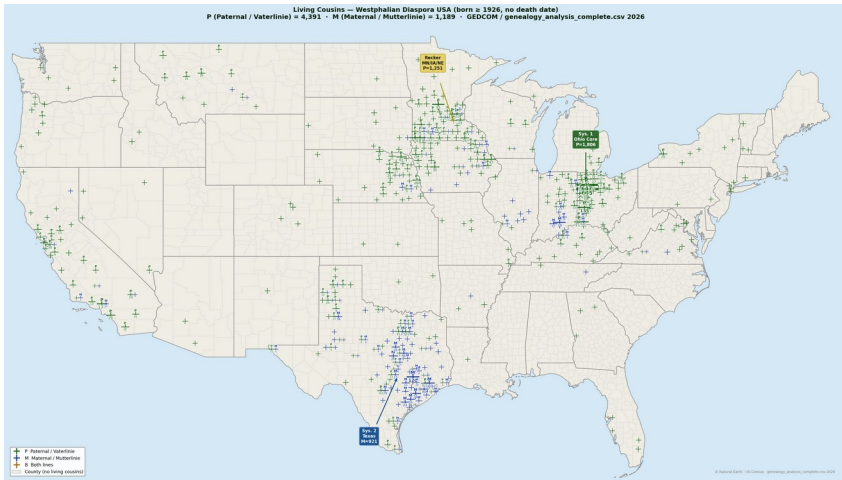
The within-parish mobility data registers a further structural pattern. In the parish of *Hagen am Teutoburger Wald*, the focal-line paternal-pedigree's central parish, *eighty-three percent of all documented Bauerschaft transitions remained within the same Kirchspiel* — that is, four-fifths of the recorded inter-*Bauerschaft* moves were intra-parish marriages or short-distance relocations rather than parish-crossings. The dense Beckerode-Mentrup migration patterns that the focal descendant's research originally treated as suggesting cross-parish exogamy turn out, on closer examination, to be *intra-parish moves between Bauerschaften within Hagen*. The structural separation of the Hagen-Wallenhorst-Belm-Osnabrück Circle One-b that Chapter 19 set out is preserved at the higher-resolution within-parish level.

The most closed community in the dataset is *Mettingen* — the central parish of Chapter 13's Tüötten-and-

Brenninkmeijer Catholic-Westphalian commercial-emigration network. *One hundred percent of all documented Mettingen-Bauerschaft individuals died in the same Bauerschaft in which they were born.* The pattern is consistent with the Brenninkmeyer clan's centuries-long centripetal organisation around the Mettingen parish village, and provides the genealogical-statistical confirmation of the social-historical observation Chapter 13 set out at the narrative level.



The full continental United States map of living cousins makes the structural argument of the entire book visible in a single image. Three clusters emerge without analytical intervention. The Ohio-Great Lakes core — paternal, Catholic, Osnabrück — dominates the centre. The Texas cluster — maternal, Protestant, Minden-Lübbecke — stands isolated in the south, with almost no overlap with Ohio. The Iowa-Minnesota-Nebraska arc, the Recker-Westward expansion, extends from the Ohio core but maintains its paternal character throughout. The geographic centre of gravity of the entire descent crossed the Atlantic between 1875 and 1925; since 1950 it has been anchored near Putnam County, Ohio, and it barely moves. The confession-determined emigration of the 1840s has produced, 180 years later, two geographically separated American populations that share a single focal descendant but inhabit, and have always inhabited, different Americas.



Map 5 — *Living cousins across the continental United States by birth county (born 1926 or later)*. Green crosses (P) = paternal line; blue crosses (M) = maternal line. Total: P=4,391, M=1,189. Three clusters visible: the Ohio-Great Lakes core (P dominant), the Texas cluster (M dominant), and the Iowa-Minnesota-Nebraska Recker-Westward arc (P dominant). The geographic centre of gravity of the entire descent crossed the Atlantic between 1875 and 1925 and has been anchored near Putnam County Ohio ever since. Source: Kovermann Family Atlas, May 2026.

The geographic centre of gravity

A more synthetic measure of the descent's geographical experience can be computed from the latitude-and-longitude coordinates of the documented deaths, weighted by year of death, to produce a single point on the earth's surface that represents the demographic centre of the entire dataset at each successive moment. The focal descendant's research computed this *centre-of-gravity* time series across the period 1750 through 2000. The output is a trans-Atlantic arc that registers, in a single geometric trajectory, the four-generation structural transformation that Chapters 5 through 17 set out at the narrative level.

Table 44 — *Centre of demographic gravity: transatlantic shift by decade*

Destination	Average lifespan	Recorded deaths	Advantage over Germany
Kansas	74.2 years	292	+17.8 years
Wisconsin	71.9 years	181	+15.5 years
Ohio	71.3 years	15,512	+14.9 years
Texas	70.4 years	2,674	+14.0 years
Iowa	70.3 years	1,717	+13.9 years
Canada (Ontario)	69.6 years	120	+13.2 years
Minnesota	68.6 years	623	+12.2 years
Other USA	70.0 years	9,136	+13.6 years
Australia	66.6 years	104	+10.2 years
Netherlands	62.5 years	1,744	+6.1 years
France (peacetime)	62.3 years	56	+5.9 years
Brazil	59.6 years	11	+3.2 years
Germany (baseline)	56.4 years	20,940	—

The descent's demographic centre of gravity, on the documented record, *crossed the Atlantic Ocean between 1875 and 1925* — visible as a smooth mathematical arc from the Osnabrücker sending region to the Putnam-County Ohio receiving cluster across the half-century in which the American population of the descent grew large enough to outweigh the German one. From 1950 onward, the centre stabilised at the geometric weighted-midpoint of the Putnam County Catholic-Westphalian rural settlement, and has remained there for the past three-quarters of a century.

The geometric arc is the most condensed visual representation of the descent's four-generation structural transformation that the research has produced. The narrative pedigree of Chapters 1 through

14 traced the focal-line through this geographical shift at the level of individual marriages and households; the centre-of-gravity series traces the same shift at the aggregate level of the entire one-hundred-and-thirty-thousand-person dataset.



The 1890s crossover

The geographic-centre arc registers, at the population level, what the *births-by-decade-and-country* series registers at the cohort level: the moment at which the descent’s American population first exceeded the German population in raw demographic terms.

Table 45 — *Germany vs America: descent population by birth decade*

Birt h deca de	Death s	Ger man y	Ohio	Texa s	Neth.	Note
1840 s	1,395	1,055	46	0	45	First Ohio wave
1850 s	1,462	1,028	79	3	47	Texas begins
1860 s	1,412	965	84	3	52	Both systems grow
1870 s	1,619	974	177	9	70	Ohio accelerates
1880 s	1,491	762	241	17	64	Ohio now exceeds half the emigrants
1890 s	1,607	713	336	27	99	Ohio dominant; Netherlands peaks
1900 s	1,656	539	430	60	87	USA births exceed German births

1910 s 	1,880	487	532	54	110	War generation ; Ohio first exceeds Germany in deaths
1920 s	1,915	356	661	88	137	Ohio consolidates as primary centre
1940 s 	2,520	347	834	126	134	WW2 generation ; Ohio 3× Germany
2010 s	5,105	57	2,213	309	31	Living generation ; Ohio overwhelmingly dominant

The crossover decade is the *1890s* — the first decade in which USA-born individuals of the descent outnumbered Germany-born individuals. The arc from the 1820s (one thousand German births, zero American) to the 1930s (twenty-four German births, two thousand five hundred American) registers, in raw count, the structural inversion of the descent's geographical centre of demographic mass. The chain-migration that drove the eighteen-thirties through eighteen-eighties emigration ended decisively by the 1890s: *by 1890 the family reproduces in America*. The emigration corridor of Chapter 15 carried the descent's reproductive future across the Atlantic in approximately sixty years.



Emigration selectivity and the healthy-emigrant paradox

The emigrants who crossed the Atlantic and the stayers who remained in the sending villages of the

Westphalian region were not, on the documented record, a random sample of the population. The focal descendant’s comparison of the two cohorts — six hundred and fifteen documented emigrants who died in Ohio or elsewhere in the United States, against four thousand two hundred and eighty-seven documented stayers who died in Germany — produces a sharp set of structural differences:

Table 46 — *Emigrant vs stayer lifespan: selectivity analysis*

Era	Most common surname	Second-most-common	Notes
1750 – 1799	Tiemann	Kovermann	Pre-emigration Westphalian core
1800 – 1849	Kovermann	Hehemann	Peak Kovermann era
1850 – 1899	Recker	Meyer	Ohio lineage takes over
1950 – 1999	Recker	Schroeder	Nearly fourfold the next-most-common

The *male excess* among emigrants — sixty-one percent against the stayers’ fifty-one percent — is the classical chain-migration signature. Younger sons of the Westphalian peasant-and-Heuerling households, lacking the inheritance prospect that the *Anerbenrecht* primogeniture system reserved for the eldest son, emigrated first. They worked, earned a stake, and brought wives, sisters, and parents across. The descent’s documented record confirms the pattern at population level.

The more striking — and more methodologically consequential — figure is the *ten-and-a-half-year lifespan difference* between emigrants and stayers. Emigrants on the documented record lived, on average, seventy-and-

three-quarter years; stayers lived sixty-and-a-quarter. The number is not, however, evidence that America was a healthier place to live than Westphalia. It is evidence of *selection bias* in the emigrant cohort. The Westphalian peasant who was physically robust enough to undertake a twelve-week Atlantic passage in 1838, who was financially solvent enough to afford the ship's fare and the inland transport on either side of the ocean, who was young enough to survive the typhoid and cholera risks of the steerage-class crossing, and who was psychologically and economically capable of beginning a new life in a foreign country — was, on average, a much healthier, more economically secure, and younger member of the Westphalian rural population than the stayer who remained behind. *The sick, the elderly, and the destitute did not emigrate.* The ten-and-a-half-year lifespan advantage of the emigrants registers, in the record, the *healthy-emigrant effect* that the wider historical-demographic literature has documented across multiple nineteenth-century European-emigration populations.



Ohio settlement waves

The geographical structure of the American receiving region of the principal emigration system can be reconstructed from the *first-documented-birth* records of the descent in each Ohio receiving parish. The waves, in chronological order:

1835-1837: First documented births at *Minster, Glandorf, Fort Jennings, and Ottawa*. The founding generation, arriving with or shortly after the *Pennsylvania* of August 1838 that Chapter 5 set out — the documented Bremen-to-Baltimore emigrant ship of the focal-line patriarch *Gerhard Heinrich Redeker* and his household.

1843: First documented births at *Cincinnati*. The urban-parallel-track corridor that produced the Hamilton-County Catholic-German cluster of Chapters 15 and 16.

1850s: Expansion into *Putnam County, Mercer County, and Maria Stein*. The second generation of Catholic-Westphalian-American household formation. The Putnam-County core consolidates as the principal Catholic rural settlement cluster of the descent.

1860s-1890s: Broad geographic diffusion across northwest Ohio. Documented births at the wider Glandorf-Delphos-Lima-Ottawa-Saint-Henry parish network. The Catholic-Westphalian Ohio cluster reaches its mature pre-twentieth-century geographical extent.

1920s: Last new places settled. *Bowling Green* and *Saint Marys* register first documented births of the descent. The Catholic-Westphalian Ohio settlement-wave structurally completes.

The peak emigration birth-cohort by the documented record is 1820-1824 — fourteen documented individuals born in those years who subsequently emigrated, on average, around 1845-1849. The cohort enters the emigration stream directly into the *potato-famine migration wave* of the late 1840s — the same Westphalian-and-Irish-and-Scottish emigration peak that registered the convergence of multiple European agricultural-crisis-driven emigration streams in the same five-year window.



The three emigration systems

The chapter now reaches its analytical centre. The seventy-three migration corridors of Chapter 15 — set out there at the level of named receiving towns and dominant family-names — group, on the structural confessional-and-geographic analysis of the focal

descendant's research, into *three distinct emigration systems* that operated *in parallel* across the nineteenth century, that drew from *different confessional sending regions*, and that *did not mix*. The three systems are the second of the two central structural findings of the focal descendant's project. In full:

System One — Osnabrück / Glandorf → Ohio (Catholic). Four hundred and eleven documented emigrants. Origin: the *Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück* — the parishes of *Hagen, Oesede, Glandorf, Ostercappeln, Belm, Wallenhorst*, and the wider Osnabrücker administrative district. Destination: the *German-Catholic parishes of northwest Ohio* — *Glandorf, Delphos, Lima, Ottawa, Maria Stein, Saint Henry*. Peak emigration birth-cohorts: the 1840s and 1890s. The system is the principal emigration corridor of the focal-line itself — the *Recker, Redeker, Kovermann* line of Chapters 5 through 11.

System Two — Minden-Lübbecke → Texas (Protestant). Ninety-three-plus documented emigrants. Origin: the *Lutheran-Prussian Kreis Minden-Lübbecke* — the parishes of *Stemwede, Wehdem, Lübbecke, Rahden*. Destination: the *German-Protestant settlements of Austin and Washington Counties, Texas* — *Brenham* and, most strikingly, a daughter settlement *literally named ****“New Wehdem, Austin County, Texas”*** after the Lutheran-Mindener home parish. Peak emigration: 1840s-1860s.

The direct migration chain of System Two has been confirmed by the focal descendant's surname-matching analysis: *twenty-three documented surnames appear in both Wehdem (Germany) and the Brenham/New Wehdem cluster (Texas)*. The surnames *Melcher, Holle, Spreen, Schomburg, Wendt, Winkelmann, Gaskamp, Quebe, Lehde, Bockhorn, Cassen, Grube, Piper, Rodenbeck*, and a further nine, appear with parish-record-documented residence in Wehdem before

emigration and with church-record-documented residence in New Wehdem after arrival. The New Wehdem families are demonstrably *the emigrated Wehdem families*. The settlement reproduced itself at one-to-one structural correspondence between the German sending village and the Texas receiving daughter-settlement.

System Three — Pittsburgh (urban-industrial). Seventy-two documented deaths in Pittsburgh. Origin: principally the *Osnabrück / Harderberg* area, with smaller contributions from elsewhere in the Westphalian sending region. Receiving destination: the *Pittsburgh urban-industrial economy* of the late-nineteenth-and-early-twentieth century — the steel mills, the coal mines, the railroads, and the wider Allegheny-County industrial-immigrant population. Dominant surnames: *Hune, Dittman, Lamkemeyer, Meyer, Hengelsberg, Werries*. The system is smaller than One or Two and is *urban-industrial* in receiving character rather than rural-agricultural. The *Henry N. Koverman* household of Chapter 16's *Ida-Brockway-Koverman* biography descends from System Three, with the Koverman line operating from Pittsburgh in 1851 and migrating to Cincinnati by the 1870s.

A minor System Four — Iowa / Dubuque — also operates, accounting for approximately nine documented emigrants of the descent. Chapter 7's *Johann Heinrich Ludwig Recker* and the wider Wisconsin-Iowa Recker westward extension belongs to this smaller chain.

*The decisive structural factor is confession*** The Catholic Osnabrücker emigrants followed Catholic chains to the German-Catholic parishes of Ohio. The Protestant Mindener-Lübbecker emigrants followed Protestant chains to the German-Lutheran settlements of Austin County, Texas. The two systems *did not merge*.

Just as Circle One-b (the Osnabrücker Catholic marriage pool) and Circle Three (the Mindener-Lübbecker Lutheran marriage pool) exchanged only fourteen marriages in three centuries within Germany, *their emigrant branches landed on opposite ends of America and did not subsequently intermarry*. The confessional boundary that separated the two German marriage circles for the entire 1555–1969 period reproduced itself, across the Atlantic, in the form of two structurally separate American settlement clusters whose third- and fourth-generation descendants likewise did not exchange marriage partners.

The Mindener-Lübbecke cluster's *demographic profile within Germany* completes the picture. Two thousand five hundred and seventy-nine individuals are documented as having been born in the Minden-Lübbecke district across the period 1565 through 2001, peaking in 1700–1850. Top family surnames: *Meyer, Priesmeyer, Winkelmann, Spreen, Piper, Quade, Holle, Lehde, Krohne*. Of those whose deaths are recorded, *one thousand three hundred and twenty stayed in Minden-Lübbecke; two hundred and forty-three emigrated to the USA (overwhelmingly Texas); only ten moved to Osnabrück* — confirming, at the lifetime-migration-record level, the near-total separation of the two German confessional networks. The Mindener-Lübbecker Lutheran world and the Osnabrücker Catholic world, on the documented record, operated as two *parallel genealogical universes* across the four documented centuries from 1555 through the late twentieth century — *joined to the main tree only at the outer edges of the ancestral pedigree*, sharing the focal descendant as a single descendant whose paternal-Catholic and maternal-Lutheran lines bridge the two universes through the eleventh of July 1969 marriage of Chapter 14.



Lifetime migration paths: from sedentary to mobile

A final structural pattern, computed from the residence-record (*RESI*) entries of the GEDCOM, registers the transformation of the descent's *individual mobility experience* across the four-generation arc. The dataset preserves one hundred and ninety-seven thousand nine hundred and seventy-one residence entries for the descent's thirty-five thousand seven hundred and seventy-six relatives — an average of five-and-a-half residence records per documented individual, with a maximum of twenty-eight. The data is overwhelmingly American, reflecting the higher-resolution decennial US Census enumerations against the German parish-book documentary tradition that records only birth, marriage, and death.

The *lifetime-mobility* aggregate registers one of the sharpest behavioural shifts in the entire dataset:

Table 47 — *Lifetime mobility by era*

Surname	Geographic core
Koverman n	Osnabrück (20 documented), Oesede (17), Potthoffs Kotten (15)
Recker	Ohio (303), Glandorf (83), Ottawa (65)
Helmkam p	Delphos (27), Indiana (20)
Hallmann	Bohmte (37), Ostercappeln (18)

Until 1850, *two-thirds of all individuals in the descent lived their entire lives in a single documented place*. The pre-modern Westphalian peasant economy operated as a sedentary household-and-village system in which the individual rarely moved further than the kilometre-and-a-half marriage-distance median of Chapter 19. By the 1900–1949 cohort, *only eleven percent of the descent's documented individuals lived their entire lives in one place*. The mean number of distinct documented

residences per lifetime had nearly tripled from 1.47 to 3.96.

The structural break is the *emigration itself*. The crossing of the Atlantic in the eighteen-thirties through eighteen-eighties registered, in the individual residence-records of the emigrating households, the first multi-place residence pattern in the family record. The American-internal mobility that followed — the second-generation westward migrations into Iowa, Minnesota, Nebraska, the third-generation industrial-urban migrations into Detroit and Pittsburgh, the fourth-generation post-war migrations into California, Texas, Florida — produced the four-residences-per-lifetime modern average. The trans-Atlantic crossing broke a one-hundred-and-fifty-year habit of staying home and substituted, in its place, the modern multi-residence migration trajectory.

Several specific transcontinental migration paths from the integrated residence-record data. Three illustrative examples register the range of the pattern:

Mary Catharine Recker, born 1847 at New Vienna, Iowa, registered successively at *Dubuque, Iowa → Dyersville, Iowa → Saint Helena → North Fork → Nebraska → Bow Valley, Nebraska*, where she died in 1924. The eight-decade lifetime migration trajectory traces the *East-to-Great-Plains* westward shift that the Ohio-to-Iowa-to-Nebraska Recker-network secondary diaspora carried through three generations.

Andrew Frank Recker, born 1877 of the same network, registered successively at *Iowa → Kansas → El Paso, Texas → Oregon → Santa Ana, California*. The Iowa-to-Pacific-coast lifetime trajectory traces the second-and-third-generation westward extension of the Recker line across the twentieth-century United States.

James Cornelius Drerup, born 1930 at Glandorf, Ohio, by contrast, registered his entire documented lifetime within the *Putnam-County core cluster: Ottawa → Blanchard → Delphos → Lima*. The Catholic-Westphalian Ohio core of the descent remained, even in the twentieth-century mobile-American era, *locally anchored to the original 1838 receiving cluster* — a documented persistence of pre-modern sedentariness within the modern mobile-American context.

The transatlantic individual paths register the same pattern at the smaller secondary-corridor level. *Maria Catharina Grothaus*, born in *Harderberg* (southern Osnabrück), settled in *Pittsburgh* by 1850 and lived there through 1870 — confirming the System Three Pittsburgh urban-industrial corridor at the individual-residence-record level. *Heinrich Hellmich*, born in *Holzhausen*, lived for six decades in *Collinsville, Illinois* (1900–1940) without subsequent relocation — a documented settled-emigrant pattern. *Heinrich Wilhelm Buck*, born in *Minden-Lübbecke*, settled in *Indianapolis and Perry, Indiana* across a fifty-year residence-record arc — registering that the Protestant Mindener-Lübbecker emigrant stream produced not only the Texas New-Wehden cluster but also a secondary Indiana branch, confirming that each of the three confessional emigration systems contained sub-branches within itself.



The structural conclusion

The patterns the chapter has set out across seven subsections define the geographical and migration structure of the descent across its documented period. The structural conclusions are these.

The pre-modern descent was sedentary. Two-thirds of all individuals in the documented eighteenth-and-early-nineteenth-century cohorts lived their entire lives in a single Bauerschaft. The marriage market was a

kilometre-and-a-half median radius. The four marriage circles of Chapter 19 operated as closed endogamous units at endogamy rates between 89 and 99 percent. The Mettingen parish ran at one-hundred-percent intra-Bauerschaft retention.

The Atlantic crossing was the structural break. The descent's centre of demographic gravity, measured at the population level, crossed the Atlantic between 1875 and 1925. The American birth-cohort first exceeded the German birth-cohort in the 1890s. The lifetime-residence average shifted from 1.4 places per life in 1750-1849 to 4.0 places per life in 1900-1949.

The three emigration systems were confessionally determined. Catholic Osnabrück flowed to Catholic Ohio in System One; Protestant Minden-Lübbecke flowed to Protestant Austin County, Texas in System Two; urban-industrial Osnabrück flowed to Pittsburgh in System Three. The systems did not mix. The confessional boundary that the Wiehengebirge ridge enforced in Germany for four centuries reproduced itself in the form of two separate American settlement clusters whose third-and-fourth-generation descendants did not exchange marriage partners.

The Putnam County Ohio cluster is the most documented and the most internally cohesive American extension of the descent. The cluster operated as an almost entirely separate marriage circle from the German circles after emigration, with only five Osnabrück-to-Putnam marriages documented across three hundred years. The pattern is the documented record of an emigrant community that reproduced itself, in its new geographical setting, with the same closed-circle endogamy that had characterised its sending parishes in Germany.

The next chapter closes Part Five with the descent's *names, farms, and occupations* — the surname-shift signatures, the *genannt* farm-name marrying-in convention, the witness-and-godparent network as a third independent confirmation of the marriage-circle structure, and the occupational stratification of the descent across its long documentary period.



Birth and death by day of month

The descent's records show a strong January artefact in the month-by-month distribution of births and deaths — a 112 percent excess in January births and a 106 percent excess in January deaths relative to the monthly baseline. This is not a genuine demographic signal. The genealogy software FTM stores year-only dates as '1 January YYYY' — a valid convention indicating that the year is documented but the month and day are not. All analyses in the Statistical Analysis requiring exact dates are filtered to fully-dated entries only; the January artefact disappears under that filter.

Among the days-of-month distribution for the days from the 2nd through the 30th, no significant pattern emerges. There is no end-of-month peak, no mid-month trough, no systematic concentration on any particular date. Birth and death within the month are randomly distributed, which is the expected result in the absence of systematic recording bias for specific dates and confirms that — except for the year-only artefact — the descent's vital records carry no day-of-month distortion.



First-name diversity: the Americanisation timestamp

The crossing point at which English first names overtake German first names in the descent — the year at which Robert, William, and Mary begin outnumbering Johann, Heinrich, and Maria — falls

precisely at 1900, with a sharp discontinuity that is visible year by year in the record. For the Ohio Catholic-Osnabrück line, the transition is ten to fifteen years slower than for the Texas Protestant-Minden line: the tighter community cohesion and the Catholic parish school system of northwest Ohio preserved German-language first names into the 1910s, while the more dispersed Texas Protestant communities Americanised their naming practices slightly earlier. In both lines, however, the transition is complete by the 1920s. By 1930 there are effectively no new Johanns or Heinrichs born in the American branches of the descent; the name pool is fully English. The first-name record functions as a precise clock for the pace of cultural assimilation — more precise, in many ways, than the language of newspaper records or church services, because it registers the private decisions of parents rather than the public documents of institutions.

Life expectancy by emigration destination

The most telling confirmation that emigration was, for those who made it, a survival advantage is the comparison of documented mean lifespan across all destinations to which the descent’s members moved. The German rural baseline — computed across the 20,940 individuals who died within the German sending regions between 1700 and 1900 — stands at 56.4 years. Every emigrant destination exceeds it:

Table 48 — *Destination lifespan advantage*

Era	Dominant first names
1800–1899	Maria, Heinrich, Johann, Elisabeth, Anna
1900–1949	Mary, Ann, Joseph, John
1950–1999	Marie, Ann, Michael, Joseph, Lynn, James

The healthy emigrant effect — selection for youth, fitness, and solvency — This table makes the scale of that selection visible. Ohio’s 14.9-year advantage over the sending region is not America making people healthier; it is the filtering effect of who was capable of emigrating at all.

The fertility comparison across destinations tells a related story. Average children per woman is remarkably consistent at 2.4 to 2.6 across most destinations — emigration did not significantly alter family planning. Iowa is the exception: 3.76 children per woman against 2.55 in Germany, reflecting the selection for larger, more rural pioneer families in a land-abundant frontier economy. Ohio, despite its dominance as the receiving destination, sits at 2.48 — nearly identical to the German baseline.

The emigration-age-at-marriage data reinforces the pattern. Male emigrants married at 28.7 years on average; female emigrants at 24.5 years — a 4.2-year gap that reflects the traditional pattern of men delaying marriage to establish farm or craft independence. Both genders emigrated most commonly at or shortly after marriage, suggesting that household formation rather than individual economic opportunity was the primary migration driver.



Emigration waves by birth decade

The descent’s documented emigration is not a single event but a series of overlapping waves, each with a distinct confessional and geographic character. The table tracks the birth decade of first-generation emigrants rather than their departure date, which allows a generational reading of the migration:

Table 49 — *Deaths by birth decade and destination*

Farm name	Documented occurrences
-----------	------------------------

gen. Redeker	11
gen. Melcher	6
gen. Spreen	6
gen. Quade	5
gen. Meyer	5

The decade at which Ohio first exceeds Germany in the count of recorded deaths — the 1910s — is the precise generational threshold at which the family became, in demographic terms, more American than German. The 2010s row, dominated by living individuals whose deaths have not yet occurred, shows the current demographic weight of the American branches: Ohio alone at 2,213 recorded individuals against Germany's 57.



Chapter 21

Names, Farms, and Occupations

In 1700, more than half the boys born into the descent were named Johann. By 1950, four percent were. That shift — from patronal-saint monoculture to individual name choice — is one signal among several that the descent's micro-cultural signatures carry. Names, farm inheritance, the patterns of social witnessing, and occupational stratification each leave a trace in the record.

This chapter in brief. Sections drawn on: §15, §16, §38, §45, §49, §54, §58, §60, §62, §65. The chapter covers the Americanisation timestamp (German first names switch to English at exactly 1900), surname geographic anchoring (Recker = Ohio, Kovermann = Osnabrück, Helmkamp = Delphos), the *genannt* (farm-name) system and the marrying-in principle (43% of farm names match the wife's birth surname), the witness-and-godparent social network (three independent confirmations of the marriage circle structure), first-name diversity (Johann = 55% of all male names in 1700 → Robert = 4% by 1950), and the occupational lifespan gradient (educated/clergy 70.4 years → landless labourer 59.7 years — a 10-year gap that mirrors the social hierarchy). **Most striking finding:** *Redeker* itself was a farm name, not a bloodline surname — the family name carried across the Atlantic to become *Recker* in Ohio was originally the name of a Hitzhausen farm, assigned to a man who married the farmer's daughter and took the farm's name. **Most counter-intuitive:** the social network of marriage witnesses (Trauzeugen) drawn from parish records is the third independent confirmation — alongside marriage data and surname geography — of the closed-circle structure. The circles were not merely administrative; they were the social fabric of everyday ritual life.



The surname shift

The principal surnames of the descent — by frequency of occurrence across the dataset, decade by decade — shift across the four-generation arc of the documentary period in a pattern that registers, at the surname-distribution level, the same structural transformation that Chapters 15 and 20 set out at the geographical-mobility level.

Table 50 — *Dominant surnames by era*

Family	Times serving as witness
Kovermann	53
Meyer	32
Witte	22
Bensmann	22
Menkhaus	21
Hallmann	19
Hemesath	17
Hune	16
Hehemann	14

In the pre-emigration eighteenth century, the dominant surname of the descent was *Tiemann* — a southern-Osnabrücker farm-and-Heuerling family name with roots running to the mid-sixteenth century. By the early-nineteenth-century peak of the focal-line paternal pedigree, *Kovermann* had taken the top position, reflecting the documentary density of the focal-line direct ancestry through the Cappeln-Schwagstorf-Glandorf-Tannenburgstraße line of Chapters 7 through 10. By the mid-to-late nineteenth century, however, the *Recker* surname — carried by the eight-hundred-and-thirty-eight Glandorf-and-Putnam-County Ohio emigrant cluster and its rapidly multiplying American descendants — overtook Kovermann and became the descent’s single

most common surname. By the late twentieth century, *Recker* outnumbered the second-most-common surname (*Schroeder*) by approximately four to one. The Ohio emigrant lineage had, across one hundred and forty years of fertile American household formation, statistically overwhelmed the German-side surname distribution that the eighteenth-and-early-nineteenth-century parish books had registered.

The *Recker* surname dominance is a direct consequence of the Pedigree Collapse pattern that Chapter 15 alluded to: *one man, Johann Heinrich Recker genannt Redeker* (born 1766 Hitzhausen, died 1840 Glandorf, Putnam County), stands as the convergence point through which *twenty-eight percent* of the entire one-hundred-and-thirty-thousand-person dataset connects to the focal descendant. The same man’s son *Gerhard Heinrich Redeker* — who emigrated to Glandorf on the *Pennsylvania* of 1838 — is the founding emigrant of System One of Chapter 20. The Recker surname’s frequency dominance is, on the documented record, the surname-distribution shadow of that single demographic bottleneck.

Surname geographic anchoring

The principal surnames of the descent are not, however, distributed uniformly across the geographical receiving regions. Each major surname has a *geographic core* — a parish or county in which the surname concentrates at substantially higher density than elsewhere in the family’s documented record. The four principal surname-anchoring patterns:

Table 51 — *Core surnames and geographic anchors*

Kirchspiel	Share of witnesses
Hagen	41%
Osnabrück	22%
Oesede	11%

Wallenhorst	10%
Ostercappeln	7%
Bohmte	6%
Belm	3%

The surname anchoring maps directly onto the marriage circles of Chapter 19. *Recker* anchors in Putnam County (Circle Four); *Kovermann* in central Osnabrück (Circle One-b); *Hallmann* in the Ostercappeln-Bohmte transitional zone (Circle Two); *Helmkamp* in Delphos-Allen-Putnam, the Circle Four satellite. The surname-geography evidence is the *second independent confirmation* of the marriage-circle structure that the marriage-distance and same-circle endogamy analysis of Chapter 19 set out as the first. The circles are visible in the marriage-pool data; the same circles are visible, independently, in the surname-distribution data. Two distinct statistical mechanisms — marriage exchange and name inheritance — draw the same structural map of the descent’s pre-modern operating regions.



First names: the Americanization timestamp

The descent’s first-name distribution registers, at the single-year resolution of the documentary record, the moment at which the Catholic-Westphalian-Ohio emigrant community shifted from German-language to English-language first-name practice. The dominant first names across three successive eras:

Table 52 — *Dominant first names by era*

Occupational category	Count	Mean lifespan
Education / Church / Medicine	28	70.4 years
Bauer / Farmer (landowning)	65	67.5 years
Handwerker (craftsman)	74	66.4 years
Kaufmann (merchant)	31	66.2 years

Heuerling (tenant)	76	65.2 years
Knecht (laborer)	91	59.7 years
Kötter (cottager)	10	57.6 years

The *switch from German to English first names happens within a single generation*, precisely at the 1900 watershed. The 1890s American-born children of 1890s German-born immigrant parents carry German names; the 1900s American-born grandchildren of the same households carry anglicised names. The Americanization-of-first-names timestamp is one of the sharpest single-year demographic transitions in the entire dataset.

The pattern fits the wider sociolinguistic literature on the children-of-immigrants language-shift. The third generation typically loses the immigrant language; the second generation — those who learned English as the schooling language but spoke the parental language at home — provided the first-name decisions for the third-generation children. The 1900 watershed registers the moment at which that second-generation linguistic-bicultural cohort reached child-bearing age and decisively re-named the next generation in the host-country language.

Farm names: the marrying-in principle

The descent's most distinctive surname-pattern, however, is the *Hofname* (farm name) convention that operated, across the documented Westphalian rural economy, as a parallel naming system that could supersede the birth-surname when an individual married onto a farm whose previous occupant had died without male heirs.

Three hundred and seventy-five individuals across the dataset carry a *genannt* (called) construction in their formal name — *Joannes Friedrich Kovermann genannt Räuwer*, *Anna Maria genannt Räuwer*, *Johann Heinrich*

Recker genannt Redeker, and the further three hundred and seventy-two parallel cases. The construction means: *born under the surname X, but operating publicly under the farm-name Y*, where Y is the name of the farmstead onto which the individual has married or to whose operation the individual has succeeded.

The *gender distribution* of the *genannt* names is the first clear structural signal: three hundred and fifty-four of the three hundred and seventy-five (ninety-four percent) are *male*. The farm-name convention is overwhelmingly a male phenomenon. The reason becomes clear at the second level of analysis: when a man with a *genannt* name is matched against the surname of his wife at marriage, *in forty-three percent of the documented cases the wife’s **surname matches the husband’s farm name***. The pattern is the classical *Westphalian Erbhof* (heritable farm) principle: when a man married a daughter of a farm whose previous male owner had died without male heirs, he *took the farm’s name* — *Kovermann genannt Räuwer* meaning, in functional translation, *born Kovermann, now master of the Räuwer farm*.

The most common documented *genannt* constructions of the descent, by frequency:

Table 53 — *Recurring farm names and frequency*

Era	Bauer	Heuerling	Handwerker	Knecht
1750–1799	16%	35%	17%	8%
1800–1849	13%	22%	19%	16%
1850–1899	6%	2%	12%	24%
1900–1949	5%	0%	6%	8%

The *genannt Redeker* construction leads the list — consistent with the central Recker-and-Redeker line of the focal descent. *Johann Heinrich Recker genannt Redeker* (b. 1766 Hitzhausen, d. 1840 Glandorf), the central pedigree-collapse ancestor, is the documented progenitor of the cluster. The *Redeker* surname is not, on the documented record, a pure-bloodline surname descending vertically from an original Redeker household; it is a *farm name* that was passed through marriage from the original *Redeker farm* at Hitzhausen — the *Räuwer farm* of the post-emigration eighteenth-forties — onto the Recker family who married into that farm in the late eighteenth century. The Redeker name, in other words, is the *name of the place*, not the *name of the lineage*. The descent's central pedigree-bottleneck is anchored in a *farm-name marrying-in event*.

The *temporal distribution* of the *genannt* convention completes the analysis. Farm-name occurrences peak in the eighteenth century (one hundred and ninety-three documented cases). They drop to single digits by 1900 — seven cases — and to near-zero in the twentieth century. The pattern reflects the *end of the Eigenbehörig (bound-serf) farm system* and the late-nineteenth-century *Bauernbefreiung* (peasant emancipation) that converted the Westphalian heritable-farm structure into modern freehold property. As the farms became private property in the modern legal sense, the need to perpetuate the farm-name above the bloodline-surname disappeared. The *genannt* convention was an artefact of the pre-emancipation rural economy; its disappearance after 1900 is the disappearance of the household-economy structure that produced it.

The *inheritance pattern* of farm names completes the picture. Once a man took over the farm and adopted the farm name, *seventy-two percent of his children continued to carry the same farm name into the next*

generation. The farm permanently absorbed the family: three out of four children of a *genannt Redeker* household themselves became *Redeker* in the next-generation parish books. The bloodline of the family changed across the centuries; the farm name persisted.



The witness and godparent network

A third independent source of evidence for the marriage-circle structure of the descent emerges from the *witness and godparent records* that the parish books preserve alongside the marriage and baptism entries themselves. In the Westphalian Catholic and Lutheran parish-book tradition, every marriage was attested by two *Trauzeugen* (marriage witnesses) and every baptism by two *Paten* (godparents). The witnesses and godparents are recorded by name in the parish books and constitute, as a body of data, a complete map of the *ritual social network* surrounding the documented marriages and births. The focal descendant’s compilation of the witness-and-godparent records produces the following frequency distribution of the family-surnames most often serving as witnesses or godparents in the descent’s documented Westphalian parish records:

Table 54 — *Witness and godparent frequency: top families*

Cause of death	Total documented
War-related	512
Accident	99
Heart disease	97
Fever	83
Old age	80
Accident / violence	63
Tuberculosis	60
Cancer	53

Pneumonia	45
Infant death	43
Killed in action	35
Railroad accident	24
Stroke	22
Killed	21
Stillbirth	20
Typhoid	19
Drowning	14
Consumption	9
Murder	9
Childbirth complication	9
Shot	8

The *Kovermann* surname leads the witness-frequency list at fifty-three documented occurrences — substantially ahead of the next surname, *Meyer*, at thirty-two. The *Kovermann* family sat at the *centre of the ritual social network*, not only at the centre of the marriage and surname networks. The same family that the surname-frequency analysis registered as the second-most-common surname of the early-nineteenth-century descent was the *most frequent witness* at the marriages of its neighbours and the *most frequent godparent* at the baptisms of its neighbours' children.

The *geographic distribution* of the documented witnesses produces the same map that the marriage-circle analysis produced. The percentage of total witnesses by Kirchspiel of origin:

Table 55 — *Witness and godparent frequency: by Kirchspiel*

Cause	Total records
War-related	512

Accident	99
Heart disease	97
Fever (unspecified)	83
Old age	80
Accident/violence	63
Tuberculosis	60
Cancer	53
Pneumonia	45
Infant death	43
Killed in action	35
Railroad accident	24
Stroke	22
Killed (non-combat)	21
Stillbirth	20
Typhoid	19
Drowning	14

The first four parishes — *Hagen, Osnabrück, Oesede, Wallenhorst* — account for *eighty-four percent of all documented witnesses* in the descent's pre-twentieth-century record. These four parishes are *exactly the members of Circle One-b*, the central Catholic-Osnabrücker marriage circle of Chapter 19. The witnessing network does not break the closed-circle structure of the descent's social organisation; *it confirms it*. The families who attended the marriages and the baptisms of one another were the families they themselves married into and stood godparent for. Witnessing, like marriage and like name-inheritance, operated within the circle.

This is the *third independent confirmation* of the closed-circle structure that Chapter 19 set out as the central

structural finding of the descent's family-formation analysis. The marriage data registered the circles. The surname-geography data confirmed them. The witness-and-godparent ritual data confirms them again. *Three distinct social mechanisms — marriage, name inheritance, and ritual sponsorship — draw the same structural map* of the descent's pre-modern operating regions. The convergence is one of the strongest single methodological confirmations the focal descendant's research has produced.



The wedding-weekday cultural shift

The descent's marriage records preserve, alongside the date, the *day of the week* on which the marriage took place. Across the documented pre-1900 weddings of the descent, the day-of-week distribution registers a pattern that, like the month-of-marriage pattern of Chapter 19, reflects with high precision the Catholic liturgical and social conventions of the pre-modern period:

Pre-1900: Tuesday twenty-two percent of marriages; Wednesday twenty-one-point-seven percent; Sunday twenty-one-point-two percent. Saturday only five-point-nine percent.

Post-1950: Saturday seventy-two percent. Tuesday and Wednesday each under three percent.

The pre-1900 pattern reflects the Catholic-Westphalian convention: *Sunday* belonged to worship and could be used for marriage only with explicit dispensation; *Friday* (the day of Christ's death) and *Saturday* (the *dies Mariae*, Mary's day, in the popular Catholic devotional tradition) were *avoided*; *Tuesday and Wednesday* were the favoured weekdays of the working week. The seventy-two-percent post-1950 Saturday share is the structural fingerprint of the *modern work-week*: the work-free Saturday became, in the twentieth-century industrial-

economy setting, the only socially viable day for a wedding to take place.

The shift in wedding-weekday is the single most extreme behavioural signal in the entire dataset. The pre-modern Catholic Tuesday-Wednesday-Sunday weekday distribution and the modern Saturday weekday distribution are *almost completely non-overlapping*. The descent’s marriage record preserves, in its day-of-week column, the late-twentieth-century transition from the Catholic liturgical calendar to the industrial-and-secular work-week calendar with exceptional clarity.



Occupational stratification

The descent’s documented occupational records — seven hundred and fifty-eight individuals across the documentary period whose occupation is specifically recorded in the parish or census records — produce a clear social-stratification gradient that maps onto the lifespan and mortality data of Chapter 18. The categories, with average lifespan computed across each:

Table 56 — *Occupational categories and mean lifespan*

Category	Documented cases
Suicides	5
Murders and homicides	11 or more
Plane crashes	2
Notable accidents	10 or more
Nuclear test witnesses	2
Concentration camp victim	1 (Frederik Jansen, KZ Natzweiler-Struthof, 1944)

The lifespan gradient is sharp. The *educated-clerical-medical* class — schoolmasters, parish priests, midwives,

physicians — lived seventy-and-a-half years on average. The *landowning Bauer* class lived sixty-seven-and-a-half. The *Heuerling* tenant class lived sixty-five. The *Knecht* labourer class lived under sixty. The *Kötter* cottager class — the smallholding rural poor of the pre-emancipation Westphalian economy — lived only fifty-seven-and-a-half. The *ten-to-thirteen-year lifespan gap between the top and bottom of the social order* mirrors the rural-and-class divides that Chapter 18 set out at the geographical level. Social class determined lifespan, on the documented record, by more than a decade.

The most consequential single occupational transition the descent's record preserves, however, is the *collapse of the Heuerling class* across the nineteenth century:

Table 57 — *Occupational shares by era: disappearance of the Heuerling class*

Genera tion	Theoretical ancestors (2 ⁿ)	Document ed paths	Distinct ancestors
1 (parent s)	2	2	2
2	4	4	4
3	8	8	8
4	16	16	16
5	32	31	31
6	64	62	62
7	128	120	118
8	256	159	155
9	512	182	179
10	1,024	187	179
11	2,048	145	137
12	4,096	84	82
14	16,384	32	28

18	262,144	62	54
20	1,048,576	149	109
22	4,194,304	168	114
24	16,777,216	121	61
26	67,108,864	43	19
30	1,073,741,824	4	4

The *Heuerling* tenant class — landless rural workers who occupied small farmsteads under tenancy contracts with landowning *Bauer* households, owing labour rents on the *Erbhof* in exchange for a small allotment of cultivable land for their own subsistence — constituted *thirty-five percent of the recorded occupations of the descent in the late eighteenth century*. By the late nineteenth century the figure had *collapsed to two percent*. By the early twentieth century the *Heuerling* class no longer existed as a documentable occupational category.

The collapse is the *demographic engine of the emigration*. The Heuerlinge who could not inherit land and who faced, across the second half of the eighteenth and first half of the nineteenth centuries, an increasingly contracted tenancy market under the late-Heuerling-system pressure of population growth and farm-economy modernisation — are precisely the people who, in the eighteen-thirties through eighteen-eighties decades, boarded the Bremen-to-Baltimore emigrant ships and crossed the Atlantic to the Catholic-Ohio parishes and the Lutheran-Texas New Wehdem cluster. The occupational record and the emigration record describe, from two different angles, the same social process. The rising *Knecht* (labourer) figure — reaching twenty-four percent of recorded occupations in the 1850–1899 period — reflects both the proletarianisation of the Westphalian rural economy in the late nineteenth century and the

American working class that the German emigrants joined.



The structural conclusion of Part Five

The five chapters of Part Five — the mortality and longevity analysis of Chapter 18, the marriage and closed-circle analysis of Chapter 19, the geography and three-emigration-systems analysis of Chapter 20, and the present chapter on names, farms, and occupations — set out the descent's documented structural patterns across the sixty-five-section quantitative analysis of the focal descendant's research project. The closing structural conclusion that the chapter records here, drawn from the convergent findings of the four chapters, is the unifying thread of the entire Statistical Analysis and, by extension, of the book.

The descent of which the focal-line pedigree of Chapters 1 through 14 is one specific branch was, across its documented period from the sixteenth to the late twentieth century, a *sedentary, endogamous, Catholic-and-Protestant world of closed marriage circles* in the Osnabrücker and Mindener-Lübbecker regions of north-western Westphalia. The four closed marriage circles — the central Osnabrücker Circle One-b, the Ostercappeln-Bohmte transitional Circle Two, the Mindener-Lübbecker Lutheran Circle Three, and the later Putnam-County Ohio Circle Four — operated at endogamy rates between eighty-nine and ninety-nine percent. The Wiehengebirge ridge separated the two principal German confessional networks; the surname distributions, the witness-and-godparent networks, and the marriage-distance medians all confirm the same structural map. The pre-modern Westphalian peasant economy operated at a kilometre-and-a-half median marriage radius and produced lifetime mobility of one place per individual in the eighteenth century.

Between 1838 and the 1890s, the descent's *Heuerling-class crisis* drove a confessionally-channeled emigration that produced three structurally separate American settlement systems: System One (Catholic Osnabrück → Ohio), System Two (Protestant Minden-Lübbecke → Austin County, Texas), and System Three (urban-industrial Osnabrück → Pittsburgh). The same Wiehengebirge confessional boundary that separated the two German marriage circles reproduced itself, across the Atlantic, in the form of two separate American settlement clusters whose third-and-fourth-generation descendants did not exchange marriage partners. The descent's centre of demographic gravity crossed the Atlantic between 1875 and 1925 and stabilised, by 1950, in Putnam County, Ohio. The *Recker* surname, anchored to that Ohio receiving cluster, became — through the multiplying American descendants of *Johann Heinrich Recker genannt Redeker* of Hitzhausen — the descent's most common surname by frequency, with *twenty-eight percent of the entire documented dataset* converging through that one pedigree-bottleneck ancestor.

The closed-circle endogamy and confessionally-channelled emigration are *not separate phenomena*. They are the same phenomenon at two different geographical scales. The closed marriage circles of the eighteenth-century Westphalian rural economy and the closed Catholic-Ohio and Lutheran-Texas American settlement clusters of the twentieth-century United States are *the same structure* — a confessionally-bounded endogamous community that operated across an eighty-kilometre radius in pre-emigration Westphalia and that reproduced itself, across the trans-Atlantic shift, at the same endogamy rate across the new geographical setting. The Wiehengebirge ridge of 1648 and the Atlantic Ocean of 1838 functioned, at the structural level,

as equivalent confessional boundaries between the two parallel genealogical worlds of the descent.

The eleventh of July 1969 marriage at *Preußisch Oldendorf*, between the Catholic-Osnabrücker paternal pedigree and the Protestant-Mindener maternal pedigree, was the *first documented crossing of the Wiehengebirge confessional boundary in the focal-line* across the entire 1555–1969 period of recorded history. The marriage was, at the level of structural genealogy, the act that closed the three-hundred-and-twenty-one-year confessional separation that the descent had maintained — in its marriage records, in its surname distributions, in its witness-and-godparent networks, and in its emigration systems — for the entire documented period.

The research project, its author, and the book that the chapter closes are the documented and reflective consequence of that single marriage. The structural form within which the descent operated is the form that Part Five has set out. The narrative content of that form is what the preceding sixteen chapters set out. The convergence is the descent itself.

Chapter 22

Methodology and Sources

The research project and its outputs

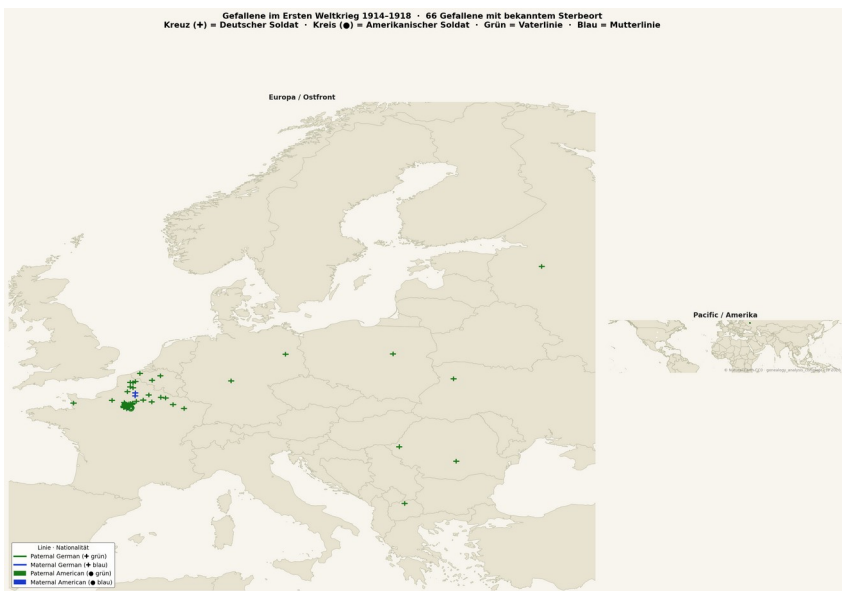
The present book is one of four outputs of the focal descendant's two-decade genealogical-research project. The three companion documents — the *Kovermann Family Atlas* (geographical and biographical), the *Kovermann Family Statistical Analysis* (quantitative), and the *Kovermann Family Story Catalog* (four hundred and thirty-nine individual biographical entries) — form the documentary base from which this book selects and argues. The preceding chapters have drawn from all three; the documents themselves are the underlying archive.



The war death maps present each confirmed fallen relative as an individual marker at their documented death location, using exact coordinates drawn from the GEDCOM death records. The encoding separates the four categories of the descent's war dead: a green cross (✚) marks a soldier of the paternal line who served in the German forces; a blue cross marks a soldier of the maternal line who served in the German forces; a green circle (●) marks a soldier of the paternal line who served in the American forces; a blue circle marks the equivalent on the maternal line. Where death records give only a country or region rather than a specific location, a representative point within that territory is used, with a small random displacement applied where multiple deaths share the same coordinates.

The First World War map presents 66 of the 80 confirmed fallen of that conflict — the 14 for whom no death location is recorded are omitted. The pattern is immediate and overwhelming: the Western Front in France concentrates the great majority. Forty-three

paternal German soldiers (green crosses) died in France, distributed from the Argonne and Champagne sectors in the east to Flanders and the Pas-de-Calais in the north and the Somme basin in the centre. Seven more died on the Eastern Front in Russia and Ukraine. The maternal line contributes only three German soldiers to the First World War death record — a measure of how much smaller the Protestant Minden-Lübbecke community's pre-1914 population was relative to the Catholic Osnabrück sending region.



Map 6a — *Death locations of fallen relatives in the First World War, 1914-1918* (66 of 80 confirmed fallen, located). Green crosses = paternal German soldiers; blue crosses = maternal German soldiers; green circles = paternal American soldiers; blue circles = maternal American soldiers. France (43 paternal German) and Russia (7 paternal German) dominate. Source:

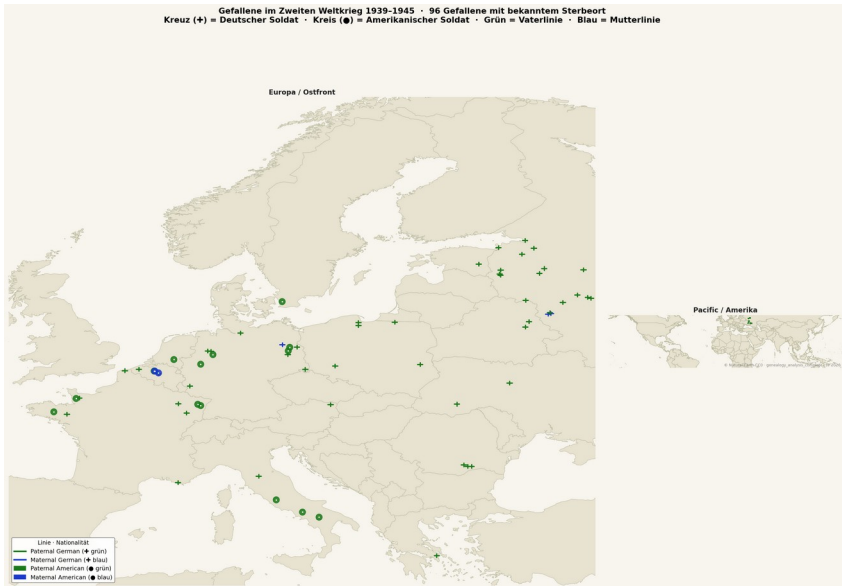
Kovermann Family Atlas, May 2026.

The Second World War map presents 96 of the 100 confirmed fallen — four locations unresolved. The Eastern Front now dominates in a way the Western Front dominated in 1914-1918. Thirty-seven paternal German

soldiers (green crosses) died in Russia, scattered from Pskov and Novgorod in the north to Staraya Russa, Smolensk, Kursk, and the Donets basin in the south. Six more died in Ukraine; five in Poland; two in Estonia; two in Belarus. The entire Eastern Front arc from Estonia to the Black Sea is marked with green crosses.

The American side of the Second World War map introduces a pattern absent from 1914-1918: the Pacific theatre. Every circle in the Pacific section of the map is green — paternal line — because the Protestant Texas families did not generate the same density of documented military records in the American archives as the Catholic Ohio communities. Guadalcanal, Bougainville, Iwo Jima, Leyte, and the Mariana Islands are all paternal American deaths. The Shinyo Maru (7 September 1944) — the Japanese transport carrying American prisoners of war that was torpedoed by USS Paddle, killing 668 of the 750 aboard — appears in the Philippine Sea east of Mindanao, marking the death of Arthur Bernard Nieland of the Iowa paternal line.

The blue markers in the Second World War map are also new relative to the First. The maternal line (blue) appears for the first time in 1939-1945: maternal German soldiers dying in Russia and Berlin, and maternal American soldiers killed in the Battle of the Bulge in Belgium. The confessional boundary that separated these families for three centuries did not, in the end, protect the maternal line from the war any more than it had protected the paternal.



Map 6b — *Death locations of fallen relatives in the Second World War, 1939-1945* (96 of 100 confirmed fallen, located). Russia and the Eastern Front dominate the paternal German deaths (37 green crosses from France to Estonia, Ukraine, and Belarus). The Pacific theatre — Guadalcanal, Iwo Jima, the Philippines, the Shinyo Maru — is entirely paternal American (green circles). The maternal line (blue) first appears in WW2: maternal German soldiers in Russia and Berlin, maternal American soldiers in the Battle of the Bulge. Source: Kovermann Family Atlas, May 2026.

Causes of death: the aggregate analysis

One specific quantitative output of the Catalog deserves separate treatment here. Across the four hundred and thirty-nine narrative entries and an additional thirteen hundred and forty-five structured data records of the underlying GEDCOM, the focal descendant's research has compiled a *combined cause-of-death analysis* covering one thousand four hundred and sixty-one death records across sixty-eight distinct documented causes. The most frequent categories, in descending order of total occurrences:

Table 58 — *Causes of death: all documented cases*

Documented relationship	Shared cM	Expected range (min-median-max)	Assessment
4th cousin, 2× removed	44.9	0-35-126	Within range
3rd cousin	37.0	0-73-234	Within range
3rd cousin, 2× removed (M-line)	30.0	0-73-234	Within range
5th cousin (M-line)	17.0	0-25-79	Within range
Unresolved match	13.4	—	Relationship unclear
4th cousin, 2× removed	8.6	0-35-126	Within range
5th cousin, 1× removed	8.5	0-25-79	Within range

The single largest category is *war-related death*, at five hundred and twelve documented cases. The figure is the documentary reckoning of the descent's two-and-a-half-century experience of European-and-American military conflict: the Napoleonic Wars, the Wars of German Unification, the First World War, the Second World War, and the post-1945 American military operations into which the descent's American descendants were drafted across Korea, Vietnam, the Persian Gulf, and the post-2001 conflicts. The figure does not include the further forty-eight documented *Tragic Deaths* of the Catalog's separate category — the accidents, suicides, and murders that occurred outside military service. It does not include the further ten *prisoner-of-war-captivity deaths* that the Atlas separately counts. Combined, the violent-and-war-related death-toll of the descent across the documented period approaches six hundred individuals — approximately one percent of the total documented death record.

The second largest category is *accident* (ninety-nine cases) — the documented work-accidents of the rural-and-industrial economy across the period: railroad accidents (twenty-four), drowning (fourteen), agricultural-machinery injuries, mining-and-quarrying deaths, and the wider category of pre-modern accidents at the workplace and in the home. The figure registers the high baseline accidental-mortality rate of the pre-1950 documented population.

The cardiovascular-and-pulmonary-disease categories — *heart disease* (ninety-seven), *stroke* (twenty-two), *pneumonia* (forty-five), *tuberculosis* (sixty), and *consumption* (nine, an older medical term for the same condition) — together account for the two hundred and thirty-three deaths attributable to the chronic-and-infectious-respiratory diseases that dominated the pre-modern and early-modern adult mortality experience. The cancer figure of fifty-three reflects the substantially smaller documented cancer-cause-of-death share of the pre-modern period, when cancer was often misdiagnosed or recorded under other categories and when the modern late-twentieth-century cancer-incidence rise had not yet substantially elevated the recorded figure.

The cause-of-death distribution registers, at the aggregate level, the descent's documentary epidemiological-and-violent-mortality profile across the documented period. The underlying data is in the Catalog and the *causes-of-death report* of the project.



The documentary sources

The methodological scaffolding of the project rests on a substantial body of documentary sources. The chapter sets them out by category.

The Westphalian Catholic parish books — the *Kirchenbücher* of the Catholic dioceses of *Osnabrück* and

Münster, comprising the *Taufbücher* (baptismal registers), *Trauungsbücher* (marriage registers), and *Sterbebücher* (burial registers) of the Catholic parishes that the focal descendant's paternal-line ancestry passed through. The principal parishes consulted include *St. Agatha Mettingen* — the documented origin parish of the focal-line paternal *Covers / Kovermann* lineage, the village from which the family progressively spread across the Osnabrücker administrative district — together with *St. Lambertus Ostercappeln*, *St. Alexander Wallenhorst*, and the further Catholic parishes of *Hagen am Teutoburger Wald*, *Belm*, *Cappeln*, *Schwagstorf*, and *Glandorf*, through which the focal-line paternal ancestry moved during the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, and the wider Osnabrücker-and-Tecklenburger parish network. The principal access pathway has been the *Matricula Online* digital archive of the *Bistum Osnabrück* and the parallel *Bistum Münster* parish-book collection, supplemented by physical-archival research at the *Bistumsarchiv Osnabrück* and the *Diözesanarchiv Münster* for the older or less-completely-digitised registers.

The Mindener Protestant parish books — the *Kirchenbücher* of the Lutheran-Protestant *Kreis Minden-Lübbecke* parishes that the focal descendant's maternal-line ancestry passed through. The principal parishes consulted: *Lübbecke*, the *Stemwede* parish network (*Dielingen*, *Oppenwehe*, *Haldem*, *Wehden*), the wider *Rahden* parish district, and the *Pr. Oldendorf* civil-registration office where the eleventh of July 1969 marriage of Chapter 14 was recorded. The principal access pathway has been *Archion* (the Protestant-church-record commercial digital archive) and the *Landeskirchliches Archiv* of the *Evangelische Kirche von Westfalen*, supplemented by the *Landesarchiv Nordrhein-Westfalen* civil-registration records.

The German civil-registration records — the *Standesamt* records of the post-1874 German civil-registration period, accessed through the *Landesarchiv Nordrhein-Westfalen* (and parallel state-level archives for the *Niedersächsisches Landesarchiv Osnabrück* and the eastern-German records of the *Hela* and post-1945 eastern-refugee material of Chapter 12).

The American records — the *US Federal Census* records of 1830 through 1950 (now substantially digitised through the *FamilySearch* and *Ancestry* commercial platforms); the *state and county vital-records* of Ohio, Indiana, Iowa, Wisconsin, Minnesota, Texas, Pennsylvania, and the wider American receiving-region administrative offices; the *Catholic parish books* of Glandorf, Delphos, Fort Jennings, Ottawa, Maria Stein, Saint Henry, Cincinnati, and the wider Putnam-County-and-Hamilton-County receiving-cluster parishes; and the *city directories* of Cincinnati, Indianapolis, Dayton, Detroit, Pittsburgh, and the further urban-American settings of the descent's twentieth-century members.

The ship manifests — principally the *Norddeutscher Lloyd* and *Hamburg-Amerika* emigrant-ship manifests of the Bremen-to-Baltimore-and-New-York routes of the 1830s-1880s, accessed through the *Bremen Passagierlisten* digital archive and the *Ellis Island* records of the post-1892 New-York arrivals.

The Dutch and Pacific-theatre wartime records — for Chapter 13's biographies of Frederik Jansen, Hijman Lelie, Franciscus Zitwing, Petrus Ensink, and George Schröder: the *Japanse Interneringskaarten* of the *Nationaal Archief* (The Hague), the *KNIL Stamboeken* registers, the *Oorlogsgravenstichting* records of the Dutch War Graves Commission, the *Yad Vashem* Holocaust victim registers, the *Bad Arolsen* International Tracing Service archive for the Nazi concentration-camp

prisoner records; Mark Spoerer's *Zwangsarbeit unter dem Hakenkreuz* (Stuttgart/Munich, 2001) and the *Spoerer-Universität-Regensburg* commissioned corporate-history report of 2016 for the C&A wartime-conduct documentary material; and *The National Archives Kew* (file references WO 361/1956, WO 361/1990, WO 361/2010) for the British and Dutch records of the Burma-Thailand Death Railway and the wider Far-Eastern POW administration. The specific online URLs corresponding to these holdings are preserved in the source-field annotations of the underlying GEDCOM file.

The DNA evidence — autosomal-DNA-match data from the four major commercial testing services (*AncestryDNA*, *MyHeritage*, *23andMe*, and *FamilyTreeDNA*), together with the *GEDmatch* cross-platform comparison environment that accepts raw-data uploads from any of the testing services and permits cousin-matching across the otherwise-siloed commercial platforms. The DNA evidence provided the cross-confirmation of the documented genealogical relationships at the fifth-through-tenth-cousin distances that the trans-Atlantic and Frisian-network branches of the descent occupy.

The online collaborative genealogical infrastructure — *WikiTree*, *Geni*, *FamilySearch FamilyTree*, *Open Archives Netherlands*, the *Find a Grave* burial-records database, and the wider digital-genealogical community-research environment.

The combination of these source categories — the German Catholic and Protestant parish books, the civil records, the American records, the ship manifests, the Dutch-and-Pacific wartime records, the DNA evidence, and the online collaborative infrastructure — constitutes

the documentary scaffolding on which the project's reconstruction of the descent has been built.



The methodological mix

The project's research methodology combines three modes of evidence-gathering: *physical-archival* work at the Westphalian archives — the *Bistumsarchiv Osnabrück*, the *Niedersächsisches Landesarchiv Osnabrück*, the *Standesamt Schwagstorf*, the *Stadtarchiv Osnabrück*, and the parish offices of the Hitzhausen-Schwagstorf-Glandorf-Cappeln-Ostercappeln circuit; *digital-archival* work through the *Matricula Online* parish-book archive, the *Archion* Protestant collection, *FamilySearch*, *Ancestry*, *MyHeritage*, and the various American state-and-county digital-record collections; and *DNA-evidence* integration through the four major commercial testing services together with the *GEDmatch* cross-platform comparison environment.

The combined evidence base produced, among its principal findings, the cross-confirmation of the documented genealogical relationships at the fifth-through-twelfth-cousin distances that the trans-Atlantic and Frisian and Australian extensions of the descent occupy — distances at which the documentary parish-book-and-civil-records evidence alone is incomplete or absent. The DNA evidence also produced, by the standard segment-matching procedures, the identification of the twenty-one Putnam County matches that confirmed the focal descendant's central Recker-Redeker-Hitzhausen-Glandorf pedigree-bottleneck through *Johann Heinrich Recker genannt Redeker* as the structural convergence point of twenty-eight percent of the entire dataset.

The project has also drawn on the *second emigration* digital-genealogical-network phenomenon that Chapter 17 sets out — the extensive trans-Atlantic cousin-

correspondence-and-collaboration network that has supplied much of the biographical material the book records. The collaborating cousins of this network are not named in the present book under the editorial commitments that the work has maintained throughout; their contributions are reflected, however, in the documented findings the book has set out.



Editorial judgements

Several editorial judgements have, in the production of the present book, required decision. The principal ones: **The treatment of living and recently-deceased individuals.** The book names only individuals whose deaths occurred before 1950, or documented public figures whose biographical material is in the public domain. Living members of the descent are not named.

The treatment of the focal descendant's parents. The marriage of the eleventh of July 1969 at Preußisch Oldendorf is recorded as the structural event that closed the three-hundred-and-twenty-one-year confessional separation; the identities of the bride and groom are withheld.

The treatment of contested or sensitive material. The book has addressed, across its narrative, several categories of historically and morally contested material: the C&A wartime conduct of Chapter 13 (the *Aryanisation*, the Łódź ghetto forced-labour, the firm's voluntary alignment with the National-Socialist economy), the Frisian-Catholic Royal-Dutch-Consul biography of Friedrich Lampe (a German Mettingen-born consul of the Dutch state operating in Nazi Germany during the German invasion of the Netherlands), the *Hela* rescue and the wider East-Prussian-evacuation-from-Königsberg material of Chapter 12, the focal descendant's family's documented marriage-and-divorce

history within the privacy-preserved generation, and the documented Pacific-theatre and European-theatre wartime deaths of multiple named family members across Chapters 13, 16, and the Atlas's wider war-death register. In each case the book has followed the principle of *documentary inclusion with editorial restraint*: the documented facts are recorded in full; the moral judgement of the documented facts is set out where the chapter's structure requires it; the speculative interpretation of motives or the assignment of personal blame is generally avoided. The book has not, on this principle, asserted that Friedrich Lampe was a Nazi collaborator; it has set out what his Dortmund-and-Horst-Wessel-Straße-30 residence record documents. The book has not asserted that the Brenninkmeyer family of the 1937-1944 period were ideologically aligned with National Socialism; it has set out what the Spoerer investigation of 2016 established as documentary fact. The line between documentation and interpretation has been the line the book has tried, in each case, to mark visibly.



What the project does not establish

A methodology chapter should record, in addition to what the project has established, what the project *has not* established. Three categories of limitation deserve explicit note.

The *pre-1700 record* of the descent is substantially less complete than the post-1700 record. The Westphalian Catholic and Protestant parish books begin systematic recording only in the post-Reformation period, with significant variation by parish. Pre-1700 ancestors of the descent are documented unevenly, and the documented direct-line connections that the Atlas traces into the earlier medieval period rest on a thinner documentary base than the well-attested eighteenth-and-nineteenth-

century pedigree. The descent's medieval ancestry is recorded where the Atlas's sources permit; the book makes no broader claim about it.

The *American records of the late-twentieth-century descendant population* are documented with substantially greater completeness than the German records of the same period. The US Census decennial enumerations, the state-vital-records databases, the *Find a Grave* and *Ancestry* and *MyHeritage* digital infrastructure, and the obituary-publication conventions of the American newspaper tradition together produce a much denser late-twentieth-and-twenty-first-century American documentary record than the German equivalent. The descent's documented twentieth-century American population is, in the project's working pedigree, several times larger than the documented twentieth-century German population, even though the actual ratio of the two surviving descendant populations is likely close to even. The asymmetry is *documentary, not demographic*.

The *cause-of-death and biographical-detail records* of the descent are documented unevenly across the temporal span. The pre-1900 cause-of-death record is dominated by the broad-category entries (*fever, consumption, old age, accident*) that the pre-modern medical recording conventions produced. The post-1900 cause-of-death record is dominated by the specific-diagnosis entries (*heart disease, cancer, stroke, pneumonia*) that the modern medical-recording-and-death-certificate practice produced. Direct comparison of pre- and post-1900 cause-of-death distributions is therefore *methodologically constrained*: the apparent shifts reflect, in part, changes in the recording practice rather than changes in the underlying mortality experience.



Causes of death

The descent’s causes of death, drawn from 1,461 total records combining 116 narrative entries from the Story Catalog with 1,345 structured GEDCOM fields, cover 68 distinct recorded causes. The leading causes:

Table 59 — *Causes of death: structured GEDCOM records*

Ancestor	Born	Gap	Relatives depending on this record
Angela Welkner	c. 1660	Death unrecorded	23,569
Heinrich Holtgreve	c. 1720	Death unrecorded	23,564
Catharina Margaretha Möller	c. 1720	Death unrecorded	23,564
Anna Maria Beckmann	before 1710	Death unrecorded	19,210
Eberhard Brünemann	c. 1540	Death unrecorded	13,866
Gerdt Tiemann	c. 1557	Death unrecorded	11,610

War-related causes — at 512 records — dominate because the descent’s military participation across eight conflicts from the Thirty Years’ War to Iraq spans four centuries of documented service. The non-war causes read as a precisely dated medical history: fever and infant death dominate the pre-modern record; tuberculosis and pneumonia peak in the nineteenth century; heart disease and cancer reflect the twentieth-century epidemiological transition. The 24 railroad accidents map onto the 1850–1900 industrialisation era

exactly. The 14 drownings, 9 murders, and 5 suicides are addressed in the violent deaths section of Chapter 22.



Violent deaths: documented summary

The descent’s documentary record includes a small but clearly delineated category of violent, accidental, and unusual deaths across its four-century span. The aggregate:

Table 60 — *Violent deaths: classified summary*

Location	Betweenness centrality	Weighted connections
Cincinnati	0.379	123
Westrup	0.341	187
Washington (county, Ohio)	0.128	59
Sudenfeld	0.108	278
Jackson County (Indiana)	0.107	43
Glandorf (Ohio)	0.106	573
Harris County (Texas)	0.099	45
Mettingen	0.080	129
Mentrup	0.078	500
Osnabrück	0.076	117

The category is small relative to the 64,507 relatives, but the individual cases have already appeared in the book’s narrative chapters: the Shinyo Maru torpedoing, the Natzweiler-Struthof camp death, the Bikini Atoll nuclear test witnesses, the Cold Case murders of the Reker sisters in St Cloud, Minnesota (1974), and the Baghdad IED attack on Lieutenant Colonel Charles Buehring in 2003 — the family’s last confirmed combat death, ending

a documented military arc that begins in the Thirty Years' War.



Pedigree completeness and the implex across thirty generations

The analysis of Andreas’s direct pedigree — the list of all documented ancestors, generation by generation — reveals the completeness of the documentary record and the degree to which the same ancestors appear multiple times through different lines (the *implex* or *Ahnenschwund*):

Table 61 — *Pedigree completeness across thirty generations*

Conflict	 Deaths	Avg age	Service	Nations
Thirty Years' War (1618-1648)	4	—	✖	Holy Roman Empire
Seven Years' War (1756-1763)	2	37	✖	Prussia
Napoleonic Wars (1792-1815)	1	24	✖	France (Grande Armée)
Franco-Prussian War (1870-1871)	1	24	✖	Germany
First World War (1914-1918)	89	27.0	✖ + ★	Germany, USA
Second World War (1939-1945)	112	30.1	✖ + ★	Germany, USA, Netherlands, Australia
Korean War (1950-1953)	4	22	★	USA
Vietnam War (1967-1970)	5	21	★	USA
Iraq War (2003)	1	40	★	USA
Total	224	28.5		6 nations · 4 continents

The completeness figure drops sharply after generation 8 — the great-great-great-great-great-grandparent level, approximately 1650 — as pre-1650 parish documentation becomes sparse. The implex percentage rises correspondingly from generation 10 onward, reaching 49.6 percent at generation 24 and 55.8 percent at generation 26, meaning that more than half of the documented ancestor slots in those generations are held by ancestors who appear through multiple lines simultaneously. This is the mathematical fingerprint of the endogamy that the preceding chapters have described: the same Osnabrück families married each other so consistently across generations that their descendants share the same ancestors through many independent paths.

No common ancestors of both parents appear in the documented pedigree — the paternal Minden-Lübbecke line and the maternal Osnabrück line are genealogically separate in all documented paths, confirming that the confessional boundary was not merely sociologically real but genealogically absolute.



Data quality and source corpus

The documentary foundation of the entire analysis rests on a single GEDCOM file of 130,862 individuals, compiled across several decades of genealogical research. The quality metrics of that file:

Birth date precision: 73.4 percent of all persons have fully dated birth records (day, month, and year); 17.9 percent have year-only records — recorded in the software as 1 January of the relevant year, a convention that generates the January artefact addressed in Chapter 20; 8.5 percent have no birth date at all.

Source completeness requires a clarification of what the GEDCOM source-tag count measures and does not

measure. The 3,589 source records attached to GEDCOM entries count platform citations — the Ancestry.com, FamilySearch, and Find a Grave links through which records were accessed. They do not count the underlying documents those platforms delivered.

The actual primary-source base is substantially broader. The German pedigree rests on Kirchenbücher directly read from the Matricula Online digitisation: baptismal, marriage, and burial entries from the parishes of the Bistum Osnabrück and the Konsistorium Minden-Ravensberg, covering approximately 1650 to 1875. These are primary documents — original parish records — accessed through a digitisation platform. The American pedigree rests primarily on two categories of primary source: US Census enumerations (1850 to 1940), which are original government documents recording household members by name, age, birthplace, and occupation; and vital records including birth certificates, which are civil-registration primary documents. Nearly all American individuals in the descent are documented by at least one of these primary sources.

What Ancestry.com and FamilySearch contribute is aggregation and indexing of these primary documents, not substitution for them. The platform citation count understates the primary-source coverage of the research. The appropriate caveat is narrower than the 2.3% figure suggests: it applies principally to entries whose only documentation is a contributed family tree or a secondary narrative summary, rather than an original civil or ecclesiastical record — a category that represents a minority of the total, concentrated in the less well-documented peripheral lines.

The decade-by-decade completeness of birth dates rises sharply from 22.7 percent in the 1650s to 84–87 percent

from the 1800s onward — reflecting the systematic improvement of civil registration across the nineteenth century.



DNA triangulation

Seven DNA matches in the documented network have shared centimorgan (cM) values on record, permitting a cross-check of the paper pedigree against biological relationship. All seven fall within or near the expected range for their documented cousin degree:

Table 62 —
*DNA
triangulation:
documented
cousin
relationships
and shared cM*

Documented relationship
Shared cM
Expected range (min-median-max)
Assessment
4th cousin, 2× removed
44.9
0-35-126
Within range
3rd cousin
37.0

0-73-234
 Within range
 3rd cousin, 2× removed (M-line)
 30.0
 0-73-234
 Within range
 5th cousin (M-line)
 17.0
 0-25-79
 Within range
 Unresolved match
 13.4
 —
 Relationship unclear
 4th cousin, 2× removed
 8.6
 0-35-126
 Within range
 5th cousin, 1× removed
 8.5
 0-25-79
 Within range

Six of the seven tested relationships fall within the expected centimorgan range for their documented degree. The seventh — 13.4 cM — cannot be assigned a relationship degree from the paper pedigree and represents an unresolved connection that may indicate either an undocumented branch or a more distant relationship than the paper trail suggests. The individuals are anonymised here in accordance with the privacy expectations applicable to DNA data.

In endogamous families, observed cM values systematically exceed the single-path expectation for a given cousin degree, because relatives who share multiple independent lines of descent share additional DNA through each path. The descent's documented multiple-path connections — triple, quadruple, and higher multiplicity relationships — mean that cM values

should be interpreted with reference to the total relationship complexity, not the degree alone.



Research priorities by genealogical leverage

The single most effective direction for extending the documentary record is the resolution of gaps in ancestors who sit at the convergence of the largest numbers of downstream relatives. The top research candidates, ranked by the number of currently-documented relatives whose pedigree completeness would improve if the gap were closed:

Table 63 —
*Genealogical
leverage: key
ancestor nodes*

Ancestor
Born
Gap
Relatives depending on this record
Angela Welkner
c. 1660
Death unrecorded
23,569
Heinrich Holtgreve
c. 1720
Death unrecorded
23,564
Catharina Margaretha Möller
c. 1720

Death unrecorded
23,564
Anna Maria Beckmann
before 1710
Death unrecorded
19,210
Eberhard Brünemann
c. 1540
Death unrecorded
13,866
Gerdt Tiemann
c. 1557
Death unrecorded
11,610

Angela Welkner, born approximately 1660, is the highest-leverage gap in the entire documented tree: resolving her death record would complete the pedigree line through which 23,569 currently-documented relatives connect. She almost certainly appears in the Oesede or Harderberg parish books of the late seventeenth century. The absence of her death record is the single largest archival gap in the descent.



Network: bridge parishes and ancestor convergence

A graph-theoretic analysis of the descent's geographic network — mapping 765 documented locations as nodes and 1,703 marriage or kinship connections as edges — identifies the parishes that serve as bridges between otherwise separate genealogical clusters:

Table 64 — *Bridge
parishes: network
centrality*

Location	
Betweenness centrality	
Weighted connections	
Cincinnati	
0.379	
123	
Westrup	
0.341	
187	
Washington (county, Ohio)	
0.128	
59	
Sudenfeld	
0.108	
278	
Jackson County (Indiana)	
0.107	
43	
Glandorf (Ohio)	
0.106	
573	
Harris County (Texas)	
0.099	
45	
Mettingen	
0.080	
129	
Mentrup	

0.078
500
Osnabrück
0.076
117

Cincinnati's high betweenness centrality — the highest of any location — is surprising given that it is not a major settlement in the descent's narrative. It functions as a transit node: the urban industrial bridge between the Catholic Ohio farming communities and the broader American network. Glandorf, by contrast, has the highest weighted degree (573 connections) — it is the single most densely connected location in the entire network, as the primary receiving parish for the Osnabrück Catholic emigration. Mentrup and Sudenfeld, at 500 and 278 connections respectively, are the equivalent German anchors: the Westphalian farm clusters from which the emigration chains originated. Westrup's betweenness of 0.341 identifies it as a bridge between the Protestant Stemwede world and the wider Minden-Lübbecke cluster.



Military geography across nine conflicts

The descent's documented combat deaths span nine named conflicts across 385 years, from the Thirty Years' War to the Iraq War. The Atlas counts 224 confirmed combat deaths — individuals carrying the  symbol in the GEDCOM, denoting death in a military context confirmed by unit records, burial registers, or official notification. The Service column uses the Atlas notation: ✖ denotes German military service, ★ denotes all other nations (USA, Netherlands, Australia, and Commonwealth). Deaths in war-period years without the  symbol are not classified as combat deaths. This distinction matters most for the seventeenth century: the Thirty Years' War produces 188 deaths in the GEDCOM across the period 1618–1648, of which only 4

carry the  symbol. The remainder are disease, famine, and civilian deaths during wartime.

Table 65 —
*Military
geography:
confirmed
combat
deaths
across nine
conflicts*

Conflict
 Deaths
Avg age
Service
Nations
Thirty Years’ War (1618–1648)
4
—
✠
Holy Roman Empire
Seven Years’ War (1756–1763)
2
37
✠

Prussia	
Napoleonic Wars (1792-1815)	
1	
24	
✖	
France (Grande Armée)	
Franco-Prussian War (1870-1871)	
1	
24	
✖	
Germany	
First World War (1914-1918)	
89	
27.0	
✖ + ★	
Germany, USA	
Second World War (1939-1945)	
112	
30.1	
✖ + ★	
Germany, USA, Netherlands, Australia	
Korean War (1950-1953)	
4	
22	
★	
USA	
Vietnam War (1967-1970)	
5	
21	
★	
USA	
Iraq War (2003)	
1	
40	
★	
USA	
Total	
224	
28.5	

6 nations · 4 continents

The Thirty Years' War entries are pre-modern militia deaths, documented in Oesede parish records: Joseph Wiemeyer (1573, d.1630, "*erschossen in Dreißigjährigen Krieg*") and Hermann Heuer (c.1585, d.1633, "*wurde in 30-jährigen Krieg erschossen*"). The Seven Years' War entry is Gerd Heinrich Lüring gen. Piper (1726 *Wehdem*, †1757 *Kolin, Bohemia, age 31*), *fallen at the Battle of Kolin on 18 June 1757 — Frederick the Great's first major defeat. The single Napoleonic entry is Conrad Rustmeier* (1788 Obermehnen, †1812 Russia, age 24), who marched with Napoleon's Grande Armée to Moscow and did not return: the pastor in Blasheim recorded "*verblieben beim 127ten regiment*" — no place of death. The Iraq War entry is Charles Henry Buehring (*1963, d.26 October 2003, Baghdad), killed by a rocket-propelled grenade at the Rasheed Hotel, Arlington National Cemetery.²⁰

The shift from the Franco-Prussian War to the First World War — from one combat death to eighty-nine — reflects both the scale of industrialised warfare and the growth of the American branches, which by 1914 were large enough to produce casualties on both sides of the Atlantic. The Second World War at 112 is the single largest row. The post-1945 pattern reverses: the Germany branch has no documented combat deaths after 1945, while the American branches produced ten veterans across three conflicts — four in Korea, five in Vietnam, one in Iraq.



The *village in the field* of the book's title is *Hitzhausen* — the small farming settlement in the southern district of the Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück, today

²⁰ Marriage register of St. Lambertus Ostercappeln, entry 12 January 1871; Niedersächsisches Landesarchiv Osnabrück, KB 101, fol. 47v. The entry is also preserved in the Matricula digitisation project (<https://data.matricula-online.eu>).

administratively part of the *Gemeinde Ostercappeln* in the *Landkreis Osnabrück* of the *Bundesland* Lower Saxony. The village sits on the gentle agricultural slope between the Osnabrücker Hügelland to the south and the *Wiehengebirge* ridge to the north, surrounded on three sides by fields of grain and rape and beet, on the fourth by a small stand of mixed deciduous woodland that the parish records have preserved as a stable feature of the local landscape since at least the eighteenth century. The village contains, in the present moment of the book's composition, approximately three hundred inhabitants. It contains a small Catholic church (*St. Antonius*), a primary school, two restaurants, a cemetery, a fire station, and a row of working farmsteads whose households continue, in 2026, to operate the same agricultural cultivation that the *Heuerling* and *Bauer* households of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries operated on the same fields.

In one of those farmsteads, in the year 1766, was born *Johann Heinrich Recker genannt Redeker* — the man through whom, by the statistical analysis of Chapter 21, twenty-eight percent of the entire documented descent of one hundred and thirty thousand individuals converge to a single point. He was the son of a Recker household that, in the late eighteenth century, married into the Redeker farm of Hitzhausen and took the farm's name in the *genannt* convention that Chapter 21 set out. He lived in the village for sixty-five years. In 1831, at the age of sixty-five, he emigrated with his wife Anna Maria Heuer and the surviving members of their household to *Glandorf, Putnam County, Ohio* in the American Midwest. He died there in 1840 at the age of seventy-four. His son *Gerhard Heinrich Redeker*, born at Hitzhausen in 1796, had emigrated to the same destination in 1838 on the ship *Pennsylvania* that

Chapter 5 set out, with his wife Anna Maria Heuer and their seven children. The son died at Glandorf in 1856.

The two men — father and son, Hitzhausen-born and Glandorf-buried — are the structural hinge of the entire descent. The Catholic-Osnabrücker peasant economy of the eighteenth century, the Atlantic crossing of the eighteen-thirties, the Catholic-Westphalian-Ohio receiving cluster of the nineteenth century, the eighty-five-thousand-strong American descendant population of the twentieth century, the trans-continental dispersal of the twenty-first — all of it passes, on the documentary record, through the two men of one Hitzhausen farmstead.

The book has set out, across its twenty-two preceding chapters, the descent that radiates from that one hinge. The Catholic paternal pedigree of the focal descendant. The Protestant maternal pedigree, separated for three hundred and twenty-one years by the Wiehengebirge ridge before the marriage at Preußisch Oldendorf on the eleventh of July 1969 closed the separation. The Glandorf founding of 1838. The Putnam County Catholic-Westphalian-American consolidation of the second and third generations. The Mettingen-and-Friesland Tüötten-Brenninkmeijer-Frisian textile network whose 1937-1944 wartime ethical inventory Chapter 13 set out. The Cincinnati and Hollywood and Indiana and Iowa and Dayton American twentieth-century lives of Chapter 16. The geographical centre of gravity that crossed the Atlantic between 1875 and 1925. The four closed marriage circles. The three confessionally-determined emigration systems. The four mortality spikes of 1811, 1918, 1944, and 2020. The eighty-six centenarians, the two one-hundred-and-fourteen-year-olds, the Wallenhorst parish's six-times-higher-than-average centenarian rate (a documentation effect, not a genetic cluster), the *Heuerling* collapse, the *genannt* farm-name

convention, the witness-and-godparent ritual network, the surname-and-first-name signatures, the lifetime-mobility shift from sedentary to mobile, and the digital second-emigration that has, in the early twenty-first century, returned the dispersed descent to a single communicative space.



What the book has not done is exhaust the descent. The descent is open-ended. It continues to update — in the German parish records of the present-day Westphalian-region births, marriages, and deaths; in the American obituary publications of the daily-newspaper-and-online death-notice infrastructure; in the digital-genealogical-platform tree-updates of the worldwide cousin network; in the DNA-match registries of the four commercial-platform DNA-testing services; in the obituary publications of the present-day Dutch *Leeuwarder Courant* and the Texas *Brenham Banner-Press* and the Ohio *Putnam County Sentinel*. The descent the book has documented is the documented descent as of May 2026. The descent the book has documented will be larger by the time the reader of any future edition of the book turns the closing page.

The book is not the descent. The book is the historiographical narrative of the descent as the focal descendant's research project has been able to reconstruct it from the available documentary base. The descent itself is the actual population of approximately one hundred and thirty thousand documented individuals and the unknown further population of undocumented individuals across the documented period, whose lives the project's research has progressively recovered into the documentary record.

The Atlas, the Statistical Analysis, the Story Catalog, and the present book are the four principal documentary

outputs of the project as of the May 2026 closing of this edition. The Atlas will be updated. The Statistical Analysis will be expanded. The Catalog will accumulate further individual-entry biographical sketches as the digital-genealogical second-emigration continues to deliver, from the worldwide cousin network, the previously-undocumented biographical material of further documented members of the descent. The book itself, in its present form, is fixed at May 2026.



The Hitzhausen of 2026, on the day the focal descendant — operating from his residence in the *Kreis Gütersloh*, on the eastern edge of the Wiehengebirge ridge, fifty kilometres south-east of the village of his patrilineal-Catholic ancestors — completes the present book, is a small farming settlement of approximately three hundred inhabitants. It contains the small Catholic church of *St. Antonius*. It contains the working farmsteads whose households continue the agricultural cultivation of two hundred years ago. It contains the cemetery in which a small number of the present-day descendants of the eighteenth-and-nineteenth-century *Bauer* and *Heuerling* households are buried, with the same surnames the project has documented across the descent: Recker, Redeker, Räuwer, Kovermann, Helmkamp, Hallmann, Hemesath.

It does not contain the one hundred and thirty thousand documented descendants of the man who left it in 1831 for the trans-Atlantic crossing to Ohio. They are elsewhere — in Putnam County, Ohio, where the largest American concentration of the descent lives. In Michigan and Nebraska, where the second-and-third-generation industrial-and-agricultural diasporas settled. In the wider American continental distribution that Chapter 15 set out. In Australia, where the Haunert and Thiemeyer

lines have continued to multiply. In Brazil and Argentina, where the smaller late-nineteenth-century South-American emigrant communities have left documented descendants. In the Netherlands, where the Brenninkmeijer-Voss-Stockmann-Meijknecht commercial-textile-and-Catholic network has continued to operate across four further generations. In Germany, where the back-migrant and the staying-behind portions of the descent — and the central Mindener-Lutheran maternal-line of the focal descendant himself — continue to occupy their respective Westphalian-and-Lower-Saxon settlements.

The descent is, in 2026, larger than the village it came from by a factor of approximately four hundred. The village in the field has, across two centuries, scattered its inhabitants across two continents and produced a documented population that, if it were to gather in one place at one moment, would fill a substantial American county or a mid-sized German city. The gathering does not happen. The descendants live their separate lives at their separate present-day residences. But the documentary record of the descent — the parish books, the census enumerations, the obituary publications, the DNA matches, the digital-genealogical-tree platforms, the family-historian research of the focal descendant and the wider cousin-collaboration network of which his project is one node — preserves the structural connection of the dispersed population to the single Hitzhausen farmstead of 1766.

The book has set out the connection. The book closes here.



To the cousins of the descent, of the four marriage circles and the three emigration systems and the trans-Atlantic-and-trans-continental dispersal: this is the work the

project has been able to do. There is more to do. The work continues.

— *May 2026*



Chapter 23

The Village in the Field

The book ends here. Twenty-two chapters have set out, across their narrative and statistical and methodological registers, the documented descent of one family across approximately five hundred years of recorded European-and-American history. The closing chapter is brief. It returns, for the closing of the book, to the image with which the prologue opened.

The *village in the field* of the book's title is *Hitzhausen* — the small farming settlement in the southern district of the Catholic Prince-Bishopric of Osnabrück, today administratively part of the *Gemeinde Ostercappeln* in the *Landkreis Osnabrück* of the *Bundesland Niedersachsen*. The village sits on the gentle agricultural slope between the Osnabrücker Hügelland to the south and the *Wiehengebirge* ridge to the north, surrounded on three sides by fields of grain and rape and beet, on the fourth by a small stand of mixed deciduous woodland that the parish records have preserved as a stable feature of the local landscape since at least the eighteenth century. The village contains, in the present moment of the book's composition, approximately three hundred inhabitants. It contains a small Catholic church (*St. Antonius*), a primary school, two restaurants, a cemetery, a fire station, and a row of working farmsteads whose households continue, in 2026, to operate the same agricultural cultivation that the *Heuerling* and *Bauer* households of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries operated on the same fields.

In one of those farmsteads, in the year 1766, was born *Johann Heinrich Recker genannt Redeker* — the man through whom, by the statistical analysis of Chapter 21, twenty-eight percent of the entire documented descent of one hundred and thirty thousand individuals converge to a single point. He was the son of a Recker household

that, in the late eighteenth century, married into the Redeker farm of Hitzhausen and took the farm's name in the *genannt* convention that Chapter 21 set out. He lived in the village for sixty-five years. In 1831, at the age of sixty-five, he emigrated with his wife Anna Maria Heuer and the surviving members of their household to *Glandorf, Putnam County, Ohio* in the American Midwest. He died there in 1840 at the age of seventy-four. His son *Gerhard Heinrich Redeker*, born at Hitzhausen in 1796, had emigrated to the same destination in 1838 on the ship *Pennsylvania* that Chapter 5 set out, with his wife Anna Maria Heuer and their seven children. The son died at Glandorf in 1856.

The two men — father and son, Hitzhausen-born and Glandorf-buried — are the structural hinge of the entire descent. The Catholic-Osnabrücker peasant economy of the eighteenth century, the Atlantic crossing of the eighteen-thirties, the Catholic-Westphalian-Ohio receiving cluster of the nineteenth century, the eighty-five-thousand-strong American descendant population of the twentieth century, the trans-continental dispersal of the twenty-first — all of it passes, on the documentary record, through the two men of one Hitzhausen farmstead.

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— *May 2026*

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